TITAN-RA AND THE PRINCESSES OF PORTALS

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by DragonCobolt26

Summary

When Adora Gray was twelve years old, her best friend in the whole world was Kat Weaver and they went to a very special camp for very special girls - the kind of place parents send their kids when they're...

Not.

Normal.

After that camp, Adora Gray was not friends with Kat Weaver anymore. Now, at age eighteen, Adora feels trapped between her mother's expectations and her own desire and her own guilt...until she follows a tiny owl into an old shack off the road, and stumbles head first into a place called the Boiling Isles - the Demon Realm, a place where all of humanity's dreams and nightmares came from.

There, Adora will find a new home.

A new mother.

A new life.

A new calling.

And some old, old, old secrets...

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

-ood witch Azura stood before the snarling beast, staff smoking with mystical prowess. With a tremblin- nd she-

The page was covered in mud and splattered with rain.

The girl picked it up, and then kept running, her flashlight waving around wildly.

Her camp outfit was not made for this weather. It was cold and rainy, and Camp Pure N' Straight was made for people who had to handle New England autumns – but not New England storms. The rain was coming down sleeting and thick, pattering through the thick forests that felt like they had been untouched for centuries.

The girl, holding the paper to her chest looked around and shouted.

"Kat! Kaaaaaaat!"

There was no response.

She kept running.

She found another page. Then the cover and half the book – *The Good Witch Azura and…* but the rest was covered with mud. She didn't even pick it up, because she could hear the sound of crying, cracking branches, rumpling brush. She ran forward and caught on a branch, stumbling. She almost fell forward onto Kat, who was hunched over next to a huge old tree. In the darkness and the thickness of the rain, the beam of the flashlight was visible and shone directly into her face. Kat lifted one hand, hiding beneath it and hissing, like an animal.

"K-Kat! Kat, I found you, Kat!"

"Go away!" Kat shouted, her voice thick.

"I-" The girl stood there, the beam of the flashlight trembling in her hands. She bit her lip, then stammered. "I-...I'm…"

Kat glared at her. In the shadows of the trees, protected by the rain, her eyes – mismatched blue and gold – were nearly feral with tears and anger and fear and sadness. She grabbed onto the lowest branch of the tree, dragging herself up, her camp outfit even more scraggly. She wasn't wearing a jacket for one thing. She didn't shiver, though. She was too busy shouting.

"You're what? You're *sorry*?" Kat grabbed onto some mud and flung it. It splattered on the girl's chest and face, making her step back. "You're *always* sorry! But you never *do* anything, Adora!" She almost choked as tears stung at the corners of her eyes –

bright in the flashlight, impossibly visible against the rain. "You...you…" She trembled, then closed her eyes.

"I-I….I was gonna...I was gonna s-say they were my books…" Adora whispered.

"You were *gonna*," Kat choked out. "You…" She put her hand over her face.

Adora stepped forward, hesitantly.

She put her hand on Kat's shoulder.

Kat reacted exactly like she had when she was eleven, and Olivia had tried to bully her on the playground. Except this time, there were no teachers, and there were no other kids. There was just her and the woods and the rain, and her fingers scraped at Adora's face and cheek and hair as she shouted. "I hate you! I hate you! I hate you!" Kat shouted. "You're always right! You always get everything!" She sobbed, her shoulders shaking.

Adora, her arms raised up to protect her face, whimpered.

"I wish...I wish I'd never met you!" Kat shouted at her, then stood. "I wish I was dead! I wish...I wish...I wish I was…"

She turned and then ran. The flashlight flickered and went dim – the water from the rain seeping into the housing, cracked against a rock. Adora felt blood stinging in her eye. She ignored it. She stumbled to her feet, and shouted. "Kat!" She started to move through the woods. "Kat!"

Then…

The dream always ended the same way.

She stumbled through the woods, emerged between the trees – and there was something in the darkness beyond her, lit by a thin slip of the moon peeking through stormclouds. It was *big* whatever it was. Then two eyes, huge and bright and reflective, turning to face her, catching the moonlight and flashing it into her eyes. Then the shriek – and then…

Adora's eyes opened. She was panting and trembling in her bedroom, her face beaded with sweat. She sat up, slowly, in her bed, her body quivering. She could hear her mother's voice, echoing from down the stairs – she sounded like she was on the phone. "I see. I understand. Of course. I see." She was using the clipped tone that meant she was *angry*. Very angry. Adora groaned softly, then looked out the window of her house. Across the way, she could see their neighbor heading out for her day job, humming cheerfully. The family – a married couple without any kids – had moved in after…

She shook her head, trying to cast off the dream. Instead, she slid from her bed and looked around the room. No matter what Mom

had to say, she couldn't find fault with this room: Her Azura books were hidden, her old comics were tucked away. In their place were textbooks on every STEM subject, a few weights for her lacross training, and there...she smiled, a little sheepishly. There was her wooden practice sword, sheathed and hanging up in the corner. Mom was a stickler that Adora get into the same fancy pants college she had gotten through – but Adora had managed to finagle in her HEMA studies by finding a few examples of HEMA clubs at the same college.

It'll help me get in, I swear.

It was one of her few tiny victories.

The door to her room opened without a knock and there stood Mom, dressed in her red business suit. Adora's mother had been in a car accident when she had been young – the same car accident that had killed Dad. Adora, who had been safely in a car seat at the time, had no memories of it. Apparently, she hadn't even gotten a scar from it. On cue, the notch on her eyebrow twinged. She ignored it. Mom, meanwhile, had come away with… well, she had grown her hair long to cover what the plastic surgeons had managed to correct. Her lips were pursed as she looked down at her nose at Adora.

"We need to talk," she said, firmly.

Adora sighed, softly. "W-What is it, Mom?" She asked, sitting on the bed. "My grades are doing okay, right?"

Mom stepped into the room. “Oh. No. No.” Mom shook her head. “It’s not your grades, Adora.” She frowned. “According to the phone call I received, you were at the local...GSA.” She brought out the acronym with clear disdain. Adora felt her heart sink. Cold, clammy fear prickled along her body. No. No. No. No. She had talked to the teachers involved, no one would have *reported* her, Miss Bright was a *good* teacher, she’d never call in. Adora froze still and her hands clasped on her lap. She remembered the stinging sensation on her wrist – back at Camp, they had given her rubber bands, and if she ever felt *impure thoughts* she was supposed to snap it. The pain came back fierce and hot, despite the camp and the rubber bands being far, far behind her.

“W-Who, I...w…” Adora stammered.

“Mr. Horde,” Mom said, pronouncing the name as if it were French, despite no one else doing the same. Adora’s sting of betrayal became furious rage and even brighter fear. The old crotchety man was one of the most nosy people that went to their church – he wasn’t even going to school! He just...lived nearby. She looked down at her lap.

“Explain yourself,” Mom said, her voice flat.

“I-It’s...it’s f-for straight people too, I just...I just-”

“Ah, yes, well, I see!” Mom said, her voice prim. “You don’t mind if every college campus learns that you’re a *political* activist. You

know with the current climate, how extremely damaging politics like that can be."

"T-They say...they want politically active people…"

Mom sighed. "For *reasonable* politics, Adora." Her hand reached down, and she stroked Adora's hair, tucking it back behind one ear – neatening her up as her words made her feel so pathetic and small. Her voice dripped into Adora's ear, gently. "Not for running around with a bunch of *queers*. And you don't want your colleges, your future workplaces, to think you're some lesbian. Do you?"

Adora clenched her hands even tighter. Her knuckles showed.

"Now, you're going to go to school and tell the GSA that you were mistaken when you signed up. You will dedicate yourself to your studies and...if you want a political opportunity, we can have you join up with something sensible – how about the Young Republicans? They can always use new members."

"Y-Yes, Mother," Adora whispered.

"Here," Mom said, reaching around from behind her back and holding out a pamphlet for the Young Republicans. She had it printed already. Of course she did.

“Now,” Mom said, smiling thinly. “You have to get to school, don’t you?”

She isn’t smirking, Adora thought. *She doesn’t smirk. Her scars just make it seem that way. They just make it seem that way. They just make it seem that way.* She thought the words over and over and over as she threw on her red jacket, slung on her backpack, got her textbooks, and took the flier. She forced her hands to not clench and crumple it up, her heart lumping in her chest. She walked out to the sidewalk, the crisp air biting her lungs as she looked around herself, then headed for the spot where the school bus would come and pick her up and take her to Gravesfield High School. She looked back down at the pamphlet.

There was a smiling blond woman and a smiling black man, both in suits, shaking hands.

The future of the right…today!

She looked up. Across the street, she saw the house that had once been Kat’s house. Her foster parents had moved away after she had...Adora shook her head.

She has to have died, you know, her mother’s voice, echoing from the past, whispered into her ear. *It was nearly freezing, in the rain, without a jacket, off into those woods. People can still get lost in those woods. And it is not as if she was a particularly rational girl – ah well.*

No. She had to believe Kat was alive. Somewhere. She had to have run away, and now she was-

The pamphlet tugged out of her hands. She blinked, looking down, and saw...a tiny owl had snagged onto the printed paper and had taken advantage of her distraction to steal the...the thing that would lead to her mother immediately murdering her if she lost it! Adoraa jerked, shook her head and started to hurry after it. "Hey! Give that back!" She exclaimed, even though she *knew* it was absurd, even though she knew it was just an owl. But the tiny owl hopped into the air, wings flapping, and skimmed across the street, heading for the woods that clustered around Gravesfield.

Adora rushed after the owl as it hopped, skipped, scampered, and came into the clearing beyond the woods – to...to…

Adora froze, her jaw dropping.

I thought this place fell down. Mom said it fell down!

And she had never checked. Not because she trusted Mom, no. But because every second of being inside the old, run down house in the woods – the abandoned building that had stood near her street since she had been a little girl – would remind her of Kat. She would see the little scribble of her face and Kat's face, with A+K drawn next to it. She would find the corner where they had tucked their sleeping bags, before Mom had started to come down hard on them both, before...before she had started to whisper to Kat's foster parents.

It's not normal, she had said. *They should both go. Here, I've already found the camp.*

Adora shook her head, realizing that she had frozen long enough for the tiny owl to scamper into the house.

"Get back here!" She exclaimed, rushing towards the door.

She opened the door, scrambled in, then dove for the owl – but he had already hopped behind her grasp. She skidded along...dirt? She blinked, slightly, as the owl hopped onto a boot, then got snatched up by a pale hand. The hand was attached to an arm, which vanished into a set of robes, which covered a pair of bright, bright eyes. "What do we have here, Owlbert!" The figure snatched the Young Republican flier. "Yeesh! They have this stuff in the human realm too?"

"Give that back!" Adora said, scrambling to her feet.

The robed woman blinked at her, throwing her hood back. She was pale and old, with a sharp featured face, bright golden eyes, silvery hair that bloomed around her head as if she had never even heard of styling her hair. She had a few wrinkles here and there, but otherwise seemed quite healthy. She smirked slightly at Adora.

“You want some trash?” She asked, as the owl hopped up onto...onto her walking stick. That was the name that stuck stubbornly into Adora’s mind. But she knew it was not a walking stick. No walking stick was that long. No walking stick was so well carved. No walking stick...would have the owl settle into place, close its wings around its body, close its eyes and shimmer into *wood*. What had been flesh turned to smooth wood, and the woman, with the flier tucked under her arm, reached over and *twisted* the owl into place with a smooth click. And now her *walking stick* had an owl shaped head.

But it wasn’t a walking stick.

It was a staff.

“I-It’s not trash!” Adora said. “It’s, I, for me! That is! I...that’s my...mine.”

“Well, it’s trash in the human realm,” the woman said, chuckling as she did so, tucking her staff against her shoulder with a smirk, and sliding the rolled up parchment into a bag that hung near her hip which itself was full of more things that Adora recognized: A few magazines, a pair of glasses, a bra, other things buried beneath. Adora blinked at her.

“Human...we’re both human!” she said, hurrying after the woman as she walked towards the...the other door out of the house. Except it wasn’t a house. It was a tent. The floor was dirt. And when Adora turned back, she saw the doorway leading out to the familiar, orange and brown dusted woods of Gravesfield was

floating in the air, a solid two inches off the floor. She would have noticed, had she not dove through it. With a *click*, the door closed, then folded in on itself, snapping shut until it was nothing but a closed briefcase, which drifted through the air like…

Like magic.

...to the woman's hand. She snagged it from the air and gave her a toothy grin.

"Are we, blondie?" she asked, brushing her hair back to reveal that her ear had a single sharp point.

Adora's jaw dropped.

Then the woman slipped out of the tent flap, leaving her alone in the dimness.

Adora blinked several more times.

This is impossible. I've gone insane. Mom was right, I was gay, and thus, crazy. I have gone insane crazy gay! The kind of gay that makes you crazy!

She walked to the tent flap, then reached down and swept it up – and saw that she had, indeed, gone completely insane crazy gay. She was not in Gravesfield anymore. She was not in Connecticut

anymore. She was, in fact, not on *Earth* anymore. She was standing in a market stall, full of tents that had been set up with tables showing off wands, statues, paintings, gemstones, pulsating organs (wait, organs?), strange flowers, vines, captured beads of glass hanging suspended in flames, glowing potions, staves, robes, hats and what appeared to be floating balloons made up to look like eyeballs. Adora goggled at those – until one of the 'balloons' swung its iris around and glared at her.

"Eaugh!" Adora screamed and stumbled backwards into something broad and tall. She spun around and gaped at the huge, muscular and *very purple* woman glowering down at her. Adora wasn't sure if she should panic because she was mortal and killable or panic because she was very gay. She stepped back, stammering. "Sorry, sorry, sorry!"

"Hey, I wasn't complaining," the woman said, grinning.

"Huntra, back off!"

"Oh, I didn't know you had your eye on her, Eda the Owl Lady," Huntara said, grinning, while Adora spun around to see the old lady from before was gesturing her over. She rushed to her side, hissing.

"Where the *heck* am I?" she whispered.

“The Demon Realm,” Eda said, cheerfully. “Now, quiet, I need you for something.”

“Are you going to eat my soul!?” Adora asked, horrified.

“I, what? No!” Eda said, laughing. “I’m a *witch*, honey, not a demon.”

“Witches can eat souls too!” Adora squeaked.

“Well, I’m not gonna eat your soul, just...stand there. No, a little to the left.” Eda waggled her finger – and a spark of golden magic shimmered around her fingertip. She swirled a circle into the air – and then, with a flash, a table appeared from nowhere and the ground beneath Adora’s feet shifted, then rose an inch, then two. She yelped, flailing her arms, but managed to remain standing as she was hefted up above the crowd, while Eda tossed her various bits of trash out onto the table and spread her arms wide.

“Come one! Come all! And marvel at the artifacts...of the *Human Realm*! With one genuine, actual, factual, human! Watch as she demonstrates her eerie *human powers*!” Eda said, waving her hand wide. “What powers are those? Why you have to spend a snail to find out!”

People who had been drawn by the call were perked up by the promise. They started to walk forward, murmuring excitedly as Adora saw some were witches, like Eda. Some were *definitely* not witches, some were definitely not even remotely close to human.

One was a huge snail, for crying out loud. The snail waggled his eyestalks at her and spat a golden coin onto the table, which Eda picked up and started to wipe clean.

"I wanna see what cool powers a human has," the snail said, in matter of fact, totally understandable English. Adora had no idea why, but she just never expected a snail to know English.

"Well, show away, blondie!" Eda said.

Adora froze. Her brain whirled through every possibility she could think of. She stammered. "B-Behold!" She said, reaching into her pocket and yanking out her smartphone. "My...r...rectangle...of power!" She waggled it, terrified that the demons and witches would soon grow wrathful and furious at being scammed – since more of them were throwing in gold coins by the moment. The demons and witches kept blinking at her. "Uh, by the power of...Ge-Ohmm-Etry!" She said, holding it up and tapping randomly and blindly at the touchscreen, until the songs finally hit shuffle and it started to play *I Kissed A Girl And I Liked It* by Katy Perry.

"Uh, shoot, I didn't mean to play this song, sorry!" She stammered, while the crowd gasped and murmured in approval.

"I've never seen a rectangle do illusions!" A witch whispered.

"This song's catchy and faintly exploitative lyrics fill me with delight!" a demon exclaimed.

“Show us more abilities of your fearsome rectangle!” Another demon – this one short and horned – shouted, cupping his hands around his mouth.

“Heh, can I pick em or what?” Eda said, cheerfully, as the coins continued to pile up.

“You sure can...you can sure pick a quick route *to prison*!” A booming voice rang out, and a hand grabbed onto Eda’s wrist from just around the corner of her tent. A burly looking creature that might have been a demon or a witch – it was hard to tell, thanks to the conical face helmet-mask thing that Adora was fairly sure she had seen in a few historical textbooks. She blinked as the guard – for guard that had to be – hastily brought his hands around to snap a pair of gleaming, rune encrusted handcuffs around Eda’s wrists.

“Hey, no fair!” Eda exclaimed, her fingers sputtering with impotent sparks. She scowled. “You jerks were a lot more fun *before* the Golden Guard taught you how to *cheat*.”

“Hah!” The guard said.

Then Eda slammed her heel into his foot. He had a thick boot, but her foot drove home with enough strength to make him jerk backwards and yank his foot up. He clutched it and shouted – while Eda...sung her hands around and knelt down then stood up again. Somehow, her hands were in-front of her now, while still

being manacled. Adora hadn't quite seen how she had managed it, but before she could leap to help, Eda bonked the guard in the head, then bonked him again with the staff, sending him down. Then she tossed the staff out with a little 'hup!' and it…

Hovered in the air.

Adora realized she needed to stopped being shocked by this.

"Now, lets just...get this off…" Eda muttered, looking down at her wrists.

Two more guards were coming towards her, the crowd starting to draw back, gasping in shock and alarm – though, for one thing: Katy Perry had stopped playing. In its place was *When Worlds' Collide* by Powerman 5,000. The lyrics started driving as Adora realized two things with a bright flash of inspiration. The first?

She was either crazy, or she was actually in another world – and if she was in another world, then she had a duty to do what she could to help.

The second?

She *could help*. She stepped forward, put her foot on the prone and groaning guard, grabbed onto his hilt, and drew his sword with a quick rasp. The shining blade was light in her hand and felt

exactly how she expected it too. She gripped it in both hands as Eda laughed, then tossed her handcuffs away. "Eat slugs, Golden Jerk!" she said, sounding pleased, while the two guards rushed forward, shouting war cries at the top of their lungs.

To Adora's shock, everything she had been taught about swords did *not* immediately fly out of her head. She parried one strike, dodged from another, then brought the pommel around to bonk the other guy in the nose. His nose-armor crumpled with a squeal of metal and he stumbled backwards. But then the other swung at her belly, and Adora realized she was not fast enough to bring her arm down to parry. But then she saw his sword sweeping under her feet. Then she saw him shrink, becoming smaller as she blinked.

She looked up, and saw that Eda had dragged her up onto the back of her staff. And she was flying.

She was *flying*.

She was flying in the air!

On a staff!

"You think you can get away!?" The guard shouted. "Just because you can fly!? Huh!? Well…" his voice faded as Adora screamed and threw her arms around Eda, squeezing herself to her back. "...you

can! Does that make you happy? Satisfied? I hope so, Owl Lady! I *hope* so!”

His voice faded to nothingness.

The village beneath them – more a town, really – was surrounded by thick forests. Clouds bloomed overhead. The colors were all subtly wrong, done in shades of purples, blues, oranges and greens that were all so *faintly* incorrect, save for when they were extremely incorrect. A mountain rose to the south, and another to the south east, with clouds drifting by around them, snow dusting around them. To the north, there was more clouds – but she swore she could see an even huger mountain that way. It had a strange...shape. Her brow furrowed, then she yelped as the staff dove. She hastily tucked her sword under her arm, to free up her hands to more firmly grab onto Eda.

“Normally, I’d be giving you a fun introduction to the Demon Realm, blondie-”

“Adora!” Adora shouted.

“Hey, I don’t know you that well,” Eda said, laughing. “But we need to get out of here and go to ground *before* the Guard shows up.”

“Why?” Adora asked, clinging to her. “Is he trouble?”

“He?” Eda asked.

A shimmer of light crackled ahead of them – a flash of bright red, which *snapped* into the shape of a robed figure. Pale white robes, sleek golden mask, gloved hands, their body was entirely covered. They rode a sleek staff of a subtly different design as Eda’s – and they threw their arm wide, and a burst of flames exploded into the air between Eda and her route of escape. Eda pulled him, skidding into the air and coming to a stop as the mysterious figure laughed. Their voice was definitely female.

“Owl Lady!”

“Golden Guard,” Eda said, sounding annoyed.

“Ohh, it’s a *girl* guard,” Adora whispered.

“You’ve stuck your head in the noose often enough…” The Guard said, standing up onto her broom. Her mask, Adora noticed, had tiny cat ears carved into it – and...ah, she had a cat tail as well, sweeping behind her. Oh. Wait. That was literally a cat’s tail, not a costume cat tail. A cat demon!? She blushed, hard, as the cat-demon stood on her flying staff without a single sign of concern, despite the hundred plus foot drop beneath her. “You know, the Emperor *really* has been as generous as possible – but even his patience is running thin.”

She shrugged, palms up. “One of these days, he’s gonna send me and the Coven Heads and Kiks and Lilith and every guard he’s got all to take you down, and I really doubt you’ll manage so well then.”

“Heh, I’d like to see you even *find* me,” Eda said, smirking at the guard.

“Yeah, man, where would the Owl Lady live! Could it possibly be the *Owl House*. The Owl House right over there?” The Guard pointed back at a clearing in the woods, where a several story house had been established. Even from a distance, it looked...homey. Welcoming. Adora bit her lip, then tensed as she readied herself to…

She wasn’t sure.

Throw herself at the Golden Guard when she had a chance? So far, the Guard hadn’t paid much attention to her.

“Okay, finding me, easy! *Getting* to me, that’s a little trickier,” Eda said, chuckling as she did so, her arms crossed over her chest as she used her knees to keep the staff steady.

“I mean, I can always just burn down the forest,” the Golden Guard said, dryly.

Eda frowned. “And piss off the entirety of Bonesburrough? The Emperor can’t afford to alienate his subjects like that.”

“Oh wow! You’re *right*! It’s totally impossible to just, like, *lie* to the bunch of gormless rubes!” The Golden Guard laughed, her voice high and...and...Adora’s brow furrowed. Despite the fact they were hovering, steadily in the air, her stomach dropped out from under her. She craned her head around Eda’s shoulder – and barely noticed the faint wet *plop* of something landing in her hands. She looked down and froze as she suddenly realized how Eda the Owl Lady had gotten out of her restraints.

Her *hand* had fallen off. It was now in her hand, with a tiny bony stump sticking out of the base, like a cartoon. Adora’s eyes widened and she opened her mouth, frozen so completely in shock and revulsion she didn’t even scream.

“What, you’ll blame me?” Eda asked, frowning as the hand twitched its fingers in a little ‘throw’ gesture.

“...yeah, basically,” the Golden Guard said. “Evil Wild Witch Edalynn Clawthorne burns down Bonesburrough woods in wild magic gone wild. Seems pretty simple to me. Or, alternatively, you-”

The hand had moved.

The hand had moved.

The *hand* had moved!

Adora's entire body was filled with the paralytic terror that overcame anyone when they were holding a detached, disembodied hand and were suddenly aware that said hand was not merely dead flesh, but undead flesh, moving and squirming. The screaming, crawling horrors she remembered from *The Good Witch Azura Book Five: The Tomb of the Terrifying Tentacles* exploded inside of Adora's brain and she let out an all mighty *eaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaauuuuuuuuugh* as she threw the hand as hard as she could. It whistled through the air and slammed directly into the Golden Guard's mask.

"Augh!" The Golden Guard exclaimed, flailing at the hand, jerking one leg up – her other foot kept remarkable balance as Adora noticed, with surprise, that while her hands were gloved, her feet were actually mostly bare. Her arms flailed wildly, and she drew out a fluttering piece of paper, then slapped it against her own mask moments before Eda shot forward. She snatched her own hand off the Golden Guard seconds before the parchment flash – then exploded with a crack of bursting fire. The Golden Guard was flung off her staff and plunged towards the trees.

"Serves her right, little psycho-" Eda said.

The Golden Guard thrust out her palm, made a twisting motion, and her staff whistled around, flew down, and she landed on it with her feet, her tail slashing through the air and her ears pinned back. She banked up like she was riding a surfboard, her staff meeting their level as she skimmed up and then drew another

collection of papers, which each flashed, then turned into blue spikes. She punched each one and each shot directly at Adora and Eda. Eda yelped – but Adora snapped the sword up that she had kept tucked near her arm this whole time.

The ice – for ice it was – struck her sword and exploded.

Then they were over the clearing. The Golden Guard hissed, then froze. She stopped, as Eda skidded to a stop with a triumphant laugh.

For a moment, all three of them were still in the air as Adora looked into the Golden Guard's mask.

"...Adora?" the Golden Guard whispered.

Adora's stomach flipped six times over. She blinked, then reached tenderly out. Her fingers touched the mask, sliding it up, and up, revealing slender lips, revealing orange-brown skin, revealing familiar blue and green eyes.

Kat and Adora looked at one another for the first time since 2016.

And then a hideous monstrous owl head burst from the ground, beak swallowing Kat from her ankles to her head in a single ferocious gulp. Her squalling voice vanished into the ground as a lump traveled along the owl head, into the tube-shaped body that

protruded from the ground. The owl, his face stupid and simple, looked directly into Adora's eyes. Then he coughed up the Golden Guard mask and said. "Hi Adora! I'm Hooty! Hoot Hoot!"

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Edalynn tossed her staff onto a rack, waved her hand to bright to life every magical glowglobe in the entire house, and then flung herself down onto the couch in the center of the room. "Woof!" She said, her head resting against her pillow, her eyes half closed. "I'm *beat*. It didn't use to be this hard, ya know?" She asked, while Adora stumbled, shell shocked, into the interior of the Owl House. She blinked several times.

"I-Is Kat dead?" she asked.

"You mean Catra?" Eda asked. "Nah, I try and not kill teenagers. Even twerps working for big dumb jerk like Belos." She sighed, quietly. "Hooty will vomit her up in a digestive cocoon a few miles away and she'll be able to break out and, hopefully, run home with her tail between her legs. Not many people want to try the Hooty express, I'll tell you that."

Adora sagged with relief. She slumped, then leaned against the door, skidding down it with a whump.

"...wait, you know Catra? The Golden Guard?" Eda asked, sitting up. "The Rune Witch? The Cat Demon that has been working for

Belos?”

“Y-Yeah!” Adora said. “Except she’s *none* of those things. Her name is Kat Weaver, she’s...she...we…” She looked down. “We were friends.”

“Wait, that’s a human name,” Eda said, slowly, her eyes narrowing.

“That’s what I’m saying, Eda! Kat was my friend! From the *human realms*. She’s a human being, like me! At least, I thought she was. No, she is. She was!” Adora flushed. “We were the best friends. We used to do everything together. She was an orphan, and...and I had lost my dad…” She looked aside. “But my mom got convinced that we were...ya know…”

“No, what?” Eda asked.

Adora blushed. Hard. She didn’t want to keep explaining, but…

She supposed she owed Eda. Eda had brought her here – and that meant, she had brought her to where she could finally do something she had always wanted to do. She had brought her to where she could *make up* to Kat. She had to find a way to fix this. To fix them. She lifted her chin, her cheeks blushing.

“She thought we were...lesbians,” she said.

Eda blinked at her, arms still cocked behind her head.

"And?" she asked.

"And that's bad!" Adora exclaimed.

"You don't want to be lesbians? But girls are amazing!" Eda said.

"I think that...yes, I know! But...the...it's...there's…" Adora wasn't even sure how to explain it. She looked down at her knees. Then, slowly, Eda reached into her pocket, taking out the Young Republicans flier. She held it out between thumb and forefinger, waggling it. "Let me guess, these guys are still as lame as they were when that guy was around."

"Which guy?" Adora asked.

"Ya know. Big nose? I'm not a crook?" Eda said.

"Oh, uh, Bush, I think," Adora said, frowning.

"Yeah, Bush, that guy," Eda said, nodding. "Well, here in the Boiling Isles, no one cares what kind of anyone you kiss. Well, unless you're a guard working for the Conformatorium and Belos.

Then they kinda do care, a lot.” She shook her head. “Sucks, doesn’t it?”

“That doesn’t make any sense!” Adora exclaimed, springing to her feet. “Kat is...she...we…” She blushed. “I thought she was...like me. But what if she wasn’t? Maybe that’s why…” Her finger went to the scar on her eyebrow. The scar that Kat had given her, the day that they had never seen eachother again. She whispered. “Oh no, what if it’s all my fault?” She started to pace. “I’m why Kat ran away! I’m why she ended up here, in the demon realm! And I’m why she’s working for Belos! If it wasn’t for me, I-”

“Whoa, slow down kiddo,” Eda said, holding up her palm, stemming the tide of Adora’s words. “Tell me what happened. No judgments here.” She sighed. “We’ve all made mistakes in our past around here, in the Owl House?”

“Even Hooty?” Adora whispered.

“Especially Hooty!” Eda said, chuckling.

Adora sighed. She walked over, then took one of the comfy chairs. She sat down.

“We were at the Pure n’ Straight summer camp for confused girls,” Adora whispered. “I smuggled some...books there. Books I wasn’t supposed to have. But when they were found, they were near to Kat’s bed, and so she got blamed for it. The councilors made her do all the punishment stuff, and...and she ran away, crying, right

into the rainstorm. Because I didn't say anything." She closed her eyes. "I was...I let her take the fall for it."

"How old were you?" Eda asked.

"Twelve," Adora whispered.

"Twelve!?" Eda exploded. "Honey, darling, Adora, you...what on the bones of the Titan makes you think that you need to make every right decision when you're *twelve*. And what kind of fun summer camp makes a twelve year old feel so bad that they run away into boiling rain!?"

"W-Well, it wasn't boiling," Adora whispered, her voice choked as she sniffled and wiped at her nose. "B-But, uh…" She blinked. "The camp was to make us not gay."

"Oh," Eda said. "Who sent you?"

"My mom…" Adora whispered, looking down at her snotty hand, forlornly.

"So. Let me get this straight," Eda said, her eyes narrowing. "When you were twelve, your *Mom* packed you off to the Conformatorium because you like kissing girls – and then made *you* feel like *you* were at fault because a girl tried to *escape* from being tortured into being straight?" She stood, scowling. "Remind

me of this next time I visit the Human Realms so I can commit some *arson*."

"Oh who!?" Adora asked.

"We'll let that be Eda's little secret for now," Eda said, smirking. "But for now? Say goodbye to your old mom, Adora Human Girl!"

"My name is Gray, Adora Gray," Adora said.

"And say goodbye...to your *new* mom!" Eda slung her arm around Adora, yanking her to her feet and holding her close. "Edalyn, the Owl Woman and your adoptive, but still smoking hot, mom!"

"Buh!?" Adora stammered, flailing her arm wildly.

TO BE CONTINUED

Adora Gray And Making Rent

Chapter Summary

Catra gets some new assistants. Adora gets a job!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The castle of Emperor Belos sat in the heart of the Boiling Isles – a foreboding, dark place of fire, brimstone, and barely restrained magic. A smokestack like pillar rose from the heart of the castle, loosing thin streamers of flames and soot into the air periodically, while the fluttering banners of the Belosian Empire caught the hot breeze and shifted against the walls. The guards of the Emperor's Coven stood at attention at the gate, and patrolled along the walls.

Within the castle's corridors, there was one creature who was one step below Belos in terms of power, influence, control.

Said creature kept a secret, buried deep inside her tiny head.

The next step after one remains zero.

Kikimora tented her fingers.

Well, maybe a fraction could-

The front gates of the castle opened with a roaring *crash* and the Golden Guard came stomping in, her tail dragging and her mask off. Her face was splattered with muck, mud, and bits of stringy bile, while her short cropped hair was stringy with a kind of thick, cocoon like substance. She growled and tugged at some of it as she started to walk down the corridor, clearly about to pass Kikimora without noticing the tiny demon was there.

"Ahem."

The Golden Guard sighed, then glowered down at her. "Yes, what?"

Kikimora narrowed the one of her eyes that was visible – her hand-hair remained clasped around her head in a sweeping curve of flesh, concealing a good portion of her face, while her high collared robes did for the rest of it. The Golden Guard scowled, then stood a bit straighter.

"Yes, what is it, Kikimora?" she asked, her voice not even approaching respectful.

"You were out on patrol. Now, you're three hours behind schedule and covered in *slime*." Kikimora frowned behind her collar. "Explain yourself."

“Sometimes, teen girls like me just love to roll around in muck for no reason, Kikimora, check on Penstagram, everyone’s just *wild* for it!” She waggled her hands mockingly as she started to stalk away, her shoulders hunched and irritated.

“You ran into The Owl Lady, didn’t you?” Kikimora asked, her voice smug as she walked after Catra. “After so much braggadocio-”

“Someone’s been in the dictionaries,” Catra muttered under her breath.

“-and you have nothing to show for it. What would the Emperor say, if he was to hear this.”

“I don’t know, Kikimora,” Catra said, then turned and glowered down at her. “What would Lilith say if she heard that you were trying to interfere in Emperor Coven business?” She smirked, slightly. “Last time I checked, Lilith was in charge. You run *bureaucracy.* Not covens.”

Kikimora narrowed her eyes. “You presume much, Golden Guard.”

Catra snorted. “And you talk too much, Kiks.”

“Don’t call me Kiks!” Kikimora growled, but Catra was already stalking off – flicking a bit of slime she picked from her hair and straight into Kikimora’s face.

The urge to rush off and tell Belos was overwhelming. But Kikimora forced herself to wait. Be patient. There were other ways to get her revenge on the arrogant, stuck up foundling that Belos had showered with such acclaim. She had been welcomed into a Coven, without even casting magic *properly*. Kikimora shook her head.

I have a better way to get revenge… She thought. *All it takes is a stamp.*

She, in fact, went to her office, pulled down the papers, hummed cheerfully as she started to white out the large **REJECTED** word in the box. Once she had finished, she examined the papers closely, to make sure everything was just as it should be. She nodded, then brought her stamp down with a huge *whump*. Green text – **APPROVED –** snapped up in the box next to the picture of a smiling, white haired demoness who was trying to wave at the camera midway through getting her coven ID picture taken.

Kikimora, behind her collar, smirked.

Her eye shifted to the other paper, which had six different **REJECTED** red marks on it, several printed across the witchling's face so that the only thing visible was her bright purple hair.

A light touch, she thought to herself. *A light touch is what is needed for Catra.*

Then she grabbed the other paper and started stamping **APPROVED** over every single red mark, cackling to herself as she applied her stamp with malicious will.

***

Catra stood in the shower, watching the last bits of grime and gunk slide off her body and down the drain. The pouring, hot water – spelled into existence in the basement of the castle and pumped through pipes of brass and steel – continued along her shoulders and soaked the base of her neck. Her clawed fingers dug into the tile wall as she clenched her teeth. Tears pricked at the corners of her eyes. She would not cry.

She would not let Adora Grey make her cry.

She *refused*.

Why can't I have anything? She thought. *Six years. I had six years, clawing my way into a real life, and Adora comes in...and she...she...*She closed her eyes. Adora didn't have anything. She'd been clinging to the back of the Owl Lady's staff, like some...some rube. Some total mark. Catra brushed her fingers through her hair, sighing as she felt the pulsing, pounding rage at her temples subside, as she felt the thumping in her chest slow.

Adora is not going to win this.

She nodded to herself.

No. I'm going to win this.

Six years. Six years and she had been back at the camp again, looking at Adora's face. The memories were murky, and full of confusion – things skipped around, the color was always washed out, sometimes the voices were muted and distant. It was hard to remember anything before she woke up in the hospital, the Emperor kneeling beside her, asking her where she had come from. She had thought, at first, that he was just a weird Jesus freak – but slowly, she had realized he had no idea what or who Jesus was.

That…

That he'd never hurt her.

He had taken her under his wing. He had shown her magic, and he had been so...so impressed with how *quickly* she understood it. Those early lessons, it had been as if the world itself was falling over to teach her, and the whole way, she had cast every spell with a fierce, abiding joy.

I can do it. And you can't, Adora.

She turned the water off, then grabbed for a towel, her claws blindly scrabbling outside of the fogged glass that blocked off the shower.

"Here ya go!"

She snatched the towel from the helpful wall hanging that had shifted clos-

"WHA!"

Catra leaped and landed on the very top of the shower, her feet planted on the corner edges of the stall, her back almost smashing into the tile roof. She swung the very thick towel around herself to somewhat protect her modesty, and glowered down at the figure standing in the bathroom. It was a public bathroom – one of the showers used by the Emperor's Coven after missions, but she had made sure every single freaking member of the Coven, Lonnie, Kyle, Rogellio, *all* of them, that she was never, ever, *ever* to be disturbed and because *she* was the Golden Guard, they *freaking listened*.

The woman standing in the shower wore the uniform of the Emperor's Coven.

But Catra didn't recognize her.

She was tall, taller than even Lilith – and unlike Lilith, she was as broad as she was tall, her muscular body filling out the uniform like a champ. She had a wide jaw, black lips, white hair, and a completely poleaxed expression on her face. Her arms ended not in hands, but demonic claws, and a scorpion tail whipped up around from her back, hanging over her shoulder.

"Whoa!" she exclaimed. "Where'd you go!?"

"I'm up here, idiot!" Catra snapped, then hopped down off the shower wall, landing behind her, scowling as she swept her towel tighter around her body. The girl turned to face her – then blushed. Hard. She looked up and left, rubbing the back of her neck with one claw. "What, you've never seen a girl before?" Catra's voice dripped acid sarcasm.

"Not a girl as pretty as you, no!" The girl exclaimed, her cheeks burning. "I mean, did I say pretty? I meant...intimating! And...and scary! Hoo! Uh! I'm...I'm really not...this...my name is Scorpia!"

"Wow, did it take you all week to come up with that?" Catra snapped before she could stop herself. The Boiling Isles convention of naming people stuff that was extremely obvious, especially held true among demonic members of the Isles, sometimes made her human born sensibilities rankle.

"But aren't you Catra, the Golden Guard?" Scorpia asked.

"...why are you here!?" Catra asked, glowering at her.

"I'm your new second in command, sir! Ma'am! That is, uh, Cat'am! Ca...ca...M...Ma'm, I'll stick with Ma'am, Ma'am is...is…" Scorpia tapped her claws together as Catra gaped at her.

"Who says!?" She exclaimed.

"Oh, the transfer papers got stamped today, sir!" Socpria said. "I rushed on over, then I asked that big lizardy guy-"

Catra scowled, then threw her towel aside. She started to yank on her uniform as Scorpia's explanations trailed off into a confused stammering 'buahm...bhah...uh…' - but then Catra was out the door of the shower, and Scorpia was following after her. She shook her head. "W-Wow, you're brave. I've never met anyone so fearless!" Scorpia's eyes shone. "Is that why you're the best of the Coven? I should be taking notes!"

Catra ignored her as she headed for the offices near the back of the barracks. She pushed the door inwards with a *crash* and stomped in. "Titandamn it, Lilith, what the heck is this!?" She thrust her palm at Catra.

Lilith Clawthorne, the head of the Emperor's Coven and one of the most powerful witches on the Boiling Isles, did not even have a

single hair out of place. The entire office could have exploded and she would have been entirely placid in the face of Catra's anger. She looked from her to Scorpia, then back to Catra. "Ah, Kikimora has approved the transfer," she said, her voice dry. "Took her long enough. Though, I was expecting one of the other candidates."

"Oh…" Scorpia looked unsure.

"Guard Scorpia, it's quite all right. You would not be up for consideration if you weren't of value," Lilith said, standing from behind her desk. "But Catra, the Emperor and I have been in discussion for some time – your independent operations are impressive...but you're beginning to run up against some of the most dangerous criminal elements on the Boiling Isles. Pirates. Demon Hunters." She paused. "My sister."

Catra repressed a shudder. Not so much at the memory of Edalyn...more…

That hideous tube.

Lilith pursed her lips. "It was agreed you would need some, to be blunt, muscle."

"Oh, that's me! I got loads of muscle," Scorpia said. "We scorpion demons have the proportional strength of ant demons! Which is a *lot*, let me tell you, sir! Ma'am!"

“Quite,” Lilith said. “And, furthermore, I will not be the head of the Emperor’s Coven forever.” She smirked. “And when I am gone, you will need to prove that you have the ability to command. The ability to lead. The ability to plan, and direct, and manage logistics, and all the other things a coven head does.” She said, reaching out and placing her hand on Catra’s shoulder. Catra flushed – then what Lilith said actually penetrated. Her jaw dropped.

“M-Me?” she whispered. “Head of…”

“Not for a while, no, I am not quite an old biddy yet, but…” Lilith chuckled. “I figure after my sister has been captured, we’ll have a lot to do…”

She shrugged.

Catra blushed, then looked at Scorpia, who was trying to look like a big old...puppy dog. Catra sighed. *It feels weird being the only person who gets Earth references,* she thought.

“...fine,” Catra said. “But if you slow me down, you’re dead.”

“Wow!” Scorpia exclaimed. “This is a way healthier work relationship than I expected.”

Catra sighed. "I can handle one annoying under-"

The ceiling lights flickered. Lilith frowned, lifting her brows as she looked up at the ceiling. "Something is wrong," she said, quietly, then gestured with one hand. Catra nodded, turned, grabbed her mask from her pocket and slipped it over her face, while Scorpia hurried after her out of the room, her claws clacking as she tried to get her mask anywhere near her features. She was still bouncing it back and forth as the two of them came around the corner of the third sub-basement level, to find that the reason why the lights were dimming was because a witchling was standing next to a large power conduit, the metal bracing open and her hair was reaching inside of it.

No.

Not her *hair*.

Catra blinked as she realized the witchling's hair had the slightly slick, glistening texture of an abomination's goo. It was yanking a valve up and down, and as she manipulated the conduit, the girl turned around to reveal that she was wearing a modified Coven Guard mask, with glowing red eye-holes that made her look quite a bit more intimidating than even the best masked, best armed members of the Guard.

Catra gaped at her, while the witchling flipped her mask up, revealing youthful, light brown features with purple eyebrows and bright purple eyes. She lifted a small scroll to her lips and spoke into it. "Log Update, Supplemental – the magical conduit is

definitely using some form of construction magic to channel energy from the deeper parts of the Titan's dessicated flesh to the magitech constructs in the palace. I think if I could just take apart *more* of it, or maybe examine the Heart of our dead god then I could learn how this magic is transmuted and transformed from generalized wild magic into a useful coven style magic! There also appears to be an angry cat-demon looking at me and Scorpia! Hi Scorpia!" She waved at Scorpia with one of her hands, then continued speaking into her scroll. "Reminder: Scorpia is the tall one, possibly with the scorpion tail."

"What are you *doing*!?" Catra hissed, walking over and slashing the goopy strand of hair off of the witchling's head. The disconnected chunk splattered to the floor and the girl looked mildly bemused before she twirled her finger, flashing a tiny magical circle into existence – a moment later, her hair regrew with a soft *splort* noise.

"Experimenting!" The girl said. "Oh! Wait! Are you…" She rubbed her chin, then looked at the scroll, tapping a few times, then brought up a recording of her voice.

"Note to future Entrapta: Your new...thingy...the thing that...the people who tell you what to do who you later forget, look up the name later!" The recording said. Entrapta blinked, then tapped a few times at her scroll, and then a *different* recording – this one sounding as if she was running at the time, with the sound of tinny explosions ringing out in the background – played: "Boss! The word is boss!"

"Ooooh!" Entrapta said, then tapped at her scroll again – and Catra snatched it from her hand, crumpling it, then throwing it

into the pipe, where the thrumming pulse of yellow energy burst it into flames.

"Who. Approved. Your. Transfer?" Catra growled.

"Well, probably Kikimora, she approved everyone's transfers, since she's the head of bureaucracy, right?" Scorpia said, as Entrapta blinked at her with clear confusion.

"Transfer? To what?" she asked.

"The Emperor's Coven! You're in an Emperor's Coven uniform!" Catra said, pointing at Entrapta.

"Oh yeahhhh!" Entrapta exclaimed. "It's cause they get to use every kind of magic!" her eyes glittered as she spun around. "Construction magic to build fortifications, abomination magic to create machines, divination magic to know what new kinds of machines to build when the old machines stop working, plant magic to...to…" She hesitated. "Oh, you could make fuel from plants, for the machines!"

Catra put her hands over her face, her mask sliding half off her face in her frustration.

"You like machines, huh?" Scorpia asked. "Well, wildcat here, she's our boss, so you better make machines for her."

“Oh, I can make a chewtoy!” Entrapta said.

“That’s *dogs*!” Catra shouted.

“What’s a dog?” Entrapta asked, blinking at her.

“Ah, there you three are.”

Lilith was advancing down the corridor towards them, with Kikimora at her side. Lilith arched a single eyebrow, then smiled ever so slightly as Catra hastily slammed the conduit shut and then stood at attention. Her tiny little nod and the faint sparkle in her eyes made Catra feel slightly less like clawing Entrapta’s eyes out.

Slightly.

“Now that you’ve met your team,” Kikimora said, her voice oh so official. “We have a mission for you, Golden Guard.”

“Sure, Kiks, what is it?” Catra asked, leaning against the conduit, as if she was not annoyed at all, her tail snaking left and right behind her. She didn’t glance back to make sure it wasn’t bristling. It was flat and straight because she was damned if she was going

to let Kikimora win this little...exchange. Kikimora let out a quiet growl – but Lilith took over for the briefing.

"The Emperor's Coven is at the forefront of ensuring that wild magic and criminals are handled. Well, there happens to be an individual that we need apprehended and arrested, for engaging in a certain amount of…" Lilith considered. "...chicanery."

"Oooh, chicanery!" Scorpia sai1d, excitedly, her claws clicking together.

"Who is it, ma'am?" Catra asked.

Lilith smiled. "His name is Adegast." She twitched her finger and a glowing flare of blue magic snapped into existance before Catra. She held out her hand and caught the scroll she had summoned in her palm – with an image of Adegast on one side and a map to his hovel on the other, and a list of crimes.

Catra nodded. "Got it, ma'am!" she said, saluting Lilith, who inclined her head, then turned and wlaked off. Once she was out of sight, Catra groaned.

"What's wrong?" Scorpia asked. "We get to take down a big bad demon criminal, wildcat!"

“Firstly, don’t call me that!” Catra said, holding up her finger. “And secondly...there’s someone else I want to *deal* with and this Adegast is nowhere near-”

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“-the Owl House!” Eda said, her arms spreading as she twirled around the final room. “And that’s the final step of the tour, what do you think, kiddo?”

Adora blinked as she looked around the narrow closet, with the tiny window that showed an oceanic view of bubbling seas and a distant, rising mountain that looked, for all the world, like the vast bent knee of a corpse.

“I just have a few questions, ma’am,” she said.

“Eda, please, don’t call me ma’am. I’m not old enough to be a…” Eda paused, then started to count her fingers, one by one, thinking as she did so. “...oh Titan, I am old.” She shook her head, slightly, while Adora grinned and walked over to the window. She looked out at the glimmering seas, then turned back to face Eda.

“This place is amazing,” she whispered. “But, uh, do you own a dog?”

“What?” Eda asked. “No, of course not, that’s-”

She stopped short, then pinched the bridge of her nose. “King! King, get out here, meet your new roomie!” She called out. Adora blinked and stepped away from the windowsill...then drew in a breath so sharp and so fast that she nearly choked on thin air. She thrust her finger at the figure looming in the doorway.

“What. Is. That?!” She squeaked.

The *that* in this question was about two feet tall and covered in soft looking black fur. He had claws and paws, and a tiny little fluffy tail, and a kind of bony skull that covered the entire upper part of his head, with bright yellow and pink eyes, and two thick horns that protruded from the top of his head. One was cracked in half.

Adora squealed and then grabbed the adorable little guy up, then hugged him tightly. “Oh my god, he’s so cute!” She gasped. He wriggled and squirmed, arms flailing.

“Hey! Put me down!” he exclaimed, which caused Adora to scream and drop him. Her hands grabbed her face.

“Oh no! Have I gone crazy? Am I hearing voices? Or did I get the ability to talk to animals?” She hissed to Eda, who cackled.

“He’s not an animal, Adora,” Eda said. “This is King!”

“I am the mighty King of Demons,” King said, his voice full of haughty pride as he used his forepaws to brush his fur back to flatness.

Adora blinked, crouching down and cocking her head. “You...don’t look like Asmodeus.”

“Asmo-what?” King asked.

“Uh...nothing! Nevermind!” Adora said, chuckling nervously. “Just a dumb, uh, Earth thing. I’m from Earth. By the way. A human!”

King sniffed at her curiously, then let out a soft ‘humf!’

“You don’t *smell* like a human,” he said. “I always kinda expected them to smell more edible.”

Adora blinked and looked down at her arm – while Eda frowned. “Hey! No eating your adoptive roommate.”

“Roommate!?” King asked, his voice shocked. “I thought *I* was your only roommate. How is she even going to pay rent if she’s a

human?”

“*You* don’t pay rent,” Eda said, her hands on her hips.

“We have to pay rent? Is there rent?” Adora asked, standing up.

“Wellllll…” Eda said, considering. “Kinda. But you don’t have to pay rent right this second. The Owl House is running on a pretty thin budget – see, I make potions and sell them for a tidy profit. It’s just the Golden Guard and her goons running around makes it tricky for me to sell everything.” She considered. “But you are a newbie. And a human. So, if you keep your head down, and I make trouble elsewhere, you can sell my potions and we can have enough food to eat.”

Adora nodded. “Of course, right away!” she said.

“Whoa, wait, hold up,” King said. “You’re just going to do it? Just cause she asked?”

“Yeah, why not?” Adora asked. “It has to get done, I’m here, I can do it.”

Eda and King both blinked at her, looking as if they had never heard something like that before in their lives. Adora blushed, slowly, while Eda nodded. “King, you go with her,” she said, firmly.

“Weh!?” The noise King made when he was shocked was so adorable that Adora almost melted right then and there. “Why me?”

“She’s so obviously easily manipulated and trusting that anyone will be able to lead her off into some deadly peril or something,” Eda said, shaking her head and grabbing King by the scruff of his neck, then planting his furry belly on Adora’s red jacketed shoulder. Adora froze, her eyes wide as she felt his weight – slight, and warm, like a cat. Her cheeks flushed even more as excitement completely overwrote her immediate reaction of being offended.

“Oh my god,” she whispered. “He’s on my should! Just like Azura the Good Witch’s familiar!”

“Uuuuugh!” King groaned.

Eda gave him a big thumbs up.

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Adora mentally ran through the checklist that Eda had given her again and again with every step she took away from the Owl House, while King crawled around on her shoulder, then slipped under her jacket collar and landed in one of the huge pockets she had in the inner vest. There, his head peeking out of her collar, he settled happily as she muttered under her breath. “Don’t drop bottles, don’t take refunds, don’t trust anyone in a bathrobe and

slippers…" She frowned. "Who might be wearing a bathrobe and slippers?"

"I dunno, anyone," King said. Then, curiously, he asked her. "What's that?"

"What's what?" Adora asked, her hands shifting as she kept the huge bag of potions she was lugging over her other shoulder from shifting. She crossed her eyes, trying to see where King was pointing.

"That! That thingy!" He pointed more.

Adora craned her head. "Uh, my hair?" she asked, nervously.

"Why does it *do* that, though?"

"D-Do what?" She asked, taking one hand off the bag, patting her hair nervously. "It just, it's just like that!"

"I guess humans are just weird," King said, shaking his head, as Adora patted her hand back from her curl to her pony tail, her cheeks burning. She was so distracted by this that she nearly walked face first into a wall – but instead she hopped to the side and entered into Bonesburrough on foot – the forest fading behind her as the hustle and bustle of the town surrounded her. Adora looked around with wide eyes, tensed and half ready for

the guards to leap on her...but other than give her a few curious looks, most people seemed more interested in their own business.

I wish I had a sword, Adora thought to herself, while she rummaged in her pocket and pulled out the crumpled set of directions Eda had given her. She started to follow the first, muttering under her breath. "Don't drop bottles, don't take refunds, I- hey, wait, King, can you hold these dire-" The space ahead of her, visible around her directions, was suddenly filled with a person. "-waah!" She skidded to a stop, her feet kicking out from under her, but managed to grab onto the wall of a building to stop herself...and blinked as she saw a luminously beautiful girl, about her age, walking across the street, her nose in a book. She had green hair, pointed ears – like other witchfolk – and was...was…

"Pretty…" Adora whispered.

The girl jerked her head away from her book, then shot Adora a look filled with what can only be described as contempt.

"...pretty...nice! Day...we're...hay-ving!" Adora stammered, forgetting how to pronounce words in her panic. "...do you want a potion?"

The girl let out the most discouraging noise that anyone could ever make – a soft *tsch*! - and then turned and kept walking. Adora sagged against the nearest wall, whispering. "King. Kill me. Please."

“Okay!” he said, then lifted his claws. “Wait, wait, not until we sell the potions, or else Eda will kill me.”

Adora peeked around the corner. Now that she was looking lower than the girl’s face, she saw she was in a neat, trim uniform - gray-black on the chest and tunic, with purple hose for leggings and arms. Softly, she whispered. “Is that a school uniform?”

“Yeah, I think there’s a bubbling crock-pot of teenage hormones and dumb love triangles called Hexside near here,” King said. “Why?”

“Double kill me!” Adora whispered as she leaned back around the corner. “I just told the most popular girl at school-”

“You don’t know if she’s popular,” King pointed out.

“-that she was pretty, she’s going to think I’m a freaking big dumb lesbian!” Adora groaned.

“You are, though,” King said, proving that despite having only met Adora an hour before, he did know her intimately.

Adora closed her eyes. “Lets just. I’m never going to Hexside, right?”

“Not unless you want to learn to cast magic,” King said. “Which you can’t and don’t want to, so, you’ll never even run into this girl and her dumb book!” He flipped his hand dismissively. “Now, continue, my crimson chariot! Onwards, to you doing all the work while I lay around in your pocket.”

“Right. Right.” Adora nodded. “How do you cast magic, anyway?”

“Witches have a bile gland near their heart, I think,” King said. “Some demons too.”

“Huh.” Adora blinked. “Well, then, definitely not learning that.”

She started to walk, then frowned.

Then how did Kat cast magic? She was definitely throwing magic at us?

“What about the Golden Guard?” she asked.

“I mean, she’s a cat demon, cat demons got bile glands,” King said, eyes closing as he did so. “Simple.”

Adora frowned, but didn't contradict him.

She did, after all, have potions to deliver.

And, hopefully, she'd never, ever, ever, ever, ever meet the green haired girl again.

Ever.

***

The first door that Adora delivered potions too tried to eat her arm – the doorbell opened and sucked her in at the wrist and only by kicking the door as hard as she could could she wrench her hand free. The second turned out to not be a door, but instead a massive demonic creature that took offense at her knocking on his shin and trying to smash her flat underfoot. The third door opened with a whirr and a click, revealing several automatic crossbows that peppered the alleyway wall behind her with crossbow bolts.

In short, by the time Adora reached the final delivery spot, she was nursing two burns, three cuts, and an aching back. She rubbed her spine, wincing as she felt something shift and pop inside of her. King, who had been a pretty huge help – in that he had laid around in her pocket and occasionally told her when something was beginning to chew on her shoeleather to get at the tasty toes within – looked up at her and asked: "So, ready to

quit and go home? Cause I've been ready to quit and go home for a few hours now."

Adora blinked down at him, then laughed. "Are you *kidding*!?"

She spread her arms wide, wincing slightly. "This place is great!"

"Weh!?" King almost fell out of her pocket.

Adora laughed. "My whole frigging life, I've been told to be scared of stuff. Brown people! Immigrants. Gay people. My mom is a total paranoid *freak*. Since, I mean, she votes Republican, you know?"

"I don't even know what a Republican even is!" King said, his eyes narrowing in frustration as he threw his hands up.

"But here? Here, I actually need to- wah! Get off!" She shook her arm to wriggle off one of the chewing beasts that was trying to get at her succulent flesh through her now somewhat tattered jacket. "I actually need to watch out for *real* dangers! It's like...I'm finally *good* at stuff!" She grinned then added. "Also, all I have to do is follow Eda's directions and everything works out. Do you know how rare that is? Following my mom's instructions back home usually just got people to think I was a total dweeb." She made a face. "Getting your head dunked for being a dweeb when you're in the lacrosse team is like…" She shook her head. "I don't even know!"

King grumped. “I was hoping you’d be all discontent. Then I could convince you to go get snacks instead of delivering a dumb potion.”

“Heh,” Adora said, grinning. “How about this, once we deliver this last potion, I’ll get you two cookies for the time you warned me about the pit trap.”

“Weh!” King sounded more cheerful at that idea as Adora brushed aside the curtains draped over an alleyway to reveal a huge, glittering castle, gleaming and bright in the heart of Bonesburrough. King perked up while Adora narrowed her eyes.

“Who lives here?” King asked.

“Adegast,” Adora said, her voice soft and quiet. “But the thing is...does this make any sense to you? Most people who buy Eda’s potions are pretty middle class to lower class. Their houses are small, they live in the scummier parts of Bonesburrough. Which, like, seems to be most of it, as far as I can tell.” She shook her head. “How does a giant castle even *fit* here? And why is it in this part of the town, this isn’t even on a hill or near the center of town.”

“Who cares?” King asked. “He probably just paid a bunch of snails for a cheap castle, right?”

“Yeah, but *why* a castle here?” Adora asked. “Do you know why people build castles?”

“...to have...a big house?” King suggested.

“To protect something,” Adora said, frowning. “Lets be on our guard, King.”

A flicker of motion out of the corner of her eyes made her dive immediately into a set of thick, prickly thorns. King yelped, but she clapped her hand over his muzzle, peeking out of the roses and thorns – pointing as she did so at a set of three staves carrying three robed and masked members of the Golden Guard. One was clearly a demon with scorpion claws and a tail, while the other had flowing, glistening purple hair that trailed in the air behind her. And in the center of the formation was…

“Kat,” Adora whispered.

“Ra,” King added.

“Huh?” Adora asked.

“Her name is Catra. The Golden Guard. Eda grumbles about it often enough.”

“Oh,” Adora whispered. “I didn’t want to dead name her, uh...wait, she’s still a girl, though?”

“What does that have to do with-” King shushed up as the three of them landed in the courtyard before the castle doors. Catra took her mask off and twirled it on her finger, looking around slowly as she did so.

“This is the place,” she said.

“Sure is, wi...Golden Guard!” The scorpion girl said, her voice muffled behind her mask.

“What are we doing again?” the purple haired girl asked.

“We’re here to arrest this guy,” Catra said, then shook her head. “We should knock, huh?”

She used her toe – exposed, thanks to her shoe-less feet – to scrape along the stone pavement. Her toenail was, like a cat’s claw, sharp and extensible and hard black, and soon, she had scraped a complex symbol onto the ground.

“Ooh, what’s that?” The scorpion girl asked, her voice clearly delighted.

Catra lifted her leg up above her head, then brought her heel down on what she had carved. A blue light flashed and a massive fist the size of a small car exploded out of the ground, glistening – carved, it seemed, entirely out of ice. Ice or no, it smashed into the door with an explosion of splinters and a haze of dust and debris. Adora gasped, while King let out a soft *weh*. Then, from the dust, coughing and waving his hand, came a bearded man in a blue robe covered in white stars, his frumpy wizard hat in disarray and dangling around his brows.

"A-Ah! Golden Guard, what are-" he started, but Catra had already started yanking things off her belts – small slips of paper, which exploded with green light. Vines burst from her hands and whipped around the man, yanking him off his feet and hauling him to be trussed up before her. "Ah!"

Adora narrowed her eyes. "*Catra*," she whispered.

"Blah blah blah, you know what I like about this world?" Catra asked, planting her foot on the man's chest. "No Miranda rights."

"Hah! Gottem!" The scorpion said, while the purple haired girl flipped her mask back.

"What's a Miranda?" she asked.

"Long story," Catra said, smirking.

“W-Waa-aah wait wait wait wait!” Adaghast exclaimed as Catra hooked her finger under the vines, then hauled him up and slapped him into the scorpion's arms. She cradled him with the gentleness of a mother holding a newborn baby, clearly not wanting to snip or snap him apart with her claws.

“Nah.” Catra said, shrugging. “I prefer to not piss off the Emperor when I can help it. Kind of bad for your life expectancy, wizard.”

“Wait! I know something! A secret!” Adaghast said, his voice desperate. “A powerful, powerful artifact. A-A…”

“Let me guess, it’s some secret ancient blade?” Catra asked, rolling her eyes.

“A blade of power!” He said, nodding. “Carved from living titan bone itself!”

“Sure, sure,” Catra said, turning to face him, smirking as she twinkled her fingers. “And I’m a fairy princess.”

“You are!?” The scorpian exclaimed, excitedly.

“No! I’m being sarcastic Scorpia!”

“Oooh!”

“I have a map!” Adaghast squeaked. He managed ti wriggle and point with his nose. Catra sighed.

“Entrapta,” she said.

Entrapta did nothing. Said nothing. She was, in fact, looking off into space.

“Entrapta!” Catra snapped.

“Oh! Sorry!” Entrapta said. She walked off – but not on her feet. Instead, her hair undulated and swelled like living tissue, swinging her off and leaving Adora feeling faintly queasy. She gulped and rubbed her own hair, trying to not imagine the pressure that put on the scalp. Then back came Entrapta, holding not one map, but several.

“Oohh wowwww!” Catra said, her voice dripping with...the...exact same kind of tone she used to use to cut their enemies to bits verbally when she and Adora had whispered and gossiped together. “A bunch of rube maps to sell to tourists? You really are desperate.”

“T-Those are the fake maps I use to trap people!” Adaghast squeaked as the vines tightened around him.

“You do know we’re cops, right?” Catra smirked. “Like, we can just lie and claim you confessed, you don’t have to actually-”

“Put! Together! Say! Word! Grayskull!” Adaghast wheezed, his head almost ballooning as the vines tightened more and more.

Catra frowned, then held the papers together. She looked at them, then muttered.

“Grayskull,” she whispered.

A flash of light slapped her face and she blinked in shock – the papers faced away from where Adora crouched, but even from a distance, she could see that the map had changed, the papers having flowed together. Catra cocked her head, then grinned, slowly.

“Girls,” she said. “Who wants to get some extra credit from teacher?”

“We’re not in school, though,” Scorpia whispered.

“I’d love to go to school and learn more things!” Entrapta said.

"Ugh!" Catra rolled her eyes, then hopped onto her staff, standing on it with her feet and floating straight up into the air. "On me, guardsmen."

"Allyoop!" Scorpia said, climbing into her staff while still holding Adaghast. She shot off into the air after Catra.

And Adora?

She saw her chance.

Entrapta was rubbing her chin and muttering. "I'd learn more about divination, first…"

Adora sprinted forward, grabbed onto the sleek gray metal of her staff, stammered a quick "Sorry!" to Entrapta, then tried to get the staff to go. Squeezing her knees and gripping her hands, she found that the staff very badly *wanted* to go, and she shot off into the air, streaking after Catra and Scorpia.

Entrapta snapped her fingers. "And potions!"

She looked around.

“Huh,” she said. “I guess I’m off shift!”

Chapter End Notes

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Adora Gray and the Sword

Chapter Summary

> Adora finds an old sword she can't even hock for snails. Catra takes it extremely well, with a stable and emotionally balanced response.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

King clung to the staff behind Adora, his eyes wide. “Have you ever flown a staff before!?” He exclaimed, while Adora clung to the staff she was holding – seeing that the capstone of it was a coiled up, tentacular octopus. Adora, for herself, had a single thing going through her head.

Ahhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhctually this isn’t so bad!

She sat up a bit and felt the staff shift under her weight as her fingers tingled with the touch of magic. She crested the brown trees and swept up behind Catra and Scorpia, the two of them streaking through the air with the wizard Radaghast in tow. She frowned intently, while King clambered up her back and peeked his head over his shoulder.

“You’re a natural, Adora!” he said, cheerfully. “I was sure you’d crash and die instantly.”

"Y-Yeah!" Adora said, laughing softly. "I guess this comes from reading every single Azura book." She grinned, sheepishly. "And my mom said that it was stupid. And would stunt my growth. And kinda satanic. Also, she once saw the cover where Hectae and Azura teamed up and grilled me if it was gay, and, like, what was I supposed to say? Not tell her that Prince John Glitterding and the King of the Rogues, George, totally hook up! It's very sub-textual, but it's there and-"

"Uh, Adora, they're landing," King said, his voice flat.

"Oh!" She blinked.

The two were sweeping down towards a thick, old growth part of forest.

"Right!" Adora squared her shoulders and started to bring her borrowed staff down – repressing the guilty twinge in her belly at having stolen it. When she landed, it was behind a tree and some brushes, and when she peeked around the tree, she saw that Scorpia and Catra were both looking around, Catra looking furious.

"Oh my Titan," Catra groaned. "Where is Entrapta!?"

"Probably distracted," Scorpia said, clacking her claws.

Catra sighed, then reached into her robes. She yanked out a small...Adora blinked. It looked like a crow, save that it had tiny holes on the chest, and when the mouth opened, Adora swore she could see a microphone in it. *Crow...Phone?* She thought, while Catra spoke into it. "Guard Entrapta, you better have a really, really, really good reason for not being here," she said.

"I sure do!" Entrapta's voice came from the phone. "This place is full of illegal schematics and diagrams. This guy's definitely a demon, probably a puppeteer, and he's got a bunch of...ooh, faaaaascinating!"

"Well, okay," Catra said, seeming mollified. "Record everything and-"

"Log Number One: Puppeteer is capable of simulating entire environments using a kind of psycho-reactive fog emitted from their fog glands!" Entrapta's voice came from the phone, cutting Catra off.

"You're using your phone, Entrapta!" Catra snapped.

"Oh! Sorry!"

The phone clicked and the beak swung shut as Catra shook her head and shoved the phone into her robes. She turned, then, to Radhagast. "Wizard, huh?" she asked, then smirked, reaching up. She rubbed the back of her palm against his cheek and a single

dark claw *snicked* out of her fingertip. "This thing you're leading me too better be really amazing, or else we get to find out how good a puppeteer demon's fog glands work when they're attached to an abomination soldier." She chuckled.

"U-Uh…" Radaghast paled.

Wind picked up around Adora's feet. She frowned, then looked over her shoulder – she swore she had…

"Did you hear that?" King whispered.

"I almost did too," she whispered back. She glanced back at Radaghast, who was hastily spilling every detail he could. His voice echoed as she walked towards the sound of the distant voice – and when she brushed aside some hanging leaves, she saw that the trees had grown up and around an ancient looking manor house, the kind of big-as-heck mansion that she had always dreamed about living in, ever since she had read the first Azura book when she was a kid. Course, in the real world, people weren't just foundling orphan witches who got recruited by sage old mentors.

Yeah. Real world. Like the demon realm? Adora thought.

Distantly, she heard Radaghast: "T-This was once a haven of wild witches, before the Emperor...ahem…"

She almost stepped on a long white bleached skull, sitting among the leaves. Adora jerked her foot up and froze.

"...dealt with them."

"Eep!" Adora whispered, while King pointed – and she saw that the manor house front doors were blasted inwards, long splintered and left to rot. Adora hastily stepped over the skull, then came to the stairs leading up to the front doors, where she saw that there was a scratched out name above the door – with only the last bit visible under the marks. *...skull.* Adora frowned, then started inside of the building. She saw around her every bit of lost grandeur: Scorched, burned up furniture, rotting floorboards, a long dusty chandelier that clung to the ceiling, vines of thick orange leaves growing in through every window. The entire place reeked of dust and mildew...and death. King waved his paw before his nose.

"Ugh," he said. "And I thought the Owl House had a distinctive smell."

"It's...not exactly what I expected to see from a *wild witch*," she said, shrugging. "I expected more, like. A hut."

"Emperor Belos calls everyone who doesn't follow his rules a wild witch," King said, nodding. "It can include stuffy jerks like whoever lived here, not just cool people like me!" He paused. "Or Eda, I guess."

Adora clutched the staff between her hands, biting her lip hard. She looked at the stairs that led up to the second story – but no. That didn't feel right. Her gaze slowly tracked across the room, looking for a basement entrance. She felt the call of...of *something*. Her chest ached as she put her hand against her throat, rubbing her fingers there.

Crack.

Adora spun around.

Catra, her robes fluttering around her shoulders, her staff nowhere to be seen, smirked as she leaned against the door frame.

"Hey Adora," she said, her voice a dangerous purr.

Adora clenched her shoulders and tightened her fists around her, uh, borrowed staff. Catra shook her head slowly. "Titan, I am...really thinking I should bring up Kikimora's hiring practices to Lilith, there has to be a way we can get someone who doesn't let her staff get stolen out from behind her."

The staff shook and trembled, suddenly. Catra chuckled. "Ah, she finally noticed," she said, while Adora dug her feet in, straining hard to keep a hold of the staff – but the stick wrenched out of

her hands and shot away with so much collected momentum that it shot straight at Catra like a cannonball. Catra took a step half an inch to the side, the smirk not even leaving her features as the staff whistled past her shoulder and made her robes billow dramatically.

"Nice try," she said.

"I wasn't *trying* to hit you, Kat!" Adora said.

"Cat*ra*," Catra said, scowling. "That little girl you used to look down on isn't *here* anymore, Adora."

"I-" Adora took a step backwards, her hands clenching. "What...happened to you, Kat?"

Catra scowled at her. "What happened? Well, lets see, after you abandoned me to die in the forest so you didn't get in trouble, I was found by someone who actually cares about me, taught about a *real* god that actually *exists* and shown how to use magic." She smirked. "I'm hot stuff here, Adora, and you're...you." She shook her head. "Still wearing dumb red jackets, still doing your hair like an absolute goofball. It's kinda sad."

Adora frowned at her. "You're working for a tyrant."

"Yeahhhh, I'm sure the 'wild mages' who live in *mansions* like this were soooooo nice," Catra said, rolling her eyes and taking another step forward. "Belos has a vision for these islands. And it's a vision where *I'm* given what I've *earned*."

Adora stepped back again, frowning. "And what is that, huh?" she asked. "How many people have you sent to that Conformatorium?"

"Less than you'd think," Catra said, grinning as her claws snicked out. "A lot of them prefer to fight."

Adora frowned. "Well, I'm not going to let you just…"

"What? Throw a demon who scams people into deadly traps and *eats* them into prison?" Catra crossed her arms over her chest and laughed. "Titan, Adora, you really are a rube. Like, you should maybe talk to that Owl Lady of yours about her *harmless pranks* in the human realm. Or maybe, her c-"

Adora's foot settled on a plank that snapped in half with a gunshot fierce *crack*. Adora had a single moment of paralyzing terror, then she fell backwards as a patch of floor the size of a small car opened up under her and she plunged straight down into darkness.

Catra stepped over to the edge, peering down. "Adora?" she called down. "Are you dead?"

Silence.

Catra shook her head. “You dummy.”

She used one of her bare toes to scrawl a rune onto the ground and kicked it with her heel. A vine of glowing green plantlife exploded up and she snatched it up and out of the air, then leaped down the pit – lowering herself inch by inch on the vine.

Scorpia, who stood in the doorway with Radaghast, gulped.

“I gotta find stairs!” she said. “...or use this staff!” She held her staff up, waggling it in the air.

***

Adora sat up, feeling her arm throbbing in a way that she knew meant it was very, very broken. “K-King, are you okay?” she hissed – peering around in the dimness of the basement. There was a very faint blue light coming from *somewhere*.

“Y-Yeah, I’m okay!” King scampered to her. They were both laying in a pile of rubble, but there was no sign of the hole they had fallen down. She remembered being swept to the left, then the right, tumbling head over heels, not simply shooting straight

down. Considering how long she had fallen, that did make sense. She smiled at him sheepishly, taking out her phone. She tapped on the flashlight one handed, holding her arm close to her chest, and King scampered up her back and shoulder again, nosing at her nervously. "Your arm! I heard it crack!"

"I'm fine!" Adora said, smiling shyly. She had tried to shield his body as best as she could. "I always had kinda brittle bones, actually. Doctor said I had a calcium deficiency and everything." She bit her lip, swinging the phone slowly around – and saw that she was in an enclosed rectangular chamber, with the only exit being a kind of a hatch in the wall, with a leering skull carved on it in a bass relief. She frowned, slightly.

"How did we get here?" she asked.

"I think this house has a house demon in it," King said, hesitantly. "But if it's still alive, it's not very talkative."

"Right, like...the tube thing…" Adora whispered.

"Hooty!" King said. "He's an abomination, but we all tolerate him."

Adora gulped, then walked to the hatch. She held her phone in her teeth while she touched the wheel with her good hand and found it spun easily. She twirled it around and opened the hatch – and found the blue light had been leaking around the edges of the

hatch. It came around the corner, bouncing down from a corridor. She gulped. “Hmphmnk phht eh hey hoot?”

“Huh?” King asked.

She grabbed her phone with her hand. “Think that’s the way out?”

“If it is, then your scary ex is that way,” King said.

“She’s not my-” Adora flushed, hard, and...and hated how her belly fluttered with butterflies and rainbows at the very idea, despite her broken arm. “She’s not my ex. But...we can always run back the other way.”

She tried to not imagine what running on a broken arm would be like.

She walked down the corridor, past other chambers, which looked in on rusted swords, spears, axes, and bows. She hesitated at some of those, peering in with her phone, whispering. “What was this place? An armory?” She bit her lip. “M-Maybe Catra was right. Maybe these people were bad – or...or maybe they were a resistance to Belos?” She liked that idea a bit more.

“Eda did say there were some people, way back when Belos first founded the empire, who fought back,” King said, rubbing his

muzzle with his clawed hand. “They were all led by one family, whose name was...was…” He paused. “I can’t remember!”

“Heh, we can ask her when we get...back…”

Adora stood before the entrance to the room where the blue light was coming from. Save it wasn’t coming from *inside* the room. It was coming from a radiant blue wall of pure energy, crackling and buzzing. As Adora watched, the light flickered once or twice – beginning to fade, it looked like. She bit her lip, then whispered. “They made a shield to protect that place. But it’s fading. How long can a spell last?”

“Unno!” King said, shrugging.

“Okay, let me try something.” Adora said. Then she mentally smacked herself. “King, can you hold this?”

“Hold your lightcube? Sure!” King said, taking her phone in his claws and then beginning to shine it around in every direction but where she needed it to be shone. Since the flickering field was providing intermittent blue glow in the corridor, Adora was able to pick up a chunk of rubble from the floor with her good hand. She hefted it and tossed it, trying to time it for when the shield was flickering down. The rock sailed through. She nodded.

“Okay,” Adora said. “Hold on.”

“Why wou-*weh*!” King yelped as Adora leaped.

She felt a tingling buzz…

Then she was through, skidding to a stop inside of the chamber the shield was protecting. “Yes!” she hissed, clenching her teeth as the landing sent jarring, shooting bolts of pain along her arm. She gasped softly – then blinked as she noticed the strobing pulse was offline. She turned back and saw the shield was just gone now. “Oh *come on*!” She grumbled. “If I waited five seconds, I could have just *walked* through!?”

“Thems the breaks!” King said, swinging the phone around wildly, plunging Adora’s view into darkness, then light, then darkness again.

She grabbed the phone back with her good hand.

“Weh!”

Adora slowly tilted her view around and saw that she stood in a room that looked as if it had once been a planning center. It was empty, the chairs long since knocked over, the table in the middle having a dusty carving of what looked like a supine, skull faced corpse sprawled on it, with the knee jutting up into the air, the palms spread wide as it lay back in death. Adora walked towards it, her voice soft. “What is *that*?”

“Uh, a map?” King said, sounding annoyed.

“A map of *what*!?” Adora gasped.

“The...The Boiling Isles!”

“*That’s* the Boiling Isles!?” Adora spluttered, looking at him with shock.

“Yeah!” King said. “We’re all living on the body of a vast decaying Titan, the god we worship! Neat, huh?”

Adora gulped.

Then she lifted her gaze up to the head of the table and realized she was mere inches away from a decaying skeleton, clutching a long, deadly looking sword. Adora screamed and jumped backwards, then screamed again as her broken arm was jarred. She dropped her phone, and the light shone upwards, casting terrifying shadows as the skeleton slowly leaned forward, breathing out a misty pall, a sigh like the end of the world. Adora scrabbled backwards and the skeleton fell forward onto the ground with a crash, bones flying apart, and a long desiccated chunk of flesh tumbling away from the ribcage. The sword rang with a musical note as it crashed to the ground – trembling and buzzing, while King clung to Adora’s shoulder.

“It’s okay! It’s okay!” he said. “it’s just a dead guy, not a monster or anything.”

“...r-right…” Adora whispered, trying to control her thundering heart.

Then she heard, distantly.

“There you are!”

She snapped her head back to the door – and then looked back at the sword.

“K-King, are there any other exits?” She asked, grabbing onto the sword, hissing as she stood. The sword was sleek and perfectly balanced. The metal of the blade was obsidian black, the hilt bone white. There was a bright, gleaming orange eye in the center of the crossguard – a hardened gemstone that glittered and flashed. The sword itself felt spectacularly fitted to her hand, as if her whole life, she had been waiting to hold it. King, scrambling down to her phone, swung it around.

“No! We’re trapped!” he said.

“Looks like we’re gonna have to fight then,” Adora said. She bit her lip, looking down at the sword.

And for a moment, reflected in the light of the phone, were...glowing letters. Glyphs. She swore they were akin to the things she had seen being scrawled by Catra to cast her magic. Her brow furrowed and she swore...she swore…

“Adora, if you really wanted to get a tour of bad ideas, you could have let me take you to Lilith’s book club,” Catra said, walking in through the door, surrounded by a nimbus of glowing pale white balls of shimmering light – they danced around her like fireflies.

Adora tried to lift her gaze.

But she couldn’t.

Her mind was consumed with one question.

“...Adora?” Catra asked. “What is that?”

“It’s a sword,” Scorpia whispered, sotto voce, as she walked up behind Catra.

“I know it’s-”

Adora muttered, softly. “By the honor…”

“What?” Catra asked, frowning.

But Adora was sure now.

She held the sword above her head, following an instinct that sang bright and true inside of her. Something throbbed in her heart – like a golden heat, like the beginning of a dawn. It was fierce, and it scared her – but what scared her more was how *eager* she was to feel it burn all the brighter. The words came from her mouth then, a bellow that shook the room.

“For the honor...of Grayskull!”

***

There is a whirling sensation – as of being caught in a vast, dark wind.

And dark it is. Dark winds. Dark light. Dark heat. Dark power.

But it is comforting dark – the warm embrace of a hug. The sensation of being wrapped in a blanket, when a howling storm screams outside.

Then…

The arm snaps *together – bone fusing and healed. Skin bubbles, then shifts, turning ebony black. Bone bursts from the back of knuckles and fingers, ending in pale white claws. Curling horns bloom from the brow and sweep backwards as golden blond turns to dark purple, flaring and growing outwards into a wild mane, curling and rippling in the wind. Toes become long and sharp and chitinous, while clothing reshapes itself last – a jacket lengthens, becoming a dark black curiass of hardened black steel, a fluttering cape of crimson blood red sweeps outwards. The sword flashes and a haze of glittering runes flare to life, wheeling and twirling like a celestial orrery for some alien sun.*

The eyes open last – brilliant orange and black, glowing with a deep inner fire.

Then, at last…

It is done.

***

Catra's jaw hung open as she looked at the figure standing where Adora had been. Scorpia, her eyes wide as saucers, dropped her own staff to the ground with a clink and a clatter. Adora...no...she wasn't Adora anymore. Adora was *human* and pathetic and...and…

And not…

"The Titan…" Scorpia whispered, her voice soft, as the beautiful figure of ebony and ivory bone stood, sword in hand, towering above her – nine, ten feet tall, and powerful as anything she had ever imagined. The sword rested tip first on the floor...and it was Adora's face, looking out of that mane of purple hair, beneath those blessed horns, with those eyes that blazed with the raw source of magic. For a moment, the expression on her features was pure…

What?

Contempt.

It was *contempt*. Looking down at Catra. Judging Catra.

Catra shook her head, slowly. "No."

No. No. No. *No*. She refused. She *refused*. Adora...was not the reborn Titan. She was *not*. That wasn't fair! That wasn't *fair*. It

wasn’t fair, it wasn’t real, it was-

Then Adora helped a lot.

She screamed and dropped her sword, looking down at her hands. “Auuh!” She grabbed her horns. “What the *freaking heck* happened to me!?” She gasped.

Catra felt her rising wave of panic drop down to a deep satisfaction. She shook her head, then walked forward. “Not sure. But when Belos cuts you open to find out, I’ll tell him to-”

“Stay back!” Adora’s hand flexed and runes flickered – Catra recognized the combination of them. Fire and ice in that pattern would- yes, the sword glowed purple and shot straight up into Adora’s palm. She aimed the sword point at Catra, her eyes blazing. “D-Don’t come any closer! I took HEMA!”

All Catra could see was the runes.

Six years. I spent six years learning them from Belos. The timeline flashed before her eyes...and...and everything she had ever been proud of turned to ashes in her hands. Taking a mere week to master the light rune? Finding the ice rune *on her own* without Belos, just by experimenting? Discovering invisibility, something even Belos hadn’t known was possible? Mastering the runes and finding yet more intricacies in their application, such as how intent

shaped their outcome – all her hard won, hard earned expertise. All of it dripped and dribbled between her fingers to the floor.

*Six years. And Adora does a glyphic combination that complicated in seconds...and doesn't...even...**notice**.*

The noise that escaped her lips wasn't really a word – it was a snarl, a scream of primal rage. She shot towards Adora, her claws snapping out – but she didn't come straight at her. She whipped past Adora's shoulder, slashing with her right hand and slapping with her left. The fire rune she left behind did more damage than her claws, which caught on one of Adora's arms as she yanked it up to ward her face. Catra noticed that her claws didn't so much bite as *spark* off her skin. She landed and skidded as the fire rune exploded, sending Adora staggering. Her little dog yapped after her.

"Adora!"

Adora shook her head – but before she could get to her feet, Catra walked forward, grabbing onto her horn with one hand and driving her knee into Adora's face. She felt the merciless crunch of cartilage under her knee as she sent Adora skidding backwards, her eyes fierce and hot. Catra lifted her hand up, claws flicking out.

And Adora pushed up with her palm – runes flashing around her. Catra's eyes widened and she leaped backwards, skidding along her spine as a column of ice the thickness of a giant's wrist punched up from the ground, the tip plunging into the ceiling.

With a roar of dislodged stone and cracking foundations and pouring earth, the sky came down into the corner of the room. Catra slapped down a plant rune and vines swept up and around, keeping the whole ceiling from falling in as Adora scrabbled to her feet, her jaw opened in shock. She looked down at her hand – as if she had had no idea what she had even done.

The ice pillar kept growing. Light spilled, blinding bright into the room.

"Get her!" Catra said.

Scorpia, who was still frozen, on her knees, didn't even more.

Adora grabbed her dog, grabbed her sword, then leaped. She clearly aimed to land on the ice pillar and run her way up.

Instead, she sailed up, through the hole in the roof, and then landed beyond with a whump that Catra could hear. Catra snapped out her wrist, conjuring the mechanical staff Belos had crafted for her. "Scorpia!" She shouted. "Get on your staff! Now!"

She shot up through the hole as the whole rebel manor rumbled and started to collapse in on itself. Her head wheeled left, right, left again. She looked wildly for Adora, for her dog. But there was no sign of them. She swung around in a wheeling search, Scorpia sticking with her, and they hunted.

And hunted.

And hunted.

***

The cell doors slamming in the Conformatorum between Radaghast and the rest of his life were still ringing in Catra's ears as she arrived at Belos castle. By then...she had calmed down. She had brushed her hair flat and sleek, smoothed out her tail, and worked out what she was going to tell her Emperor. Scorpia clacked her claws together as the two of them walked in, Entrapta following after with a pile of scrolls, papers and parchments in her arms.

"So, uh, wildcat, are...what...uh…"

"Don't tell anyone about what we saw," Catra said.

"...are you sure?" Scorpia whispered. "That was...the...I mean...from all the books and the lege-"

"Don't. Tell. Anyone." Catra turned, looking at Catra. Then, softening her voice, she added. "It was just a wild magic trick. Belos is the one who talks to the Titan. He knows what's right and wrong better than any crazy old witch in the woods." She shook her head. "It's better if no one knows, cause then no one can get

confused, right?" She snorted. "It's not like the citizens of the Boiling Isles are particularly hard to trick. Radaghast managed it, and he's made entirely of suspicion and goo."

"And gas!" Entrapta added from behind her pile of scrolls.

"So. Just keep it mum," Catra said.

"Got it!" Scorpia said, giving her a fierce salute.

Catra paused.

"You two...didn't...do too terribly," she said, hesitantly. "Though, Entrapta, you're off the team unless you do something *really* amazing with those papers."

"Hmm? Okay!" Entrapta said, nodding. She immediately turned and headed off towards the workshops – normally used by the Emperor in his many experiments.

Catra sighed. "Make sure she actually does something," she said to Scorpia, rubbing the back of her neck.

"Got it! And I'll keep her safe," Scorpia said. "Those tools are pretty dangerous."

"Ehhh…" Catra shrugged.

Scorpia gave her…

Catra cocked her head as Scorpia waggled her claw at her.

“Is that a thumbs up?” she finally hazarded.

“Yeah! Wow, you are smart,” Scorpia whispered, her voice full of soft awe. She turned back and started to walk away.

Catra shook her head. She turned and headed towards the throne room. Peeking in through the cracked open door...she saw her mentor, her…

The name always skittered around in her brain – like ice tossed onto a hot skilett. She didn’t want to say it or think it. But both of them knew what it was. She forced down the frog in her throat and walked into the throne room, flanked by the flickering torches that surrounded the high throne. Emperor Belos sat at it, his imposing figure accentuated by his raven beaked, horned mask. His articulated metal gauntlets clicked as he tapped his pointer finger on the throne’s armrests, while glowing blue eyes peered from the dark recesses of the mask.

“Ah, Catra,” he said. “You’ve returned just in time.”

"Emperor," Catra said, kneeling. She planted her palm to the floor and dropped her head down low. She hesitated – *returned just in time?* She weighed her words carefully, and decided that venturing onto uncertain ground was a mistake. She flicked her yellow and blue eyes up to look at him. "What was it you wished to tell me."

"A fascinating report has returned to us from Bonesburrogh," The Emperor said. "Have you ever heard the legend...of Titan-Ra?"

Catra nodded, firmly. "Uh, an avatar of the Titan. The wild witches claimed that she was going to save them from your rule – but, well, she never showed up."

"A figure matching the exact legend was spotted fleeing from the Old Woods towards the north by no less than six people," the Emperor said, steepling his fingers. "You were on patrol in that area. Did you see her?"

Catra felt time...slow. Then stop.

She saw before her two possibilities.

Tell him the exact, absolute truth.

That was easy enough – she had faced off against Adora, who was not this mythical figure. She couldn't be. There was no way

that she could be an avatar of the Titan. Not after Catra had...not after everything Catra had done for the Titan. She had done more for the Titan than anyone else on this whole *damn corpse*. But her mind saw it clearly...Belos was the one who spoke to the Titan. She could see Adora kneeling before him. She could see Adora accepting his hand. She could hear her.

Sure, I can help.

And Catra?

Catra saw herself in an office, dust growing on her papers.

After all. You don't even have a bile sack. You're a powerless human. Nothing but a pathetic, useless-

There was one possibility.

"No," Catra said. "But I doubt there's a real Titan-Ra running around." She shook her head. "Do you want me to find the impostor and deal with...her? Him?"

"Her," Belos said, quietly. "It does make sense that she would try and hide from my Coven and the righteous justice that would fall upon such an imposter's head. But if she truly is Titan-Ra, then the Titan has plans for her – and she must be brought into my

service.” He lifted his head a bit, his voice growing more focused. “Do you understand this, Golden Guard?”

“I do, my Emperor,” Catra said, bowing her head low.

“Now, what was it you wished to report to me?” Belos asked, curiously.

Catra smirked. “You’ll never guess who showed up in the Demon Realm. My, heh, my old *friend* Adora. The one who abandoned me. Who...turned on me.” She smirked, slowly. “And she’s in the company of the Owl Lady.”

“How fascinating,” Belos said, his eyes narrowing. “A human in our realm, though. You know what this means, Catra?”

“I do,” she said.

“It means there is a way to get from our realm to their realm,” Belos said, using his finger to draw the line through the air. “A method that we can use. That we can *take*.”

Catra grinned, lopsidedly. She had gotten away with it. She was going to thread this needle and come out ahead. On top. Where she *deserved* to be.

"We think very alike, Emperor," she said. "Now, here's *my* idea…"

***

The forest swept past, branches snapping at her face, her arms.

And still she ran.

She ran, and the rain got colder. Her running got slower.

She emerged...and there was the Boy.

He was always there, in the dream, standing there. Looking at her with those sad, sad eyes of his. He looked at her.

"*What do you want with me!?" She grabbed him. Shook him. "What do you want with me!? What do you-"*

Catra jerked upright, her heart hammering and racing in her chest. She clutched at her own breast, her eyes half closed as she panted softly. The sheets of her bed were in tatters – something that she hadn't needed to worry about in years. The nightmares had stopped being so present...but...seeing Adora had plunged

her right back into them. She rubbed her palms against her face, then slid from the bed. She padded to her writing desk, scribbling the runic combination she needed, then laid the paper on the bed. She watched, pensively, as purple light flared around the sheets and the tears and rips started to slip together, threading themselves until they were entirely mended.

She sat on her chair, her bare feet resting ankle first on the ground. She flexed her toes and watched her claws snick out, then retract. She wasn't sleepy anymore. Her body tingled with energy and she frowned, drawing a circle with her claw. It was the beginning of all runes, all magic, a circle. She glowered at the empty circle, then lifted her claw up and off the desk.

"Screw this," she muttered, then stood and started to walk through the corridors of her castle. Her plan was a good one – but right now, she wished she had gone for something that involved less *waiting*. She knew that, intellectually, even if she had chosen a plan that involved a direct assault on the Owl House, she should be sleeping now. Instead, she stalked through the corridors, wandering the castle aimlessly – walking past paintings of the history of the Empire.

Then, she came to one of the small libraries, her feet carrying her there instinctively. For a second, she hesitated – but then she felt a deep sense of mingled shame and relief as she saw that Lilith was up late as well, reading what seemed to be a large tome on healing magics. The pale Clawthorne lifted her head up, seeing Catra standing in the doorway. She smiled, slightly.

"Ah, Catra," Lilith said. "...can't sleep?"

“No,” Catra said, softly.

“Is it...Adora?” Lilith asked, softly.

Catra tensed, then snorted. “No,” she lied with the same ease she used on the Emperor. She walked over, then flopped herself along a chair, hooking her arms over the back as she sprawled onto it like she was a liquid rather than a flesh and bone creature. She looked pensively down at the floor. “...maybe a little,” she admitted.

Lilith sighed. “I understand what it’s like, growing up with someone as close to you as that. I mean, you were basically like sisters?”

Catra’s cheeks heated. “Y-Yeah. Basically,” she lied, again.

Lilith nodded. “What you should focus on is bringing her into accord with the way of the world,” she said. “By showing her a better world is possible, and letting herself move past her damage, she can be happy. With you.” She nodded, firmly. “Now, doing that is more difficult than it seems. But you must...be patient with her. You have to put aside any anger you have, and focus on what it is you want for your future, together.”

Catra frowned. “And what if she’s a threat?”

Lilith chuckled. “Catra. Adora, no matter how spectacular a human she is, is not a threat to you. For one thing, the Owl Lady is no teacher – she won’t be learning runes from her any time soon. Lacking that, what can she even...do?” She paused. “Swing a sword around?”

“Heh,” Catra said. “Don’t underestimate Adora with a sufficiently heavy pokey thing. She managed to almost get us both killed that way.” She stretched, languidly, arching her back as she casually dug her claws into the expensive chair. She stretched her fingers and sighed in relief as she dug in furrows slowly and loudly. “Wasp nests do not like getting poked, it turns out.”

Lilith frowned. “Catra, that chair is extremely expensive. It’s Darius favorite.”

“Yeah…” Catra yanked her claws free, smirking. She felt a lot better. Talking to Lilith and annoying Darius tended to do that. She wriggled her fingers. “Thanks, Lilith.”

“Catra,” Lilith reached out, putting two pale fingers on her wrist, stopping Catra before she headed out. She looked at her seriously. “Just remember...if Adora was as close to you as Edalynn was close to me, then a part of her, no matter how small, *wants* to fix things. She just can’t hear it yet.” She smiled. “There’s hope in the future.”

Catra snorted. “Sure,” she slid her hands into her pockets and padded off.

When she slept, she dreamed of nothing but quiet, comfortable blackness.

And when she woke, she worked two glyphs. The first was to expand her lung capacity – a twist on the classic fog-producing fire/ice glyph, worked in with the plant glyph. It wasn't perfect, since it had to remain stuck to her body and if it fell off before she took another breath, she'd be in serious trouble. But it'd still go well with the invisibility rune she scribbled next.

Mutely, her lips closed tight, she took off into the air.

And once she had chosen her place, she settled in to watch.

Cats were ambush predators, after all.

TO BE CONTINUED

Chapter End Notes

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Adora Gray and the Transfer Student

Chapter Summary

Adora goes to school! Catra's plan goes into motion.

Chapter Notes

Content Warning: There's some dental horror in this one (teeth falling out) but the teeth DO get back into the mouth!

"You should probably *tell Eda*!"

Adora, who was swabbing her teeth as hard and as fast as she could with her toothbrush and spitting out some Boiling Isles style toothpaste into the sink, shook her head and set the toothbrush down. "No *way*," she said, sighing. "I got the rent money, I told her her enemy Adagahst got arrested…" She frowned. "Who knew she had so many enemies?"

"Me! And most people," King said, nodding as he perched on the sink. "But you need to tell her."

"Tell her whaaaaaaaaaaat?" Hooty asked, his head sliding wormlike in through the window, rotating in a corkscrew manner as his tube-like body twisted into the room.

"Nothing!" Adora said. "I, uh, saw...a...the...there was...a…" She flailed around. "A cat! r...ra! I saw...a...a cat...dra...rgon...ragon...cat-dragon." She nodded. "It was big! And a cat! And King here, uh, thinks, we should tell her. About it!"

Hooty narrowed his eyes.

"Okay!" He said, then swung his head back out of the window.

King shook his head slowly. "Fine. I won't tell her. But not because I like you. This is because I am going to enjoy watching your disastrous collapse." He looked quite sure of that, lifting his little snoot. Adora petted his head without thinking and he let out a shocked 'weh!' and then fell off the counter, waggling his paws. "Hey! No petting!" He sighed. "Once you're done with the toothhaste, I shall be upon my throne of power also known as your bedroll."

He scampered off, while Adora blinked. "Tooth…" She took a second look at the tube she had used, seconds before she felt her teeth rattling and squirming in her mouth. She yelped as each tooth came free with a series of pops, cheering and laughing as they started to run around inside of the sink. She remained perfectly still – shocked to her very core – as the teeth smashed into one another – then started to hop back into her mouth, socketing back in with wet, squishing noises. Once they were done, her teeth did feel quite clean.

That did not stop an entire full body shudder running from Adora's head to her toes as she grabbed the toothhaste tube and jammed it back into the drawer.

When she lifted her gaze…

...she looked back at herself.

This should not have been shocking, save for two things. Firstly, Adora was wearing her red jacket, and not a white shirt with a tie, which she was fiddling with. Secondly, she wasn't fiddling with a tie. Thirdly, she was looking in at her own home bathroom – the mirror had become a window, a window into her own home. She blinked at her own reflection, while her reflection looked over her shoulder, at the sound of a voice.

"Are you quite ready, Adora?"

Mom! Adora thought, as the mirror Adora said.

"Just-" She coughed, her voice sounding a bit high and scratchy, like she had a frog in her throat. When she spoke again, she sounded exactly like how Adora sounded when she heard herself recorded – higher pitched than she expected. "-Just a second, uh, Momther. Mother. I mean! Mom!"

The door to the bathroom opened and Adora's mother stepped in, shaking her head slowly. "Ready? Your tie is a mess. What will the interviewers think when you go to college – they'll think you're a complete slob. Here." She took hold of the tie, tugging it open as Adora stood perfectly still – looking completely terrified. She flinched as Adora's mom did the loop, then the tie, then cinched it tight. Adora's mirror self grunted softly, while mom leaned in close.

“This messy tie...is a learning experience, Adora. Here and now, I can cover for your mistakes. But I won’t always be here.” She touched her cheek. “You cannot be sloppy. You cannot make mistakes. You cannot fail me.” She frowned. “Are you going to cry like last time?”

“N-No,” Adora whispered.

“Good,” her mother’s voice was cold. “I had to go to a great deal of trouble to get a second chance for you. A great deal of effort. You understand that?”

“Y-Yes,” Adora said, nodding.

“Good,” her mother gave one of those tiny little half smiles of hers. She reached up, touching up just one last bit of hair – the little motion that should have felt comforting. Instead, it had always felt to Adora like one last reminder that she would never, ever, ever be perfect. Then mom turned to go. Adora, mirror Adora that is, put her hands to her face. She shuddered and closed her eyes, then turned and bent over the sink. Her voice hissed softly.

“Stupid, stupid, stupid…”

“Hey, kiddo!” Eda’s voice called up the stairs. Adora jerked her gaze from the mirror, then back to it – and saw only herself, looking white as a sheet. “You ready for dinner?”

Adora fumbled at the door. “Be right now!” She called out.

Then she headed down the stairs.

And in the quiet of the bathroom, with the light humming and bright, the shadow of a moon-shaped frown flashed onto the wall, crawling against the flat tile like a projection. Above it, a pair of purple eyes glowed with hateful light, then the whole thing faded.

Even had Adora been looking at the wall, even had she been in the room, she wouldn’t have seen it.

She’d have needed to look at the mirror for that.

Adora did see, when she came down the stairs, a wide arrangement of food set out for her. There were curled bits of...green stuff, and writhing...tentacles and some...eyeballs and a bunch of cups with, uh, liquids of many alarming and frightening colors. The only thing about it all that didn’t make her stomach heave was the smells. That actually made her stomach growl eagerly, while Eda spread her arms above the food. “So!” she said. “I’ve never had a human actually visit the Demon Realm – but, well, you have to be able to eat *something* from here, right?

We've got eggviled deggs, badcon, some sork! People like sork, right?"

"Whoa, we have enough snails to buy griffon eggs?" King asked, nosing his snoot at the huge tray at the back which had a nearly earthlike looking egg yoke done to perfection at the back.

"We also have some, uh…" Eda paused. "Well, okay, so, you know how everything around here likes to nibble on you? Well, that's what hofu tries to cater too! And I just now realized why you might not be interested in that…" She picked up an alarmingly pink pile of goo. "Let me just toss this."

Adora sat at the front of the table, biting her lip. "Well, I…"

She started thinking about how she *should* say she was heading home.

Save…

That mirror image. Had it been some of that magic she had been able to cast in that other form? She closed her mouth. Did she want to go back to that? To...*that*? She hesitated, for a long moment, her fingers drumming on the table. When she spoke, it was quiet, pensive. "Eda…" She looked up at her. "...what is Belos' *plan*?" She bit her lip, while Eda blinked at her, then sat down, the hofu having been put back in the fridge in the kitchen. She sighed.

“I don’t know,” she said, simply. “But he’s been forcing all witches and demons that can cast magic into his Empire, then putting them into Covens. When you join a Coven, you can’t cast any other kind of magic. And something tells me that his plans for control go as far as you can imagine.” She shook her head, slowly. “It’s gotten worse since the Golden Guard showed up, too.”

Adora flinched.

“So, you’re saying this world...needs a hero,” she said, her hands tightening.

“That’d be nice, but, uh, Adora, mystical heroes don’t just pop out of nowhere,” Eda said, chuckling. “People have to save themselves. Like me!” She grinned and planted her thumb on her chest.

Adora squared her shoulders. She stood up, then walked over to where she had tucked the sword away when she had gotten home. She picked it up, then turned back to Eda, holding it up on her palms. “I found this, that is, we found this when King and I went out. And...Eda...when I hold it aloft and say magic words, then I turn into something else.” She lifted her chin, then lifted the sword. “By the honor of Grayskull!”

…and nothing happened.

Eda blinked at her.

"Did you say...Grayskull?" she asked, slowly. "As in House Grayskull?"

"You know them?" Adora asked, while King let out a surprised 'weh!'

"I mean I heard about them in school," Eda said, scratching at her ear with her finger. "It was ages ago and I wasn't really paying attention – but they were supposed to be one of the oldest witching families, up there with the Clawthornes." She snorted. "But unlike the Clawthornes, they're all dead, like suckers."

"Belos killed them," Adora whispered.

"Oh," Eda said, frowning. "Then I take back my gloating, it's no fun if that jerk did it."

Adora rubbed her chin, frowning intently. "But it worked in the basement."

"What worked, exactly?" Eda asked. "What did you turn into?"

"Titan-Ra!" King said.

"You did *not*!" Eda exclaimed. "Titan-Ra is a myth! A legend! Totally baloney." She flicked her hand – which fell off with a thump onto the floor. Adora, who had started to pace, didn't even notice. Her hand brushed nervously along her blond hair as she frowned.

"But I did become *something*," she said. "And if this place needs a hero, then I can be that hero! I can help stop Belos."

"Whoa, kid, you just ran away from the human realm. You should slow down before you get in over your head," Eda said. She stood up, then guided Adora back to her seat. "Start with food."

Adora sighed. Eda had a good point. She regarded the meal laid out before her, then picked up a squirmy, wriggling tentacle from the sork, and popped it into her mouth. Her eyes widened as she chewed – then swallowed.

"That's great!" she said, excitedly picking up another piece of dubious meat, popping it into her mouth and chewing happily.

King shook his head. "She likes your cooking. This is all the proof I need she came from an abusive home."

Eda grinned, then offered Adora a fork.

***

Eda and Adora flew through the air on the back of Eda's staff, Adora sitting a bit more comfortably now that she had flown herself. She watched as Bonesburrough whisked by beneath her, then they started to cruise down towards the large library in the heart of the town center, Eda hopping off her staff and then taking it in her hand and – with a wave of her palm and a shimmering of golden magic – banished it into somewhere else. Adora, who had crammed her sword into her backpack and was getting increasingly nervous at the way the bottom was distending, frowned. "I wish I could do that with my sword…"

"You can just carry a sword around, ya know," Eda said, shrugging. "What are they gonna do, arrest you?"

"You there!"

Adora jerked and spun around in time to see a short, round headed demon with a rather pronounced nose being set upon by two of the conformatorium guards. They grabbed onto their arms, yanking them off their short, stubby feet, while the demon kicked their legs. "Un-hawnd mwe!"

"Weapons are not permitted in town!" one guard said, reaching behind the demon's back, yanking out a massive looking curved knife.

"It's fhore my pwotection!" the demon squeaked.

"That's what we're here for, *pipsqueak*," the guard said, growling as his comrade shook the demon from side to side.

"Oh, right, I guess they can," Eda said, twirling her finger with a smirk. A glowing circle of light was inscribed in the air – and a moment later, a flash of light popped up beneath the two guards, who yelped as their captive was replaced by a pile of hissing mini-Hooties, who started to writhe and squirm around in a hideous fashion. Crying out in horror, they dropped the pile, while Eda and Adora ducked into the library.

Entering into the library, Adora and Eda walked to the front desk, where a beaked nose demon stood, spectacles in hand, polishing them. "Yo, buddy," Eda said. "We need everything you got on the history of witch families in Bonesburrough."

"Ah, Edalynn. The Owl Lady…" The librarian set his glasses on his beak. "You do have several books on the overdue list-"

"C'mon, we just need five or six more," Eda said.

The librarian looked torn between duty and fear. Adora smiled at him weakly.

"In this case, your flagrant criminality is irrelevant. All books pertinent to the witch families of Bonesburrough were confiscated

by Principle Castaspella this morning," the librarian said.

"What!?" Eda asked, while Adora whispered.

"Castaspella?" she asked, dazedly.

"That-" Eda scowled, then narrowed her eyes. "Why?"

"Apparently, someone ate the school's copies and history still needs to be taught," the librarian said.

Adora sighed. "Well, uh, we can go to the school then and-"

"No, we can't," Eda said, scowling. "Castaspella hates me."

"Why!?" Adora asked.

"Uh," Eda paused, then waggled her hand. "I may have accidentally done several hundred pranks. Also, we both tried to date the same person once." She smirked. "I won that one. And I don't think she ever forgave me for the time when her brother...heh, so, uh, it's really funny actually, see, I dared him that he couldn't get to Beast Island and-" She hesitated, seeing Adora's expression. "It was all a long time ago, but she just always held a grudge. And the island thing ended well, he got married, didn't he?"

Adora sighed. “Well, I guess that’s that then. What do we do now?”

“What do we do now!?” Eda asked, laughing. “We do a *scam,* Adora!”

“Please stop planning more crimes in the library,” the librarian said, somewhat plaintively.

***

Adora stood perfectly still as Edalynn gestured to her with both hands. “And here, we have my cousin from out of town, Adora Clawthorne. Adora, this is Principle Castaspella.”

Principle Castaspella was a beautiful looking witch, with elegantly pointed ears, dark black hair, olive brown skin and a slender build. She was dressed in an official set of robes and she regarded Adora with skepticism, her lips pursed into thin little lines.

Adora felt that skepticism herself. Her ears had been en-pointed by a little cantrip, and it felt deeply strange.

“Is this her old school’s uniform?” Castaspella asked, gesturing to Adora’s red jacket.

“Uh, no?” Adora asked, while, at the same time, Eda slapped her back.

“Yeah, of course,” she said. “She went to Bileside, near Pit Harbor.”

“Yeah! I, uh, also, sometimes have a speech impe-deement where I say no instead of, uh, yes!” Adora stammered. “Wo-eerds! Are...hard!”

“I see,” Castaspella said, pursing her lips. “Fortunately, we can take in a transfer student, assuming you have the official paperwork proving that she has been educated in everything she needs up to this point.. You *do* have this official paperwork?”

“Do I have the *official* paperwork?” Eda laughed. “Do I look like some two bit swindler?”

“Yes,” Castaspella said, her voice dry, as Eda scowled at her – reaching into her jacket pocket (she had put on a rather official looking suit and tie and everything for this meeting) and withdrawing a set of rolled up scrolls she and King had worked on together. Castaspella regarded them suspiciously, then sighed. “This does seem to be in order.”

Adora, whose heart was thumping so hard her chest hurt, breathed a slow sigh of relief.

A rapping sound came at the door.

"Ma'am," a gruff, male voice spoke through the door – opening it to reveal a hunched, older looking witch with a square jaw, a single sharp fang that peeked over the edge of his lip, and the entire upper half of his head was covered with a kind of fleshy hood that covered all but his eyes, which were bright blue.. "We have a transfer student here waiting to be processed."

"Two in one day, Vice Principal Bump? How remarkably sudden," Castaspella said, her voice suspicious as she shot Eda a narrowed expression, clearly expecting something. She turned, opened the door, and said. "Come in, come in, we can process two of you at once." She stepped back…

And the door swung in.

And standing there in the gray skirt, tunic and collar, with pale gray sleeves and leggings of the school uniform...was Catra.

Adora goggled at her – then shook her head and goggled harder as Catra walked in, nervously brushing her hand through her hair, a pair of huge, thick glasses glinting on her face. Glasses! Catra didn't need *glasses*? She smiled, shyly, then looked at Adora curiously, as if she had never seen her before. Adora kept gaping as Castaspella arched an eyebrow.

“And you are?” she asked.

Catra nodded, gulped. “Um, I’m Elizabeth,” she said, holding out a set of parchments that looked even more official, well stamped, and proper than Adora’s makeshifts. “Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce. My family just moved in from near Glandis, and, well, here I am.” She gulped. “I can change my loyalty completely and utterly! At the drop of a hat!”

“Hmm, that will keep you from being beaten up for being from Glandis, true,” Castaspella said, looking at her papers. “Well, this is all in order-”

“How!?” Adora exclaimed.

Everyone looked at her.

“Excuse me?” Castaspella asked as Adora flushed, then stammered.

“S-She’s...her name is Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce!”

Catra gasped – stepping back, her hand going to her chest. Her acting was so good that...was it acting? Adora felt a momentary twinge of panic in her chest, even as Castaspella frowned at her.

“Miss Clawthorne, we do not tolerate making fun of anyone for their names. Apologize to Miss Applesauce immediately.

“Sorry...uh…” Adora said.

“Now, you two will need to be shown the grounds, one of our best students can handle that,” Castaspella said, turning and ushering Eda towards the door. “And you, *Eda*, can leave as quickly as possible.”

And in the silence of the room...Catra stuck her tongue out at Adora.

Adora glared at her.

***

Catra loved it when a plan came together. She walked next to Adora – and since no one but Adora was looking at her, she let every bit of her smirk across her features. She leaned in, whispering. “Hey Adora…”

“What are you doing here?” Adora hissed back.

"Keeping an eye on you," Catra purred, quietly. "Emperor's orders."

"I-" Adora cut herself off as the two of them came out of the principal's office and stood before a corridor full of other witchlings, demons, and the lockers of the Demon Realm. Adora did a double take: She had probably just now noticed that the lockers had *teeth*.

"Hello new kids!"

Turning, she saw a tall, black skinned, cheerful looking male witch. He jogged towards them as Catra spotted that his uniform had him in the illusion track – in short, one of the most dangerous kind of magic there was. She filed that away while keeping up her 'big nerd girl in a scary new place' act. Adora was looking at him quizzically, probably trying to figure out the color coding.

The witch offered his hand. "Hi, I'm Bowdandivar Porter. You can call me Bow! I'm in illusions track, and head of the Human Club and the Archery Club." He beamed brightly at them. "You're two from Glandis and Bileside?"

"Yeah!" Adora said. "Human Clube? I mean, uh, club?"

Oh Titan, did she get brain damage when she picked up that sword? Catra thought, a bit nervously.

“Yeah,” Bow said, cheerfully. “Humans are so *cool*.” His eyes shone. “Did you know that they have amazing technology that doesn’t even use magic at all! And there are so many kinds of human.”

“There are?” Adora asked.

“Yeah, I learned it all from a human plastic scroll – one of the ones that shows a whole movie if you figure it out,” he said, cheerfully. “There were humans with orange fur, and humans with big horns, and humans who had beaks. My favorite one was the guy with the bow, Robin Hood.”

Adora blinked slowly. “Did, uh-” She hesitated as Catra put her hand over her mouth, her shoulders shaking. “Did it have a little song that went, like...do dee doo do do dee doo do?”

“Yeah!” Bow said. “Are you also fascinated by humans?”

“Kinda,” Catra admitted.

“Uh, no? Yes! I mean, I know a lot, but not *because* I’m secretly human, who’d be secretly human here?” Adora asked, clearly panicking. Catra knew from experience, though, that the Demon Realm was full of the most credulous idiots to have ever been born from the flesh of a dead god. Right on cue, Bow nodded.

"I wish you were, it'd be so cool to meet a real human," he said, as Adora went to his left, and Catra slinked to his right. She caught herself and started to move more slouchy. She needed to act like she was just a big nerd.

Now, I can keep an eye on Adora. Any time she does anything, I know. And then I can choose what Belos knows. She smirked slightly as Bow excitedly pointed out the detention pit – much to Adora's horror. *Everything will be right under my claw.*

"Catra! Hey, Catra!"

Catra jerked her head around, and glared daggers at the student who was waving at her. Said student was *Scorpia*. She mimed a slit throat with her finger and Scorpia blinked, then flinched, as if she had just remembered everything they had planned.

"What was that?" Bow asked, turning to face her.

"Oh, uh, someone was calling me a cat," Catra said, shrugging. "Cat demons are kinda rare outside of Palm Stings, I'm used to it."

"Well, tell me anything at all you need to make you comfortable!" Bow said, happily.

"Uh, could I see the lie-berry?" Adora asked, somehow being so nervous and anxious that she had managed to mispronounce a

world she knew how to say. Catra shook her head a bit sadly, while Bow nodded.

"Sure, come on!" he said, taking a left. Catra moved to follow – and then twisted and squirmed, darting aside seconds before a foot slammed down onto her tail.

"Hey!" she said – then blinked as she looked into the face of a girl she knew. By reputation, more than anything else. The girl in question had not even noticed that she had been about to plow into Catra, too busy talking to a haughty looking triclops demoness. Catra's 'hey' jerked her attention and she frowned, slightly at her. Green hair, pale skin, haughty.

It was Amity Blight. The Blight's up and coming abomination mistress. Catra had heard reports.

"Oh, sorry, normally, new kids know how to stay out of the way of their betters," the tricops said, smirking as she used two of her eyes to look scornfully down at Catra – while her lower left was stuck on her pentsagram scroll, which she was scrolling along.

"Yeah, Boscha, you distracting me is her fault," Amity said, her voice cool as she walked past Catra. Catra watched her go, biting her lower lip as she leaned against a wall.

...she's pretty... she thought.

In the Emperor's Coven, there wasn't a whole lot of time for any romance, period. A few guards did get caught smootching on duty – there was nothing that could stop anyone crammed together as close as they were from doing that. But Catra...it wasn't that she was *stuck* on Adora. It was just that no one she had ever met had been good enough for her. Which included Adora. Catra clicked her claws against the wall, considering her mission, and...she shook her head.

I need to keep an eye on Adora, she thought.

Then she stepped away from the wall.

And a teeny tiny thought flicked through her mind. It was not entirely formed. Her conscious mind didn't even register it.

...she'd be jealous…

In the surface of her brain, Catra did think: *But, getting a handle on the daughter of* the *abomination genius of the Boiling Isles? Now that is something worth while.*

She started to walk after Amity, her hand ducking into her pocket. She tapped a quick pent to Entrapta and Scorpia to tell them to monitor the library, then started off after Amity. She caught up with her without even needing to move too quickly, her smile shy,

her glasses catching and glinting in the light. “A-Are…” She paused. “I…”

“Yes?” Amity asked, sounding prim and focused.

But Catra, in her glance over, immediately twigged that Amity probably met people who were more interested in her rich parents than her. So, that was a bad approach. Then her eyes spied the very edge of a book. Normally, people wouldn’t be able to identify a book from an edge of a cover, but...this book she knew so well she could practically rewrite it from memory. She let out as close to an Adora-ish gasp as she could manage.

“You read the Good Witch Azura!?”

Amity’s entire face turned beat red. She clutched her bag to her chest. “What!?” She exclaimed, sounding horrified, like Catra had just called out her being a non-magical witch who got by on cheating and chicanery. “No! What’s a Good Witch Azura!?” She hesitated, then looked like she was torn between running away and summoning an abomination to beat Catra black and blue. Catra held up her hands.

“W-Whoa! I’m not...I r-read them too!” she said, sheepishly. “My name is Elizabeth. Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce.”

Amity’s flush didn’t fade so much as it just intensified. “I-I didn’t know anyone else in the Boiling Isles read them. I...are you a new

student? Yes, of course you are, what a...stupid question." She paused. "Which was your favorite?"

"I liked The Good Witch Azura and Hectae's Third Alliance, book 14," Catra said, grinning. "Did you ever think that, like...Azura and Hectae...had a *thing* for each other?"

"Oh my Titan, yeah!" Amity whispered, leaning in close as they resumed walking.

***

Scorpia hunched low to keep her head from peeking over the stacks. She narrowed her eyes, using the very tips of her claws to scoot the books aside, peering through them. Beside her, Entrapta was humming and fiddling with a small-

Scorpia jerked her head around. "Is that Catra's staff?" she whispered.

"Hmm? Oh yeah, I borrowed it to see how it channels magic using tech," Entrapta said. "Belos' engineering is *amazing*, but this is decidedly behind the curve of the modern tech I've seen in the castle. I think it might be a prototype that he gave to the Golden-"

"Entrapta!" Scorpia whispered. "We need to be under cover! Normal students at Hexside don't have staffs! Yet! Hide it!"

“Mmm...okay,” Entrapta said. “I’ll have to take notes on sociology then, instead of tech. Which is just as fascinating – I’ve never seen so many hormonal, immature witches in one places at once. Oh, there’s our subject.”

Scorpia jerked her head back. She was right, there was Adora and Bow. They were walking into the library, with Bow gesturing wide. Then together, they walked to the stacks, Adora looking impressed – but then both yelped as, with a purple spray of glitters and sparkles, another witchling appeared before them. She and Bow laughed, while Bow gestured between them. Scorpia sighed.

“I wish we could hear what they were *saying*,” she breathed.

“We can use this,” Entrapta said, her hair holding up a small directional magical microphone. Scorpia picked it up and gingerly held it – then, in her nerves, snipped it in half. As the two halves fell to the ground, Entrapta wordlessly held up a second microphone. This time, her claws trembling, Scorpia flicked the switch on and aimed it.

“-mmer Park!” she was saying, taking Adora’s hand and shaking it. “So, you’re one of those clawthornes...my mom says that the Owl Lady is the best witch in the whole Boiling Isles. She sounds so cool.”

“She is! Uh, a little scary and weird, but cool,” Adora said, nodding. “Say, uh, just a crazy, uh, random question, do you two

know about Catra? The Golden Guard?”

“Yeah,” Bow said.

“Everyone does,” Glimmer said.

“Okay, what if I thought that the Golden Guard was going to this school,” Adora whispered. “Like, right now.”

“Whoa!” Bow whispered.

“Then I’d be suspicious!” Glimmer said, punching her own palm. “My mom-” She stopped herself before saying anything more.

“Heh, Glimmer’s mom *hates* Belos almost as much as the Owl Lady,” Bow said, nodding. Adora grinned, shyly.

“Okay so…” She said, leaning in. “That other new student? Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce? She’s *Catra*.”

The two other students blinked at her.

“How?” Bow asked. “I mean, she has glasses.”

“Yeah, that doesn’t make any sense,” Glimmer said, shaking her head. “If she wears glasses, then she’d have to take them off to wear the Golden Guard costume – then she wouldn’t be able to see.”

Adora blinked at the two of them.

Scorpia breathed a slow sigh of relief. *What kind of manipulative genius are we playing with?* She thought. *She saw right through Catra’s disguise.*

“Faaaaaaaascinating,” Entrapta whispered. “Lets add variables to the experiment!”

“No, Entrapta,” Scorpia whispered back. “Not yet! Catra said we’re just here to wa- oh, they’re leaving.” She stood, knocking over the shelf with a crash, her microphone almost tumbling from her hands. She tensed, ready for everyone to yell at her, but Adora, Glimmer and Bow were already out the door…

And then she turned to find herself looking at a frowning teacher.

“Uh…” Scorpia said.

“Detention.”

Entrapta and Scorpia yelped as the school guards – skull faced, leering creatures – grabbed onto their arms and dragged them away from their task, and towards detention. Entrapta, her eyes wide and excited, whispered to Scorpia.

"This is going to yeild so many results!"

Scorpia groaned.

Adora Gray does a Microaggression

Chapter Summary

Catra works on seducing Amity Blight - something that is entirely part of her long term strategic goals and definitely NOT her sublimating her feelings about Adora onto the first girl she's met who also likes The Good Witch Azura, don't you dare suggest otherwise - while Adora repeatedly puts her foot in her mouth.

...metaphorically, not literally.

Chapter Notes

So, you may have noticed, there was a long break between this chapter and the prior one! Basically? My e-mail and discord got hacked by some dipshit and I'm still in the process of getting all that stuff sorted. I'm going to try and get back onto schedule with this here story, so, never you fear! Now, on with the story!

…oh, also, everyone is eighteen! Just to be clear. This is a crossover fanfic where some characters are canonically nineteen and twenty, and some are sixteen or fifteen, so, I split the difference and made them all eighteen.

…also, this is where those of you reading this on AO3 learn I am also an erotica author. Sorry and/or you're welcome!

NOW! On with the story!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

I can never, ever, ever let anyone learn this.

Catra's icy thought rushed through her brain faster than she could process it – a momentary flicker of paranoia making her glance over her shoulder, nervously. Fortunately, for once in her life as the Golden Guard, her underlings were following her instructions...even if it was somewhat unexpected in the case of Scorpia and Entrapta. Those two were doing their job, leaving her unobserved…

Leaving her secret…

Safe.

"And then when Prince Glitterding burst through the painting with a sword!" Catra whispered. "And Hectae drops the 'forsooth, he doth lived!' line?"

"It was *so cool*!" Amity Blight squealed, her purple eyes glittering as the two girls walked together past the lockers of Hexside. "Did you catch the lead up to it, it's so subtle."

"Lead up?" Catra asked, her brows twitching up.

"Yeah, when Prince Glitterding's 'body'," Amity said, twitching her free fingers, her other arm looped around the book-stack she was holding to her chest. "Falls onto the dust, the description says that it *leaves no mark*. Because-"

“Because it’s an illusion, duh!” Catra gasped. “I read that book thirty times, I just got that!”

Amity giggled. “I caught that, first pass, I called it, I called it.”

“Wow,” Catra whispered.

“You know, I’ve never met anyone whose even heard of the Azura books, Elisabeth,” Amity said, smiling shyly.

Catra blushed and brushed some of her brown hair behind one of her ears – adjusting her fake glasses with the same gesture. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw that Amity’s cheeks were beginning to practically *glow* pink. Catra ducked her head forward, hiding her ruthless grin. *Got her,* she thought. Then her ears twitched. She could hear smug voices and laughter coming up behind her. She turned a bit and peered over her shoulder – and saw that a triclops that might as well have ‘queen of school’ printed on her forehead. Save, well. She had an eye there.

“Amity, what are you doing hanging with this *dork?”* The triclops said, sneering. Catra flicked through her memory and slotted name to face: *Boscha*. That was who Amity had called her. Catra had seen notes on her in one of the dozens of reports and files that she had snoozed through in her role as the Golden Guard, and not a single one of them sprang to her mind now. She supposed she’d have to wing it.

Amity pursed her lips. “Elizabeth here is a new student. I’m just showing her around, Boscha,” she said.

“Y-Yeah,” Catra said, shrinking slightly and shifting behind Amity, peeking over her shoulder. It felt strangely familiar to do that. She gulped and tightened her grip on her schoolbooks as Boscha sneered and shook her head.

“Just leave her to the losers like Bow or Glimmer,” Boscha said. “She’s a cat-demon, you know what *they’re* like.”

The other girls surrounding Boscha giggled.

Catra felt her claws *snick* into the book. Cardboard and paper curled under razor sharp edges as her knuckles suddenly whitened. She felt short of breath. Sick, even. She gulped. *What is happening to me?* She thought, her breath coming short and quick. Boscha stepped closer, and Catra heard her voice echoing from a distance.

“*They’re all…”*

Black and white. The memory was in black and white. The painful sparking. The stern voice. *Now, Miss Weaver, we’re just trying to help you.* She closed her eyes.

"...just basically one step away from being wild witches, everyone says it," Boscha's voice – not following the expected pattern, snapped Catra back to the present. Her skin prickled with sweat and she wheezed softly, remaining behind Amity and ducking her head forward. She breathed in and held it, trying to keep herself from collapsing.

They're not like that here, she thought. *They're not like that here. They're not like that here.*

She breathed out, feeling her claws relax from the book, while Amity said, her voice icy cold. "Like Eberwolf? A coven head? Hm. Interesting supposition, do you want to maybe stop talking out of your backside and let me finish hanging out with Elizabeth here?"

The rest of the girls oohed, softly, while Amity blinked – a faint shocked expression flickering over her face, as if she hadn't expected herself to say that. Catra's mind worked quick. She put her hand on Amity's shoulder, carefully making sure her claws were firmly retracted. "H-Hey, it's okay, we can just go," she whispered, trying to put just the right level of *aww please protect me* patheticness in her voice. Amity frowned and squared her shoulders, while Boscha shook her head, her scowl growing fiercer.

"Amity, I think you forget whose on top around here," Boscha said. "Who here is the captain of the grudgby team? Who is it who doesn't get to play at all anymore? Oh, right!" She said. "I can push around anyone I *want*."

“There’s more to life than grudgby,” Amity said, frowning.

“No there isn’t,” Boscha said, then grinned. A wicked idea clearly flickered through her eyes as she smirked wider. “See you two at P.E.”

She stalked off, her girls following after her, giggling and whispering to one another. Catra’s ears twitched as she hastily hid her school book so that Adora didn’t see her markings on it. Amity shook her head a bit, then turned to face her. “Sorry about that. Boscha thinks the whole world revolves around her.”

Catra smiled, shyly. “A bit like, uh, Hectae’s evil twin, huh?”

“Totally,” Amity said, smiling. “Besides, P.E this week’s just cardio, it’s not like she can do anything to us in Cardio.”

Catra nodded – though she was already fairly sure she knew wha-

Adora. You called Amity...Adora...in your head.

She blinked at the thought.

“Are you okay?” Amity asked.

“Y-Yeah. Fine. Sorry. Just.” Catra flushed. “Bullies are...are kinda scary.”

“Don’t worry,” Amity said, smiling slightly. “I’m not about to let the first member of, uh, uh...the...the...Azura Book Club, get, uh, bullied! Out! OF school! The club that exists, right now! I decided!” She blushed, harder. “Lets get to class!”

***

“For P.E today, I’ve decided we’re going to...shake things up!” The P.E teacher, a big burly looking demon with a cheerful demeanor and a grudgby ball between his meaty palms. “How about some amateur grudgby, everyone?”

Called it. Catra thought, while Amity glowered at Boscha, who stuck her tongue out at her. Then Catra spotted someone in the far end of the crowd of students.

A shock of blond hair.

Pointed ears.

Adora. She frowned, hard, while Boscha stuck her hand into the air. “I volunteer to lead one of the teams!” she said, immediately.

“Very good,” the P.E teacher said. “Who wants to captain the other team?”

“I guess I’ll do it,” Amity said, squaring her shoulders and stepping forward. She bit her lip, while the P.E teacher had her flip a coin and catching it from the air. She slapped her palm down and both her and Boscha leaned over.

“Snails,” the teacher said, nodding. “You pick first, Boscha.”

Boscha grinned, then pointed out one of her fellow grudgby bests. Amity bit her lip, then pointed at Adora. “Uh, you, new girl.”

“M-Me? I...uh, sure! I’ve, uh, played...sport! Before!” Adora said, looking like she was stepping out into traffic. She glanced at her...her two...Catra’s eyes narrowed. That was Bow Porter, and that glittery hair had to be Glimmer Park. Glimmer Park had a *lot* written about her in the documents – none of it conclusive. If it had been conclusive, then her entire family would be in the Conformatorium right now. And seeing them standing around Adora...seeing the way Adora glanced at them, the way Bow gave her a thumbs up.

So, she’s picked friends, already, huh? Catra thought. Her eyes flashed and she tightened her grip behind her back. *Well, I have a new friend too. And-*

“Elizabeth?”

She jerked her head around, noticing that Boscha had picked another – and Amity was pointing at her.

Catra brushed her hand through her hair, trying to look demure and innocent. She walked forward, while Adora scowled. "Hey, *Elizabeth*," she said, stressing the name, hard. "Have you ever played, uh, grudgles before?"

"N-No," Catra said, meekly. "B-But I have w-watched a lot."

Amity, glancing between the two of them, frowned and whispered. "Do you two know each other?"

"N-No, we're just new students, and...did I do something t-to make you mad?" Catra asked.

Adora blinked. "I- no! I...just...uh…" She stammered, looking guilty – which made Amity look at her suspiciously, frowning intently.

The P.E teacher coughed. "Blight. Pick your next player."

The picks went off – with Bow and Glimmer being drafted to Amity's side while the rest of the class ended up on Boscha's. The two teams were given the field and Amity gestured everyone in,

whispering softly. “All right, what’s your spell specializations?” she asked, firmly.

“Portals,” Glimmer said, nodding.

“Good, we can use your for logistics and flanking,” Amity said. “Elizabeth?”

“I-I can cast a lot of anything, but, um, I have to d-do it a special way,” Catra said, gulping.

“What *kind* of special way, Cat-” Adora caught herself. “Elizabeth.”

Amity’s expression grew even more icy. Inside, Catra wanted to purr. Instead, she tried to look as icy, blank faced, and struggling to control her emotions as she could. “W-Well, if you have to know, I’m n-not a...I’m a magicless demon. I have to cast using special glyphs and runes. I-It takes a bit of extra effort, but I s-swear it’s good.”

“Uh-huh,” Adora said, her voice suspicious.

“Stop badgering our transfer student, Adora,” Amity said.

“I’m not badgering!” Adora said, sounding surprised. “J-Just...there…” She looked torn between wanting to say three things at once – and Amity ran right over her, pointing at Bow.

“Illusions, right?”

“And archery!” Bow said.

“How can archery be any use in a grudgby match?” Amity whispered.

Bow grinned at her. “You’d be surprised!”

“All right. Glimmer, you move Elizabeth out of danger. Bow and I will spoil any attacks with abominations and archery. Adora...you seem like a tough girl. Can you get the ball through the hoop as many times as possible?BAmity asked.

“Can do,” Adora said, nodding. Amity frowned at her, then nodded. “All right. Break!”

The team shuffled back, then got into positions. Catra drew some runeing paper and a stylus from her belt. She had to play this *very* carefully. The ball was knocked into the air by a blast of fire, Adora yelping and jerking backwards in shock. As the ball arced through the air, two players from Boscha’s team rushed left, already casting spell circles. Plants exploded from the ground,

thorns trying to wrap around Glimmer and Amity and yank them out of the way. Glimmer vanished with a spray of sparkles as Bow's bow snapped into existence with a poof of illusory magic. He knocked and fired an arrow – and to Catra's shock, the ball was knocked off course, then landed before her.

"How!?" She squeaked, her glasses almost falling off.

Bow, grinning, rushed past her and then waved his hand – and six Catras and twelve balls, each of them running in different directions, appeared at once.

"The illusion was that I *wasn't* armed!" he said, cheerfully.

"Park! Did you bring a *bow* and *trick arrows* to school *again*!?" The P.E teacher shouted from the sidelines. Catra shook her head and saw plant vines whipping out, cracking into the air again and again with a series of loud *snaps*. Each snap caused one of her illusions – even the one that was balancing a ball on her head and bouncing up and down happily – to puff into smoke. She started to run forward, then slammed her glyph onto the ground. Ice hissed into existance as she hopped onto it, skidding around two of the players – only for Boscha to start hurling fireballs at her.

Then Adora sprang up and punched Boscha in the jaw.

Boscha staggered and rubbed at her mouth. "Ow!" She exclaimed, while a whistle blew fiercely, the P.E teacher bellowing.

“Foul! Unlawful physical contact!” he shouted, then pointed his finger at Adora. “I don’t know how you do things in the Pits, but here, we don’t mix martial and arcane classes! Five point penalty for Amity’s team.

“B-But...she...throwing fireballs!” Adora said, sounding like she was a kitten who had been bapped on the nose. Boscha glared at her as the team started to reset. Bow and Glimmer were looking concerned, whispering to one another, but Amity’s expression was pure ice. Catra walked in close – her head ducked forward...and whispered, so softly that she was pretty sure only Adora could hear her.

“Hey Adora,” she purred. “Having fun yet?”

“I’m going to expose you,” Adora hissed.

Catra flinched away from her, then ran back to the team – and left Adora blinking and looking even more lost.

The rest of the game didn’t provide any further chances to humiliate Adora or make her look like a bully. Boscha, true to her word, was a goddess on the court. In a different circumstance, Catra would have already been trying to work out how to get *her* into the Emperor’s Coven. But even she wasn’t exactly able to plan ahead when it took every bit of her concentration to avoid being both flattened and revealed. She had to dodge, but only just barely, each time. She had to help the team win – but not so

much so that people would notice her skill. And she had to fumble and use only simple glyphs, or else people might wonder.

In the end, she felt more worn out than she would have, had she been actually trying to kill someone.

Boscha's team still won thirty to two.

"You were saying, about grudgby not being everything?" Boscha said, sneering at Amity as Amity's team stood, splattered in mud and muck, with Glimmer nursing a burned arm, and Bow wincing as he stood on his jarred ankle. "Hmm?"

"School's rules, you lost at grudgby, you gotta own up," the P.E teacher said, cheerfully.

"Fine. Sorry," Amity said, woodenly.

"There we go," Boscha said, her voice dripping with smugness, while the teacher shook his head, then waved his hand.

"Go on, hit the showers, kids," he said, casually.

They started to amble off, Bow wincing with every step. "Well," he said, grinning. "That was pretty fun. Uh, you did a great job for a

first timer, Elizabeth."

"T-Thanks," Catra said. Then Bow's eyes widened. She flicked her gaze, following the line of his sight – and saw that her shirt had ridden up along one of her sleeves, revealing the faint edge of the Emperor's Coven symbol she had inscribed in her arm. She yanked her sleeve down subtly, but it was too late. Bow was looking over from her to Adora, and then back to her again. But by then, they had reached the showers and Catra scratched her claw gently along her finger. She didn't need to draw blood – just leave a little white mark. The mini-invisibility glyph flashed unnoticed under her hand and when she removed it, the symbol was gone. She sighed, as Amity walked into the girl's shower.

"See you, uh, later!" Adora said. "Just...gonna go into a...a...public showers. With girls. And C- Elizabeth." Her face was turning red. Bow headed off to the boy's showers, while Glimmer walked in ahead of Adora – and gave Catra a chance to smirk at her.

"What's the matter, Adora?" she crooned softly. "I remember in camp, you said you *weren't* gay." She turned to face her. Her voice was soft. "Know what they did to me?"

"I-I…" Adora gulped, then flinched as Catra glared at her.

"They don't Taze twelve year olds because they like girls in *this* world," Catra hissed, her eyes narrowing.

"Did you think I *wanted* that to happen to you!?" Adora whispered back, putting her hand on her chest. "Kat...Kat I...I wanted to protect you."

"And yet, somehow, you never did," Catra said, her voice colder than icewater. She didn't quite look into Adora's eyes. She looked, instead, at her throat – at the sleek connection between shoulder and head. The visceral sense memory of hazy fantasies flashed into her mind. Despite never having doing it, she could remember the feeling of pressing her lips to that throat. She snapped her glare up. "And now that I don't need you, you finally show up." She snorted. "How pathetic are you, Adora?"

Adora didn't have an answer. She just watched as Catra turned and walked into the showers.

The warmth of the air hit her face like a comforting caress and she glanced around at the stalls. She shivered from her head to her toes as she saw Amity Blight's pale body in one, her back to her, her hair already slicked down. The Boiling Isles' relaxed attitude towards homosexuality was only matched by their utter lack of puritanism around sex – and never before had Catra so appreciated it. She licked her lips slowly and the urge to slip up and offer Amity a back-rub was...was…

Can Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce get away with that? She thought.

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Adora walking into the room, her face wooden. Adora was barely seeing anything, or else

she'd have probably had her head explode. Or, maybe…

Maybe the camp worked on her. Maybe I was just a phase. The bitterness of the thought was shockingly strong, like licking some spoiled smilk. Catra shucked her P.E shirt up and over her head, then took the stall to the left of Amity – and as she turned on the warm faucet, she glanced over her shoulder. Adora was sliding her P.E shirt up and over her head, revealing...*oh wow*. Catra's eyes widened as she saw that in the years between their last meeting and now, Adora had become...*ripped*. Her body was tightly muscled like a Greek statue, her breasts firm and high and tipped with rosy nipples that, now that she had matured, were quite possibly the most succulent thing that Catra had ever seen. Her mouth practically watered as she watched Adora skim her shorts down, revealing she was as bare as a witchling down there – she must shave religiously. The only hitch on Catra's oggling was the thick, faded surgical scar on her chest, from the heart condition that had nearly put her in the ground back when they had been...little tiny kids. The scar had faded, but it was gnarly even years and years later.

Course.

Scars were also kinda hot.

Adora walked into a stall far away – and then Catra's attention was jerked around.

"Um, are you okay?" Amity asked, her voice soft. She was just barely able to peek over the stall, her bright eyes full of concern.

“Y-Yeah. I think Adora just...d-doesn’t like cat demons. Or maybe s-she doesn’t like me.” Catra said, then blushed...and looked around, as if she was blind. Her glasses had been set on her clothing as she found her shower, so, she had a perfect chance. “Um...w-where’s the soap?” She chuckled. “I’m so blind without my glasses.”

Amity chuckled. “Here.” She said, then walked around the stall. The closeness of her body was electrifying – far more intense than any of Catra’s flings while in the Emperor’s Coven. *Maybe it just gots hotter when you lie to a chick,* Catra thought to herself as Amity placed a bar of soap into her hands, then gasped softly. “W-Wow! Uh...claws!”

“Y-Yeah, I have em,” Catra said, her fingers flexing slightly, the claws biting into the soap. Amity’s entire face had gone red.

“W-what about these two?” Amity asked, pointing at her pointer and index finger, which Catra kept enchanted with a complicated little glyph she etched into them every morning so that they’d become dull, blunt and short when she was near a naked girl.

“...uh…” Catra said, and managed through a herculean effort of will to seem as if she was embarrassed at Amity from noticing, her cheeks blushing more and more, as Amity froze, then let out a nervous little laugh.

“H-Hah! Wow! Uh! Claws!” She stammered. “I-I should go!”

Catra considered, in that moment, how she was essentially running a triple bluff, with the goal to keep Adora under her thumb and Titan-Ra from being immediately captured and recruited by the Emperor Belos, while also getting some much needed revenge on Adora for everything she had done to her. That depended her entirely on keeping her identity as the unassuming Meow Meow Applesauce on lock and unshakable – she had already let a tiny crack show by forgetting her coven marking. So, doing anything but meekly letting Amity from sliding from the stall would be the height of short sighted stupidity. It wasn't like she thought entirely with her crotch, after all.

"...wait," Catra whispered.

Amity froze, her eyes widening.

Stupid! Catra thought. *You can still salvage this.*

"...d-d...do...you...need someone to wash your back?" Catra whispered, trying to sound shy and uncertain, her cheeks flushing.

"...haha...uh...s-sure!" Amity said, her cheeks burning. She stood there, her hands clasped before her belly. Catra tried to not make the fact she could take in every detail of Amity's body not extremely obvious – but *Titan* she was cute. She was more slender than Adora – not that that mattered, considering how much tougher and stronger witchlings were than the average human. Her green hair was showing just a bit of brown root, and

her ear-tips dripped with mositure as she stood with her back straight, her knees trembling, her nipples puffy and hard. The urge to push her up against the wall and just start *smothering* her in kisses...was repressed. Somehow. Catra managed it. She instead giggled.

"Y-You have to, um...turn around first."

"Right!" Amity squeaked. She turned around. Then, nervously, she said. "I-If that Adora ever...tries to bully you again, just get me. I'll set her straight."

"Uh-huh," Catra whispered as she started to rub the soapy bar that she had been given along Amity's shoulders. Warm water and thick suds of glistening soap bubbled and then slid along her back, streaking their way along the elegant curve of her spine and stopping right above her tight, tight little butt. Catra started to rub the soap down and then back up again, ssliding it along one shoulder, than another shoulder. Her free hand rubbed up and down Amity's arm, feeling her shiver of excitement. Catra leaned in, whispering.

"My hero," she giggled, softly. "L-Like, uh, Azura in the Theifcity of Quilla."

"H-Heh, yeah, uh, yeah!" Amity said. "T-Though, uh, Azura never had a homoerotic shower with the roguess Lan."

She paused.

"I mean homonormal!" She stammered. "Homonormal shower!"

Catra paused. "W-What's homoerotic?" she asked, sweetly.

"Nothing!" Amity slapped her hands over her face. And Catra grinned wickedly behind her as she rubbed her soap down and started to caress along Amity's buttocks, feeling the other girl tense up. She stepped close, pressing her own naked body to Amity's back, so she could reach around and start soaping up her belly. Warm water sluiced along their bodies and she shivered as her hard nipples started to grind gently against Amity's shoulderblades.

"I-I've never had a homonormal shower with anyone," Catra whispered in her pointed ear, her lips nearly touching that sensitive, sensitive tip. Amity flushed and gasped.

"T-This is against, um, a bunch of school rules," she whispered. "Public displays of affection. Wasting soap! Uh, uh, uh, uh…"

"R-Right, sorry!" Catra said, drawing back, and away. Amity looked back over her shoulder, her flush so bright that Catra was shocked that she wasn't *melting* through the floor in shame. "Sorry."

Amity looked at her, her cheeks burning.

Then she squeaked out. "Seeyoulaterthanksforthebackrub!"

Then she was gone – the wet slap of her feet and the *whip* noise of her catching a towel on the way out the only sign of her leaving. Catra grinned, smugly, leaning against the shower wall as she let warm water slide down her hair.

Gotcah, she thought.

***

"Hey, Amity, sorry I sounded super racist, but actually, that cat-demon is named Catra, and she's secretly the head of the evil Emperor's Coven!" Adora said, nodding. "No, wait, that won't work, most people think the Emperor's coven are heroic?"

"Not everyone," Glimmer said, her voice firm.

The three of them were trudging away from Hexside high, their backpacks stuffed with historical textbooks that they had managed to get from the library for future study. In truth, Adora had almost forgotten about it in the haze of everything else that had happened. There had been the grudgby game, and Catra, and that beautiful girl Amity, and then all the times she had just...she had...she put her hands over her face, groaning softly.

“Wait, what?” She asked, dropping her hands away from her face, turning back to Bow and Glimmer. Bow grinned and snapped his fingers – an illusory poof snapping around his body, revealing that his Hexside uniform had been modified: He had cut an entire chunk of the midsection off, revealing his tummy for the whole world to see. Glimmer, ignoring what seemed to be a totally normal, expected thing in her life, nodded and looked grave.

“My mother, Angela Park, and her husband, Micha, have been huge protestors against Belos’ overreach for ages,” she said, firmly. “They’ve been arrested, like, sixty times and only got off thanks to some of the best lawyers on the Boiling Isles. But I think...I *know* that they’re doing more than that. I just can’t get them to let me frigging join!”

“Huh,” Adora said. “Maybe I should ask Eda, if she knows.”

“She is the Isles most famous criminal,” Bow said, nodding as he did so. “But, uh...if we do this, we absolutely have to keep it away from my Dads. They’re not...loyalists or anything, they hate Belos as much as anyone. They just don’t want *me* to get involved.” He sighed. “They’re kinda dead set on me learning to follow in the family tradition.”

“What’s that?” Adora asked.

“Archaeology,” Bow said. “And it’s not like it isn’t interesting. I’ve done a whole bunch of research – did you know the Human

Realm has been dropping their trash into our world, and vice versa, for years? That's why the human realm has legends about griffons, dragons, demons, giraffes-"

"We have those," Adora said, frowning.

"Eugh!" Glimmer said, shuddering. "Why!?"

Adora looked nonplussed – but then she gasped, pointing.

"Amity! And...*Catra*." She scowled.

The two girls were actually standing in the main clearing of Bonesburrough, before the statue fountain of a masked, ominous figure that Adora was fairly sure was Emperor Belos. They were standing a good distance apart, both of them looking flustered, as if they were shyly circling around something. Adora's immediate impulse was to advance, get between them, maybe reveal Catra...but she stopped herself. She breathed in, sharply, and then glanced at Bow, whispering.

"Do you have any binoculars or something?" she asked.

"Sure," he said, making a circle with his fingers and, with a poof, a pair of binoculars appeared in his hand. Adora took them and put them to her eyes, straining her ears, frowning intently. She saw

Catra's lips moving – and she swore she was saying something about *apologizing*...for what? For lying? Was she coming clean?

"So, not to interrupt your spying on your ex-girlfriend thing," Glimmer said.

"She's not my girlfriend!" Adora squeaked, yanking the binoculars away – at the same moment Catra snapped her head up. She wasn't looking at Adora, though. She was looking off to the middle distance. Then she spun away from Amity, putting her finger to her ear, as if she was...touching a bluetooth headset. Adora's instincts jangled and she looked around, wildly.

There.

Scorpia was hiding in an alleyway, speaking into a small crowphone that she was holding, her face white as a sheet.

"What the-" Adora whispered.

That was when the horrible monster came flying from the sky and smashed into the fountain with a screeching roar and crumbling of stone and brickwork. Water gushed into the air as everyone in the courtyard screamed and dove for cover, Catra grabbing and throwing Amity behind her, stumbling backwards in shock. Adora's eyes widened as she took in the monster – it was made of fur and muscle, with an elongated aligator's snout, thick fur blooming beneath the neck and shrouding the body. Its claws were easily

the length of small swords, and it had a huge, barbed tail which whipped around behind it. It roared a furious bellow into the air, a thick greenish mist started to waft from it's mouth.

"What is that!?" Adora hissed.

"It's a apeacore!" Bow exclaimed. "But they never go this far into civilization!"

Adora glanced around.

No one was looking at her.

She had to do something.

She reached back to her backpack, finding the hilt of her sword.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

***

The darkness has come again – that comforting dark. The warm dark. It enfolds her like a blanket, wrapping around and around her shoulders, drawing tight and clenching.

And through it, she can hear a distant scream of fury and rage, wordless…

Impotent in the face of her power.

Then…

Skin bubbles, then shifts, turning ebony black. Bone bursts from the back of knuckles and fingers, ending in pale white claws. Curling horns bloom from the brow and sweep backwards as golden blond turns to dark purple, flaring and growing outwards into a wild mane, curling and rippling in the wind. Toes become long and sharp and chitinous, while clothing reshapes itself last – a jacket lengthens, becoming a dark black curiass of hardened black steel, a fluttering cape of crimson blood red sweeps outwards. The sword flashes and a haze of glittering runes flare to life, wheeling and twirling like a celestial orery for some alien sun.

The eyes open last – brilliant orange and black, glowing with a deep inner fire.

Then, at last…

It is done.

***

And Titan-Ra swung her sword down and to the side. The apeacore stood looming above Amity and Catra, who was scrambling, desperately, for her runeing paper. Titan-Ra reached down, and with a single hand, pulled a chunk of statue off the ground and flung it. It smashed into the side of the apeacore's head, swinging it hard to the side and sending the beast stumbling backwards into the spray of water from the fountain. Titan-Ra sprang forward, leaping over the two prone girls, and landed before them, her cape fluttering as she stood between them and the beast.

The beast started to shake itself, trying to stand.

In that moment, Titan-Ra looked back over her shoulder.

"Are you two okay?" she asked.

Amity lay on her back, looking up and up and up at Titan-Ra, her jaw dropped open...and the look on her face was somewhere between worship, awe, and shocked lust. She stammered. "W...Wh...Wh-"

"Get out of here!" Titan-Ra said. "This-"

The tail of the apeacore snapped out, the spines slamming into her belly and sending Titan-Ra flipping through the air and straight towards a building's wall. She snapped her arms up and runes flared around her arms and palms, flickering and flashing, snapping together with an instinctive knowledge. A purple bubble of light popped around her and she hit the wall and rebounded as if she was in a bounce castle, rolling and coming to her feet, the bubble snapping off as she got her feet under her. She shook her head – then saw that Amity and Catra were still in danger.

Catra lifted her hand, about to slap down a rune. But before she did, Titan-Ra swept her hand and sculpted a blooming flower that burst from the ground, enfolding the two and then retracting into the earth, moments before the apeacore smashed both of its meaty palms down onto where the girls had been. The flower bloomed behind Titan-Ra, revealing Catra and Amity. If anything, Amity looked even more star-struck. The look that Titan-Ra missed on Catra's face, missed in that chaotic moment, was murderously jealous.

"Get out of here!" She said, again, then charged the beast.

The apeacore breathed a wall of green fog that hissed and bubbled as it rushed towards Titan-Ra. But Titan-Ra was getting the handle of her magic – she simply needed to think what she needed, and the magic formed itself into patterns. It was like magic itself was flowing through her body. It was almost addictive, a surge of pure golden energy, heating her from her belly to her heart.

She slammed her bone-clawed hand into the ground and a wall of ice exploded up between her and the onrushing acid fog. Then

she whirled and pointed and a fireball burst from her fingertip, blowing through the wall and turning it into a haze of mist, which caught the acid fog and bore it to the ground. Through the cleared air, she advanced, the apeacore snarling and then leaping forward. He slashed with his claws – a blow that would have taken the head off any mortal or witchling that stood in its way. Titan-Ra ducked under the blow, then came up. She slashed with her blade, and the cut was shallow, most of the edge turned by the thick furs.

Armored, she thought, as the apeacore roared and aimed its mouth at her. She grabbed onto its snout with one hand, holding it fast, and acid tried to bubble around its lips as she brough the pommel of her sword up...and smashed it right down onto the center of the beast's head. Its eyes widened, then went crossed, then closed as it wobbled, then crashed to the ground. Titan-Ra stood above the beast, panting softly as her cape fluttered, her long purple hair catching the light of the noonday sun. She looked around, and saw that Bonesburrough citizens were gaping at her.

"It's Titan-Raw!" The round, mostly nose creature that she had seen a few days before exclaimed, pointing at her. "She defweated that sawvage bweast!"

"Yeah! Titan-Ra!"

"She's much better than the Golden Guard," one demon woman said, nodding firmly as she spoke loudly to her neighbor demon lady. "Whose never even fought one monster for us."

“She will be our new idol!” Another Bonesburrough citizen exclaimed, thrusting his fist into the air.

“Can we get an autograph, Titan-Ra!?”

“Do you work for the Emperor!?”

“U-Uh!” Titan-Ra said, holding up her palms. “Those are all, uh...big...look over there!” she pointed off at a random direction, then turned and rushed into an alleyway. A second later, Adora emerged, hastily cramming her sword into her backpack.

“Where did she go!?” One of the demons said, then grabbed Adora’s shoulder. “You there, girl! You just emerged from the same alleyway – did you see where Titan-Ra went?”

“Y-Yeah, uh, that way,” Adora siad, pointing down the alleyway

“After her! We shall get thowse autograffs!” The nose-girl said, thrusting her arms into the air.

As a mob, the entire group ran off down the alleyway.

Adora saw that her friends were waiting for her. Amity and Catra were gone, and so was Scorpia. She frowned, while Glimmer ran

to her side, practically vibrating. “That was amazing!” She squeaked. “That was so cool! You know what this means, right? We show you to my parents, and they’ll not have any excuse to keep me out of the rebellion! ...well, us! Us out of the rebellion!”

Adora blinked. “Right. Uh. I’ve never managed to turn into Titan-Ra unless people were directly at risk, though.”

“Then we figure that out first!” Glimmer said, taking Adora’s arm.

“Do either of you wonder why an apeacore attacked Bonesburrough?” Bow whispered.

“It’s a monster, monsters do monster stuff sometimes,” Glimmer said, flicking her hand.

And together, they walked past the unconscious beast, even as several Demon Hunters started to arrive, clearly having been called to deal with the issue. As they surrounded it, not a one of them noticed the glyph that glowed a pale gold, drawn in the intricate style that only a true master of runecrafting could manage. The rune persisted for a few moments more – but then dissolved into ash.

Leaving not a single shred of evidence.

Chapter End Notes

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Adora Gray and the Painstorm

Adora's jaw dropped as she stood before Glimmer Park's house.

"This is where you *live*?" she asked, spinning around to look at Glimmer so fast that she nearly toppled over and crashed into the ground. She caught herself, but her arms were still somewhat tangled up with herself, while Glimmer gave a little smile and a shrug of her hands.

"I-It's not so fancy!" she said, while the glittering, gold studded doors swung open and heavily armored men in House Park livery emerged, capes fluttering, to stand to either side of the daughter of Angela and Micha Park. One bowed low, murmuring.

"Your backpack, m'lady?"

"You're a m'lady?" Adora asked, then looked at Bow, who gave her a cheerful thumbs up.

"Yeah," he said. "Glimmer's parents are some of the richest and most powerful nobles in the whole Belosian Empire."

"And they-" Adora caught herself, while Glimmer shot her a glower. Then the three of them were ushered inside, where a huge fountain was set in the heart of a fancy ballroom. Everything was done in pale white, light pinks, and pastels. The rainbow hue shining off some of the gemstones was particularly striking, and Adora found it hard to pick what she was goggling at first. She swung her head left, right, up and down, while the door behind them closed.

"Ah, Glimmer!" A cheerful, feminine voice called down from the stairs – and emerging from the second story of the mansion came Angela. At least, Adora presumed she was Angela: Who else would have huge, gossamer wings of glimmering light spreading around a tall, delicate figure that was…not exactly what Adora had

expected, considering Glimmer's short and compact build. She smiled, warmly, then looked over at Adora. "And who is this?"

"This is Adora Gray!" Glimmer said, throwing her arm around Adora, drawing her in close.

"And why, pray tell, is she a human being?" Angela asked, arching one elegant eyebrow.

"Uhhhh-" Adora said.

"She's from the human realm!" Glimmer said.

"How did she know?" Adora whispered. "I have…" She put her hands to her ears, expecting to feel the illusions that Eda had placed there. Instead, she felt her normal, actual round ear tips. She blinked a few times – and made a mental note that going Titan-Ra messed up spells that had been cast on her. Angela sighed.

"You have picked a somewhat poor time to visit our realms, Adora the Human," Angela said, her hand going to Adora's shoulder, squeezing ever so gently. "The Empire is not as welcoming to strangers as one would want."

"Which is whyyyy, Mom, I wanted to tell you about a super cool thing Adora can doooo!" Glimmer said, brightly.

Angela pursed her lips, then twirled one of her fingers – drawing a momentary flicker of purple energy, which flashed to life and then, with a lurch, transported Bow, Glimmer, Adora and Angela into a small office full of paperwork and scrolls and books, with a large desk and a chair specially crafted to contain large, glimmering wings. Angela crossed her arms over her chest, her pursed lips turning into a severe frown.

"Glimmer," she said. "Once again, you are far too young to be involved in my…" She hesitated.

"Rebellion?" Glimmer said, bouncing, her tiny back-wings fluttering with excitement.

"Come on, Mrs. Park," Bow said, his voice conciliatory. "We can help! Especially with Adora, you're totally going to want her on your side." He paused to give Adora a big wink and a thumbs up.

Oh God, he thinks he's helping, Adora thought, faintly panicky.

Angela sighed, slowly. "Glimmer, you have once more proven why your father and I agree that this is not the place for you – rebellions against Empires are meant to be *secret*. You do not tell them to your school friends, no matter how human they are." She glowered at Adora. "I'm sure you are a wonderfully nice young woman, but-"

"She's the adoptive daughter of Edalynn the Owl Lady," Glimmer said. "And she can do this! Do the thing, Adora."

"Uh-"

"*Eda*."

Angela did not say Eda in the tone of voice that Adora was hoping for. Adora would have approved of 'Eda!' in the same way one might say 'apple pie' or 'free pizza' – but no, Angela had definitely said 'Eda.' in the same way that one might say 'tax collector' or 'anthrax.' And, worse, she had said it with a *hard* period. It was like getting a text message from your best friend that was just "hey." – easily the most nightmarish thing one could imagine.

Adora gulped, then reached behind herself, swinging her backpack around.

"T-This is not an assassination attempt!" she said, very loudly, drawing her sword. Angela's frown did not relent. Adora held her sword up. Breathed in. "By the Honor of Grayskull!"

Silence.

A ringing, resounding silence.

Glimmer and Bow both stood to either side of Adora, looking at her.

Adora gave a nervous little smile.

“S-So, uh, it, uh, it takes a little-“

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“-bit.” Aodra said as the door slammed directly in her face.

A moment later, Glimmer appeared next to her in a spray of pink and purple sparkles. “Titan, my mom is just so unpleasable!” she exclaimed. “Just because it failed…five or…six times…” She glanced away from Adora, who blushed and rubbed her shoulder.

The front door of the Park mansion opened and Bow walked out backwards, waving.

“Bye Mrs. Park! Uh, see you tomorrow!”

The door shut and he turned back to Adora, giving her a smiling wince. “Thaaaaaat could have gone better.”

“Well, uh,” Adora said. “I guess that’s that-“

“No, it’s not *that*,” Glimmer said, her voice fierce. “There’s still one person we can talk to about this.”

She grabbed onto Adora and Bow’s arm and dragged them away from the manor and towards the forests around Bonesburrough. She didn’t seem to notice that, overhead, clouds were beginning

to gather. A faint, distant rumbling could be heard – the sign that, in the Boiling Isles, meant one thing and one thing only.

A risk of rain.

Which meant, in the Boiling Isles, a risk of serious *pain*.

***

"You know what this means?" Eda asked, rubbing her chin, her eyes slightly as she did so. Glimmer opened her mouth, surely about to say something, but Eda cut her off. "There's only one responsible thing that I can do here – you have incredible power, which is going to throw you straight into danger, if you flaunt it Adora." She stepped over, sliding a bony arm around Adora's shoulder. "You have to go out there and immediately start busting up heads. You need to rob banks, you need to menace the town. We need to really put the fear of the Titan in those cone-headed jerks!"

"I won't become a super-villain!" Adora exclaimed in shock, while Glimmer blinked, clearly nonplussed.

"Well, she is the *Owl Lady*, what did you expect, Glimmer?" Bow whispered as Adora shook her head and stepped away from Eda.

"I want to help people, not rob banks!" Adora said.

Eda frowned, then held up her hand, unfurling finger after finger as she ticked off points one after the other. "Firstly, those banks are all run by Belos and his Empire. People have to pay more snails than they make, just so he can pay for armor and weapons for his Conformatorium guards and the rest of the army. Secondly, any crimes you do are going to be crimes written down by *Belos*,

the biggest jerk on the Boiling Isles. And thirdly, the way you've described it…it sounds like your power only responds when people are in trouble and need the first, clawed hand of justice to come punching directly into the face of evil!"

"You know most adults *don't* want their children running directly at bad guys," Glimmer muttered, her voice dripping with jealousy.

Eda smirked. "True. I am the best." She nodded, then smacked Adora's back. "I think this is the time to test this. Go out there and start kicking butt, kiddo. The more dangerous, the better."

"Bu-" Adora stammered as she was pushed towards the door, which closed with a thump behind her, leaving her outside.

Glimmer frowned. Bow leaned over to peer out the window, then turned to Eda.

"We should go after her," he said, nodding firmly as he did so, while Eda sighed, stretching her arms over her head, her fingers interlocked to make her knuckles pop and crackle alarmingly.

"No, this is the kind of thing girls have to figure out on their own, kiddo," Eda said. "…also, where is the rest of your shirt?"

Bow looked miffed.

"Uh, what's that?" Glimmer asked, pointing at Eda. Eda followed the angle of her finger and saw the window.

"Huh, looks like a pain storm," she said. "This is good, it'll force Adora to change or die." She nodded, sagely.

"No, *that*," Glimmer pointed again.

Eda blinked and then held up a hand covered with bristling feathers, fur, and glistening claws.

"Ah, that," Eda said, frowning. "I don't suppose either of you have seen any, uh, glowing, uh, golden bottles around here?"

Bow and Glimmer both shook their heads.

"Rats," Eda muttered.

***

Adora walked towards Bonesburrough, her hands tightening before her chest as she gripped her sword. She felt like she had slightly lost the current of her life – and was just riding along a river that was heading towards somewhere dark and dangerous. She frowned and barely noticed the distant rumbling noise – nor the sight of everyone running towards doors and windows being shut. Her head was instead entirely focused on the same circular pattern of thoughts.

Catra.

Amity.

Her mom.

Amity.

Catra.

Her mom.

The mirror vision.

Catra.

"Amity!"

"One second!"

Adora jerked her head up and yelped as she dove behind some cover before Amity noticed her. She peeked out as she saw that Amity was hurrying after a pair of green haired youths – twins, from their look – and then blinked as Amity yelped, tripping over a rock in the road. Her books went scattering and Amity scrabbled wildly for everything she had dropped. She frowned and waved a finger subtly – and a puddle of purple ooze came flowing up and out of a small bottle at her hip, forming an umbrella over her head.

Wow, neat umbrella, but it's barely dri-

Adora's thought was cut off as a single droplet of rain hit one of the cloth awnings that stretched over the market stalls and streets of Bonesburrough. It didn't so much slow down as hiss ominously, shooting through the thick cloth to spatter onto the ground right before her nose, bubbling into the mud like ferocious acid.

What!? Adora's brain exploded with sudden panicky fear as Amity's umbrella hissed and sputtered – the purple goo absorbing shot after shot of rain as more and more dropped from the sky. A stinging blast of agony hit Adora's calf and she realized she was decidedly *in trouble*.

"Forthehonorofgrayskull!" She hissed as fast as she could, yanking her sword out.

The transformation was faster this time. Darkness swept around her, tightened, bloomed. She stood – and she was, once more, Titan-Ra. She looked around, nervously, and then blinked as she felt the touch of rainwater on her shoulders. A shimmering, golden-white light seemed to pervade her body, surrounding her like a halo. Each droplet of rain hit her and simply…ran down her body. Her clothing absorbed it as if it was nothing but pure water, and the only thing that made her feel as if she wasn't on Earth was how warm and pleasant it was.

Titan-Ra held a clawed hand up, her mouth opening in shock as she spread her fingers, claw-tips glinting brightly.

"Whoa," she whispered.

Then her ears twitched – pointed and sensitive, they heard the *glup* noise of abomination goo starting to give way. She saw that Amity had gotten almost all of her books up and was starting to stand…but she apparently had more trust in her magic than she should have. A huge chunk of the goo simply sloughed aside…and Titan-Ra was there, standing above Amity, her arm and her little fluttering cape spreading wide to cover Amity's head and shoulders. Amity, her mouth opened in shock and alarm, froze as she stood and looked up into Titan-Ra's gold on black eyes.

For a moment, the two stood there, rain beginning to sleet down, cascading along Titan-Ra's muscular arms and back, beading and dripping from the broad brim of her hat. She felt her horns tingle with the touch of the rainwater, as every droplet hissed and sizzled.

Amity stood there in total silence – and the only noise that she made was the thundering of her heart as her entire face went completely, beat red.

"…a-are you okay?" Titan-Ra whispered.

"Ohmytitan," Amity whimpered.

"H-Heh, no, just Titan-Ra. Your. Uh." Titan-Ra had a faint inkling that maybe now was not the time to add *friendly* or *neighborhood* to that. Instead, she coughed. "Come on."

Titan-Ra realized that she could simply sheath her sword over her back, freeing her other arm to wrap Amity in close against her cloak and pick her entire body up. She felt as light and slender as a twig, and pressed to Titan-Ra's gambeson with a warmth that was shocking and electrifying. Hunched to make sure that not a droplet of rain got near her, Titan-Ra ducked into an alleyway and under a stone awning. There, she set Amity down, her back facing the wall. Titan-Ra planted her arms to either side of Amity, so that

her cloak and her shoulders would keep even the hint of rain away from her.

Only then did she realize that she was, essentially, hemming Amity in with her muscular arms and her cloak. Within the shadows and the darkness, Amity leaned against the wall, clutching her book to her chest, her jaw hanging open as she looked up at Titan-Ra.

"A-Are you okay?"

"Uh-huh," Amity whispered.

Titan-Ra gulped.

"What weather, am I right?" Titan-Ra asked.

"W-Why did you save me?" Amity whispered.

"I'm not about to let a pre…a…a girl get melted!" Titan-Ra stammered.

"I meant earlier, too," Amity gulped. "I mean. Are you going to protect us all from monsters?" She smiled, slightly. "Seems kind of…small fry for the avatar of the Titan. The Emperor says the Titan helps people who help themselves."

"What kind of person would I be if I just let a monster squash you?" Titan-Ra asked, offended. "And, well, people used to say that about…I mean. A lot of people say that the Titan helps those who help themselves, and I always noticed that they're the kind of people who…who…"

"Who don't need much help?" Amity asked, biting her lip.

"Yeah," Titan-Ra said, looking into her eyes. She had not realized how bright gold Amity's eyes were. How beautifully they reflected the faint, eldritch glow of whatever protective field that surrounded her. She wanted to say something, but what seemed impossible to decide on.

Amity bit her lip, harder. She was looking up into Titan-Ra's eyes even more intently now. Softly, she whispered. "Are…you…you always like this?"

"Like what? I mean, uh, it's complicated," Titan-Ra said, catching how obvious the question was before she sounded completely stupid.

Amity sighed, softly. "I know what that's like. D-Does…does it hurt?"

"The rain?" Titan-Ra asked. "No. But even if it did, I'd still keep you safe."

Amity's knees trembled and she let out a tin squeak.

Titan-Ra reached down with one of her hands. Her claw-tip scraped along the wall for a moment, to brush off any rain…then gently, she caressed Amity's bright red cheek, feeling the softness of her skin. Amity shivered and didn't move. Didn't even breathe. Titan-Ra leaned forward, and a thought crossed her head. *It's easier to be brave like this.*

Amity's lips tasted warm and sweet. Her tongue darted against Titan-Ra's, and her head tilted as she reached up and around, fingers sinking into Titan-Ra's purple hair. Titan-Ra flinched, aware that her back was soaked by the rain…then relaxed as Amity showed no sign, no sign at all, of pain. She pushed against her and kissed her with a feral eagerness that was as shocking as it was addictive. Titan-Ra grabbed onto Amity's hips, lifting her up, then pressing into the kiss as well, their tongues playing together.

This movement bumped her hat against the wall, and with a lurch, Titan-Ra realized it was slipping back, off her head. The thin awning provided almost no protection…and suddenly, dribbles of deadly rainwater was pouring down onto Amity's hair. The stinging taste of it burned against Titan-Ra's lips, but rather than a scream of pain, she heard only a shocked gasping noise. Titan-Ra blinked, looking down at the girl she had failed to protect…and saw that

while Amity was soaked, the same protective shroud that was keeping *her* safe was keeping Amity from boiling away in the rain.

Amity looked as if she was about to faint. She slid her hands along her hair, her feet dangling off the ground as Titan-Ra kept her up and against the wall. Her eyes half closed and she tilted her head back, letting the water soak her throat, her neck, her shirt – it clung to her body like a second skin as she whispered. "What…is this?"

"It's rain," Titan-Ra crooned, her eyes shining and bright.

"I-I never knew it could feel so good," Amity laughed. "T-They say this is what rain feels like in the Human Realm."

"Yeah," Titan-Ra said, then eeped as Amity threw her arms around her neck, her shoulders. She drew herself up and kissed Titan-Ra with an even more eager press of mouth to mouth. They stumbled away from the wall, letting the rain pour down them both as Titan-Ra's hands swept down to Amity's ass, holding her up and against her body. They kissed and kissed and kissed.

When Amity drew away, gasping and laughing, she sounded giddy. "W-What's your real name?" She asked, laughing. "Y-You said it was complicated, but-"

A sudden *twee twee twee* noise rang out.

Titan-Ra jerked her head up.

Two Conformatorium guards were standing at the head of the alleyway, their bodies protected by shrouds of shimmering magic as the deadly rain hit and splattered atop them. "You there!" one shouted. "Public indecency! Endangering a student! Impersonating a folk hero!"

"She's not *impersonating* anything!" Amity snarled, her eyes flashing as Titan-Ra set her down, her cheeks flushed.

"She's not in any danger, either!" Titan-Ra said.

"Well, she is now!" one of the guards said.

"Uh, Mark, we're supposed to be guards," the other guard said. "We're supposed to be, like, you're not in danger."

"Shut *up,* Steve!"

And that?

That was when Catra showed up to make everything much worse.

***

Catra hated paroling in the rain. The fact she was draped in a cloak that Entrapta had told her was almost certainty positively most likely entirely completely, save for any flaws or errors, immune from all Boiling Isles weather events ranging from painbows to hurrigales to knife-winds did very little to sooth her jangling nerves.

How did a apeacore get in through our defenses?

How? The Emperor had been standing, looking out the window at the gathering storms. *How else would we seek to draw Titan-Ra from her hiding? Did you have a chance to...speak to her, after I handed you such a valuable opportunity?*

Catra had ducked her head down. Her voice had been soft. *No, sire.*

No.

The single ringing word still burned in her ears. She gripped her staff with her knees and her knuckles with equal intensity, her

teeth grinding. She had to keep Titan-Ra out of the Emperor's hands. She had to keep *Adora* away from the court. Every time she thought about her being among the Emperor's Coven, she could see the steps: Raw magic at a human's fingertips, without needing runes or paper?

Bye bye Catra. You were a so so Golden Guard. You know, as long as you lasted.

Catra shook her head. She had to find a better excuse to keep Titan-Ra away from the court.

Which was when she spotted the flash of light.

She swung her staff around and peered down through the murky, hissing rain and saw that the flash had been Adora transforming. The burly shape of her alternate form darted forward through the rain, then swept up around...the shock of green hair made it all too obvious. Catra's hands clenched even harder and her eyes widened as she saw Adora usher Amity Blight out of the rain and into security. The two of them were close together, whispering to one another.

Amity's mine, a snarling voice hissed at the back of her mind.

Which...was stupid.

Amity was no more *hers* than any other tool was *hers*. She could be thrown away at any time. Catra wasn't the kind of girl who got attached to people when she was undercover. Titan's blood, Amity didn't even know her real name. And yet, the anger and heat in her chest was so intense that she didn't even notice she had yanked her crow phone from her vest. Ducking over so the robes around her kept the phone safe, she hissed into it.

"I have something to report…"

She watched as the guards tromped from their posts. As she watched, broodingly, she realized...that this was actually a genius plan. She could see Adora fighting against other witches, and she

could further prove that Titan-Ra would never join the Emperor's coven. All without making it seem like her fault. She smirked behind her mask.

The two guards started posturing. Adora said something back, flicking her arm out. Amity added something. The situation still hadn't escalated to a fight. Well, then, she'd have to do it herself. She angled the staff down, darting towards the alleyway...and landed with a splatter of mud and, hissing, boiling rain. She twirled her staff around and held it at her flank, while the guards yelped and sprang backwards. Adora didn't even flinch. She narrowed her eyes.

"Hey-" Catra started.

"You!"

The voice didn't startle her as much as the venom in it. She blinked and looked past Adora to Amity Blight, who was still hiding under the protective arm and cape that Adora was holding above her. She pointed, ignoring the droplets of rain that glinted on her finger. *How is that not burning her?* Catra thought.

"You, uh, know her?" Adora asked.

"Everyone knows the Golden Guard," Amity said, frowning.

"What can I say, I'm pretty famous, do you want an auto-" Catra started.

"No, you bootlicking *jerk*!" Amity shouted, then kicked a bit at the mud, sending it splashing at Catra's feet. Catra skip-hopped backwards, once more hating the fact she had to patrol in boots. The mud was thick with acid rain, so there was no chance she could have her feet out, as she preferred.

"You...don't like the Golden Guard?" Adora asked, sounding completely brain-dead shocked.

"Of course I don't," Amity said, her voice haughty. "She's a trumped up Belosian stooge who my Mom keeps fawning over. Well, I have my own opinions – and I know what I feel about someone who uses their talents the way the Golden Guard does."

"You don't like the Golden Guard," Adora said, sounding like a dawning realization was hitting her.

Catra glared from behind her mask. "Oh ha ha, very funny, *Titan-Ra*," she said, her voice as venomous as Amity's. "Course, Blight here doesn't know anything about you."

"She's Titan-Ra! She's the avatar of the titan! And it looks like she wants to kick your butt, which...heh, I mean, it says a lot about the Belosian Empire, doesn't it?" Amity asked, smirking smugly.

"Hmm, true. Assuming she's the real Titan-Ra. Which I'm going to prove. I don't think the Avatar of the Titan is going to go down like a chump," Catra said, cracking her knuckles – and then blinked as the cloud cover started to break, the rain droplets hissing and sizzling. The last one fell and she chuckled behind her mask. "Nice timing."

She snatched her robes off and threw it at Adora's face. Her titan-infused body was apparently immune to Boiling Isles weather, but Catra didn't let that slow her down. As Adora stumbled, Catra rushed forward and slid underneath the burly warrior – slapping down a plant growth rune on the ground. A vine as thick around as a redwood tree sprang to life and slammed into Adora's belly, sending her flying up and up into the air, then coming down a few blocks away with a resounding crash. Catra leaped up onto the wall, then kicked off-

And flipped in the air, her foot hitting a patch that felt more like ice than rough stone walls. She yelped, flailed her arms, then crashed back into the mud. She blinked through her mask up at the wall – and saw a thick patch of abomination goo there. Amity smirked, looking down at her.

"Oops," she said.

Catra snarled and repressed the intense urge to kiss that smug look off that smug witchling's smug face. She kipped to her feet, then snapped her fingers. "Guards, earn what little we freaking pay you and arrest her," she said.

"Uh, she's a Blight, ma'am!" one said.

"Titan *damn* it, Steve, follow my frigging-" Catra saw the glinting shape rushing towards her from the sky. She sprang backwards as Adora landed, fist first, onto the ground where she had stood. The impact rocked the ground and sent Catra flying backwards. She slapped a safe fall spell onto her chest and skidded to a stop at the end of the alleyway as Adora...no...as Titan-Ra stood in the crater she had created, steam and smoke hissing off her. The angry flash of light in her eyes was…

Decidedly…

Not Adora.

Catra frowned.

"Amity, get out of here," Titan-Ra said, quietly.

"No, I-"

Titan-Ra waved her hand. Glittering runes flared and a purple portal opened up underneath Amity, who yelped as she dropped into it.

"What's your plan, Titan-Ra?" Catra asked.

"I'm going to tie you up and drag you back to the human realm and talk some goddamn sense into you, that's what I'm going to do," Titan-Ra said, and there was Adora, once more clearly audible in her voice. Catra smirked behind her mask – and noticed both guards were cowering behind a trash can.

Fine.

She worked better alone anyway.

Adora came at her exactly like Adora always came at everything: Like a bull in a china shop. Catra ducked left, then right, then left again, smirking. It felt like they were kids again – playing around, roughhousing. The memories were grainy and grayish, but she knew every little step, every little move. She skidded backwards, her boots kicking up mud as she spoke, softly enough to only be heard by Adora.

"So, you and Blight were kissing, huh?" She asked, stepping to the left, then the right, then the left again – evading each of Adora's clumsy blows, going in a nearly totally perfect circle around her, her heels skimming along muck and mire with every movement. "What will your Mom think?"

"Leave her out of this," Adora said, then grabbed at her chest. Catra flipped backwards, landing on the plinth of the statue of Belos in the center of town. She smirked, then jerked her chin.

Adora looked down.

And saw that she was now standing on a mostly finished ice rune.

Catra leaped up and landed beside the rune. She finished it with a single swipe of her foot, lifted her arm to bring it down – and blinked as Adora's hand flashed out, clawed fingers wrapping around Catra's gloved wrist and hauling her up and off the ground. Catra wriggled around, brought her feet up, and slammed them into Adora's chest. The impact staggered the bigger woman, but the grip around her wrist was like a vice. Catra slammed her left hand's fingers into the join of thumb and fingers. The impact caused Adora to hiss, her fingers open. Catra fell, landed beside the rune, but their shifting feet had already mucked it up.

She snatched up some mud, flung it, then scrambled to her feet and drew her artificial staff in the same motion.

"Stand *still*!"

Adora thrust out her hand and green runes flickered around her fingers. Vines exploded from each of them. Catra ducked one, snarled as a second and third wrapped around her right arm, then brought her staff down in a cutting motion, whistling fiercely as she did so. She preferred rune magic, but through her staff, she could tap into every one of the Coven schools.

That included bardic magic.

The compressed sound-blade sliced through the air, severing the vines down to the base of Adora's wrist, causing her to stumble backwards.

Catra panted, softly, then twirled her staff. "I won't do what you say anymore!" she said. "You were always the boss back home, but here? I'm in charge!" She swung the staff down, whistling a high note. Another sound-blade slashed against Adora, but she crossed her arms, her clawed fingers interlocking to create a shield of magic and flesh alike. She skidded backwards, then skidded backwards again and again as Catra whistled note after note.

By now, citizens of Bonesburrough were coming out, gaping in shock at the display of magic in their community.

Catra lifted her staff up, about to bring down a concussive hammer of noise which might have knocked Adora flat on her backside, Titan-Ra or no. Then she remembered…

Right.

She couldn't beat her, not *now*.

But maybe she could…

The image flashed through her mind, and the temptation was overwhelming. Knock Adora out. Take her away. Make her grovel. Make her see Catra was right and she was wrong.

Then...then...the image was hazy and electrifying. Catra smirked, then swung her staff down, singing out a single, high piercing note.

And Adora shouted back.

"***Stop***."

A coruscating rainbow explosion bloomed from around her head and her mouth, ringing outwards. The bardic magic that Catra had conjured flurried apart into a harmless spray of sparks and Catra was left blinking in shock.

I didn't know she could do that, she thought.

Adora, also, looked as if she hadn't known she could do that.

Then Adora did what might be the smartest thing she could possibly have done.

She waved her hand, opened a portal, and jumped into it. Catra sprang forward, then snarled. "Titan damn it," she hissed, then glowered up at the gathered citizens. She spread her hands, angrily.

"What!?" she asked.

They, hastily, found something else to occupy themselves with.

***

Catra was rehearsing how she was going to report this to Belos in a way that still left her seeming like she was competent when she heard a voice calling out behind her.

“Elisabeth?”

Catra, who had shucked her uniform and tucked it away as she walked home, to let her think without people knowing she was the Golden Guard and, then, possibly asking her to report in faster than she wanted too, jerked her head up. She scrambled, grabbed her glasses and jammed them onto her face, turning around before Amity Blight came up to her.

“I thought it was you!” Amity said. “H-Hey! Uh, fancy, uh, meeting you out here, in the mugging district of Bonesburrough! Wow!”

“I live near here!” Catra said, which was almost not even entirely completely a lie, the Palace was only a few blocks away, past the factories and slums. “Uh, what are you doing here?” she asked.

“I got…” Amity paused and then her entire face went red. Catra repressed her immediate smirking realization. Of course. She had been protaled by Adora, and Adora was a *moron* who didn’t know how or where to put anyone, she had dumped her randomly in Bonesburrough. “...I was going for a walk!” Amity changed at the last second. “How about you? Right, you live here.” She paused. “Want to go somewhere less, uh, stabby?”

Catra blushed and ducked her head forward, her hand rubbing along her shoulder. She whispered, softly. “It’s...not so bad, is it?” she asked.

“No, it’s great!” Amity said, immediately, sounding stricken.

Catra, her lips hidden by her wild mane of hair, let herself grin. She grinned wide.

“But, uh, you like books! I work at the library!” Amity said. “Want to go, uh, there?”

Catra nodded, shyly, lifting her head. “I would like that. A lot. But, um, let me just call my f-foster parents…” She said, softly, sure that every last little detail she was letting slip was hooking Amity farther. She stepped away to an alleyway, taking out her crow

phone and then holding her hand over it, to make it harder for Amity to hear. She whispered into it. “Scorpia.”

“Yeah, wildcat? Uh, do you need help? I hear Titan-Ra was active around there.”

“Tell the Emperor that I’m in deep under cover on trying to recruit her,” Catra said, without a *twinge* of guilt.

Amity Blight had a crush on Titan-Ra.

Titan-Ra was a big dumb gay idiot.

Ergo.

Getting Amity wrapped around her finger meant she could pull Adora into her grasp and show her what a big dumb gay idiot she was. It was almost too perfect.

“Got it!” Scorpia said. “Entrapta is also asking how the coa-”

“Are you melted? Even a little?” Entrapta called over the phone, her voice muffled as she was clearly learning in close to try and get her words in edgewise. “How melted are you on a level of one to ninety-”

Catra jammed her crow phone back into her pocket, then turned back to Amity, who was standing a very polite distance away from her. Catra gave her a little shy smile, then said.

“Lead on!”

Amity and her started walking, together, heading for the library. Then, tentatively, Amity took Catra’s hand in hers. Her fingers intertwined with Catra’s fingers, tingling against her skin – feeling so soft and smooth and warm. Catra’s heart raced a mile a minute and she looked aside, her cheeks flushing as she twitched her ears up, her smile growing wider and wider despite herself. She put her hand on her cheek, feeling the heat of it, and thought.

Yes. My plan is going great.

She squeezed Amity's hand back.

This is all part of my plan.

They took the corner.

And the street was empty.

Then, snarling, a shadow rose from the ground. The dark on dark shape of it twisted into a scowling frown and two eyes, empty black eyes that were made of nothing but that flowing darkness. The voice that hissed from nowhere, ringing out and inaudible to anyone and everyone standing there.

No. No! No! No!

The shadow darted down and the alleyway was still once more.

TO BE CONTINUED

Adora Gray and the Owlbeast

Chapter Summary

> Catra makes extremely good, emotionally mature decisions involving Amity Blight. Adora meets a weird owl.

The rain continued to beat down against the glass of the library, while Catra and Amity sat together across a table in the kid's section. Amity had gravitated towards this place – explaining that, with the painstorm, no one would be there – but Catra honestly found it kind of adorable. The place was all soft and pastel and pink. It reminded her of...stupid people. She liked stupid people – they were so easy to manipulate. Amity…

Amity was…

Okay, Amity was wrapped around her finger.

But that's different! Catra thought, defensively. *I'm trying with her.*

"So, uh, did you see Titan-Ra and the big fight with the Golden Guard?" Amity asked, smiling as she twirled her finger on the table, and some of her abomination goo formed into a small cup. She had liberally applied herself to the staff room in the library and gotten one of their clawfee makers out. Catra was so, so, so glad that her transformation into a cat demon had given her the ability to digest Boiling Isles food. She had read once that humans could basically only eat, like, four things in the Boiling Isles and one of them was griffon eggs. And that stuff was *expensive*.

Then what Amity asked penetrated her head and she jerked her eyes up from those delicate, pink, kissable fingers and started blushing. “W-What? Uh, no!” she said, reaching up and adjusting her glasses. Amity smiled at her, a bit sheepishly, as she opened the clawfee maker and started to pinch the claws off before they crawled out of the edges.

“Well, it was really amazing!” Amity said, her eyes shining brightly. “It was more amazing than watching, like, a real life Azura fight. Well. I mean. Witch fight. Since Azura is, uh, a witch.” She giggled. “But, like, she didn’t even seem to use magic circles. It was less like she was *using* magic and more like she *was* magic!” she said, pouring the clawfee into her summoned cup. “Uh, do you want some?”

Catra, who had clasped her hands before herself on the table, realized that she had nearly jammed every single claw into her own hands. The only thing keeping her safe was the thinnest of thin margins – she managed to draw her claws back into her fingers and stammered. “Y-Yes! Uh, let me get a cup of coffee, super fast.”

“Coffee?” Amity asked, her brow furrowing – but Catra was on her feet and zipping to the bathroom before she even noticed. She slammed the door shut behind her, then glared at herself in the mirror, taking her glasses off. She panted softly, trying to control her anger. Even here. Even right now. Even when she had everything, Adora still had to *take* things. Her fingers scraped along the porcelain of the sink with a hideous screeching noise and she saw her own face in the mirror – all angles and scowls and shadows.

"I'm...not going to *lose*," Catra whispered.

You sure about that?

The mirror didn't actually speak. It was just her own thoughts. Catra turned away from it, her shoulders tensed and tight.

She doesn't love you.

Catra snarled softly.

She loves me*.*

Catra spun around. Something dark and huge stood in the mirror. It reached out with a shadowy hand, grasping at her face, her shirt. Catra scrabbled backwards, but the fingers of the clawed hand hooked on her collar and yanked her over the sink, the faucet jamming into her belly. The mirror-face mashed against hers and a breath like cold death poured against her face.

She's mine!

Catra slammed her fist forward as hard as she could and heard a *crunch*. The mirror split apart and the hand grabbing onto her collar shattered with the same lines and breaks, then faded away. Catra skidded and grabbed onto the sink with her hands, her knuckles stinging fiercely from the cracking impact. She panted, softly, her glasses teetering on the edge of the sink, threatening to plunge to the floor, while her legs dangled under her. She managed to get one foot under her, then another. When she stood, she was looking into a shattered reflection.

"...Adora?" she whispered. "Was…"

It had been big and dark. Titan-Ra was big and dark. But…

Could Adora be that hateful?

"Yeah," Catra whispered. She looked down at her hand and saw that she had a slice along her knuckle, revealing pale white bone and- and she didn't need to look at that. She hastily grabbed some towels from the dispenser and crammed them over her knuckles, covering the skin. She bit her lip, hard, and...and didn't quite remember what she had done to get back to Amity's table. She was blushing and looking aside – and Amity gasped as she saw her walk up.

"Elizabeth!?" she asked. "Are you okay?"

"Y-Yeah, uh, I-I just...th...there was a wet floor, and-"

“Oh my Titan, your hand!” Amity said, taking her hands in hers, guiding Catra to sit at the table on *her* side. Their thighs pressed together, the armless seats making it easy to sit very close, as Amity drew the towels away, revealing brilliant crimson stains that poured from Catra’s gashed knuckles. She winced, looking away, while Amity clicked her tongue softly.

“Did the frigging assistant janitor forget to put up a wet floor warning *again*?” She asked. “How did you do this-”

“I kinda...flailed and hit a mirror, I’m so sorry!” Catra said, in her best Elizabeth voice. Her best, it seemed, was more than good enough. Amity leaned low and started to twirl her finger over her knuckles, frowning as she drew a tiny shimmer of purple magic. The light flared and the blood slowed, stopped, then reversed. The cut sealed itself shut with a faint *snip*, and Catra blinked several times.

“You...know healing magic?” she asked.

“Only a tiny bit,” Amity said. She sighed. “My...Mom makes me help show off Dad’s new abomination inventions. There’s a lot of being tossed around – we witchlings are tough, but, it still helps to know how to do a little mending.”

Catra blinked, her eyes widening. “Your...mom makes you *fight* abominations?” she asked.

“N-No, just abomination troopers!” Amity said, not meeting her eyes. She was still holding Catra’s hands, her fingers tracing the line between finger and knuckle, slowly moving down towards the tip of her finger, as if she had never seen a girl’s hand before. “T-They’re like abominations, but, you know. They have armor and guns.”

“T-That’s worse, though,” Catra said. “You do get how that’s worse, right?”

Amity grinned, shyly. She lifted her gaze and the two looked into one another’s eyes as Catra realized how very close they were sitting. Amity sat there. Then her entire face started to go very. Very. Very red. She sat up, then stammered. “W-W-Wow! Uh...trash!” She pointed at the bloody scraps of cloth that Catra had pressed to her knuckles. “I’m gonna go deal with those!” She stood and hurried off. Catra breathed out a short, sharp breath.

Then-

Tick.

Tick.

Tick.

Catra jerked her head up.

The window looking in on the brightly lit kid's section was now loomed in. The loomee was a thick mound of rubberized robes and cloaks which had a large, thick chitinous claw that Catra recognized after a bit as both the source of the ticking noise...and the identifier of who was doing such a good job of loomesse.

Catra hurried over to the window, hissing. "Scorpia! What are you *doing* here?"

"Checking in on you!" Scorpia whispered. "You said you were gonna recruit Titan-Ra. Is that Titan-Ra's secret form?"

Oh Titan, the last thing we need, another mistaken identity, Catra thought. "It's complicated!" she whispered. "Get outta here!"

"Got it, going into stealth mode, wildcat!" Scorpia said, winking at her and clicking her claws in her next best attempt at finger guns. Impressive, considering she had no fingers with which to gun. Catra flailed wildly, trying to indicate she should no, leave, actually, go home, right now, when suddenly a bloom of purple hair and smiling features came into view as Scorpia ducked down. Entrapta waved at her.

"I'm here too! Observing you!" she said, then Scorpia dragged her down with a yelp. Then Catra heard a voice, firm, fierce, commanding – and completely unlike what she expected.

“Elizabeth! We have to get out of here, now.”

Catra spun around, her eyes widening as she saw Amity hurrying over, her face grim.

“W-What’s wrong?” Catra asked, forcing her voice to not sound too confident as she reached up, adjusting her glasses.

“I-I found the assistant janitor,” Amity said, grabbing onto Catra’s wrist, tugging her in close. “He’s passed out – he has bite marks on him!” Her voice was soft and scared. “I think something *drank* him. Like...like…a demon or…” She gulped, then whispered. “Something worse.”

Catra nodded, blushing. “W-We can use magic to keep ourselves safe from the painstorm outside.”

“Yeah,” Amity said. “Good thing the-”

The lights went dead.

“-power is...still…” Amity was silent for a moment. The two of them exchanged a nervous look.

Amity started with Catra towards the door. Catra, her perceptions attuned to everything around her, flicked her ears up. She felt sick to her stomach, her hand rubbing along the back of her neck. Her other was gripping Amity's hand, fingers interlaced, clinging together so tightly that she wasn't sure how they'd ever let go of one another. But as they advanced towards the door, there was a sudden rumble of thunder and lightning and the illumination stabbed through the window, casting the jagged shadows of the window frame along the ground. There was the sprawled, insensate body of the janitor, laying near the public bathroom door. And there was, looming in the entry way, a huge, dangerous looking form. Amity skidded to a stop and Catra, reacting immediately, yanked her back around the stacks.

"Oh Titan!" Amity whispered, while Catra juggled her options. She could go out and fight it – but would Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce do that? She-

"Come on!"

Amity's voice jerked Catra from her calculations and her thoughts, and her arm pulled her from cover. She bit down to keep from crying out and swung her head around to see Amity yank a book – and then a hidden doorway slid open in the wall shelves with a grinding creak and crunch, revealing a small nook that Amity immediately crammed herself and Catra into. The door slammed shut a moment later and the two of them stood perfectly still, the only noise being the faint sound of rain beating on the roof.

Catra and Amity stood beside one another, clinging to one another. Catra's glasses had been knocked so askew that if she actually needed them, she might have been in trouble. But she

slowly looked around the secret room, and saw there was a small bedroll, some magic lights, and several dozen books. Azura books, yes. But also journals. She blinked and reached up to tug her glasses into place, while Amity put her ear to the door.

"I can hear it moving on," she whispered, then sat down on the smallish bedroll. "This has been an insane day."

Catra sat next to her. She grinned, shyly. "Yeah."

"D-Do you think it was whatever attacked the janitor?" Amity asked.

"Maybe…" Catra frowned. *Or it's Scorpia, helping some more.* She slid her hand atop Amity's hand. Amity's entire face went red and she looked away. She tilted her toes up and started to bump them against the floor, her knees joggling in nervous tension. Catra's fingers cupped her hand and she leaned against her. Her voice was soft. "W-Well, at least now we have an excuse for why we didn't rush straight home." She grinned, shyly.

"Y-Yeah! Uh! Heh! Wow. Two monster attacks in one day." Amity whispered, her cheeks bright red. "Whattertheods!"

Catra slid one of her fingers between Amity's knuckles. Her clawtip teased her skin, just so slightly enough to leave the thinnest, softest of white lines. A full body shudder went from Amity's toes to her the tips of her pointed ears and Catra could

practically smell how hot she was. She leaned in and whispered, softly.

"I...c-can...y-you hold me? Amity, I'm. Scared." She whispered, her voice having just enough want, enough need, that Amity would need to either flee from the room bodily or-

Or slide an arm around Catra's shoulders. Draw her in close. Catra nuzzled against her pale neck. Then she kissed her gently, her hand sliding around to cup Amity's side, pulling her in close. Amity whimpered, then gave up even trying. Their mouths crashed together as if they were both on the highway and riding blindfolded – their noses bumped, their hands flailed, and Catra felt her fake glasses getting knocked so far askew that they nearly jabbed into one of her ear holes. Amity, to her surprise, actually pushed her onto her back and Catra allowed herself to fall there. She panted as Amity drew her mouth back.

She laughed, giddily. "W-Wow!" She said, panting. "Libraries."

"Y-Yeah," Catra said. Her tongue darted along her lips, then she grabbed onto the front of Amity's Hexside uniform and dragged her down. She spread her legs and then locked her ankles behind Amity's buttocks, drawing the other girl into a tight, almost desperate embrace. Their mouths pressed together, and tongue darted against tongue. Catra slid one hand down, one hand up. She tousled Amity's green going on brown hair, while Amity tilted her head hard to the side, moaning into Catra's mouth.

Catra couldn't wait a single second longer. She broke the kiss, panting, whispering. "Amity, I need you."

“U-Uh, you have me?” Amity asked, dazedly.

“Naked, I need you naked,” Catra clarified.

“I-I...oh! Uh! I...I’m…” Amity looked aside, blushing, hard. “I’m a...virgin.”

“...I really really really need you naked,” Catra whispered, unable to even to pretend to be Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesuace in that moment. Her left hand dipped down and cupped Amity’s ass through her skirts and Amity gulped, then shivered and then nodded, eagerly. She leaned back onto her hips, her hands going to her top. She undid button after button, then shrugged her shoulders, revealing her pale white bra, stark against her *mostly* red skin. Her blush, it seemed, went all the way down. She hesitated, then reached back, undoing a snap with a soft *click*. Then her bra fell forward and...Catra had seen her naked in the shower before.

But it was *different* here.

Amity’s blush remained as she grinned down at her.

“H-how do I look all blurry?”

"Beautiful," Catra whispered. Which was a lie. She wasn't blurry at all. Catra had called a lot of girls beautiful – most of them in the Emperor's Coven, mostly when she had started to grow up and stretch her legs. She had been shy and unsure at first, but with each conquest, she had gotten more confident. So why did her knees feel like they had turned to liquid? Why did Amity Blight, of all people, make her feel almost sick and nervous. It was like she was scared silly and drawn towards her like a moth to a flame, both at once.

Titan… Catra thought. *That mysterious monster must have me more spooked than I thought.*

"Elizabeth…" Amity whispered, softly. "You look at me like...y-you, uh, want to eat me." Her grin was shy and she giggled a little bit. "See, it's, uh. A. Uh." She trailed off, her courage failing her. She blushed and ducked her head forward. Catra sat up, pushing herself until she was bumping nose to Amity's nose.

"Amity," she whispered, instead of the sly little witticism she had been trying to throw together in the breath between laying back and sitting up. She freighted that name with so much...more than she had expected. But it worked better than *you look good enough to eat, Miss Blight*. Amity leaned into her, breasts to breasts, mouth to mouth. Catra grabbed onto her ass, then started to tug at her skirts. Amity lifted one knee up off the bedroll, shifting to her side, and Catra skimmed her panties down, down. Amity had to lift her other knee, then fell forward against her, giggling and whispering.

"T-Thanks for just not tearing it off," she breathed.

“I’m not *feral*,” Catra muttered as she tried to not mewl as Amity’s warm breath teased along her ear. “I know how expensive these panties can be.” She grinned as she got the last bit free, and Amity’s panties dangled from her fingertip. She licked her lips, slowly, while Amity giggled giddily, then leaned in and went back to kissing Catra right on the mouth. Now, it was her hands who were busy. Catra squirmed as she rolled her shoulders to help, and when her top joined Amity’s, Amity’s hands went right to her tits.

As expected.

Amity drew back, her eyes wide. “You don’t wear a bra?” she asked.

“Amity, look at my tits,” Catra said, her grin lopsided. “Do I look like I need a bra?”

Amity blinked, then blushed and then leaned forward. She hesitated...then leaned in and took one of Catra’s dark brown nipples between her lips. She sucked gently, then leaned in, moaning as she kissed from breast to breast, sucking on Catra’s other nipple. Catra groaned and rolled her head back, her eyes half closing.

Then a very strange thing happened.

Rrrrrhhhrrrr!

The noise came, at first, from nowhere. Catra jerked her head up, looking around, wildly, then realized the noise was coming from herself. Amity didn't even seemed shocked. She drew her mouth back, leaving Catra's nipples glistening and moist. This added to their sensitivity, the tingling brush of the room's air against her wet skin making Catra bit her lip to keep from moaning aloud. Amity was smiling up at her, her eyes just...pure delight. She chuckled, then leaned in, pressing her cheek to the spot between Catra's smallish breasts.

"You're purring," she whispered.

Catra blushed. Hard. A sudden sense of shame and confusion filled her, as if she had found herself dressed in a wild witch's garb, or...or...honestly, she couldn't think of anything even similar. Maybe if she had been attracted to a man, that might have been almost as upsetting and unsettling. She had never purred. Never, ever, ever. Not even when she had become the Golden Guard. But now, in this tiny room, with a monster sniffing around outside, while pretending to be an entirely different person, with this witchling she had known for...less than a week, she was *purring*?

She had fucked prettier witches than Amity! And more experienced ones!

Why was she *purring?*

She blushed, and bit back the first immediate inane response: *I'm sorry.*

Sorry for what?

Amity didn't even wait for an answer. Instead, she began to kiss her way along Catra's belly, nuzzling her muscles gently. She licked and flicked her tongue down and down and down and Catra realized that the *virgin* was making all the moves here. A part of her was so offended at the impropriety of it that she nearly broke character again – but then Amity buried her face between her brown thighs and tugged her panties aside with her fingers. Catra lifted her hips, and tried to stop the loud rumbling purr that escaped her. But she couldn't. Her claws sunk into the bedsheets under her as Amity guided her panties up past her knees, to her ankles, over her toes...and then she pressed her face against the pale white panties she had grabbed, breathing in. Catra, who was midway through lowering her legs back down, blinked at her.

Amity hastily tossed the panties aside, stammering. "I-I didn't do that!" she said, blushing.

Catra blinked at her again.

Then she burst out laughing. "Amity, you dork!" she said, shaking her head – and Amity blushed so hard she nearly burst into flames...but despite her flush, she started to laugh as well. She shook her head, then leaned in. She kissed the inside of Catra's knee.

“Elizabeth,” she whispered.

Catra felt that strange sick feeling in her belly again. It was like she felt...bad for some reason, even though a gorgeous witchling was about to *eat her out*. It was crazy. She forced the sensation down, even as Amity finished returning to Catra’s sex, having gently kissed her way down her thigh, to her belly again, then down, past the thin bar of Catra’s pubic hair. Her tongue darted up, then down, then up again, licking her slowly, experimentally. She didn’t immediately find the centers of Catra’s pleasure – but Catra hadn’t expected her too.

What she hadn’t expected, either...was…how...good it would feel. She half closed her eyes, then sighed as Amity leaned in and applied even more tongue. She started to lap at her pussy with slow, steady, eager licks, sliding up from the bottom to the tip, finding Catra’s clit more by accident than anything else. Catra reached around with her right hand, her left tightening on the sheet, and subtly moved Amity’s head – and Amity’s dainty, eager lips found her clit and *sucked*. Catra whined through her teeth, rolling her head back.

“Oh...oh Titan!” She gasped, rolling her hips subtly in time with Amity’s eager nuzzling, licking, even nipping. Her purr grew louder and more intense as she felt pleasure building, then building more as Amity licked and licked and licked. Then, as if driven by a divine, Titan blessed instinct, Amity reached around with her own hand and pushed one of her fingers deep into Catra’s sex. She crooked it and began to rub and Catra was lost. She moaned and bucked her hips fiercely against Amity as her pleasure overflowed, spilling onto Amity’s tongue. Amity moaned sweetly and drank her down, burying her face against Catra’s sex.

“Fuck! Fuck! Fuck!” Catra gasped out. “Amity! Oh Titan, yes! Yes!”

“Mmm!”

***

The muffled noises were quite clear, if you put your ear to the wall. Scorpia nodded, then clicked her claw at Entrapta, who was holding a notepad.

“Catra’s getting laid!” Scorpia said, then, proudly. “I knew she could do it, if she tried.” She sniffed. “My little wildcat is growing up.”

“I think she’s older than you,” Entrapta said, cheerfully, her hair bobbing her up and down as she hummed and took notes. “Can you tell whose performing cunnilingus on who?”

“Uh, it sounds like Blight is,” Scorpia said, pressing her ear to the wall again. “Yeah. Yeah. That’s a witchling eating demon pussy if I’ve ever heard it.”

“Faaaaaaascinating!”

***

Catra was willing to be a patient hunter.

That patience went out the window when a girl was naked.

She had Amity on her back, and their legs scissored together, before Amity had even finished wiping her mouth off. Amity gasped in shock as Catra pressed her sex against Amity's sex – their folds locking together with lewd, wet noises that filled the room. Slick. Eager. They drove Catra to grind her hips in steady, pushing motions – her tail writhing as she pinned Amity's wrists above her head. She panted softly, looking down into Blight's bright golden eyes, while Amity gasped and moaned in time with every motion. Their clits almost bumped together as Amity started to rock her hips back.

"Elizabeth! Oh! Elizabeth! Yes! Yes! Ah! I...I...didn't know girls could even do this!" Amity gasped out. "Fuck. I thought it was all just...licking!"

"There's lots of options," Catra whispered, her own eyes lidded and hungry as she looked into Amity's eyes. "We can get straps later."

"I know about this!" Amity flushed, her hips bumping back. She slid her hand up, cupping Catra's smallish breast, her finger finding her nipple, tugging it gently, gently. Catra rolled her head back, groaning eagerly as she started to feel her second orgasm rush closer and closer. Amity's back arched as she cried out in pleasure, then bit down onto her wrist, to keep herself from crying out even louder. Catra shifted, so that she was balanced on one

hand, her other hand free to rub Amity's clit. She worked her with every bit of skill she had learned...and was rewarded by Amity losing the fight.

"Oh Elizabeeeeeeeeeth!" Amity screamed, her back arching as she *spurted* a warm splash of juices against Catra, some of it getting almost to her tits as Amity's whole body quivered with bliss, then went limp. Catra ground against her one last time and felt her own peak hitting her again – trembling and gasping as she moaned.

"Adora, yes...ah...fuck…" She gasped, bucking her hips slowly, then drawing back...and letting herself flop down beside Amity. Amity, her breath coming in short, shuddering gasps, lay beside Catra, her arms lifted above her head, her eyes dazed.

"H-Huh?" she asked.

"I said...wow…" Catra whispered. She flopped one of her limp arms over Amity's belly, then dragged herself up, so she could get her lips right near Amity's ear. She whispered. "That was amazing, Amity."

"I thought…" Amity blinked, then shook her head – dismissing whatever she had thought. Catra felt her own purring coming back. The deep, reverberating thrum started to buzz through Amity and Amity turned into what was basically a puddle of happy girl, leaning into Catra and snuggling against her. "Mmm…"

Then she jolted upright, almost slamming her head into the low hanging roof of the hiding room.

"Oh my Titan!" she exclaimed, her eyes wide with fear.

"Hmm, what?" Catra asked, lazily.

"My mom is going to kill me!" She put her hands to her face. "I-I...she says I have to date only appropriate canditates. I...are you rich?"

"No," Catra said. She noticed, in a sudden jolt, that her Emperor's Coven sigil was visible on her wrist. She cocked her arm behind her neck, hiding it hurriedly as she suddenly realized just how *close* she had been to being discovered. *Good thing I'm so dang distracting,* she thought, while Amity put her hands from her cheeks to her head.

"Uh…" Amity thought for a beat. "F-From a famous family?"

Catra blushed and said. "My name is Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce, Amity."

"Right…" Amity laid back, groaning.

"Y-Your mom doesn't have to *know* we're dating," Catra whispered. "We can be like secret lovers, like in Book Nine!"

Amity blushed. "But that's a book. This is real life. I...I don't think I'm ever going to be brave enough to...to do any of that. I'm...honestly shocked I was brave enough to do *this*. Like, I thought I was never going to lose my virginity." She trailed off for a bit more, her cheeks burning as she looked aside, her voice growing softer. "It's...like I already knew what to do, though."

"That is why being with a girl is better," Catra said, smugly.

"Yeah," Amity whispered. She closed her eyes. "I don't know. I...I'm confused…"

Catra was silent. She felt the strangest feeling. It was…

This was insane.

But it was an urge to...to blurt out what her real name was. Who she was. She could make Amity love the Golden Guard, right? But no, she had made it very, very clear what she thought. And what kind of stupid spy would just reveal this. And it wasn't like Amity was *special* or anything. She didn't care about her. Amity was just a girl. Sure, she was brave. But she was also easily mislead, so she was stupid. And she was from some rich upper crust family, and she had a mom who sucked. So what. She liked Azura books. But...that was just...it wasn't like Catra *actually* liked those books

anymore. Why was she even still *thinking* about Amity Blight, she had just...just…

This was just sex. This was just a way to get to Titan-Ra, to get Titan-Ra to…

Catra blushed and scowled at the ceiling.

Amity laid against her, eyes closing, burying her face into Catra's wild mane of hair. "I...I think I like you a lot, Elizabeth." She whispered.

Catra felt like she had never been lower. She looked away, her cheeks burning.

"I like you a lot too, Amity," she whispered. But she wasn't purring anymore.

If Amity noticed, she didn't remark it. Instead, she just hugged her closer and Catra lay there.

Fighting monsters.

***

The painstorm had broken as Adora walked towards the Owl House. She sighed slightly, her arms stretching behind her back...as she saw that the front door of the house had been broken. Hooty, his eyes covered with almost cartoonish Xs, lay with his head resting against the front stoop. Adora froze...and then yanked her sword from her back.

"By the Honor of Grayskull!"

Darkness wreathed her body and flames swept from her feet to her toes. When they were gone, Titan-Ra stood in her place, her clawed toes digging into the ground. She rushed towards the door, grabbed it gently – not wanting to harm Hootie any more if he had been hurt, and stepped inside. She swept her bright, golden eyes slowly around – and saw that it looked like the whole place had been turned into a *battlefield*. A smoldering impact mark over the fireplace looked almost like Glimmer's magic...and there were half a dozen of Bow's arrows, sticking out of the wall and shimmering faintly. The stairs had been crunched and marked by claws, while the banister looked shattered in several spots.

Titan-Ra started up the stairs, sword in her hand, looking left, then right, then peeking around the corner. She heard a low rumbling noise coming from the end of the hall...coming from Eda's room. A shadow, cast by a discarded lamp, cast a crazy light against the wall...and the shadow within was looming. Huge. Terrifying looking. Titan-Ra walked forward with a slow breath, shocked at how calm she felt.

She came to the door...and peeked.

And saw.

The center of Eda's room was dominated by a massive beast of tufted feather and furs. Muscles broad and thick as entire individuals cascaded along the creature's back, while wings cupped the flanks, giving it a faintly ovoid shape. It was snarling and clawing around, and the claws looked big enough to slash a witch completely in half. Titan-Ra pursed her lips...and noticed that the far end of the room had three cocoon like shapes that were each of a different size. One was tall and thin, one was short and stout, and one of them was very tiny.

Bow. Glimmer. King! Titan-Ra thought. *God, I hope they're okay.*

She stepped into the room. "Hey, demon!" she snapped. "I don't know how you got-"

The demon turned.

And Eda's face, distorted by blackened eyes and snarling, demonic features, looked back at her.

"Oh," Titan-Ra said.

The Eda-Beast roared at her, screeching so loudly that the noise sent Titan-Ra stumbling backwards out of the room. The Eda-Beast rushed forward, claw swiping hard enough to shatter the doorframe and Titan-Ra grabbed onto her wrist, shoving her own sword behind her back with the other. “I don’t want to hurt you, Eda!” she said, wrenching the claw up and away from her face. “Calm down!”

The Eda-Beast roared at her again, and slammed into her with the other claw. The two went tumbling away from the room, hit the wall, smashed it inwards slightly, and then both started to tumble down the stairs. Titan-Ra was focused entirely on keeping her arms between her and the slashing claws of the beast. She felt an agony of indecision – she wanted too...no, she had to help Eda. But how!? She grunted with each blow, her arms locked together. Claws against her bracers was actually going better than she expected, but-

Unity.

The whispered word popped into her mind.

Had Titan-Ra not been under such stress, she might have asked...where?

And moreover...how?

But she was.

And in such times, you simply had to do what you could.

"**Back off!"**

She shouted the words out and a rainbow explosion – just like the last time she had shouted in this form – bloomed away from her in a rippling, overlapping pattern. The Eda-Beast was flung backwards and crashed into the sofa, sending it skidding and fetching up against the wall. The Eda-Beast was knocked, woozily, onto her side and was only slowly able to get to her feet. Titan-Ra felt the power crackling inside of her. Raw magic. Buzzing through her fingertips.

Unity?

She stepped forward, then thrust out her palm, and grabbed onto the Eda-Beast's head. She felt a surge of connection – and then fell forward, tumbling...and tumbling…

Then she landed. She landed with a grunt on a vast, grayish beach. The water was black, and the distant cliffs were a dark, somber gray. The sand was nearly pale white, and it was marked by a doubled set of footsteps. She lifted her gaze and saw a brilliant spec of red. A red dress. Eda. She started to run along the beach, and in shockingly short time, she came up behind the screeching, howling owl-creature that had fused with Eda. Its beak was split in a jagged black line and it screamed as it chased after Eda, who was panting and sobbing with exhaustion.

“Leave! Me! Alone!” She choked out over her shoulder.

“Eda!” Titan-Ra called out.

And Eda made a mistake.

She stopped. She turned and blinked.

“Adora!?” she asked. “How did-”

The beast leaped directly onto Eda, screeching, bearing her to the ground. Titan-Ra cried out, then stepped towards her, but before she could, the horrible beast...shrank. It became smaller, more easily held in one’s arms. Its mouth opened and it lapped, eagerly, at Eda’s face with a rough, textured tongue. She blinked as owl-slime dripped from her cheeks, while Titan-Ra finished jogging forward, then knelt down beside her.

“It…” Titan-Ra said. “It likes you?”

“Huh,” Eda said. “I...didn’t know it liked me.” She looked at the owl-beast, who screeched, but...happily now?

“Where are we?” Titan-Ra asked.

Eda scowled. "You're in my head. Rude, you know." She smirked. "But this time, I'll forgive you. Ugh. Please tell me that this little stinker wasn't running around in my body…" She said, lifting up the owl-beast, who wriggled their tiny paws happily.

"Um. Maybe a teeny tiny bit." Titan-Ra said, holding up her clawed fingers, keeping the tips from just barely touching.

Eda gave her a sour look, then snapped her fingers.

Titan-Ra stumbled away from Eda – and felt her powers vanish with a pop as she reverted to Adora, the danger having passed. She grinned, slightly, as she turned back to face Eda.

"*Whoa*."

"...whoa…" Adora whispered.

Eda stood. Except she wasn't Eda as Adora normally saw her. Her red dress had become jagged, thrown over a body that was an even more smooth combination of owl and woman – she still had her arms, her hands, and her fingers were tipped with sharpened, reddish claws, and her hair had become an even more unruly, a wild mane of white hair framing her more angular features, her ears having grown even more longer and more pronounced. Her legs now ended in splayed claws, and her ankles were narrow and

scaled, black scales. She looked down at her hands, spreading her fingers, while Adora saw that she had two broad, gray feathered wings as well.

"Whoa!" Eda said, again, her voice having a strange, alien timber to it. She blinked, and Adora saw that her eyes were black on gold, her irises bright and shining. "Whoa!" Eda looked around at her back.

"W-What happened?" Adora asked.

"It's like...the owl beast wanted to just...be a part of me. Not take me over. All I had to do was let it!" Eda said, chuckling. "Nice!" She craned her head around, peering at her back again. "Do I rock this look or do I rock this look?"

"Y-You're...really…" Adora paused. "Really hot!"

"Thanks, babe, you too!" Eda said, grinning. "You know, I'm not against some May-December stuff."

Adora nodded.

Then she blinked. "Wait, *what*?"

TO BE CONTINUED

Adora Gray and the Apple Blood

Chapter Summary

> Adora Gray turns out to be a lightweight. Catra meets Amity (again.)

Adora and Eda worked together to slowly peel open the middle of the three owl pellets in her trashed room. Within was a glistening, sticky, shuddering Glimmer Park. She stepped out of the owl pellet, breathed slowly in, touched the tips of her fingers together in a gesture of calming focus, focused, and then vanished in a glittering spray of sparkles. She appeared a few feet to her left, but arrived without her Hexside uniform. This gave Adora a remarkable view of her cushy, curvaceous body – her tits might have been the same size as Adora's, but since Glimmer was a foot or so shorter and stocky to boot, she looked quite a bit more endowed. She also appeared without a thin skein of slime and bits of owl pellet, which hung in the rough, Rubenesque form of Glimmer before splattering to the floor.

Thus naked and clean, she brushed her hands through her hair and said. "I am going to *be* in the *shower*!"

Then she stalked from the room.

Adora and Eda kept gaping after her for a few seconds, both of their jaws hanging open.

"...uh…" Adora said.

“So, is she dating anyone?” Eda asked.

“Yes,” a muffled voice came from the tallest owel pellet.

“Eda!” Adora exclaimed. “She’s- I...we’re...both...all going to school!”

“Yeah, senior year!” Eda said. “I was totally hooking up with older witches and demons in my senior year.” She chuckled. “Ah, good times.”

“Eda!” Adora spluttered.

“Can you please get me out of this?” The muffled voice came again and the two women worked with a will to yank it open. Bow Porter stepped from the container, groaning and rubbhing his hands along his face. “Ugh.”

“I’m so sorry about this, Bow,” Adora said.

“Why are you apologizing, you didn’t eat him,” Eda said. At Bow’s look, she blinked at him, then jerked her thumb over her shoulder. “The condoms are above the sink in the bathroom.”

"*Eda*!" Adora exclaimed.

"What!?" Eda asked. "My job is to be the responsible one here."

"Thanks," Bow said, wincing as he wiped some slime from his eyes. "But I brought my own, actually." He patted his belt, where his various trick arrows were normally stored. "Right next to my quiver, never leave home with out them. Heh, Glimmer gets *frisky* after a fight." He waggled his eyebrows dramatically.

"Bow!" Adora's entire face was nearly as red as her jacket.

"It's not like you don't have any in the human realm," Bow said, cheerfully. Then he paused. "Wait, don't you!? Adora, you have to-"

"Wehavecondomspleaseshutup!" Adora wheezed, putting her hands over her face.

"Fhew," Bow said. "I was worried I'd have to explain h-"

Adora bodily grabbed his arm, dragged him to the door leading to the shower, flung the door open – and caught a hazy, enticing form of Glimmer through the closed screen of the shower, then flung Bow inside. He stumbled, flailed, yelped – and then she slammed the door shut, her back pressed against it as she panted heavily.

“Nice,” Eda said, while Adora realized what she had done, was caught in a paroxysm of indecision. She reached for the air, dropped her arms, then sagged against the shower and skimmed down it, sitting on her butt. She felt as if she had never before been quite so tired in her life – everything that had happened having crashed into her at the same time. Eda, walking over with the freed King in her arms, smiled down at her.

“Wanna talk about it?” she asked, while King whined and wriggled.

“Ugh! Ugh! So slimey!”

Adora sighed. “Can I have something to drink first?” she asked.

“Well. You’re not twenty one, but...counter point, screw the rules!” Eda said. “Lets get some apple blood!”

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Adora thumped into the chair across from Eda, who had reverted to her human...er...witch form before opening the pellets. That was the first thing on Adora’s mind. “What was that?” she asked.

“Okay, kid,” Eda said. “The whole thing with me and my curse is kind of a long story. I was cursed when I was about your age –

maybe a little older.” She said, waggling her hand a bit to indicate how she wasn’t sure. “I’m not sure by who or why – but it messed up my powers, and it made me have to leave polite society. I was able to control it with the elixer – but, uh, heh, we were out.” She frowned a little bit, looking distant.

Adora looked down at the cup that Eda had set before her. The warm red blood inside did smell faintly of apples. She gulped, then sipped it. It tasted of apples, but it had a stinging brightness that made her sit right up and squeak.

“Yeah, appleblood will do that to ya,” Eda said, then sighed. “So. Uh. How was your superheroing?”

“I fought my best friend to a standstill while trying to make her see reason and she instead tried to kill me repeatedly,” Adora said, resting her head on her arm as she slouched before the table. “Also, I, uh...uh...m-met...Amity...Blight. And, uh...uh...oh, in my Titan-Ra form, I am immune to painstorms. T-That’s neat! Also, I can go into your *brain*!?”

“Firstly, firstly, lets talk about the important thing,” Eda said, her ears perking up. “You *met* Amity, huh?” She waggled her fingers. “Now, did this meeting take place on first, second, or third base?”

“What?” Adora asked, sitting up.

“First base, you go up to the knuckle!” Eda said, waggling her finger. “Second base, you’re using each-other bits as alchemical

reagents. Third base? Well, that's a bit much for someone your age, even if you're eighteen." She nodded, sagely.

"*What*!?" Adora spluttered. "No! We just...made out. A little. A lottle." She looked aside, then bit her lip. "Is it messed up that I'm...I...I feel like I'm...betraying Catra?" She blushed, hard. "Not, like, cheating on her. But, like, how can I justify doing anything with a girl when, when, when I have to help Catra. She's working as the Golden Guard for the Belosian Empire, I have to help her out and get her to-"

"Adora, honey," Eda said, reaching across the table. She squeezed her hand. "Your best friend is working for the bad guys. It sucks." She nodded. "But you can't just *fix* her. You have to hope she'll fix herself – and be there for her, when she turns things around. Until then, you do what you can." She smiled, wryly. "And you definitely can't give up on other girls, even if you can't stop thinking about how cute she is in her uniform."

"She's not cute in her uniform!" Adora said, hurriedly. "She's cute out of it! I mean, not cute! I...I don't have a crush on Catra."

"Mmhmmmmm!" Eda said, nodding and taking a long, deep drink from her appleblood.

Adora knocked back her own gulp. She blushed as she felt the hot burn in her belly.

“Okay!” she said. “Admittedly. The cat thing? It’s...ya know, it’s working for me. I love catgirls. And cats. I like how their ears go, kinda, bloop bloop.” She lifted her fingers, miming the twitches of a cat’s ears. “Like, heh, that’s why I think I’m so into witch ears, you’re like cats. You have...kitty twitchy ears.” She blinked, then looked down at her glass. She still had, like, at least seventy, eighty percent of the appleblood still in it. “I...am...you…” She pointed a finger accusingly at Eda. “You are drunking me get!”

“Sure am!” Eda said, cheerfully. “In appleus veritas!”

“That’z not even Latin!” Adora said, her head flopping onto the table as she laid down next to her cup, sprawling. “Kitties are cute.” She giggled, softly. “You know, heh, uh, on Earth, when girls kiss, they also...they pet kitties. Pussies. Pussies is another word for-”

“Mmm, yes, that’s true here too,” Eda said, chuckling.

“You! Have to tell me truth things now!” Adora said, pointing again at her mentor slash weird hot adoptive grandmother slash roommate slash landlord.

“Okay!” Eda said.

“Howz...that…” Adora closed her eyes, then flailed an arm.

“Gonna need a few more words,” Eda said, gently reaching over and stealing Adora’s glass. She started to drink from it.

“How do you do the sexy harpy thing!” Adora exploded, springing up and cupping her chin with her palms, looking at Eda like a lovesick puppy. “And are you...do you give...*wing hugs*?” she whispered, her eyes shining. “I’d love a wing hug.”

Eda opened her mouth, then closed it. “That’s the weirdest thing,” she said, hesitantly. “My whole life, the owl beast and I have been at war. But then, today, when I changed, it was like everything was different. It was like since the last time I changed, the owl beast has completely flipped around. It wasn’t trying to take me over. It was just trying to be a part of me. And once I let it, once you stopped from running away, it was like I’ve done this a thousand times before.” She looked down at her hand, frowning.

“Wowwww,” Adora whispered. Then she beamed. “I’m gonna kiss the owl beast on its head cause it’s a good girl.”

Eda grinned. “Now, it’s my turn for a truth question: Does Amity know you’re Titan-Ra?”

“Nah,” Adora said.

“So, she’s into Titan-Ra, but has no time for Adora Gray?” Eda asked.

“Nah!” Adora said, shaking her head. She was still beaming. “She’s *suuuuuper* into Titan-Ra and, uh, she…” Her smile faltered, then collapsed. “She doesn’t like me cause I’m dumb.”

“You’re not dumb, Adora,” Eda said, gently. Then she perked up. “Wait, so, she’s into your secret ID, but not into your real ID?”

“Mmhmm!” Adora nodded.

“You know what this means, right?” Eda asked.

“Mhnnno?” Adora asked.

“Shenanigans!”

Adora blinked at her. “Shen...Shenann...nishe...sh-”

“So, what you do, is you arrange to be where Amity needs to be rescued, then you swoop her off her feet, and you kiss her. Heck, do more than kiss her, get to first base.” Eda said, nodding.

Adora blinked at her slowly. Then she smiled. “That sounds nice…” She said, cheerfully. “I get to be a hero and I get to have fun nice

things too. That's nice." She half closed her eyes. "Mom said I don't deserve nice things unless I do nice things for people, so...mm...m'gonna do nice things." She sighed, softly. "Mmm does Amity taste like green skittles or purple?" She closed her eyes and started to snore quietly.

Eda shook her head slowly. "Every single thing I hear about that woman makes me want to go and beat the crud out of her."

King hopped up onto the kitchen table. "Eda, you got your teenage adoptive daughter drunk. After flirting at her!"

Eda waggled her finger. "Ah, ah, ah, King. It's only creepy if you're a man. Or a demon. When women do it, it's *sexy*."

"That's not even *close* to true!" King said, throwing his arms wide.

"Besides, I wasn't going to molest her or anything, she's drunk!" Eda said, her voice offended. "What kind of a criminal do you take me for."

"Uh-huh." King's eyelids were perfect horizontal lines, right at the midpoint of his eyes.

Eda scowled.

Hooty slithered up into view. “Eda always respects consent, hoot hoot!” he said.

“Okay, that just makes me sound like I should be on a list,” Eda muttered.

“You are!” King shouted, angrily.

“A *bad* list.”

***

In Adora’s dream, she was floating behind herself and watching herself walk to school. Adora, in the dream, was not wearing her nice red jacket. Instead, she was wearing something severe and black and cold, like something her Mom would try and get her to wear. The funniest thing, though, was that Adora in the dream was...almost crying. She trembled as she walked, her eyes half closed, and she whispered under her breath.

“It’s okay. It’s okay. It’s okay. It’s better than the cell, it’s better than the cell, it’s better...th-...then...then…”

She started to tremble, then she put her hand over her own face. Adora watched as her control collapsed and she started to cry. Not just cry, but *sob*. The weird thing – well, the awful thing – was that the crying was...*wrong*. Adora had cried before. She had

even seen herself in the mirror. She didn't make that kind of face as she cried. The dream Adora staggered against a dumpster, her shoulders shaking as she sobbed and whimpered and sniffled.

"Oh honey!"

The voice was soft and warm and gentle and made the other Adora yelp and jerk upright, stumbling back and away – nearly into the street. She timed it badly: A car was trundling by at about twenty five miles per an hour, and was just about to crack right into the dream Adora's arm – but the owner of the voice sprang forward, grabbed her and yanked her back. Adora and the figure stumbled, fell onto the grass of the house across the street. The house that Catra had lived in.

Adora, her face red and puffy, gasped and sniffed – blinking...while Adora, the real Adora, looked over to see who had yanked her dream self out of the way of the car. She was a matronly woman – pretty, middle aged, and dressed in nurse's scrubs. Her skin was dusky brown, and her hair was raven dark. She looked at Adora with a gentle smile, her hand going to her shoulder. "Sorry for startling you," she said. "I just...I saw you crying and I was, uh, wondering if everything was all right?"

She had a lovely accent. Adora wondered where it was from.

"I-It's okay," the other Adora said. The dream said. She stood up, brushing grass from her pants. "I-I have to...to go. To get to school."

“Do you want to talk about it?” the woman asked, still sitting.

“I…” the dream Adora stammered. “I…” She tugged at her sleeve – yanking it down.

But not before Adora, the real Adora, and the woman sitting on the grass saw the bruise.

“I’m okay, I have to go!”

She hurried off.

And Adora saw that the woman in the nurse’s scrub had a fire in her eyes as she stood, her jaw tightening as she reached down, adjusting her nametag. Adora leaned in – even as she felt the horrible claws of wakefulness pulling at her.

C. Noceda.

She jerked upright, panting slightly.

“...what a...weird dream,” she said, then blinked, noticing that King was still perched atop her head, having shifted with her

movement so smoothly that he was still snoring atop her like a cuddly little crown. She reached up, took King off her head, then smiled at him.

"Such a cutie," she whispered.

She set King down, checked the time – and saw that it was early enough that she was pretty sure she could use the bathroom. She noticed that her head was hurting a bit, but...not as much as she might have feared, considering the vague blurr of last night. She walked towards the bathroom – then opened the door and found herself looking in at Glimmer. Glimmer was wearing her nightgown and had it pushed all the way up and above her cushy rump. Bow, meanwhile, was in the bathroom as well. Of course, he was not simply brushing his teeth or even flossing. No.

He was kneeling on the tiles and burying his tongue deep inside of Glimmer's sex. The soft, slick noise of him licking up and down and up and down her pussy was quite loud in the nearly silent bathroom, as Glimmer was biting down onto the back of her knuckles to keep from moaning aloud, even as her hips jounced in time with Bow's eager ministrations. Her wings – small as they were – fluttered against her back as Adora stood there, froze and gaping at the pair of them.

"Sorry!" Adora exclaimed.

Glimmer jerked her hand from her mouth and gasped. "*Adora*!" She moaned – her voice shocked and tinged with pleasure as she quivered. Bow jerked back at just the right moment too, to show

quite clearly what happened when Glimmer came and came hard. Specifically, her juices splashed against his face, leaving his dark brown skin glistening and sprinkled with shimmering, glowing pink sparkles. Adora caught only a glimpse of this as she backpedaled so fast her feet were a blur.

This was when she hit King with her ankle.

"Weh!" The sleepy demon cried out as Adora felt both her feet leave the ground. She had half a second to think: *Ah, well, at least I am falling on the carpet* before her spine hit the edge of the stairs. She skidded down, crunched the top of her head onto the wooden stair, curled backwards, tried to get her arms before her, and then started to slinky down the stairs with a series of cartilaginous cracks, crunches, and snaps. Then, she sprawled on the ground – while Bow, Glimmer, King, and a hurriedly dressed Eda ran to the head of the stairs, gaping down at her in horror.

"Well, at least she's okay," Glimmer said, tugging her nightgown down.

"She's human! They're *fragile*!" Bow said.

"Oh shoot she's human!" Glimmer said, horrified, as she grabbed all of them and teleported down to the bottom of the stairs. Adora groaned...rolled onto her belly, put her arms under her, and stood up, rubbing her spine gently.

"Ow," she said.

All of them gaped at her.

Adora blinked at them. “What?” She asked, then looked up the stairs. She blinked again, then started to pat her body down gently, brushing her hands along her flanks, rubbing her arms, patting her cheeks. Every single part of her, save for the part that had smacked directly into the stairs – the small of her back, the top of her head, the base of her spine, and her elbow – was fine. And those parts were just bruised.

“Huh,” Adora said.

“...Adora…” Eda said. “Didn’t you say you used to break bones *all the time* in the human realm? Because you had, uh, a vitamin deficiency?”

“Y-Yeah,” Adora said. “M-Maybe it’s Titan-Ra?” She sounded nervous.

“I think I know who to take her too,” Glimmer said, nodding. “Cause you should be *so dead* as a human.”

Adora flushed. “Who?” she asked.

“A healer. The best healer I know,” Glimmer said, putting her hands on her hips.

“She’s in the detention track!” Bow added.

Adora looked unconvinced.

***

“Well, well, well, someone is happy today.”

Catra, who had been in the midst of adjusting the staff Belos had made for her, jerked her head up and spun around, coming to attention and snapping off a sharp little salute. “Ma’am!” she said, while Lilith Clawthorne walked into the laboratory that Catra had been forced to share with Entrapta, who was humming cheerfully as she tinkered with her staff. The faint smell of ozone and the spray of sparks coming from the device were both making Catra a little concerned.

“Ma’am?” Catra asked, trying to sound even and steady.

“You were purring,” Lilith said, smiling dryly at her.

Catra thought back over the past few minuets. She didn’t remember purring. She had just been letting her mind wander...to

her schemes and plans. She coughed, then adjusted the collar on her uniform. “Sorry, ma’am.”

“There’s nothing to apologize for, Catra,” Lilith said, shaking her head. “I’m glad to see you’re doing well. Now, we have a new shipment of weapons for the armory from BI – I want you to ensure they’re loaded.” She frowned. “The last time we let Scorpia do it, half of them ended up snipped into tiny pieces.”

“Scorpia…” Catra scowled. *What did BI stand for again?* She thought – but before she could ask, Lilith threw her another soft ball.

“Also, if you could *find* Scorpia, that would be nice. I don’t like it when someone that large goes silent and missing for so long. It makes me nervous.” Lilith frowned and shook her head. Catra nodded, then salted again. She frowned, taking up her staff and holding it. She could use both runes and the staff to cast any kind of magic she wanted...so why did she feel so unsettled. Her? Purring? Again? She hadn’t even gotten laid. She turned to Entrapta, frowning.

“Was I really purring?” she asked.

“Hmm?” Entrapta asked. “No, but I can check the recordings on my logs and see if you were purring, the corroborate them with the times you were distractedly thinking about other things. Oh! And if we use the security scrying devices, we can also see if they correlate to you smiling!”

Catra scowled at her. “I was not smiling!”

Entrapta shrugged. “I don’t really pay attention to if you’re smiling or not – unless I’m taking notes on your social interactions.” She gasped. “Wait, I should be starting to do that, though, if there’s some changes in your behavior since your date with Amity!”

“*It wasn’t a date!*” Catra shouted, her hand tightening on the staff so hard that it almost broke in half.

“It wasn’t?” Entrapta asked. “Fascinating. How many social interactions involve meeting at a place you both like, talking about things you both enjoy, then end with making love in a closet?”

Catra blushed. Hard. “I’m just *using* her. It’s like your wrench. Do you love your wrenches!?”

“Of course!” Entrapta brightened visibly and swung her mask back to reveal her huge smile. “This one’s a 10 incher, this one’s 5 centimeters – they’re really good for getting into tight spaces, oh, and this one has a lug-nut tightener, and this one can be ratcheted, and this one’s adjustable!” She said, using her hands and her hair to tug out wrench after wrench. “I’ve been thinking of naming them!”

“N-Naming them?” Catra asked.

“Yes, one, two, three, four, five!” Entrapta said.

“...I’m going to find Scorpia,” Catra said, taking a slow breath.

“All right,” Entrapta said. “But what should I list your not-a-date with Amity Blight under in my logs, if it wasn’t a date?”

“An espionage mission,” Catra said, without thinking.

“Got it!” Entrapta said.

Catra turned and walked out of the laboratory while slapping a rune on her staff and poofing it away to a pocket dimension until she needed it – and then she heard a familiar set of footprints. She stepped back into the doorway and held her breath as around the corner came Darius. The tall, powerfully built witch had dark brown-black skin and a neat set of slightly slick purple hair and beard – formed from the same abomination goo that Entrapta’s hair was formed from. Save that unlike her, his control and mastery over the material was powerful enough to make him the head of the Abomination Coven. He was dressed in his finest purple, black and gold get up, with a cape swept dramatically over one arm and his boots clicking ominously loudly as he advanced down the corridor, glaring forward.

His other hand was holding the chair that Catra had shredded.

Catra remained perfectly still as he walked past.

Then she saw him stop.

Then slam his heel into the ground. A shimmering purple puddle opened up under her and she yelped, leaping up and grabbing onto the frame of the door to keep herself from being yanked down – but a big hand of purple grabbed onto her waist and *yanked*. Her claws shredded the frame as she was pulled down – and was dropped straight out of the ceiling and landed on her feet and hands right before Darius, who glowered down at him.

"Explain," he said, coolly, holding his chair up and aiming the ruined back at her. "And use complete sentences, if you'd be so kind."

Catra cocked her head. "Ebberwolf ebberwolfed Ebberwolfiley."

Darius frowned at her. "Ebberwolf," he said. "And why, pray tell, did he say the chair stinks of you."

"He has it in for me," Catra said, shrugging arrogantly. "Always had, ever since I showed him up in the tracking game."

Darius leaned in, his voice soft. "Listen, Catra. You are playing a very dangerous game here…"

“Oh noooo, what are you going to do? Goo at me?” Catra asked, grinning as she leaned in.

Darius glared at her, his skin rippling as a line of purple slipped from his hair down his scalp, along his cheek, into his neck and under his clothing. His voice grew softer still. “I happen to have served with *several* Golden Guards. And you’re the first one I’ve ever met who I think genuinely deserves Belos.” Then he stood, and walked past her, shoving the chair into her chest. “Have it *fixed*, Golden Guard.”

Catra stumbled, grabbing onto the chair. She frowned.

“There were other Golden Guards?” she asked, softly. She shook her head, then started off to find Scorpia.

In the end, she found her in the library, holding a book very gingerly between her claws – and when Catra entered, Scorpia snapped it shut and managed to pierce the book through with both her tips. She sighed, then tossed it into the trash – where it landed next to five other books that had been impaled. But turning to face Catra, she started speaking before Catra could even say anything. “Catra! I’ve finished investigating the library attack.”

“The…” Catra blinked, then frowned. “Oh?”

“So, the janitor only a tiny amount of blood,” Scorpia said. “Way less than, say, a vampire, or a fampire, or a revenant, or a ghoul, ghost, gremlin, goblin, spooky, haunt, ghost-”

“You said ghost already,” Catra said, her ears flicking back.

“Just covering all the bases. There’s both onryō and guǐ and some others!” Scorpia nodded. “But I covered every base, and I checked down the weird possibilities, like demons or pranksters.” She reached into her pockets and pulled out a manilla folder, waving it around between her claws. Catra took it before it was sliced in half and started to flip through. For a woman without hands or manipulators of any kind, Scorpia had done a remarkable job running down all the leads. She frowned as she flipped the envelope shut.

“So who attacked the guy?” she asked.

“The only thing we detected on him with...this!” Scorpia said, taking out a vial. It had a teeny tiny bit of hair in it, the color impossible to tell without a bright light and a microscope. She held it out to Catra, who took it, frowning.

“So, Entrapta can run it through a lab and say what monster it was?” Catra asked, curiously.

“Sure can!” Scorpia said.

Catra nodded. “Good...work, Scorpia,” she said, the words sounding like she was suddenly speaking French. She shook her head a bit. “You were really running this down all day?”

“Anything to keep my wildcat safe!” Scorpia said, her voice dramatic, focused. “And to keep her girlfriend safe too.”

“I don’t have a girlfriend!” Catra said, flushing. “Amity’s just an asset.”

“She’s an asset to us all,” Scorpia said, cheerfully. “Like a million bucks – I mean, I’ve seen how she lights up your entire face when you think about her.”

“I’m scowling,” Catra said, forcing herself to scowl.

“And purring, just thinkin’ about her!” Scorpia’s eyes grew soft. “Ah, it’s young love. Oh! I’m so proud of you for finally breaking your cold shell and finding someone-”

“I’m *older* than you!” Catra flung up her hands. Scorpia tapped her claw, gently, against Catra’s chest, smiling at her.

“Maybe in years, but not in what matters.” She flung her arms around Catra, snatching her up and giving her a back-snapping hug. Catra yoweld, writhing and kicking her legs. She scrabbled, desperately, to escape, and managed to go boneless in the way

that cats could, slipping out from Scorpia's arms, landing and rolling away. She came to her feet, gasping and rubbing her back.

"No hugging!" She said. "I have to deal with the BI weapon's drop."

"Have fun dealing with Blight Industries!"

Catra froze.

Right.

That was what BI stood for.

***

The heavy stomping sound of brass feet and the steady sloshing of abomination goo sliding back and forth within tresses and pneumatic pumps filled the air as Odalia and Aladar Blight walked their goods into the Belosian armory. Catra, her hand holding the mask of the Golden Guard, peeked around the corner...and saw that Amity was, of course, among them. Crap. Catra slid her mask on, then stepped out to the bustling courtyard. She bowed low and politely to Odalia.

"Miss Blight," she said, and felt the urge to follow that up with *I fucked your daughter last night.* She pushed it out of her head

with sheer effort, while Odalia gave her a cold, cold smile. The green haired witch had aged extremely gracefully, her hair remaining *mostly* green save for a pale white streak in it. She was dressed in a sleek business suit and the only sign she wasn't simply a manager was the oracular focus around her throat. That one gemstone made Odalia a dangerous, dangerous woman – Catra knew oracular magic was one of the most difficult to master, and the hardest to apply *practically*.

Rumors – and some sensitive intelligence files she had read – said that Odalia had managed to attune her foci to connect to others, essentially allowing her to send messages to others who wore them without risking interception. If that was the case, she was violating several of Belos' laws.

But...well…

Aladar made such good weapons that Catra was pretty sure she could get away with it.

"Ah, the Golden Guard, Catra, right?" Odalia asked.

"That's me," Catra said, glad that her mask changed her voice somewhat. Also, she wasn't affecting Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce's diffident tones.

"Well, we're here with five hundred Abomaton soldiers, mark IIIs, complete with our lovely daughter, Amity Blight, to ensure that

they’re loaded, stored, and prepared properly.” Odalia said, smiling. “We’re teaching her the family buisness.”

Amity looked as if she had never been more disinterested in anything in her life. She looked at Catra as if she were a bug.

“I can provide additional spe-” Aladar started.

“No, honey, I think it is time we let Amity take over,” Odalia said, and Catra felt an immediate *ping* of raw sympathy. She leaned in, kissing her daughter on her cheek, then touched her gemstone – which flickered for half a moment, then went dim. Amity winced, ever so slightly...and Catra clenched her hands tight against her palm, feeling her claws pricking at the tips of her fingers. She felt the sudden urge to rip the *entirety* of Odalia’s actual face off. She forced the raw, burning anger down her throat, while Amity walked back. Her voice grew dry and bored as she gestured to the abomotons. Or Abomatons? However it was said, she didn’t really care right now.

Amity walked past Catra, her hand gesturing dryly to the abominations. “These are Abomaton soldiers – the mark III variation. This means they’ve been augmented with orichalicum plate armor and moonsilver circuitry to enhance their mobility. Motonic flow has been stabilized, allowing them to maintain cohesion in the face of seventy six percent more damage. Furthermore, they have several integrated weapons for defensive and offensive actions.” She sounded like she was reading from script. Catra chuckled.

“They’re not exactly lighting your world on fire, huh?” she asked. “You know, we could always talk about something more interesting.” Catra grinned behind her mask, ready to turn on the charm.

“If you’re trying to flirt with me, Golden Guard, I would hasten to remind you that I’m a representative of Blight Industries and, thus, on the clock,” Amity said – her tone just as cold and dry as before. But now she was using it as a shield. Or, worse, a weapon. Catra blinked behind her mask. She had been rebuffed that hard before – but never by a girl Amity’s age.

“What, you got a boyfriend or something?” Catra asked, more to fill space than to actually expect an answer.

“Yes,” Amity said. Then, the word slipping out before she could stop it, she said: “And-”

And cut herself off.

Catra scowled behind her mask. “And what?” She asked.

“And I think we should focus on getting these abominations loaded and prepared for patrols and other tasks-”

Catra stepped forward and put her arm between Amity and the door leading deeper into the armory, her palm planted on the

wall, her head cocked. “And *what*?” she asked.

“...and my *girlfriend*...is ten times the witch you’d ever hope to be, Catra,” Amity said, her voice soft. “And she can’t even cast magic without glyphs. I would rather we be *professional*.” She grabbed onto Catra’s wrist, levering it up and out of her way. “And get this out of the way.”

Catra watched her walk into the armory. “...right,” she said, her voice soft.

The loading and preparation of the abominations went by in a blur. Catra went through everything, took Lilith’s good job, went to her room, and found that the entire day had slipped through her fingers without even noticing. She took her mask off, and held it. Echoing in her head, Amity’s words kept repeating themselves, again and again and again. *Ten times the witch you are.* Ten times the witch you are. Ten. Times.

Looking at it, logically, Catra was pretty sure she had never been more proud of herself. She had Amity so completely convinced by her fake identity that she was willing to defend her in the face of her overbearing mother’s opinion and the actual, literal face of the Belosian Empire. She had to have known that all it would take would be Catra going to Belos and whispering one bad word in his ear, and her family, her future, would have been sunk. And instead, she had defended Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce. She had defended her.

Catra threw her mask into the wall with a shriek. It hit, cracked, rebounded, then landed on the floor. It exploded, then – not literally, but into a kaleidoscope of glittering refractions. It bounced between water drops.

Between tears.

She knelt and started to smash her palms into the mask, scrabbling at it, screaming in raw, pure fury. The mask came to pieces as she smashed it again and again against the ground, then started to claw at the stone. The rage came from nowhere – and it felt almost as bad, almost as deep black-sick as the rage she sometimes felt at Adora. She ducked her head forward, her shoulders shaking...and felt camp coming back to her. The memories of the electricity. Of the voices telling her to *be normal*. It was all in black and white – and the only color there was Adora's blond hair, her red jacket, her stupid red jacket, her expression, turning away when they dragged Catra away from her.

"Fuck! Fuck! Fuck! Fuck!" Catra sobbed at the floor, her claws aching against the groves. "*Fuck*."

Tears streamed down her chin, puddling.

"Fuck!"

She bowed her head more, her shoulders shaking.

She cried until there was no noise in her throat, save for the scratches. And then, slowly, she thumped to her side. She curled up on the floor, her eyes closing. *Be calm. Be still.* She started to trace the images of the glyphs, drawing them as she lay there, looking down at the puddle of her tears. A bit of light shone across it as she panted softly. Snot dribbled from her nose. She felt like a complete mess – her body wrung completely dry. Completely empty.

She traced the light rune in her head, again. And again. And again.

Then, in the puddle of tears, she saw a palm and a dark face looking from it. The face was not her own. She couldn't see more than a flash of soft eyes, and dark skin, and a concerned expression. Catra sat up.

But when she looked into the puddle of tears, the face was gone. Instead, slipping from her pocket and *tinging* loudly against the floor was the sample Scorpia had given her. Catra took it. She frowned at the puddle.

That's the second time, she thought.

Something is going on. She knew it. Deep in her chest.

She looked down at the sample case.

And I'm going to find out what it-

And that was when Titan-Ra blew up the abominations in storage.

TO BE CONTINUED

Adora Gray and the No Hope

Chapter Summary

> Adora Gray learns a shocking truth. Catra's mentor struts her stuff.

"I'm not going to commit *domestic terrorism*!" Adora hissed under her breath to Glimmer, mere hours before committing domestic terrorism.

Glimmer slowly looked up from Adora to the slender witchling who was examining Adora's spine with a magnifying glass being held in the beak of a remarkably well trained gryphon. Said girl hummed softly. "Well, it looks like your spine is...*not* broken!" She said, nodding as she stood up, her gryphon tossing the magnifying glass into the air, catching the narrow end in his beak, and eating the entire thing without a single hint of discomfort.

"We knew that already, Viney," Bow said, tolerantly. "We're just wondering *why* it's not broken. Like, a witch could handle that fall, but..."

"Well," Viney said, rubbing her chin. "I'll need to do some basic checkup spells on her. Do you mind, Adora?"

"No, it's fine," Adora said, still a little unsettled.

“Let me just get my materials! Puddles, get mommy her materials!” Viney said, clapping her hands twice. The gryphon scampered off, while Glimmer leaned in, her voice soft.

“But if we don’t show my Mom what we can do, as a team, then she’ll never let us into the rebellion,” she whispered.

“I’m not blowing up a warehouse full of abominations,” Adora whispered back. “I’m still not even super comfortable being a...a...a superhero!” She shrugged a bit.

“They’re not just abominations, they’re abomiatons.” Glimmer tapped her pointer finger against her palm, her eyes flashing with every tap. “They’re made by Blight Industries-”

“Blight!?” Adora squeaked, jerking up so fast that she almost fell off the makeshift desk that Viney was using as her examination table. Adora had not asked many questions when Glimmer had said she had known exactly who should check her out – and she was beginning to regret going along with the flow, considering her doctor appeared to be the same age as her, operated entirely out of Hexside, and was dressed in the flat grays of the detention track. Despite all those warning signs though, Viney had managed to heal up Adora’s bruises and was now...taking a gigantic needle from her pet gryphon’s taloned paws. Adora gulped, then snapped her head back to Glimmer, who was nodding at her.

“Yeah, Amity Blight’s mom and dad runs Blight Industries, the biggest abomination manufacturing company in the whole empire,” she said. “You didn’t know that?”

“W-wow. She’s rich too.” Adora whispered, blushing hard. She barely noticed when the needle gently tapped against her temple. She blinked. “Hey!”

“A brain sample is the best-” Viney started.

“Use a different place, I need my *brain*!” Adora said, squirming almost off the desk, her hands clapping to the sides of her head.

“Oh fine,” Viney said, then slammed the entire needle directly into Adora’s thigh.

Adora sat very still, then as the needle was drawn out and Viney walked over to another desk to start doing lord knows what to it, she said: “...ow.”

“You know, Principle Castaspella was almost gonna let me get away with two tracks, but Belos really has been cracking down on wild witch stuff,” Viney said, cheerfully. “Still, I have been studying and working on combining the Beast and Healing magics – the end result has been remarkable. Like, normally, this would require me to carry my own supplies, but instead, Puddles does it all for me.”

Puddles coughed up several large spiders, which started to scuttle along the floor. Adora yanked her feet up and off the ground before any got near her. “Oh my God!” she said. “What’s *wrong* with him?”

“Huh? Nothing, all gryphons have spider breath,” Viney said.

“Yeah, everyone knows that,” Bow added.

Adora shuddered from her blond hair poof to her toes.

“All right!” Viney said, humming cheerfully. “Well, it looks like other than a very slight deficiency of vitamin R and Evil, you’re actually pretty healthy for a teenage witchling. It looks like you have some old breaks, probably due to being deprived as a youth, but see, here?” She pointed at several glowing lines that shimmered out from a rippling orb of blue light she had conjured into existence above the syringe of blood. “Your R intake has spiked up recently, which means your parents have stopped starving you. Were they using a cage or more of a pit trap?” She asked, sounding honestly curious.

“Uh…” Glimmer said. “Adora’s human, see?” she pointed at Adora’s ears, while Adora reached up with one hand, brushing her hair back to show her rounded ear.

“Hmm,” Viney said. Then she shrugged. “The blood doesn’t lie.”

“But I don’t have a bile gland!” Adora said. “I was born in the human realms! I’m a human, as human as human can be.”

Viney twirled her finger, and a glowing blue circle shimmered to life. A moment later, a circular hole seemed to rip itself into Adora's chest. It was strange to see flesh peeling back without feeling any pain – nor see any gore. It was as if her organs and her blood were quite politely revealing themselves with as little muss and fuss as possible, the spell showing her heart and her lungs and her ribs. Adora would have been fascinated, but she had no time around being sick to her stomach and growing increasingly panicky and short of breath. Ignoring any of that, Viney walked over, then pointed with her finger. "Ah, see, right there!" She said, her finger nearly touching Adora's heart, which was pumping and jumping wildly. "See? There's a surgical scar and some old stitching."

"...wait…" Bow whispered.

"Are you saying-" Glimmer said.

"-that Adora-" Bow added.

"Is-"

"Nope!" Adora sprang off the table, causing the spell to shimmer into a wild poof of blue sparkles. Her chest was once more shut up, and her hands barely shook at all as she snatched up her backpack off the ground, the sword within clinking. "I'm human! I'm *so* human! I...I was born in the human realms! I have a mom! She's my real mom, and she raised me...a-and I just had...I had a heart condition when I was young! That was all! There was...I…" She looked from Bow to Glimmer to Bow, to Glimmer, to Viney, to

Glimmer. For some reason the room suddenly bloomed into a million tiny sparkles. She stepped back, then turned to the door.

"Adora!"

She was out the door, choking.

"Adora, wait!"

Then she was drawing the sword and hissing out the words – her voice barely audible even to herself.

But, as it turned out, even Titan-Ra could cry. She charged into the woods, running from her friends and from Hexisde. She crashed into trees and stumbled through brushes, then finally came to a skidding stop, her eyes streaming with tears. Her claws dug into the ground, and she looked up through her altered bangs to see she had come to the ancient manor that she had found the sword at. She didn't know if she had been called here, or if she had simply been drawn here by some memory. She sniffed and gasped.

"I'm human," she whispered.

How can you eat the food here?

“I’m human…”

How come the sword chose you?

“I’m human!” she ducked her head down, eyes closing tightly.

Are you?

A faint sound of shifting movement jerked Adora’s head back up again. She had shifted back to her...back to her normal form without realizing it, and as she looked up, she saw a figure standing in the heart of the manor house. Adora stood, the sword left at her feet, her hands clenched tightly. “Who are you!?” she shouted.

The figure stepped forward into the light. They looked feminine, but demonic – a living stained glass window of a creature, with angular features done in purples and pinks. Their horns glinted and they looked down at Adora, then spoke.

“Welcome...Welcome...W-W...W...Welcome.”

The word repeated again and again. Like a skipping computer, glitching out. Adora started to walk forward. Her hands were clenched tightly into fists, still, as if she was going to swing a blow.

“What are you!?” Adora said.

“I- I- I-” the figure blinked, then shivered in place. “I am Light Hope. I am...am...am...the house demon of the Grayskull Estate. Protector of the- the- the- the family.”

Adora blinked, slowly, the tears drying on her cheeks. She opened her fingers, then closed it.

“...who am I?” she whispered.

The house demon stepped forward. Adora became aware of how it, like Hooty, was connected to Grayskull Estate as much as Hooty was tied to the Owl House. Thin tendrils of smokey light, as if glass had become soft and pliant and then stretched out to connect shoulders to wall and ceiling, pushed into her back and arms, like she was a living puppet. She stepped down towards Adora, moving along the creaky old porch without a noise, then placed her hand on Adora’s shoulder. She gave her a tentative smile.

“You are Adora Grayskull,” Light Hope said. “Daughter of Marlena and Randor Grayskull, former head of the Portal Coven.”

Adora whimpered. “W-What…” She closed her eyes. “Tell me everything, Light Hope. *Everything*.”

Light Hope nodded.

And, in her glitching, meandering way…

She did.

***

Something about emotions can be exhausting. Crying. Being told shattering truths. All of it left you feeling hollow. Wrung out. It was why, when Adora came home to find King and Eda were out, she tried to stay awake until they came back to tell them everything. Instead, she fell asleep on the couch.

And again…

She dreamed.

In the dream, she saw another Titan-Ra.

But it wasn't *her*.

The Titan-Ra stood in a field of rubble and flowers as rain twinkled and pinged off her halo – and the rain burned. It hissed and sizzed and Adora felt it bite into her flesh, skinning through her body like knives of cold fire. Titan-Ra was looking down at Adora, and Adora was crawling towards her, desperately. The expression of Titan-Ra was unreadable – a mixture of...disgust and pity. She looked down at Adora as Adora crawled towards her – and the urge to say so many things burned through her.

But she didn't have to say any of them.

She reached into the sodden mess that was her chest…

And brought *it* out.

You think you've won, don't you?

Adora jerked up, blinking a few times. The door was opened and King and Eda came in, Eda carrying a bundle on her back, whistling cheerfully. "Adora!" King said, excitedly. "You're back! Eda got some food and treats and she's gonna let me eat some of them!" He scampered up to her lap and Adora smiled, relaxing ever so slightly and sliding her palm along his head.

"Yeah," she said, then hesitated. "Guys." She paused. "I have to...say something. Uh. And I don't know what it even means." She gulped. "B-But, uh…" She hesitated more, while Eda walked to her side, kneeling down, looking concerned.

“Is it about the domestic terrorism?” Eda asked.

“N-No, uh, heh…” Adora smiled, shakily. “Or. Well.” She frowned. “It kinda is now…”

She smiled, and then felt a momentary twinge of relief inside her. No matter what she had learned, no matter what she was...she had a family, didn’t she? King and Eda both listened as she spoke.

And in the mirror, the dark shape watched.

And screamed.

Silently, she beat her hands against the mirror, throwing herself against the hardened pane of glass that cut her from the world. She scrabbled against it, everything forgotten but a single furious spark. She sagged against the glass, peering in...and then closed her eyes and started to sob. She had no tears, no body, nothing in here save the shadow of a shadow, projected into this *space* that didn’t...couldn’t...shouldn’t have existed.

And still, she cried.

“They’re *mine*!” she sobbed. “My family! You *stole* my family!”

In the mirror, silently, she could see the blond one speaking, growing animated. She made gestures with her hands. Eda nodded and then looked grave, shaking her head. King spread his paws, his eyes narrowing in anger, then he mimed a punch. Eda and the blond one laughed. And the shadow remained alone.

Trapped.

Forgotten.

The shadow shifted away from the mirror. She crawled in and peered at wrong wrong wrong, not right. She shook her head, moving away from the mirror where the pink haired one was brushing her teeth with her toothhaste. She crawled, inch by painful inch, to another window – and there, she saw Amity, laying on her bed, looking down at her journal. She was writing in it. She looked away, distantly, then sighed softly, her eyes shimmering slightly – soft, wanting, longing.

The shadow put her palm against the pane of glass – the window she was peering from – and then a gust of wind caught the pane and swung it wildly open. The view was now of Bonesburrough – and the day looked warm and sprightly. Amity wasn't going to close the window.

The shadow pressed her forehead against the glass and screamed.

"*Amity*!"

Silence. Ringing and vast and absolute.

"*Ammmmity*!"

Her not-throat felt raw. Torn. Bleeding. She closed her eyes and the window began to grow dark.

And faintly, the shadow heard a quiet, amused chuckle. She released the window and dropped down, landing in brackish, dead water. She crawled, almost like an animal – following the sound of laughter. The actual *noise*. It was like the first taste of food to a starving woman, even if she knew it was pure poison. She peered around a triangular, jagged gap in the place, then squirmed and wriggled through. She felt herself pressing against a stone wall – a flattened shadow, cast in a chamber that was full of machinery and death. The corpses of drained and shucked palismans were scattered everywhere, and the vast, desiccated heart of the Titan hung overhead, hooked to a machine that pulsed and thrummed with power.

And there, standing in the room, was Belos.

"Are you ready to deal?" he asked, turning to face her. He could see her.

And she could hear him.

His face – twisted and distorted by exposure to magic – was unmasked, unveiled.

She could see his smirk.

She didn't respond.

"Well, are you?" he asked. "Luz Noceda?"

***

Glimmer had just gotten her teeth back in when Adora's head peeked over the edge of her window.

"Psst, Glimmer!" she whispered.

"Ahh!" Glimmer jerked, then spun around, facing her. "How did you get past the guards!?"

Adora grinned at her. "I used Titan-Ra powers!" She hauled herself up and in. "Okay! ...I'm ready to do some domestic

terrorism!”

“...d-don’t...you want to talk about the whole gigantic revelations about yourself first?” Glimmer asked, looking nervous. “Like, you ran away *really* fast.”

Adora sighed. “It’s…” She hesitated. “It’s lot.” She sat at the bed. “Have you ever heard of the Portal Coven?” she asked.

“Yeah, I think so. They all betrayed the Emperor, got declared Wild Witches, and were...wiped out…” Glimmer’s eyes widened. “Wait. Your parents were in the Portal Coven?”

“They weren’t just *in* the Portal Coven,” Adora whispered. “They *led* the Portal Coven. I found this sword in the ruins of their home – and I think that’s why the Emperor destroyed them.” She drew the sword from her backpack, setting it onto her lap. “This sword is important – and Titan-Ra is important. It was important enough for...for my entire *family* to be…” She closed her eyes. “Belos is why I...I grew up in the human realm. Why I have no magic. Why my whole childhood, I was...breaking bones and...and…” She closed her eyes. “He has to pay for that.”

Glimmer grinned and nodded. “Well, I’m not going to disagree!” she said, then sat on the bed next to Adora. “Are you ready to head out?”

“Yeah,” Adora said. Then she hesitated. “So, wait, just...did you really learn portal magic so you can teleport around, despite knowing the Portal Coven was all destroyed by the Emperor?”

“Well, yeah, I’m a rebel,” Glimmer said. “I have to rebel at least a little to be a rebel!” She sounded huffy.

Adora grinned back at her. Then she threw her arm around Glimmer, drawing her in close and hugging her tightly. “Thanks,” she whispered. “This whole crazy adventure has been worth it, just to be friends with you and Bow.” She murmured, nuzzling against the top of her head. She drew back. “Now, I just need to figure out what all my other weird dreams are about.”

“We can talk to Barcus! He’s in detention for mixing potions and oracles!” Glimmer said, standing as she rubbed her palms together and then twirling her finger. A moment later, Bow appeared in a spray of pinkish sparkles, wearing a tunic that left his entire midriff exposed, a heart shaped symbol emblazoned on his chest. It was all done in whites and pinks, and it went quite well with his bow and quiver. He grinned and puffed up his chest.

“Lets...skip that...I…” Adora cocked her head. “B-Bow, why does your battle armor…” She gestured to him.

“Well, the heart symbolizes the wild heart of the Titan, free from Belosian tyranny at last!” Bow said, gesturing to his chest.

"And…?" Adora pointed at his belly.

"Well, this is because I worked really hard on my abs," Bow said, a bit sheepishly. "Also, I like showing off. You know? Is it illegal for a boy to like showing off?"

"Not even a little!" Glimmer purred, clearly enjoying the show.

"I mean, maybe, the Conformatorium guards are pretty strict," Adora said at the same time.

Glimmer snorted. "All right, so, here's my plan…" She said, laying out a plan that was gloriously complex in its devilish intricacies – akin to something thought up by the great generals of antiquity. Belisarius or Julius Caesar might have been impressed by its fiendish cleverness. Patton and Rommel could have taken some notes. Sun Tzu and Genghis Khan, the Khan of Khans, would need to bow down before it.

***

Glimmer, Titan-Ra and Bow appeared in the center of the heavily guarded warehouse full of abominaton soldiers and Glimmer shouted: "*Get 'em!"*

Then she started blasting. Her glittering balls of purple energy hit two Coven Guards square in the chest, sending them sprawling

backwards and into the non-active abomatons. The goopy, glistening masses of muscular malice splattered onto the ground as the others started to rouse and become aware that they were, in fact, under attack.

Bow, his bow in his hand, snapped his aim up and loosed an arrow – it thunked into one of the abomaton's forehead, sizzled, then exploded with a flare of blue fire.

Now, Titan-Ra decided it was time for her to see what she could do. She twirled her sword, then tried to slash one of the abomination's heads right off. She missed. Instead of hitting the soft goop, she struck the gorget of creature. The gorget was made of solid brass, glittering crystal, and other bits of machinery that connected the abomination's structural muscle to the magitech augmentation that turned it from a mere goopster into a deadly, dangerous threat.

Titan-Ra's sword didn't even slow down. A glimmering flash of mirror bright metal shone into her eyes for a moment as she saw that her blade had slashed a perfect cut through the entire creature's neck and the machinery attached to the shoulders and back. Then the abomaton collapsed to the ground with a crash and splatter.

"Titan-Ra! Look out!"

Bow's voice jerked her head up – and she saw that three of the abomatons were charging towards her, their arms whirling like they were kids with tiny siblings and were doing the whole 'i'm

going to swing my arms and walk towards you and if you happen to be in my way, I will hit you but I'm not actually *trying* to hit you' thing that Adora had only ever seen in sitcoms. She lifted her sword up behind her, her other hand sweeping out as green runes flared to life and plants exploded from the ground, wrapping around abomaton after abomaton, picking the writhing creatures up. She flicked her wrist and sent all three flying into the wall of the warehouse, where they left craters in the walls.

"Wow. Your plant magic is really good!" Bow said, grinning – then grunted as a sword burs from his back.

"Bow!" Titan-Ra screamed as the Coven Guard behind Bow shoved the dark skinned witch to his knees.

"Augh! I...die!" Bow gasped, his voice dramatic – while a *second* Bow stood up from behind a discarded crate of supplies, knocking an arrow with a large, blunt head. He loosed and the arrow exploded into a net, which swept around the guard and pitched him against a waking abomaton. The other Bow bloomed into smoke and sparkles, vanishing into nothingness.

"One of these days, you're actually going to get stabbed, and I won't even know it!" Glimmer snapped, her voice frayed as she vanished out of the way of a wall of crackling golden energy flung her way by a Coven Guard who was foregoing creativity, innovation and advanced magic in favor of sheer, raw force. The golden beam struck the wall behind where Glimmer had stood, crunching it inwards, then crunching it inwards again as she appeared and vanished again and again – then she appeared behind the guard, a pale white staff in her hands.

She brought the staff cracking down onto the back of the guard's head, and the Coven Guard dropped to the ground, groaning.

Titan-Ra nodded, then swept her gaze around...but more and more of the abomatons were coming to jerky life. Lots of them. However, she had just spotted something that shone brightly in her altered eyes: A pipe running along the ceiling and into the center of the room where it then branched out to run into several machines along the entire chamber. A power source. She grinned, then shouted. "Glimmer, get Bow and the Coven Guards out of here. I have an idea!"

Glimmer nodded, vanished in a stuttering, flickering loop – appearing beside each of the unconscious and trapped guards and popping them out, before she finally appeared behind Bow, then vanished with him.

Titan-Ra pointed up at the ceiling and saw the shimmering red runes of fire crackling around her bony finger and her dark hand. She grinned fiercely as a fireball appeared there in the air above her palm. She held it for a few seconds, then flicked it with one finger. The ball of fire whipped up, and arced around, taking a circuitous route – giving Titan-Ra time to turn, sprint past two reaching abomatons, then leap towards one of the narrow windows.

The fireball flew into the power source.

The wave of concussive heat slammed into Titan-Ra's back, causing her cape to catch around her hips and ankles, billowing as her witch hat fluttered around her head – kept on thanks to her horns jutting through the holes seated in the brim. The glass shattered before her bony feet and she sailed out and landed right before Belos' castle walls. Glass shards rained around her as the entire warehouse exploded again – once, twice, three times as secondary fireballs bloomed from different machines. A huge gear smashed into the ground to her right and Titan-Ra yelped, jerking away from it.

"Well, well, well!"

A voice called down from the walls. Lifting her gaze, Titan-Ra saw the tall, slender form of Lilith Clawthorne – Edalynn's sister. She was just as haughty, arrogant and coldly beautiful as Adora would have thought, considering she was the 'square' one. She regarded Titan-Ra as if she was a remarkably fascinating insect.

Titan-Ra smirked, slightly, resting her sword on her shoulder. "Lilith, right?"

"Correct, though, you can call me Coven Head Clawthorne," Lilith said, reaching out with one hand – a staff tipped with an elegant wooden raven – all done in sleek white. She lifted her chin. "It will be rather enjoyable to watch my protégé annihilate you."

"Catra's your protégé?" Titan-Ra asked.

"Of course. Did you think I'd let a talent like that molder?" Lilith chuckled. "I've been taking care of her since she first showed up here – nurturing her potential, seeing her *grow*."

"...oh...t-that's nice!" Titan-Ra called up.

"I don't need your approval," Lilith's voice was pure ice. Then she looked aside. "Golden Guard, come."

There was no sign of Catra.

Lilith frowned.

"...Golden Guard!" she called out, firmly.

Titan-Ra shifted from foot to foot, glancing around. She saw no sign of her best friend slash arch-nemisis either. She did see Glimmer and Bow, both of them having taken cover from the explosion, both of them peeking out. Glimmer was making a frantic set of hand gestures that Adora was fairly sure made total sense to her. She couldn't follow them at all.

"M-Maybe she's sleeping in!" Titan-Ra suggested.

Lilith turned her piercing gaze back on Titan-Ra.

Her expression had shifted.

And Titan-Ra realized something.

Oh, I'm in a lot of danger.

"What have you done to Catra?" Lilith asked, her voice flat and ice cold.

"Nothing! I swear!" Titan-Ra said.

"There's one tiny problem, Titan-Ra." Lilith said. She stepped up onto the parapet of the castle walls. "I don't *believe* you."

Lilith took a step and dropped off the wall. She shot towards Titan-Ra like a lightning bolt, crackling with blue energy. Her staff would have driven into Titan-Ra's chest, had she not snapped her sword up, braced it with one palm and blocked the impact. It still sent her skidding backwards several feet, kicking up a plume of dust and sending her cape and hat fluttering wildly. Lilith glared at her, her lips pressed thin – then shoved off hard. She landed lightly on her feet, legs spread to catch her fall, staff snapped to the side.

Oh I'm so dead, Titan-Ra thought as she shifted the grip on her sword – but she worked first to get some defenses up. Blue runes

flared and a wall of ice exploded from the ground.

And a blue and white raven the size of a building and made of crackling fire sliced through the wall, exploding it into a plume of white, powdered snow. The raven grabbed at Titan-Ra's arms with its talons and she jerked aside at the last second, slashing the construction away – even as the ground under her feet bubbled, turned to mud, then sucked her down to her shins. From the mud came grasping hands, made of raw purple abomination goo. Lilith strode through the cloud of settling snow, her staff glowing, her other hand shimmering as she held a blue circle between her fingers, rather like someone might hold a badge between all their fingers.

She twisted the circle, then brought the staff up and down, conducting a flow of raw magic.

Titan-Ra swept her sword, severing some of the arms, wrenched herself free, and kicked. She rolled out of the mud pit before a blue fist the size of a car came smashing down on where she had stood. Claws of blue fire snapped into existence around her, slashing at her face, her arms, her sides, her back. Her sword flashed left, right, up, down – parrying instinctively. Every time the fire and the sword met, sparks flew, a haze of them.

Titan-Ra strode backwards, trying to get some room. She stepped onto a wooden set of slats that ran along the edge of the warehouses – a place to get one's feet out of the mud. The slats rattled, shifted, then curved, turning into an arcing ramp that sent her rolling back towards the ground.

Enough reacting! Act! Titan-Ra thought, desperately. She slashed out with her palm, and plants bloomed from the ground. Vines reached towards Lilith, wrapping around her wrists, her ankles, grabbing onto her and holding her in place as Titan-Ra scrambled to her feet, trying to get her feet from under her. Then she flicked her free hand, making desperate flinging motions. Tiny darts of flames whipped towards Lilith – who simply *vanished*.

She appeared to Titan-Ra's left.

"I am the *head* of the Emperor's *Coven*," Lilith snarled, her staff cracking into Titan-Ra's hip before she vanished and appeared to Titan-Ra's right. This time, the blow landed on Titan-Ra's arm as she lifted it up to ward off the blow. "You think you can hurt *my daughter*!?"

Vanished.

Behind – crack! Titan-Ra stumbled to her knee.

Vanished.

Above her.

Crack!

Titan-Ra fell onto her chest, her head throbbing. She put her hands under her palms, trying to shove herself to her feet.

"Get away from her!"

Glimmer's voice was distant.

"Glimmer...no!" Titan-Ra croaked.

She lifted her head – and saw that Lilith was lifting her gaze up, towards Glimmer and Bow. But before she could focus on them, Titan-Ra lifted her hand and let the magic *surge*. Purple energy swept over the two of her friends, snapping them away and flinging them right into the Owl House.

They'll be...safe…

***

Bow and Glimmer stumbled before the Owl House. "Adora!" Glimmer shouted. "I'm going back for her, I can teleport right-"

Hooty swept up and out of the ground, eating her from her feet to her head and swallowing her with a *ulp*. "No teleporting on the

premises!” He said, then grabbed onto Bow and swallowed him whole. “Hooty! Hoot Hoot!”

He blinked, looking off into space.

“Pellets now! Pellets forever!” he said, then sank down into the ground, leaving it undisturbed. Unruffled. Unmarked.

***

Titan-Ra gasped as glowing chains snapped into existence around her wrists, then yanked backwards. Lilith planted her staff on the ground before her, frowning – while Coven Guards started to advance, swords and staves in their hands. Titan-Ra lifted her head up, her brow furrowing, clenching her teeth as she tried to keep the pain from overwhelming her. But, to her surprise, the repeated battering was already beginning to fade.

“Well, well, well,” an oily, slithering voice filled the air. “It seems that you have once more earned your keep, Lilith.”

“My Emperor, it is a pleasure, as always, to do my duty,” Lilith said, stepping aside and giving Titan-Ra her first look at the Emperor himself. He was tall and robed, his brilliant white and gold uniform seeming to gird him in purity. His mask was tall and horned, golden and concealing in equal measures. The only thing of him that she could see, really, was his eyes: Glowing, bright

blue coals sitting in the darkness of the mask. He regarded Titan-Ra with a curiously familiar expression.

"Is it true?" One of the Coven Guards whispered.

"Is that really Titan-Ra?"

"She's...chosen by the Titan, right?"

"What does this mean?"

The murmuring was clear. And soft.

The Emperor Belos knelt down, then took hold of Titan-Ra's discarded sword. And he murmured, under his breath.

"Now, Noceda. Do your part."

Titan-Ra's brow furrowed, in confusion. And she swore she was the only one who saw it.

A shadow...reached across the ground. It was cast by none of the guards, and it was running *against* the firelight that glimmered

from the warehouse. It was tentative and human shaped, and it took hold of the sword in Belos' hand and yanked at it. Titan-Ra felt her connection to the sword lurch. Hard. She clenched her teeth, then gasped, then screamed as the shadow pulled *hard*. She trembled as her magic crackled, buzzed, then fizzed off her body, frothing and cascading away, leaving her...merely Adora.

"A human," Belos said, his voice condemnatory as the Coven Guards gasped and softly started to mutter among one another.

"Titan-Ra is a human?"

"What does that mean?"

"Is he a fake?"

"She's a fake. Nothing but a charlatan, pretending to know the Titan's will!" Belos said, his voice growing firmer and louder. "This sword is *fake*." He grabbed onto it...and twisted it. For a moment, his hands crackled with red sparks, and he strained. Adora grinned, slightly. That sword was-

The sword *cracked* audibly.

"Nothing but a prop," Belos said, casually dropping the two halves of the sword to the ground, splattering against the mud and the muck. "Take her away to the dungeons."

“Not the Conformatorium?” One of the guards asked.

“No,” Belos said. “The palace dungeons will do.”

The guards grabbed onto Adora, hauling her to her feet, dragging her off, her feet skidding along the ground. She felt as if everything she had known, everything she had thought she had learned, felt as if it had been tossed into a pit.

But…

Somehow.

The only question that she could focus on was…

Where is Catra?

Adora Gray and Catra's Very Bad Day

Chapter Summary

> Adora is in prison. Catra is also in prison, but it is a prison of circumstance and fate. Also, prison.

Catra's wonderful, marvelous, perfect plan to thread her way through this fraught situation and end up with everything she ever wanted ran into several snags. The first happened when she heard the sound of fighting and explosions and sprang to her feet – then slammed, directly, into Scorpia, who had come to her door on the heel of the alarm being raised.

"Titan-Ra is-"

"Get out of-"

The two girls slammed into one another and Catra sprawled onto her back. Scorpia, aghast, remained standing where she had stopped, her body as tall and broad as a particularly beautiful brick wall. "Oh, sorry, Ca-"

"Can't you do *anything* right!?" Catra snarled, springing to her feet. Her hair was a wild chaos, and her eyes – rimmed with red from her crying jag – saw little more than a haze as she glowered at Scorpia. "Get out of my way!"

"It's just, the castle is under attack, and-"

"I *know*!" Catra grabbed onto Scorpia's collar, yanking her down, the big girl bending almost in half as Catra almost spat in her face. "And if you weren't such a useless incompetent, than maybe, maybe, we'd have stopped this before it started!" She shoved the stunned Scorpia back against the wall, making her stumble and half fall down it. Then Catra was down the corridor, her heart in her throat, her skin burning with anxiety. Titan-Ra was attacking. She had to...she had to keep Titan-Ra out of the Emperor's clutches, and...get Adora to...she had to…

Argh!

She sprinted not out the front door, but rather, along the interior of the wall, coming to one of the sally ports that had been made for defenders to emerge from the castle and come at any attack sideways. She slipped from the doorway, her breath coming short and swift as she pulled her mask out from her robes, pressing it to her face. She was fairly sure that she could still salvage this.

How? How exactly are you going to fix this? A hissing voice snarled at the back of her head. *Mom always said you were a stupid failure.*

The funny thing? She had a hard time remembering her mom's face. It was always in black and white, just like memories of the camp, and the run through the woods. She couldn't remember hugs, nor kisses, nothing but the stern curve of lips and the glowering expression. She could remember the recriminations, but not...anything else. Not even color. The thought caused her to pause, moments away from the warehouse.

The second snag arrived there.

"Amity?" Catra asked.

***

Amity Blight was not aware, when she was laying in bed, writing down her thoughts into her journal, that she was going to be indirectly responsible for ruining Catra's life. Which was ironic, considering how much of her journaling was actually directly related to the aforementioned angsty lesbian catgirl.

"Amity, dinner soon!" A voice called up the stairs – it was the sound of her father, curt and slightly distracted. It was the tone of voice when mother had told him to tell Amity something and he had forgotten why it was important, but did remember that he had to do it.

A second later, Emira and Emiric leaned in at her door, grinning in like vultures.

"Amity, dinner soon!" Emira said, cheerfully.

"Yeah, Mittens, dinner soon!" Emiric added.

Amity glowered at them. "I was distracted from the dinner bell *one time*."

"Yeah, but why were you distracted, again?" Emira asked, sliding into her younger sister's room. She grinned, impishly, then made to grab for Amity's journal. Amity, knowing her entire face had gone red, grabbed her journal and jammed it against her chest, the pages crumpling.

"Nothing!" She said.

"Eliza Uh Nothing, that was the full name," Emiric said, cheerfully.

"It's that new girl at school, isn't it?" Emira asked, flopping down onto the bed as Emiric sat behind Amity. "The cat demon girl?"

"No! Shut up! Maybe!" Amity stammered, while her older siblings leaned in, both of them looking quite wicked.

"Amity, get down here!"

That was not father's voice. That was mother's voice. Amity pushed her siblings aside and stood, then hurried out of the room. The journal, which she had left behind, landed on Emira's lap and her older sister grinned eagerly, picking it up – before the book burst into purple flames, singing her fingers. Amity leaned back

into the room, glowering at her, pointing her fingers at her eyes, then back to Emira, then to her eyes again. Then she was out again.

"No fun," Emira muttered. "...still, she's crazy in love with her, based on the four words I read."

"Aww!" Emiric said. "Good for mittens."

Amity came down the stairs, and found her mother was rubbing her pendant, her lips turned down into a fierce frown. "Amity Blight, I told you to make sure that those abomatons were purchased and would do their job – so, why, oh why, are my oracular talents telling me that they're all about to be shut down in a fiery explosion?" She frowned down at Amity. "Did you store them properly?"

"Yes!" Amity said. "I…" She paused.

Titan-Ra.

The thought popped into her head immediately.

"No," she said, then.

That also popped out of her mouth before she could stop it. She realized, suddenly, that she had lied to her own mother. But...if her oracular powers had detected the danger, then if she warned Belos...and...Amity gulped, then continued, before her mother could stop her. "No, I just realized what I did wrong! I'll go fix it, don't worry Mom!"

"You'd *better*," Mom said, narrowing her eyes.

Amity rushed for the door, flinging it open and sprinting out into the gathering twilight.

Odalia Blight sighed. "Aladar, you need to design them to be less explosive."

"I did," Amity Blight's father said, emerging from the kitchen, his hands half cleaned from his work in his abomination laboratory. He narrowed his eyes and pursed his lips, then looked at his wife, who looked back at the door, and arched an eyebrow skeptically.

***

Catra stood before the warehouse, blinking at Amity behind her mask. Amity was panting, looking as if she had sprinted here from the center of Bonesburrough.

Amity blinked, then turned and pressed her back to the door leading into the rear of the warehouse. She glared at Catra.

"I won't let you stop Titan-Ra," she said.

Catra scowled behind her mask.

Great.

More complications.

The crashing and banging from within the warehouse got louder and more frantic. There was a series of glittering sparkling flashes, and Catra clenched her hands as she spoke, as calmly as she could. "Listen, Blight. You don't know what's going on here."

"I think I do," Amity said, her voice soft. "Titan-Ra is fighting the Belosian Empire. And, you know what, Golden Guard? I think she's right to do it." She twitched her fingers and some of her abomination goo flowed from a small vial at the base of her hip, clearly getting ready to be used. Catra rolled her shoulders – then felt the same mixture of excitement and annoyed nausea that she felt when she fought Titan-Ra. Which was absurd. Amity was just a tool to her.

"Heh, you want wild witches to run everything?" Catra asked, her voice sneering.

"I think maybe people shouldn't be judged by what kind of magic they use – or don't use," Amity said.

"What the heck does that mean?" Catra snapped.

"You'd never let a witch without a bile sack into the Golden Guards, would you?" Amity snorted, softly. "Coven magic and control is the only thing Belos wants – well...I think the world needs room for people that don't fit *his* idea of what makes the right kind of witch!"

Catra remained perfectly still, feeling as if something had struck her square through the heart.

She's fighting me...for…

Crash.

The sound was unmistakably the sound of a Titan-Ra springing through a building. Catra's ears twitched and she heard the low roaring of fire. Everything seemed to slow down as the first explosion went. Amity jerked her head around, then swept her hand up and, in a flash, a purple orb of glistening abomination goo surrounded her body. Then the entire warehouse went up with a roar and flare of red light. Debris went whipping through

the air and Catra...stood there. She couldn’t do anything but stand there.

Crunch.

She flipped, then crashed backwards.

Her mask went skittering away, rolling and jouncing and coming to a stop, fetched up against a tree.

Amity swept her hand down as the purple orb she had used to soak the explosion thinned, then poured into her bottle. She saw the prone figure of the Golden Guard, stretched out before her. Amity drew a sharp breath, then hurried forward. She knelt down – and...froze.

Laying on her back, her face exposed…was Elizabeth.

Amity sat there, frozen. She wasn’t sure which shocked her more.

Elizabeth, underneath that mask.

Or the jagged chunk of wood that jutted from her cheek.

Elizabeth’s eyes opened and she groaned.

“S-Stay...still…” Amity whispered, horror and shock and fear and disgust warring in her belly. She sat back on her haunches as Elizabeth – as Catra, as the Golden Guard – sat up. Her head lolled a bit to the side...and she reached up, mutedly. She took the chunk in her hand and wrenched it free. The flaps of skin left exposed hung tattered.

And didn’t bleed.

Amity’s eyes widened and she gaped at Catra as Catra put her hand to her cheek.

“What?” Catra asked, her voice shockingly normal, considering the hole in her.

Amity scrambled backwards. The horror and betrayal were crashing in like waves as she saw Catra holding her hand to her cheek. Those bright heterochromatic eyes looked up at hers – and they were the same eyes, they were Elizabeth’s eyes, there was no doubt. Amity shook her head, unable to even speak.

“W-Wait, I can explain!”

“You *lied* to me!” Amity hissed. “You’re not...you’re…”

Her eyes blurred with tears. She stood up, stumbling backwards as flashes of blue lightning seemed to slam into the air around her. It was like the prelude to a painstorm, and she'd have loved to be washed away into nothingness right now.

"I can explain," Catra whispered.

"Fuck you," Amity whispered. "I hope you do die."

She turned and walked – not ran – away, her back held up straight as Catra remained on her knees. Her hand pressed to the dull ache that was her ruined face. And she knew she should have been thinking the obvious questions.

Why am I not bleeding?

Why does this not hurt?

Why am I even alive?

But instead, all she could think of were...were…

I'm not actually Elizabeth. I'm her evil twin.

Elizabeth is a doppelganger.

This is a curse! I look like whoever you most love.

The lies came fast and tangled up on one another – words colliding, sentences snarling up like snakes. Her tongue felt fat and heavy and she couldn't so much as say a word past the lump in her throat before Amity was gone – vanished by the heat and light of the fire. Catra stood and stumbled. She moved a wide berth around the warehouse...and she peered around to see Adora on her knees, her arms chained, her sword shattered and in Belos' hands.

Catra remained standing perfectly still.

Then she slipped back into the shadows.

***

Adora's knees ached as she hung from her chains in the dungeon. She closed her eyes and tried to think of anything – but there's something about despair. It doesn't just make it impossible to plan or act, it makes it impossible to even form *sentences* in your head. Instead, Adora's thoughts were just the same endless jumble, bouncing between topic and topic, never quite forming into anything as coherent as a sentence. She knew she should cry,

but there were no tears in her. She had been wrung out by everything she had learned and seen.

"It's all your fault."

The voice that hissed from the darkness was feminine and unfamiliar.

"I'm sorry...no, I'm not sorry…"

Adora lifted her head. She blinked.

Was there someone else in the cell with her? She couldn't see them – she could only see shadows and chains and darkness. She shifted in her position, her chains clinking loudly as she swung her head around. She had been brought past Belos' throne – where a huge heart had been suspended and connected to with cables and wires and complex pumps. There, she had been brought down to this cell. And now, in the gray darkness, she swore she could hear a voice.

"Don't be! No! She's...she stole your family, just…"

"Hello?" Adora asked.

And before her eyes...some of the shadows *moved*. They flowed along the wall, like a picture given life. The figure was more suggestion than symbol, blocky and gangly all at once. But it was still, unmistakably, a person. There was a head, and some arms, and some legs. The figure was pinned to the wall by its dimensional nature, and yet, there was a feeling that they were pressed up against some barrier, squishing hard to try and peer at Adora. This blocky fingers spread.

"You can hear me?" she whispered.

The sound of footsteps.

The figure shifted, then shrank back, whispering. "I'm not here."

Then she was gone – and a light came from around the corner. Striding into the room, his expression grimly amused, was Emperor Belos. His mask had been removed, revealing a remarkably witchy face, though his ears were tattered rather than pointed, as if some old battle had ravaged him. His features were scarred, chipped here, and lined with dark splotches. He looked down at Adora, then sighed. "Well, well, well," he said. "You are a curious ramification of success."

Adora glared at him. "You killed my whole family."

"No, actually, I didn't," Belos said, his voice annoyingly smug. "I've killed quite a lot of families, and yours didn't exist to be killed,

when I was here." He reached into his robes, then drew out the hilt of the sword...and the rest of the sword. It was whole again. Adora's mouth opened in confusion.

"This blade carries quite a few enchantments," Belos said, dryly. "It's, in fact, tied to the Titan itself. Only someone who has been touched by the magic of the Titan could influence it. Once that influence was exerted, an illusion spell was easy enough to manage." He knelt down, setting the sword so that the tip rested on the ground, his hand cupping the hilt. He leaned against it. "Which means I understand how *she* got in there." He nodded to the wall – to the figure, which had left. At that voice, the figure peeked out again.

"How did she? Who is she?" Adora asked, frowning.

"My old enemy," Belos said, chuckling. "And she's there because I put here there, Adora Grayskull. And I can do far worse to you as well if you don't tell me what I want to know."

Adora gulped.

The figure looked away – the shadow projection making it difficult to see eyelines, but the tilting of her head was clear enough to see. Adora looked back at Belos, lifting her chin. She gripped onto her despair and then threw it aside with a mental effort. She lifted her shoulders, then leaned back against the wall, using her legs to give her arms some rest from her hanging position.

"Ask," she said, flatly.

"How did you *get* here?" Belos asked.

"A magical portal, obviously," Adora said. "The same way that Catra got through here."

"Ahh, Catra," Belos said, grinning. "You knew her, in the other world?"

Adora realized that if Catra had never mentioned her to the Emperor, she had as much as directly told him that they were friends. Her stomach flopped and she looked horrified – but before she could stammer anything more, Belos said. "Don't look so shocked. I knew Catra was from the human realm – and the only other realm that the Grayskulls might have sent their child would be the human realm, ergo."

"Wait, if you didn't kill them…" Adora asked.

"In any timeline where I exist, I take and keep studious notes, where only I know where to find them," Belos said, standing up with a soft grunt, using the sword as a walking stick of sorts. He looked down at her. "So, it was the Owl Lady?"

Adora glared at him.

"It's *always* the Owl Lady, in some fashion," Belos said, clicking his tongue. "Still, while it doesn't explain everything, it's still enough for me to know my next step."

"Y-You're talking like you're not from here," Adora whispered.

"He's not." The shadowy figure slid along the roof. "Aren't you. *Phillip*."

Her voice was a venomous snarl.

"Huh," Belos – or, uh, Phillip – said, lifting his head. "Can you hear her?" He looked at Adora, who nodded mutely. "Interesting. I suppose that it is the proximity to the Titan's Heart. What little blood is still in there weakens barriers between worlds quite marvelously...in truth, I am now an outsider twice over. Time, it seems, is as easily rewritten as all other laws of our Savior by these vile creatures." He sighed. "But, one must use the weapon of the arch-enemy if one is to destroy evil, sometimes."

Adora blinked at him. "T-The Savior? What savior, who are you talking about!?"

"Why our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, of course," Belos said, then turned and started towards the doorway. "Now, I have an Owl House to destroy."

Adora sagged.

The shadow flitted after him – and became inaudible, her scream of fury cutting off sharply the moment she was out of the room. Adora remained there, blinking, and working through what this meant.

He's just another camp councilor, she thought, the realization so horrible that it almost made her want to laugh.

***

Belos was in his throne room when the ragged voice stopped him. He nearly didn't hear it, over the snarling stream of invective Spanish that he was fairly sure Camila Noceda would have used as an excuse to wash her wayward daughter's mouth out with soap. But Camila Noceda, as far as he knew, didn't exist. Neither did Luz Noceda, for that matter – both troublesome wenches had been...dealt with, as far as the Emperor was concerned.

Still, he made a small gesture, a rune flashing on the base of his wrist as he used one of the many spells he had learned in his very, very, very long life – and the shade of Luz's voice cut off as he turned towards the lump of darkness near his throne.

"Yes, Catra?" he asked. "I'm sorry, I didn't-"

“I said…” Catra stepped from the shadows, revealing that she had her hand clasped to her cheek. Between her fingers, he could see she had taken damage.

Belos pursed his lips.

“...what...*am* I?” Catra hissed.

Belos cocked his head, slightly. He was still holding the blade – and then somehow, the voice managed to break through the barrier he had thrown up.

“You...*didn’t*.”

Belos hesitated – while Catra jerked her head up, looking left, right. They were standing near enough to the heart that the shadow of Luz Noceda was able to slide along the floor, moving up to hover along the wall behind Catra. Purple light flared in those shadowed eyes. “You *didn’t*,” she hissed. “Run! Get out of here, cat lady! Go! Run! Now! Now!”

“Ah…” Belos said, walking forward towards Catra. He placed his hand on her good cheek as she look torn between flight and fury.

“What’s happening, E-Emperor?” Catra whispered. “What am I? What is wrong with me?”

Belos smiled. “The answer to those questions is very simple, Catra.”

His fingers drew, using bits of sweat and the pressure of his finger, a circle on her cheek, then a quick rune. Catra started to draw away – but then magic flared and her whole body went limp, collapsing to the ground with a thump. Belos waved his hand, summoning his staff, then using it to lift Catra and float her towards the stairs heading down towards the basement. As she floated down there, Luz’s voice rang off the walls.

“Don’t you dare! Don’t you dare!” Luz snarled, her fists slamming against the barrier between the walls.

“Do you even know what Hunter was *for*, Noceda?” Belos asked, turning to face her. “In that other world? Before I had to lock you away from me?” He smirked. “You stole him away from me before I even got to use him – and in this world, I had to improvise, without even the scraps I recreated him from before. Gravewalkers need more than just magic, you know.”

He frowned, thinking, intently.

“No, no. You did see me in the human realm – though, my memories are somewhat spotty around then. Being do...decayed...hmm…” He shook his head. “Should I? No. No. I will use Catra *after*, I think,” he murmured, to himself. “I may need to...reconstitute myself after dealing with Edalynn.”

Luz screamed. It was a single, fierce scream – that was nearly a sob.

And Belos ignored her as he walked out of the throne room.

***

Adora was not sure if she was even going to try to escape.

Then the reddish light floated Catra into the dungeon, past her cell, and to the far side of the room. By craning her head, she could see the table there, and the straps. And beyond it...what looked like a rectangular plot of earth and dirt. And bones. She could see the pale shape of a bone.

Adora started to strain at her restraints then, her muscles tightening as she clenched her teeth. She could hear, through the castle, the sounds of footsteps – marching en mass. The sound of magic crackling. And her heart sank. Belos' army was mobilizing towards the Owl House. Towards Eda. And King. Towards her *family*.

Adora clenched her teeth, closed her eyes...and then whispered some words.

But she knew they wouldn't work.

“By the Honor of Grayskull…”

Nothing happened. Of course nothing happened. She strained against the chains anyway - they groaned...and then she went slack. She couldn’t break free, not as Adora. Not as weak, useless, stupid Adora! Then, something occurred to her. She opened her eyes and looked at her hand, then grinned with gathering eagerness. She had read a few of the Azura books, and she remembered book fifteen! She shifted on her knees in the cell, then whispered. “By troth, this shalt hurt!” She closed her eyes, clenched her teeth...

Then she smashed her own hand against the wall.

The restraints prevented her from bringing her full force to bear – but her bones were brittle. She could crack them easily! Save that the only thing that happened was that she thumped the wall, and her hand ached slightly. She blinked, then tried smashing harder. Her chains clinked and clattered, but did very little else. Adora gaped at her hand.

“Stupid witch toughness!” She hissed, realization hitting her. She was finally topped off on her vitamin R, just in time for it to trap herself in a dungeon. She groaned. “Azura was able to break her bones at least! Then heal them.”

“...you’ve read the...Good Witch Azura?”

The voice that came from the shadows – this mysterious *Luz Noceda* – whispered near her ear.

Adora jerked her head up. The shadowed figure slipped along the bars, projecting against them.

"Who are you?" Adora whispered.

"...I fought Belos, last time…" The voice was soft and uncertain. "But...but right before I...finished him…"

A flash. A memory of a dream. This time, Adora was looking down at the figure, crawling towards her. The rain was beading along him, and he was melting, his face turning into a horror of black muscle and tissue. "We're human, Luz! Not like these...these filthy witches*!"*

He was reaching up, towards his chest…

"He did something."

...he drew out a disk. A ring of stone. It shone with some kind of power.

"Then I was...trapped here." She whimpered. "I was trapped here so long. I thought...I never...I didn't...h-he said he'd let me out, he promised he'd let me out." The soft sound of her sobbing rang off the walls. "He *promised* he'd let me out."

Adora gulped. "It's okay," she whispered.

The shadowy figure bloomed with a wave of darkness, arms and legs reaching up and down, towards the ceiling and the floor. They surrounded Adora, as Luz screamed. "*It's not okay!* It's not okay! You don't get to *say* that! You stole everything from me! And you let my *sister* in...you don't even know she's *alive*-"

"I don't, I-" Adora stammered. "You have a sister, but...what?"

Luz screamed again, then power crackled along Adora's spine.

"You saw her! In the mirror! You saw her! You saw her! And you *left her there*! You left her there with that *monster*!"

Adora's eyes widened. "T-The vision of me? But that was me, not your sister! A-And what monster? I didn't leave anyone with-

Those shadow hands clawed along Adora's body – and Adora had this horrible, sinking feeling, that if those fingers had been able to touch her, they would have dragged ragged gouges out of her

cheeks, out of her flesh. They would have pulled at lips and eyelids, and yanked at ears. Strangling, desperate hands.

"Vee is a *shapeshifter*!"

And Adora realized who the monster is.

***

Lilith marched with the rest of the Coven Guards, frowning and glancing back. The Emperor stood behind her, his own mask firmly set onto his head, his hands clasped behind his back. "Sir, are you sure you should be here?" she asked. "I can capture my sister without your assistance…"

"I wish to be here when the Owl House is destroyed," the Emperor said, his voice even as he turned his glowing blue gaze upon her.

"D-Destroyed?" Lilith coughed. "Well, uh, we will have an easier time taking my sister alive if we show some circumpsection when it comes to-"

The Emperor lifted one hand, palm flat to her. His voice was quiet. "Do you really want to show her any kind of mercy? Or lenience?

After what her pupil, Adora, did to the Golden Guard?" His voice was soft, wondering.

"I...I'm sure she had no idea her student was so violent," Lilith said, her hands gripping onto her raven tipped staff. Her knuckles lightened as she glanced away – to the head of the column of Coven Guards, who were beginning to push aside the underbrush. A sudden flare of purple light flashed out and, far sooner than expected...Hooty arrived. Lilith felt her entire body convulse with disgust at the sound of his cheerful, horrible voice.

"Surprise! Hoot hoot!"

His tube-shaped body began to flail around wildly, sending guards flying and screaming through the air.

"It seems that there is truly a wild witch studying portal magic," Belos said, sounding impressed at the glowing purple portal that was allowing Hooty to enter into the field and lay about himself. Before he could say anything more, something swift and deadly dropped from the sky. Lilith had only a second to react – she flung herself between her Emperor and whatever it was that was banking towards him. A flash of claws were pulled at the last second as a swirl of feathers and wings ended with a humanoid figure dropping down and skidding to a stop at the far side of the rust red clearing.

"Get out of my way, Lilith!" Eda snarled.

Lilith gaped at her sister. She had seen her transformed into the owl beast, by the curse that inflicted her sister. She had never seen her transformed into *this*. It was as if she was smoothly merged – owl and herself, transfigured into something of elegance and beauty.

"Sister, stand down," Lilith said, standing up as she did so.

"I think not," Eda said, her eyes flashing. "Not until your Emperor gives me back my Adora."

"Your Adora put my Catra in the hospital!" Lilith shot back.

"Really?" Eda asked. She frowned. "And who put your Catra in the field of battle for that bozo anyway? Oh, right, it was *you*."

"Some of us understand *duty* better than-"

The Emperor decided that it was his moment to introduce something more emphatic to the conversation. His staff thrust out and a blazing wave of red heat burst from it. Trees immolated and Eda threw her arms and her wings up, letting the sparks cascade off her form. She fanned them wide and screeched, shooting for the Emperor. Lilith flashed between them again with a flicker of blue lightning – but her sister was faster than she thought possible. Her clawed hand shoved Lilith down by the head – scraping her scalp and mashing her into the mud.

Her free hand slashed.

And Belos' mask shattered. The man stumbled backwards, his cry of pain shocked and clear. Guards rushed forward, but a blast of wind from Eda's wings sent them stumbling backwards. She flipped and landed, then laughed. "I wish I had worked with this curse earlier! I might have to thank whoever did it!"

Belos was down on his knee, his hand going to his face. Glowing, glistening greenish blood was dripping between his fingers. His one good eye blazed with hatred. But then, softly, he let out a *heh*. "Ah. So. It's of the Collector too."

"What are you talking about?" Eda asked.

The Emperor stood as Lilith forced herself to her feet, wiping mud off her features.

Belos stood. "Your curse." He panted. "The entity within – it is connected to the Collector, somehow. How doesn't matter. What matters is that when their power changed the world, it left the curse untouched." He laughed. "Which means that this will work on you."

He reached into his vest and drew out a small ring of shimmering material.

And the entire forest blazed with light as Eda, her claws bared, screamed – and the light swallowed her up.

Leaving not even shadows.

***

"Let me go," Adora said. "And I'll get Vee away from my mom. I'll...I'll put everything back the way it's supposed to be. I'll fix it. Just let me out before the Emperor gets back."

The shadow of Luz Noceda remained still for a long time.

"Promise?" she asked, her voice sullen.

"I promise!" Adora said, frantically.

Luz's eyes narrowed. "I don't...know how long I was stuck in there. I don't know how long I waited to hear something. Anyone. Do you know what it's like, not being able to talk to anyone, to hear anyone, to listen to anyone? A-And then when you do...it's...some *blond* girl whose stealing your *life*? Your mom? Your girlfriend?" Luz surged closer – not by shifting along the walls, but instead by growing, so her shadow-cast features seemed to fill the whole room.

"You were dating Catra?!" Adora asked, shocked.

"*Amity*!" Luz screamed at her, her voice ringing into her ears. Adora flinched, then winced.

"Oh." She bit her lip. "Sorry."

"You promise. You're sorry. But I'm still the one that...augh! Fine! Fine! Fine*finefinefinefine*!" Luz's voice became a venomous hiss, snarling in close and tight. "I'll try. I yanked the sword's enchantment. I can...I can do something. I have to do something. I have to do something. I can do something."

Her shadow-self slipped behind Adora. Adora gulped, then wrenched and strained at the chains. She didn't feel Luz's fingers sliding along her wrists, she didn't *feel* the shadows. But somehow, she could tell that they were there. Luz's voice grew soft, desperate. "C'monnn! C'monnnnn!" She sounded like she was near to tears. "I can almost feel it. I can almost *feel* something. I can feel something!"

Click. Click. Shuffle. Click.

The noise, which Adora thought might have been her chains coming free, echoed from down the stairs. She jerked her head up – and her blood went cold. Belos stumbled into the room, his

hand on his face, blood - *that wasn't blood* – seeping between his fingers. His one good eye flashed as he glared at Luz and Adora.

"It feels some days...as if I am spinning a great many plates and they keep trying to *escape* from me," Belos snarled. His attitudes of confidence and smug arrogance had been obliterated. "Don't worry about your mentor and adoptive mother. She's not a threat anymore." He leaned against the bars, glaring down at Adora. "And don't even try to adjust those chains, Luzura." His voice was pure mockery as he dropped the shifted name.

Adora glared at him. "She was trapped in that other place for...how long?"

"How long does it take for a new world to be made from an old one?" Belos asked, panting softly. He stepped from the bar. "It is a question I don't know if men were meant to know."

"You...you know you're a really *bad* Christian!" Adora shouted after him as he turned away from the bars and started to walk towards Catra. "Christians are about love! And forgiveness! In, uh...uh…" She wracked her brain. "Johns-"

"Don't you dare quote scripture at me!" Belos turned back, grabbing onto the bars with both hands. His face was ruined, utterly ruined, beneath his palm. A snarling skeleton, leering from skin that was practically soughing off his bones. "God is a vengeful god. He works upon the world through his chosen people – his divine agents. As David destroyed the Philistines – he committed grave sins, but he did them for *God*. Because God can

see a plan greater than you can. And through me, he will see this world purified!”

“How long have you been clinging to that?” Adora hissed at him.

“I cling to nothing,” Belos said, regaining some of his composure. “Now. I am to set myself to rights. It...will be difficult making another…” His voice grew soft. “Another…”

He walked away. Out of sight.

Adora clenched her hands, tight. She strained against the chains and watched as Belos strode towards Catra, who remained silent and still. Not breathing. Not alive. Not moving. No. No. She had to be alive, if he was going to use her to restore himself, somehow. As she watched, Belos’ body began to tremble. A peeling noise, like the sound wet plastic makes when it is tugged open inch by inch, filled the room. Luz had drawn back. She was whimpering, her voice drifting in and out of Spanish and English. Something in what Belos had said, something in what he was doing...it had terrified her.

Adora closed her eyes.

“By the Honor of Grayskull,” she whispered.

But she didn’t believe it. Not deep where it counted.

In the throne room, over the dungeon, the Titan's Heart remained suspended.

Belos leaned in. Something *reached* from his chest. It was gray-black. Slimey. Writhing. Fingers of bone protruded from the mass – even as his left arm went limp and rubbery, as if his skin was a jacket that had been half shucked.

Adora opened her eyes.

She saw the clawed *thing* reaching towards Catra.

"By the Honor…" she said, her voice gathering in strength.

The Titan's Heart...*beat*. Once.

"...of *Grayskull*!"

TO BE CONTINUED

Adora Gray meets Luz Noceda

Chapter Summary

> Adora loses her cool and kind of sort of accidentally ends the world a little bit. Catra gets a new perspective on life!

Edalynn Clawthorne woke up in chains, hanging from her ankles, in the belly of the Conformatorium. Around the momentary thought of 'ah, must be Tuesday', a hazy recollection of everything that had happened to her today came back…

And with it came the strangest lurch in her chest.

She blinked and squirmed a bit in the chains restraining her. Her brow furrowed, while she looked around the chamber she was restrained in. There were two coven guards standing by the bars, both holding staves that they had crossed over the bars, as if she was going to burst through at any second. She noticed, also, that each of the corners of the chamber had snarling gargoyles carved in them, holding enchanted orbs in their mouths that looked ready to unleash one heck of a curse at her, should she try any funny business.

Despite this, she couldn't stop the huge smile spreading across her features.

"What a wonderful way to wake up," she said, sighing cheerfully as she stretched in her chains. "Hey you two, sleep well?"

“I dunno, my bunk bed was kinda unco-”

“Steve!”

The other guard cut the first one off.

“What? She asked?” Steve shrugged.

“You can’t just talk to her, she’s the Owl Lady,” the non-Steve said.

“Well, she’s not casting any spells, so, like…” Steve shrugged. “You’re not casting any spells, right, Owl Lady?”

“Not even one, Steve,” Eda said, cheerfully. “But I could, if I wanted too.”

The two coven guards exchanged a nervous glance at one another.

“You see! Your Emperor seems to have yanked my curse right outta me,” Eda said, nodding. “Makes sense, it was giving me my cool...*harpy powers*.” She waggled her eyebrows in time with the words. “It was a hot look. But it did kind of mess with my magic a little – and that’s gone. Which means the moment I figure out how to circumvent those petrification orbs, I’m going to bust right outta here.”

“Fat chance,” the non-Steve said.

“Uh, are you gonna beat us up if you do?” Steve asked.

“Not you, Steve, you seem cool,” Eda said, nodding at him. “You though?” She glowered at not-Steve.

“Hey, I’m cool!” Not-Steve said.

“Name a cool thing you’ve done,” Eda said.

“Uh…” Not-Steve paused. “I once disobeyed the Golden Guard, she ordered me to pick up a locker room and instead, I had Steve do it.”

“That wasn’t cool, man,” Steve said, his voice still holding a hint of bitterness.

“That’s just delegating!” Eda said. “I hate delegating. It’s almost as bad as organizing. Or worse? Hierarchies.” She shuddered. “Ugh.”

"Well, hey, hierarchies can be useful, organizationally speaking," Steve said, leaning on his staff. "What if you need to make decisions rapidly in a crisis circumstances and have no time for democratic processes to guide you out of them? Having an emergency leader in that situation is just common sense."

"You're *really* losing the cool points, Steve," Eda said, sighing. "What you do in a crisis is just whatever and it all works out."

"That's not workable!" Steve said, sounding frustrated.

"It's worked out well for me so far," Eda said.

On cue, the orbs all hummed, whirred, then went dead, the magical light within them dying as if someone had severed the connections from gargoyle to whatever power source was shunting magic into them.

"Case in point!" Eda said, then snapped her fingers. Her chains fell off her and she dropped, flipped, and landed, both palms glittering with golden light. She swept one hand up and the stone floor underneath Steve turned into a pair of winding snakes with the head of a certain horrifying owl tube. They swept around his body as her other hand dropped down and the ceiling tiles dropped straight down and transformed into a metal cage that closed tight around the other guard. Their staves went clattering to the ground and Eda picked both up in her hands, her grin wild and feral. The immediate impulse to run out and start blasting was overpowering – but she was stopped.

Not by common sense, long term planning, worries about Adora, or anything else absurd like that.

No, she was stopped because a hand grasped her arm and yanked her back. Eda yelped, cartwheeling her arms and bonking a robed figure on the head – said robed figure having emerged from a secret door that had opened silently in the corner of the cell.

"Ow!" The figure groaned, rubbing their head.

Eda froze. She dropped the staves, then turned...and grabbed onto the hood of the figure, tossing it back.

"...Raine!?"

The green haired, brown skinned witchling rubbed their head, wincing at the bulge growing on their brow. Despite having not seen them for years, their features had been burned into Eda's memories. You didn't easily forget someone like Raine Whispers – doubly so when the last time you had talked…

Eda pushed her guilt back down, while Raine smiled, sheepishly at her.

"Edalynn," they said, softly. "We need to get going before anyone notices you're gone and the orbs have been cut."

“I-” Eda stopped herself, then smiled, slightly. She had questions – millions of them, actually. When she had last talked to Raine, they had been ready to join the Bard Coven and give up wild magic forever. They had the small symbol of the Bard Coven’s membership on their wrist – visible as the robes slipped back with a gesture of their hand. But despite serving Belos, it seemed that there were boundaries that even Raine couldn’t see crossed. Eda allowed herself to be drawn into the secret passage, which shut with a grinding creak behind her.

“It’s good to see you again,” Eda whispered in the darkness.

“Thanks,” Raine said, then chuckled a bit dryly. “Not that you can exactly *see* me in here. Heh.”

The two went deeper into the darkness of the Conformatorium – but soon, Eda could feel that they were heading down, and under something vast and rushing. A river was flowing overhead. She threw the mental map of Bonesburrough up in her mind, and whispered. “We’re heading for the castle?”

“Yeah,” Raine said. “I...I meant to tell you, Eda. I’ve been working against Belos all this time.”

“I knew it!” Eda laughed and then bonked her head directly into a pipe. She heard a soft hiss from Raine.

“Sorry, forgot, there’s a-”

“A pipe there, I know.”

There was a short pause.

“I forgot how much more it hurts to run your head into things when your head doesn’t just fall off.”

Raine chuckled.

Then.

“Wait, what?”

***

Catra came to wakefulness – just in time to be plunged into a nightmare. Belos was leaning over her, but his face was a horror. Glistening and dripping, skull-like, leering. He leaned over her and his voice was soft. “You’ve served your purpose.”

Catra was twelve again. She was running through the forest, terrified of every shadow, cold and whimpering. She squirmed against the chains, but her wrists were trapped – and then Belos' fingers pressed to her ribs – and slid into her skin. They grew and lengthened like tongues, like vines, plunging under her skin and straining against her as if she was made of paper. She gasped and felt something deep inside of her creak, then strain, then break as she couldn't even bring the air in to scream. She clenched her teeth, her back arching as blackness flooded her vision.

The Belos-horror was becoming a distant figure, at the end of a tunnel.

And there was a light, a glorious, heavenly light.

It was funny, Catra always assumed that Heaven was bullshit – and that if it was real, it would be whites and blues and golds.

Not purple and red.

Her vision snapped to normal with a wet *squelching* noise. Black muck splattered her face and some of what had been stolen slipped back into her, surging like water in her body. She collapsed back onto the stone slab, gasping for air, as she felt black ichor and bits of gore drip down her face, off her shoulders, dangling from her ear. She blinked several times.

Belos, his face shocked, his jaw hanging open, gaped down at the hand that had punched through his rotting chest and now held a glistening black lump that might have been his heart. The hand was black fingered and had claws tipped with white bone. Standing behind him, her eyes a furnace of blazing gold on black sclera, was Adora.

It was strange seeing Adora like this – transformed, as she had been before, but...different. She didn't have the hat or the cape, instead, she wore something that was like her favorite jacket, done in strident purple and dark black, with gleaming onyx buttons. It was as if she had taken the Titan-Ra form and made it her own glorious self.

She held Belos' heart between her fingers, her arm emerging from his chest like a jack in the box.

"Let. Her. Go." She snarled.

Belos' fingers withdrew from Catra's arms and she felt the pain of their emergence. Scars puckered her skin now – reddish marks from where he had plunged into her. He lifted his hands – and Adora withdrew her arm and released his heart in his chest, where flesh flowed and knitted again.

Catra groaned. "Adora…" she whispered.

"It's okay, I'm here, Catra!" she said, grabbing onto one of the chains, snapping the links with a yank. Catra managed to get the

words out, despite the fatigue and the aches.

"You...dummy!"

Adora blinked at her, looking so adorably innocent and kissable.

Then Belos grabbed onto her by her jacket's hem and threw her through two of the prison cells. The bars bent and exploded out of their moorings, stone powderedized, and the ceiling collapsed in one of them with a roar. Catra, her one hand free, tried to get herself up, but her other arm was still restrained, as were her legs. She groaned and laid back, her head throbbing. Through slitted eyes, she saw that whatever Belos had taken from her was still enough to keep him standing, even if he was still far from...what was he?

Adora emerged from the rubble, with a split lip and a fiery look in her eyes. She spat to the side. "Why don't you tell her what you really are? What did Luz call you? *Philip*?"

"Philip?" Catra croaked.

Belos chuckled. His voice sounded melodious, despite his body being a dripping, blue eyed horror. "She's lying," he said. "Catra, I was trying to heal you-"

“He was trying to use you as spare parts!” Adora said. “Catra! Look!”

She pointed and Catra tore her eyes from the ruined dungeon to where she was chained. Huh. There was, in fact, a plot of dirt and mud, surrounded by alchemical equipment – stuff she half recognized from her studies. And jutting from the back was...bones. Human bones. Her throat worked, slowly. A lot of human bones.

“What...is this?” Catra whispered.

“Gravewalker.”

The voice hissed from the wall – and Catra snapped her head around. A face, cast like a shadow, two dimensional and blocky, peered at her. Catra hated the desperate look in those flat eyes. They reminded her too much of looking into her mirror.

But the word made Catra’s stomach flip over. She looked down at her wrist, then shook her head. “I-I’m not a Gravewalker. Those are...are constructs made by turning corpses into puppets – you make them think they’re a person by copying someone else’s brain, but they don’t have *blood*!” She said, fiercely. “They don’t have a bile sack or…” She hesitated, her hand going to her chest. “I…” In hazy memory, she could see herself looking down at her own slashed finger, in the library. There had been no blood.

The librarian had been attacked.

She had bled.

His blood.

She wasn't a Gravewalker.

You've been cut before, remember what Belos used to do?

She wasn't a Gravewalker.

He'd tell you to talk to him and then…

She wasn't a Gravewalker.

None of your memories are in color. Not after you woke up here.

Belos sighed. "Very well," he said, sounding annoyed. "Yes. You are a Gravewalker, Catra. But that's no shame. You were to do a great service for your Emperor, who has given you...so much." His face sloughed slightly, as Adora growled. "I made you a Golden Guard. I gave you a home. A cause!"

“What did you *do* to my friend?” Adora stepped forward.

“Don’t you *get* it!?” Belos asked, turning to face Adora. “Catra is not your friend. She never was!”

He lashed the air with his arm.

“Kathleen Weaver *died six* years ago.” He laughed. “I found her! Cold as the grave. Dead of exposure and chill – and I made her into *Catra*. And look at what she’s done in this world, what she has done without you!” He pointed his finger at Adora.

Catra’s face felt cold.

“I…” She whispered.

Belos turned back to her. “Adora wants you to be chained to the past. She wants you to give up everything that you are – and what? To be that dead girl? That pathetic weakling? That abused child who ran off to die?” He stepped towards her. “Do you want to be that? To do that?”

“Catra…” Adora whispered.

Catra's claw scraped along the earth, subtly. She ducked her head forward.

None of your memories are in color.

She finished the circle.

You're…

Ice exploded up and slashed open her cuffs – and she leaped from the bedside, skidded...and then stepped between Belos and Adora. She snatched a chunk of ice, then swept her hand along it, and the rune transformed it into her sword.

"Get away from my Emperor," she snarled.

"Catra…" Adora whispered.

Belos fell to one knee. He clutches his chest – and Catra looked from him to Adora. His voice was weak. "Protect me, Catra...my Golden Guard," Belos wheezed, and Catra growled and then started to walk forward. She moved a bit wobbily, but with more and more strength, every second. Adora's heart hammered and her brain whirled. She jerked her head back, evading the ice blade as Catra swung it at her head, the humming blade slicing into the wall to her left.

“Catra!” Adora said. “Please! You’re not just his creation-”

“No, I’m better than that!” Catra said, gritting her teeth. “I learned magic!” She swung her sword. “I became the Golden Guard – I did all of that!” she swung her sword again – and Adora, in desperation, held up her hand...and a blade of purple steel flashed into existance in her palm. It was longer, thinner, less ornate than the blade she had born as Titan-Ra. Sparks of magic exploded as the two swords struck against one another.

“He was trying to use you to save himself!” Adora snarled, locking blades with Catra.

“You’re *lying*!” Catra shoved back. “You and your Owl Lady want to destroy everything he built – and for what? For some stupid freedom? You know what *freedom* is!?” she shoved hard enough that Adora stumbled. “It’s the chance for a little girl to go and die in a Connecticut winter storm!” She brought her sword flashing down and Adora lifted, blocked, then twisted aside and caught Catra in the stomach. She lifted her up, then slammed her down – but Catra writhed free at the last second. She rolled away, fetched up against some rubble, and stood.

Catra felt as if she should have been nearly fainting. Instead, rage kept her on her feet. It thrummed through her bones – rage at Adora, for trying to take her life. Rage at Kat, for burdening her with the memories of a weak, pathetic child. Rage at Belos, for not doing a good enough job in building her. Rage at the Boiling Isles for endlessly throwing complications at her, when she had a life she wanted to live.

Well.

She could *fix* some of that complications.

“He’s not actually a witch!” Adora said, her blade intersecting with Catra’s. “He’s a human-”

“Shut up!”

Sparks flew as Catra brought her sword down in an overhanded chop.

“He’s-”

Their swords met again, another chop. This time, Catra’s ice sword exploded with a spray of blue chips. Rather than give her a chance, she dove forward, darting between Adora’s thighs. She slashed with her claws, wildly, drawing flashes of bright red blood. She dug her claws into Adora’s shoulder blades.

“Auugh!”

“Hold her there!” Belos said.

He reached into his own chest cavity, and drew out a circlet. It glowed. It thrummed. It pulsed with energy.

Catra dug her claws in.

Adora lifted her hand up, smashing her forearm into Catra's nose. Catra clung on, grunting as she felt something crunch in her face.

But Adora wasn't trying to knock her off.

She hurled her sword at Belos like a lightning bolt. He lifted the circlet – and the sword hesitated not a moment, sweeping through the circlet, through his chest, and into the wall. He splattered against it, pinned there by the cross guard fetching up against his moldering ribs. The two halves of the circlet fell aside and he remained there, gaping in shock at the sword that was buried in his chest. His jaw dropped slowly down, unhinging, then clattering to the floor as the blue light in his eyes dimmed. Then flickered.

Then went out.

Catra and Adora stood there, panting.

"E-Emperor?" Catra whispered.

The ruin that had been Emperor Belos slumped, then splattered onto the ground.

There was nothing there but mold and worms.

Even the sword glittered, clean and pure – every bit of him had simply sloughed off of it, like water beading along wax paper.

Catra released Adora's shoulders, dropped to the ground, then ran to the pile.

"Y-You killed him!" she whispered, looking up at Adora.

"H-He…" Adora whispered, her body shimmering, then flashing. She was replaced with her normal human self, falling to her knees, blood dripping down her back, soaking into her white shirt. "I didn't have a choice."

Catra growled and sprang to her feet as the two halves of the circlet hit the ground. One rolled half over, then clacked over, while the other simply rang as it bounced several times, before coming to a stop at the shoes of a normal teenage girl, who had simply materialized near the wall without anyone noticing. She was thin and short, with close cropped brown hair, brown eyes, and a thin notched scar over one eyebrow. She was dressed in a blue and white T-shirt, with shorts over the long, stretchy winter

leggings worn by people in colder states. She had slip on white shoes.

She blinked a few times, patting her chest, then patting her hair. She looked at her hand, then wiggled her fingers.

Catra and Adora both slowly looked from one another to her.

The girl spread her hands.

And the entire wall she stood beside trembled, then began to split apart. Purple fire crackled between the bricks and she yelped as a similar flame flared around her fingers. “Hah!” She said.

“...Luz Noceda?” Adora asked, hesitantly, feeling a droplet of blood creep down her back.

The wall crunched back into place – for a moment, Adora swore she could see the space between the bricks. Not earth and dirt and other chambers, but something deeper and darker. Luz clenched her hand, then spread her fingers again – and the wall began to spread apart. Her eyes gleamed and she beamed.

“Hah...haha...ahahahah!” Luz laughed.

It was not a comforting laugh.

Catra stood up, slowly. “Who the heck are-”

“You!” Luz glared at Catra, then pointed her finger at her. A bolt of purple, multicolored light shot from her finger and slammed into Catra. She was smashed back against the wall in a poof of smoke. Adora cried out, leaped forward and caught a big brown tabby that landed in her arms. Her eyes were blue and gold, and blinked in shock as she looked around wildly. Adora gaped, then sprang to her feet, holding...the...cat...the cat that was Catra from her arms.

“What did you do!?” She spun to face Luz, who was looking quite pleased with herself.

“She *stole* my girlfriend!” Luz said, furiously. “I...I was stuck in there so *long…”* She put her hands onto her head, clenching her teeth, her eyes half closed. The walls shimmered and shadows began to crawl along it – flowing like snakes. “Shut up shut up shut up! I’m not there anymore!” She closed her eyes, tightly. “I’m free, I’m free!”

The shadows drew in closer and Adora could hear the whispering – and a lurch hit her.

What happens if someone can do anything with a thought...and their thoughts are about that*?*

“SHUT UP!” Luz screamed and then made a shoving gesture. The shadows burned away in purple flames and the entire room started to tremble and come to pieces around them. Bricks flew apart and twirled around as Luz clutched at her head again, stumbling. “I’m free! And...and I’m gonna fix it! I can fix anything! I can do anything!”

Catra meowed and kicked her lower legs.

Adora didn’t speak Cat.

She didn’t have to speak Cat to know what *we need to leave, now* meant.

Adora bundled Catra against her chest and sprinted for the stairs. The floor rocked and quaked, trembling and throwing her left and right as she heard Luz’s powers behind her – it was like the whole world was buzzing with a hissing static. She came up into the throne room, to find that the coven guards were looking around wildly. There was Kikimora, and there was Scorpia and Entrapta. “Where’s Catra!?” Scorpia asked, grabbing onto Adora’s arm.

“I...right here?” Adora asked. “We have to get out of here, right now!”

“What!? Cat!? Ra!?” Scorpia spluttered.

Entrapta, meanwhile, was holding up a small doohicky in her long, flexible hair. “According to my readings, a highly powered dimensional entity capable of rewriting the fabric of reality is right under the basement! Wow!” She laughed. “This is almost *exactly* the kind of energy you’d expect to see from the Collectors. But they’re just legends! That’s amazing!”

“What’s a Collector?” Scorpia asked.

“We-” Adora started, but Entrapta barreled over her.

“Mythological godlike beings that once visited our world from beyond the veil of time and space, primarily interested in cataloging and storing various ephemera – strange demons, different kinds of magic, historical artifacts, beastly spirits..” She nodded. “Worshiped as the Huntsman by some fringe cultists, they also-”

The entire floor exploded upwards. Purple fire roared up in a column of brilliant heat, scorching the ceiling and turning the fluttering Belosian flags into so many bits of ash. Adora scrambled backwards, while Scorpia sprang back and Entrapta remained perfectly still, holding her device up.

“Faaaaaaascinating!”

The flames swept away and Luz Noceda remained hovering there. Fires streamed from her eyes like inverted tears, sweeping up and

away, while her hands glowed between the cracks – knuckle joints, fingernails, palms. She was sobbing as she put her hands over her face. "I can fix it! I can...fix it I can fix it-"

"Run! Now!" Adora shouted.

Scorpia snatched up Kikimora and Entrapta and turned and sprinted for the door. Adora rushed right after her as the flames grew and the world shuddered and quaked more. The castle started to collapse, bricks and towers alike crumbling to pieces. The skies, Adora, saw, were turning a strange pattern. It looked like a checkerboard of purple and black – but the pattern was all...wrong. It was beginning to slip, square into square, creating a dizzying, nauseating intersection of lines and colors. Bonesburrough was shaking as well – and witches and demons alike were running for cover, screaming and waving their arms in fright.

Lilith Clawthorne dropped from the sky, landing on the ground before Adora, Scorpia, Entrapta and Kikimora. She put her hand to her chest, her expression grim as she looked at the growing pillar of fire.

"Is this...please tell me this isn't Eda's fault," she said.

"It's not!" Adora gasped. "It's mine. I-"

"Lilith!"

Everyone jolted as Luz shot from the fires. She skidded to a stop before Lilith, hovering before her. She had left a trail of fire along the ground – but rather than leaving behind ashes, wild flowers were blooming around the narrow line of flame. The flowers were wilting and their petals rolled off, turning into spiders. The spiders, themselves, blew out strands for parachuting and were carried away by the wind...and as they drifted away, they turned into glittering orbs of light. It was pure chaos, uncontrolled and beautiful and terrifying, all at once.

Luz made a nervous finger guns at Lilith, her smile shaky as flaming tears continued to stream from her features. "Heyyy Lilith! Auntie! Lilith! Cool Aunt! Cool! Hey! I'm back! I was gone, but-"

"I...who...are you, strange human child?" Lilith asked, her brow furrowing slightly as she took a step back.

Luz's face was so pained that Adora's heart ached. She held Catra tight to her chest as Luz whispered.

"Y-You...you know me...uh...I'm Luz! Luz Noceda! D-Daughter of...of Camilia Noceda! Your sister...w...we...we...we…" She was breathing fast. Shallow. "You know me! You know me!" She grabbed onto Lilith's arms. Lilith hissed, clenching her teeth.

"Y-You're hurting me, let me go!" she exclaimed.

"Please, just-"

Lilith pushed her away and Luz's head hung forward. She put her hands over her face, then breathed in. "I can fix this! I can fix this I can-" she whispered.

"Luz, wait, don't-" Adora started.

Luz pointed at Lilith – and Lilith screamed. There was a crackling flash – and when the light faded, Lilith looked like she had been transformed from flesh to wood, glossy and polished, her features painted on, her joints the ball and socket of a mannequin. Except...even that would have been preferable.

Mannequins were *intact*. She had landed in a jumble of limbs, and strings were attached to each, but the strings were tangled.

Luz grabbed her hair, her eyes closed. "No! No! I can do it! I can fix it!" She pointed and the crackling light flared – and Lilith appeared again, her pieces jammed together, limbs socketed together all...wrong. An arm was backwards, a leg was in the shoulder, her palm planted to the ground, her head lolled at a forty five degree angle. But her voice was chipper.

"Luz! It's so good to see you I missed you so much," she said, but the cadence came out as all one long patter. She patted Luz's shoulder with a foot, and Adora, Scorpia and Entrapta started to back away, while Kikimora, in what might have been the wisest thing she had ever done, simply sprinted away at top speed.

Luz whimpered, then beamed and leaned into the mannequin she had crafted. “There. Fixed. Fixed. I’m gonna fix it all.” She whispered, her eyes closed.

“Adora!”

Adora spun and saw that Glimmer and Bow were rushing to the scene – drawn by the chaos. Eda was with them, and a robed figure, who she didn’t recognize. She didn’t have time to recognize anyone, because Luz shot away from Lilith to fly straight at Eda.

“Edaaaa!” She threw her arms around Eda, squeezing her tightly. “Eda, Eda, Eda, Eda!” She rubbed her face against her shoulder, her eyes closing as her flaming tears left tracks of blackish char along Eda’s skin. Eda, her arms flailing, blinked and looked confused. But before she could, Luz drew back. “Wait, we need King! King! Little King! King and his crown, he’s so *cute*, always cute, cute, cute, cute!” She clapped her hands twice and with a purple roar of fire, a portal opened and King yelped, falling through it with a shocked ‘weh!’ Before he could do anything, Luz snatched him up and hugged him to her chest.

“Never ever letting you go ever!” she whispered.

“Unhand me! What is going on! Adora! Save me!” King said.

"*No*!" Luz screamed. "No! No! No! You're *mine*! You're my family! Mine!"

She waved her hand and the ground crackled and split, crunching and opening up a rift that tumbled rocks, boulders and bits of trapped plumbing into a infinitely deep chasm that dropped into the same checkerboard insanity as the sky. The crack had Adora, Scorpia and Entrapta on one side, Eda, King, the robed figure, and Bow and Glimmer on the other. Adora flailed one arm, while Catra clung to her arm and yowled.

"Who is this!?" Eda shouted.

Adora gulped, then…

"She's your daughter!" she said. "But Belos...erased her! Trapped her in some other world, somehow!"

"I don't-" Eda started, but Luz glared at Adora, her eyes glowing purple. Adora felt a pain stab into her brain, aching and hurting and screaming through her nerves.

"You took my *place*," she hissed.

"I let you out!" Adora exclaimed. "Please! Luz, you need to calm down! You're hurting everyone."

“No! I’m going to fix it!” Luz whispered. “Fix everything.”

The pain intensified.

Then Luz’s eyes widened.

“What?” she whispered.

The pain was gone.

Eda reacted quickly. She shouted. “Now! Sparkles! Get them out of here!”

“Right!” Glimmer sprang forward. She vanished, slammed into Adora, grabbed her, then vanished again. Adora, Catra, and Entrapta appeared on the other side, while Glimmer put her palms together, focused and the entire world lurched around them. Eda was included in the circle, as was her companion. Adora saw the only one who was out of reach was King, who was wriggling. She reached for him, a desperate lunge.

“Noooo!” Luz screamed.

Eda was yanked back with a yelp as Bow grabbed onto Adora's collar, yanking her back.

They vanished.

Appeared before the Owl House. Glimmer turned, then punched hard down at the ground – her fist slamming directly into Hooty's brow. Hooty, who had emerged from the ground and was seconds away from swallowing them whole, fell backwards with a grunt. "Ow! Jeeze!"

"Guys!"

Bow's shout drew everyone's looks.

The whole Boiling Isles was changing. The trees were trembling and being ripped up and out of their roots. Leaves were changing colors and chunks of the earth itself were lifting up and tumbling out of place. People screamed as glowing lassos swept down, grabbing onto them and yanking them to the sky. Echoing it over all was Luz's voice, ringing out loud as the end of the world. "I can fix it, please, please stop screaming, I can fix it! I can...just please stop screaming! Stop! Stop! Stop it!"

"We have to leave!" Adora said.

"How?!" Glimmer asked. "The whole *world* is going!"

“Eda’s door!” Adora exclaimed.

They all turned and rushed into the Owl House. They found the door, nestled in the corner of Eda’s room, tucked where she had always left it. Adora grabbed it – and felt claws jabbing into her cheek and neck. Catra didn’t try and cause damage – just pain. But she didn’t need to do much for Adora to realize it. “Amity! Get Amity!” she shouted to Glimmer. Glimmer nodded. Vanished.

The door unfolded.

Glimmer appeared with Amity, who was looking stunned, dazed, her hair having transformed to a bright bubble gum blue. She put her hands on her head. “Adora? Why did a strange human girl turn my hair blue?”

“Door! Now!” Adora shouted.

The door opened.

The Owl House exploded around them. Wood flew in splinters and Hooty let out a cheerful holler.

“At last! I am free from my servitude! Hoot hoot!”

He was whipped up into the tornado of purple fire as Luz Noceda hovered over the group of them. Her body was streaming with purple fire, the cracks in her skin having grown. Her eyes blazed with the light of creation itself and her voice reverberated across the whole of the Isles. "**Are you trying to take my *batata*?"**

"Door!" Adora shoved. The entire group burst through the door as Luz's hand reached towards them – growing larger and larger, as if perspective was shifting and twisting like taffy.

Adora slammed the door shut.

A Collector could do, essentially, anything they wished. They were beings above and beyond magic – meta-creatures that slipped between realities like a bookmark shifted between pages. If a human or a witch was a sentence, they were a typewriter. A word processor. But imagine, if you will, what would happen if a sentence tried to write an entire novel. Given time, a sentence can become a book.

But not all at once.

Instead, it would become a cancerous thing – an endless sprawl, without rhyme or reason.

Luz Noceda, with all five minutes of her experience of being a Collector, tried to blow a hole between universes.

The gateway door, fortunately, was built to channel and use the blood of the Titan itself – a creature of immense magical power. That included safety systems, in case of catastrophic failure. It was, in fact, why they were called fail safes: They *failed* in a way that was *safe*.

The only problem was at that level of power, it was more...fail safe*ish*.

The door exploded in Adora's face. Splinters and ash slapped her backwards and she smashed into a tree, then sprawled to the ground. She groaned and thanked God that she had gotten her healthy heaping of vitamin R and Evil before this. If she had been her old brittle self, she would have definitely, one hundred percent died. Instead, she merely coughed, gasped, then started to stand up. She brushed some wood flakes from her head and turned.

Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, Entrapta, Amity, and Catra all looked at her. Then they looked around themselves.

They were standing in a bright, cheerfully green set of woods that was situated outside of Gravesfield, Connecticut.

"Where...are we?" Bow asked, slowly, rubbing at his face.

“We’re in the human realm,” Amity whispered.

Catra meowed angrily, wriggling her paws.

“Can someone please tell me what happened?” Scorpia asked. “Who was that human girl? How did she get her spooky powers?”

“I don’t...know every detail,” Adora said. “But, uh...I think I know at least some of it.” She bit her lip, then sat down on a stump. “Emperor Belos had *something*. It was a device, made by the Collectors, I think. That’s what you called them, right Entrapta?” She asked, and Entrapta nodded, cheerfully – taking all of this in serious stride. “He used it to reverse a defeat – a defeat so total that he thought he was going to die. A defeat brought about *by* that girl, Luz Noceda. He...unmade her. Wrote her out of the story. Crammed her into some *place* between the worlds, where she was trapped for...for a long time.”

Amity shivered at that, gulping as she did so.

“But when I...um…” Adora rubbed the back of her neck. Catra let out a quiet growl. “...when I killed the Emperor?”

“You *what*!?” Scorpia exclaimed, springing to her feet.

“Nice!” Glimmer said.

“He was evil, Scorpia,” Bow said, matter of factly

“It doesn’t matter right now!” Adora said, glaring at the three of them. “What matters is I *broke* the thing he used – and Luz Noceda was let free! But somehow, she got the same powers as a Collector-”

“Long term exposure to dimensional energies while contained in the space between spaces,” Entrapta said. “It’s the only logical possibility!”

“Well, she has those powers, and she’s trying to fix everything,” Adora said.

“...and...she turned Catra into a...cat?” Scorpia asked.

“Y-Yeah,” Adora said, while Catra paced in circles, growling loudly, clearly beyond frustrated.

“What do we do now?” Amity asked, her voice grave as she drew her knees up against her chest, her eyes confused. She put her hand on her blue hair, shaking her head slowly.

“Well, we...we have to find some place to stay,” Adora said. “Then some way to get back. Then some way to stop her.” She nodded, firmly.

“Do you know how to do any of that?” Entrapta asked – and the lack of judgment in her voice made it hurt way worse. Adora squirmed.

“Well-”

“Adora?”

Adora snapped her head up.

A plump, short, cheerful looking woman with dark hair, dark eyes, and a familiar face was walking towards the group, wearing a backpack and hiking clothes. Her brow was furrowed with confusion as she opened her mouth, looking slowly over the crowd. “How did you get ahead of-” she stopped, then turned back...and looked at Adora. Who was standing behind her. In a red jacket, with a backpack, and hiking boots. She looked back forward, at Adora and the rest of the Boiling Isles refugees.

Adora blinked at her.

“...you’re not...Mrs. Noceda, by any chance?” she asked.

Camila Noceda, the one time mother of Luz Noceda, blinked slowly.

And what she said next shocked everyone.

"Why are you in *She-Ra* cosplay?"

Luz Noceda and the Evil Horde

Chapter Summary

> Adora Gray stops being the main character (for now.) Luz Noceda meets new friends and they're all evil and hot.

Camila Noceda, the one time mother of Luz Noceda, blinked slowly.

And what she said next shocked everyone.

"Why are you in *She-Ra* cosplay?"

Adora Grayskull, of the House Grayskull from the Boiling Isles, who had been raised as a human being for most of her life, opened her mouth and said: "Uhhhhhhhhhhh-"

***

ONE ETERNITY AGO

ONE DIMENSION TO THE LEFT

***

Luz Noceda screamed as she tumbled backwards and fell through the crackling wall between universes. Her Titan-gifted body fell away from her with a crumbling sensation as she felt her connection to that vast, timeless power grow drawn, taut, then snap. Her hands flailed wildly and she grabbed onto the edge of the portal, craning her head up and over it, even as her arms screamed at her with the pressure pulling her up. Up. Up.

Through it, she could see the melting Belos, the strange object that he had held, inverted by the force pulling her upwards.

He looked triumphant.

"You *pu*-"

Luz's fingers lost traction and she fell upwards into the World-Between-Worlds, screaming out Spanish that her mother had most definitely *not* taught her.

When she had last been in this place, she had been sinking downwards. Because the last time she had been here, Luz was fairly sure she had been *dying*. No, not even that. She had been dead. And she had fallen down, into the vast bubbling blackness that sat at the bottom of the World-Between-Worlds. She could remember the chilling coldness sweeping through her soul as the light had faded, bit by bit...she had only been saved at the last moment by the Titan himself, pulled up and away from the infinite oblivion that had waited for her.

This time, she fell *upwards,* traveling in the same direction as the motes that flitted through this world towards their unknowable destination.

Well.

Luz learned what the destination was as she screamed upwards.

She was falling towards a ceiling of glowing white light. It was as vast as the dark ocean below, and it blazed with a shimmering heat. She fell into it, tumbling – and felt her body crackling and buzzing as energies swept along her. She yelped and flailed her arms, then snatched onto something with the tips of her fingers. She looked around wildly, and for a moment, Luz saw something that her cool aunt, Lilith Clawthorne, would have given her eye-teeth and her bile-sack to see.

She saw the bubbling furnace of raw energy that pulsed at the heart of all things.

She saw the vast waves of coruscating energies, buzzing outwards and sweeping through a hazy connection of shimmering lines – like spiderwebs made of raw lightning.

And she saw the way everything connected together, all at once.

And the only reason she was still around to remember seeing this and was not boiled apart into a haze of quarks and potentiality was because her hands had caught on the edge of the space between the World-Between-Worlds and this vast furnace of reality. Luz clenched her teeth – and thought of Amity, and Stringbean, and Hunter, and Willow, and Guz, and her mom, and King and Eda, and every last weirdo on the Boiling Isles, and magic, and learning about runes, and kissing Amity. With this raw, burning heat in her arms, she pulled herself up, inch by inch, back into the World-Between-Worlds.

She hauled herself against the tugging gravity of the past, her lips skinning back as she reached up, grabbed, pulled. Grabbed. Pulled. Her fingers dug into the crumbly wall-stuff of the world, and her shoes scrabbled at the wall, while tears of effort was pulled past her eyes. Then her hand reached up and found, blessedly, an actual *ledge*. Something she could haul herself into. She pulled herself up with another manic burst of raw energy – and saw that she was looking in through a portal.

Luz did not even look inside the portal. She simply knew that if she stayed in the World-Between-Worlds, then she'd be yanked upwards into the Furnace again, and she would…

She wasn't sure what would happen.

But she wouldn't enjoy it.

She shoved herself forward, tumbled, then sprawled onto her back, gasping and panting.

Behind her, the portal she had tumbled through snapped shut.

Luz was alone on a metal floor, lit by a dull reddish light. The air smelled of ozone and acrid stinks. A distant voice crackled on the PA, and a tired, bored sounding person said: "Kyle, report to section-2 for mandatory labor. Repeat, Kyle, report to section-2 for mandatory labor."

"Sucks to be Kyle," Luz whispered, sitting up slowly, her arms trembling.

Okay, she thought. *What was that?*

Well, down was death. Up was...life? Strange images popped into her head – an after effect of seeing the cosmic potentiality she had been dangling into. Luz rubbed her temples, her eyes closing. "I think I saw the beginning of the universe. All universes." She laid back onto the ground again. "...that thing...Belos sent me into the past with it? Why?"

She gasped, sitting up.

"Oh no! I've been Hecate'd in book seven!"

Luz's reflection on the possibility that she had been deleted from time was interrupted by a pair of voices.

"I told you, the energy signature came from down here."

"Ssshrr...rawrr!"

"You're always complaining."

"Rrrhhh!"

Luz tensed, then looked left, right, left, then flung herself between two big pipes. She squirmed in, wriggled, used every bit of her inner-otter energy to cram herself between pipe and wall and then peek around it. *Be the otter,* she thought. *Be tube shaped. Pipe shaped. No humans here, just some innocent, otter-ish pipes.*

The two figures who entered into the room were a short, stocky, rather pretty looking girl of about Luz's age, with dusky brown skin, dreadlocks, and a muscular build. She was dressed in a red and white shirt that looked fairly military, and was holding a truncheon that sparked and hissed at the tip – a shockstick!

Oh no she's really hot! Luz thought, blushing as she peeked around the pipes.

Next to the stocky girl was a tall, broad shouldered lizardman with bright green scales, piercing slitted eyes, and a long thick tail, with the slightest of adornment in the form of long, feather-like scales giving him quasi-hair and arm tufts. He wore a sleeveless version of the same shirt that the girl was wearing, with a collar that showed off his huge abs.

Oh no he's really hot! Luz thought as she crammed herself deeper into the wall.

"C'mon, lets start scanning," the girl said.

The lizardman hissed in annoyance.

"Yeah, I know, Rogellio, but the faster we get this...done…" the girl had pulled out a small handheld device and was aiming it at where Luz was hiding. "Who are you!?"

"Just a pipe technician, doing some pipe things!" Luz said, waving one arm at them. "Can't believe how many, uh, pipes, I gotta...gotta…lay. I mean fix! I mean-"

The girl jabbed the shockstick against the pipe.

It turned out the metal was *very* conductive.

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Luz groaned as she came too, strapped to a metal chair in a room full of angular edges and ominous, glowing wires, cables, and tubes. The centerpiece of the room was a gigantic, dark red crystal that hovered a few feet off the ground and positively throbbed with magical energies. Luz had actually been getting pretty good at *feeling* magic on her skin – it came with a tiny wash of tinglingness every time she cast a spell or, Amity cast a spell, or when Amity was near her, or when she kissed Amity or…

Luz groaned quietly. Thinking about Amity was not helping and hard to stop. She looked down at her restraints, then yelped as a voice spoke from behind her.

"Ah, finally. You're awake."

Luz craned her head around and saw the figure hovering around to come between her and the gemstone.

They were a woman – tall, elegant, and clad in a sweeping red robe. Their face was concealed by a red mask, which darkened to black around glowing white eyeholes. A red gemstone was set on her forehead, while her hair was a brilliant black waterfall that bloomed around her head and swept past her shoulders, looking more like shadows than real hair. Her fingers were gray and peeked out from fingerless red gloves. She had them pressed together, and her voice was a dangerous purr.

"You're not as young as the last First One that fell through a portal," she said.

Oh no! Luz thought. *She's also hot.*

On the Boiling Isles, evil had thankfully managed to avoid the stereotype of being hotter than good. Eda was good, and she was foxy as hell. Kikimora...was more cute than hot. Hunter? Well, okay, Hunter was hot, but he was also very sad, which helped balance out his evil, and then he chucked the evil, so, he was classic good guy turned bad, turned good. Darius? Darius was a good guy, hot too. But Belos had never really been that hot, and he was evil as heck. It was a nice swerve from all the books and anime and fan-fiction she had read.

Well.

It seemed that she had traded one whimsical land of nightmarish terror for another, and this one was playing by new rules.

Bad guys could be hot.

Luz frowned at the girl as she said. "I'm not a First One, uh, ma'am. I'm Luz! Luz Noceda, the human."

"Hmm," the woman said, narrowing those white-on-white eyes. Her fingers lifted and red energies crackled around her fingers. A

spark of pain shot through Luz's body, starting from her head and working her way down to her toes. She clenched her jaw, hard, and trembled as the energies finished buzzing through her.

"Ow!" Luz said. "*Ow*. Frick! That hurt! Hey!" She glared at the woman, who cocked her head.

"Human," she said. "And yet, my spell says you're not from Etheria."

"Neat name!" Luz said, panting, softly. "Now, uhh...can you please, let me go? Since I am not a First One and- and, uh, uh, what are you doing?" she asked, as the woman floated around behind her.

"Oh, I'm just going to probe your memories," the woman said, her voice a dangerous croon as she leaned forward. "Because the only other human not from Etheria I've ever met...well...I have big plans for her. And I need to know if you're a threat to them."

"H-Hey, uh, uh, uh, uh, how about instead…" Luz said, looking around frantically. She started closed her eyes, trying to force down panic. "How about instead I just tell you everything you want to know! Youuuu got me, I'm a First One! Hah!"

The woman hesitated for a moment. "Hmm," she said. "Do you know how to activate the machinery of Etheria?"

"Yes!" Luz said, immediately and without hesitation. "I absolutely do."

The woman was still for a long moment, her finger touching the side of her head, cool and gentle. "And why should I not rip that knowledge from your mind?"

Luz started talking again, as fast as she could. "M-Memory magic is extremely dangerous. You might end up just ripping apart the very information you're trying to get! I've seen it happen! Literally, my best friend's memories got burned up and that was by mistake, now, imagine, if you're doing it on actual purpose! Foosh! Memories gone, no worky the stuff, it's all...all kinds of bad." She nodded. "So, uh, uh, you can just...not...not do that and I will show you how to activate the machinery of Etheria."

"I see," the woman said, then drew her fingertip away from Luz's head. "But I will still need your compliance." She walked around to stand before her – her fingers lifting, spreading. Luz tensed, readying herself for pain. Then her eyes widened as she saw a darkened figure was crouching in the tubes and rafters overhead. Luz's eyes flicked up and the woman hesitated, then turned around.

"Who is- *Catra*."

The figure leaped down and landed before Luz and the woman with a click of claws and bare feet. Luz took her in: Slender, tall, with rangy muscles and a wild mane of brown hair that looked like

you could just bury your entire whole actual face directly into and just lose yourself in it for days. She had a bright red crest-helmet that framed her face – pretty, with intelligent eyes, one of which was gold, one of which was blue. She had orange-brown skin, and the faint tiger-stripe lines of a tabby cat on her arms. She also had cat ears and a cat tail.

Luz had had no chance against Rogellio. She somehow, she had had even less chance before Catra.

"Uh…" Luz whispered, her entire face going brilliantly red, while the tall woman glowered at the girl.

"What are you doing here, Catra?" she snarled.

"I've been sent to bring your prisoner to Lord Hordak. By Lord Hordak's orders," Catra said, her voice smug as she crossed her arms over her chest, looking up into her eyes. "Unless, Shadow Weaver, you want to tell me to tell him you won't let him take a look at his new prisoner."

Shadow Weaver – *what a perfect name for evil*, Luz thought – let out a quiet snarl. "I...see…" she breathed in, then gestured. The restraints clicked open and Luz was able to stand, rubbing her wrists. "I am glad to see that you've finally learned some responsibility. A shame that you had to drive away Adora to get it."

Catra's entire body tensed. She clenched her hands, then turned and jerked her hand. "Come on, prisoner."

Luz followed after her, looking back at Shadow Weaver as they walked through the door.

It slammed shut, cutting the two off from the dark room and the hovering, ominously glowing crystal.

***

Luz thought wildly to herself. *We never once discussed what counts and does not count in our polyamory discussions when it comes to being blasted into alternate universes. We covered what if Willow was bi. We covered what if Eda got deaged. We covered what if Boscha challenged us to grudgeby and it got weirdly erotic in the locker room after we won and cornered Boscha in the showers! But we never once covered alternate universes. What kind of short sighted fools were we?*

While she thought, Catra stalked ahead of her, clearly irritated to be put on this job. And where were they stalking?

Well, Luz tore her gaze from Catra to the surrounding place she was in. Everything was sleek gray metals, complex machinery, jagged edges. Then they came to a window and she gasped, stepping over and mashing her face against it, her palms spreading as she peered out at the vast, polluted city that the tower they were in looked out over. The spires and towers were nearly organic in their confused profusion of pipes, wires, connecting components – grown, piece by piece, but not by flesh

and bone and muscle...no, they had been grown by the factories that were belching smoke into the air nearly everywhere. Drones and robots both legged and winged hissed from place to place, and dozens of soldiers in face-concealing armor marched by on the promenade below, with tanks rumbling beside them.

"This is Etheria, huh?" Luz whispered.

"No, this is the Fright Zone," Catra said, slouching over to her and then leaning with her back against the glass, her hands in her pockets. "It's the boring part of Etheria."

"This is the *boring* part!?" Luz boggled, turning her face to Catra. "What's the rest like? Lasers everywhere?"

"No, the rest of Etheria is the princess part, full of dumb...stupid princesses and their stupid rebellion," Catra said, her voice bitter. "All sparkles, nothing underneath."

Luz blinked. *Rebellion. Fright Zone. Evil. Good!* She frowned, considering her options. On the one hand, immediately running off to the rebellion (made of princesses, too?) seemed like the extremely obvious thing to do. Of course, this cat-girl...this Catra...was a soldier for the bad guys. She'd just try and capture Luz. And Luz had seen her obvious grace and athleticism.

Luz had once had tiny noodle arms. She had worked very hard to get ready for both grudgeby and flier derby and the Gland Prix – and the result had sculpted her into one fine mama jama, if she

had to go off the way Amity's entire face burst into literal incandescent fire whenever Luz took off her shirt. But she was no Catra. Now, if she had her magic…

"So, you're Catra, right?" Luz asked.

"Noooo, my name's Elizabeth Meow Meow Applesauce," Catra said, rolling her eyes expressively.

"Right, stupid question," Luz said, stepping away form the window, moving to her side. "I'm Luz. Luz Noceda. And I happen to be an expert on both princesses, rebellions, alliances, and fights against the above."

Catra frowned, turning to face her. "You?" she asked.

"It's true!" Luz said. "I've fought an evil shapeshifting monster. I once took down a gang of child murdering demon hunters. I regularly beat up Coven Guards, and those guys? Those guys are…" p*retty similar to the masked troops that are on your side.* "...no joke!" She grinned. "Maybe instead of a prisoner, I can be your plucky sidekick!"

"Plucky?" Catra asked, arching an eyebrow.

It's not fibbing if you're doing it to evil, Luz thought.

Catra cocked her head to the side, then snorted. “We’ll see if you’re still alive. After Hordak gets done with you.”

She started down the corridor again.

Luz gulped.

One step at a time, Noceda, she thought. *One step at a time. Then you’ll get back home, and you’ll get to Amity, and you’ll fix everything up there.*

Her eyes dropped to Catra’s tail. Then jerked back up again as they came to a large doorway that was sealed shut – and started to slowly grind open, gears working on gears to pull it open and reveal a massive, darkened chamber. Lights flickered to life and shone up to reveal a set of stairs leading to a tall throne. Sitting upon it...was Lord Hordak. A red cloak spilled over muscular shoulders, while a skintight suit clung to a narrow, almost skeletal chest that narrowed down to a waspish waist. His face was pale white and gray, and made of angles and hard lines, with brilliant red eyes and two long, pointed ears. He looked like a vampire lord, waiting impatiently for his minions to come before him, and his sharpened fingers clacked loudly as he drummed them on the arm rest.

Inwardly, Luz groaned.

He's hot too*!?*

Luz gulped as Catra leaned against a nearby pillar, arms crossed over her chest. Luz took a step forward. Then another. Then another. She stood before Lord Hordak, who regarded her with pitiless red eyes.

"Hi," she said, a bit hesitantly.

Great. Two evil emperors. I wonder if he also has a dark secret.

Luz considered.

Okay, he definitely has a dark secret.

Something, batlike and swift, swept past Luz's head and she yelped and grabbed reflexively for her hoodie – but she wasn't wearing her hoodie and couldn't sweep the hood over her head. Instead she just cringed away from the winged, cherub-like creature that landed on Hordak's shoulder like some kind of eerie familiar. The babyish features contrasted with its gray skin, glowing red eyes, and eerie likeness to the sallow emperor of this industrialized...heck. Luz gulped, while the creature opened its mouth and recreated her voice, echoing and mocking.

"Hi. Hi. Hi."

“Sir, I’ve lived on the Boiling Isles for almost a year, and that’s still the creepiest thing I’ve ever seen,” Luz said, frankly. “H-Have you considered in, uh, investing in some interior decoration? Mosaics? Last, uh, evil emperor I saw had really impressive propaganda!”

Those red eyes narrowed.

“The...*last* Emperor you saw?” he asked, his voice a deep and resonant burr that ran through her bones like an earthquake. “Tell me of this Emperor.”

“Uh, his name was Belos, though, actually, his real name was Philip Wittebane – he was a witch hunter from my world, and he went to another world, called the Boiling Isles, where he was-”

Lord Hordak snorted, then flicked his fingers, dismissively. “He is irrelevant then.” His eyes narrowed once more. “Though, you have traveled to other worlds. Do you have access to portal technology? Have you used a starship?”

“Ohhh, we’re more, uh, *Cosmic Frontiers* than *Luzura,* huh?” Luz said, rubbing her chin.

“Hmm?” Hordak’s ears twitched up and she realized he could hear her, even when she was sottoing her vocce as much as possible.

"I, uh, I have used a starship before, definitely!" Luz said, nodding as she did so. "The *Excalibur*. Under, uh, Avery. Captain Avery. You've probably never heard of him."

"I don't keep track of inferior species and their paltry astronavies," Hordak snarled. "What was your specialization?"

Don't say engineering or science, Luz thought to herself. *Tactical? Maybe, but then he'd see you as a threat. Wait, no, obviously.*

"Esper!" she said, nodding and putting her hand up, giving the Esper Salute.

"Esper?" Hordak asked, eyes narrowing.

"Paracasual natural phenomenon through applied mental powers," Luz said. "Focused through geomentic displays."

"Ah…" Hordak sounded disgusted. "A magic user." He leaned back in his throne. "Still. She may be useful, even if she doesn't have any technical training."

Luz tried to not wipe her brow of perspiration. Instead, she just thanked God that her mom and she had watched their way through three whole seasons with Hunter and Gus. She hadn't read the novelizations, or the tie-in books, since those were a whole bundle of snakes and continuity and she only had room in her heart for three or four confusing multiverses, not the six that

the *Cosmic Frontier* books branched into once the series went off the air and more books came out in the 2010s. Two years after the show had been set too. Wild.

"Where should I take her, sir?" Catra asked, boredom dripping from her voice.

"Have Shadow Weaver ensure her compliance and put her in your squadron, Force Captain," Hordak said. "Now. Go."

"Yes sir," Catra said, then sighed, turning and grabbing Luz's arm and dragging her out of the room. As the doors ground shut with a grinding of metal on metal, Luz yanked her arm out of Catra's grip – and felt the tingling touch of her claws on her skin. She rubbed her skin, wincing slightly.

"Don't you keep those things filed?" she asked as Catra smirked at her.

"No, I just retract them when I need too," Catra said, lifting her hand, then flexing her index and middle fingers. With a soft *snick* her black claws retracted, leaving blunt, smoothed fingertips.

Luz stood very still as a blush crept up from her neck to her cheek to her ears as she looked at those fingers and all that they implied.

“I. See.” She whispered.

“Anyway, lets get you brain washed,” Catra said, shaking her head.

“Hey, hey, hey, what if…” Luz said, walking with her, tapping her fingers together. “We don’t and say we did.”

“Hmm, while it would be fun to annoy Shadow Weaver...no,” Catra said, smirking at her.

Luz hurried forward, then turned back to face Catra, holding up her hands. Catra looked at her a bit like she was a bug. But a cute bug? Possibly. There were cute bugs, Luz had proven that scientifically for her sixth grade book report. Yes, few people had agreed with her thesis on tarantulas and wasps, but they all been cowards. Cowards and fools, who had not recognized her genius.

“Hey, listen!” Luz whispered. “This place is a nightmare. You want someone who can watch your back, right?” She grinned, slightly. “Listen. I may not look like much, but I happen to have been taught by the best troublemaker the Boiling Isles ever saw. I’m savvy. Smart. I know *magic*.” She leaned in close, her voice growing soft. “If I’m on your side, then you can get ahead. And Shadow Weaver doesn’t *know* that Hordak gave the order to get me...ya know. Bzz bzz. Bzz. Auug.” She mimed being electrocuted.

Catra rubbed her chin, frowning.

“Magic?” she asked. “Princesses know magic – what kind of magic do you know?”

“Runes,” Luz said. “Uh, got any paper, or a pen?”

Catra sighed. “This better not be a waste of my time,” she said, in irritation, as she walked past Luz. Luz felt a sweeping wave of relief hit her as she followed after. All she had to do was hope that the runes she had learned on the Boiling Isles worked here. On the one hand, uh, they had not worked in the human realm. But this was a realm *with* magic. She gulped, then started to rummage in her pockets. She yanked out her phone – and saw she wasn’t getting any signal or wi-fi. But she did still have her camera and full batteries. She started snapping pictures of everything as quickly as she could.

Catra glanced back at her. “What are you doing?”

“Nnnnothing!” Luz said, tucking her phone back into her pockets.

Back when she had first been learning magic on the Boiling Isles, runes had been found in all sorts of strange places. Maybe she’d get lucky again.

Maybe.

They came to a small office tucked away off into the corner of the Fright Zone, where someone was bustling away, humming and making a racket of clicks, clacks, and shattering noises. “Oops! Ah drat! Oh dang, uh...uh!” Catra walked in while Luz peeked around the corner and her eyebrows shot right up as she saw that the room had a tall, burly girl with a really cute butch hair cut and a pair large clacky scorpion claws rather than hands, and a curved scorpion tail that swept up behind her back and hovered over her shoulder, complete with a stabber. The stabby thing! With the posion!

“Stinger!” Luz said. “That’s what it is.”

“Scorpia, what are you doing?” Catra asked, her expression looking disbelieving.

“Oh, hey Catra!” Scorpia said, her entire face lighting up in a way that communicated to Luz instantly that she was madly, madly in love with the cat-girl. Which, fair. Then Luz noticed that what Scorpia was doing was knocking over ink wells, snipping pens in half, and generally ruining every attempt she was making at paper-work-ing.

“The newbie needs a pen and paper,” Catra said.

“Who is this?” Scorpia asked, leaning in to peer at Luz.

“Hi! Luz Noceda!” Luz said, offering her hand to the scorpion girl and then realized what a mistake that might be as Scorpia

reached out with her clawed arm – the snipper snaps widening to enclose around Luz's hand. The mental image of Luz's severed hand flashed through Luz's head, but before she could yank her hand back, Scorpia very gently closed her claw around her hand and shook it cheerfully.

"Luz Noceda! What an beautiful name! I'm Scorpia, when did you join the Horde?" she asked, curiously.

"Shortly after *Dragonflight,"* Luz said, automatically, before hurriedly correcting. "I mean, uh, right now! Today. It's a wild story, I just got...there was a portal, and…" She hesitated, feeling the panicky worriedness hitting her. What was going on back on her home?

It's probably fine, she forced herself to think. *Belos had been totally butt-kicked. Yes, he blasted* me *out of the world. But that just means everyone thinks I'm dead. Again. Which means they will be even happier when I come back and go, 'hey, I'm alive again!'*

"Wow," Scorpia said. "Portals. What's a portal?"

Catra shrugged, spreading her hands. "Why are you asking me? Get her a pen!"

"Rightio!" Scorpia turned and almost slapped Luz in the face with her tail. When she turned back, she was holding (gingerly) a pen and a bit of paper, pinched between her claws and holding them

out towards Luz. Luz took them, set them on the desk, then breathed in slowly. She pulled out her phone and whispered softly.

"*Dios mío, deja que esto funcione."* she started to flick her finger on the phone, sliding past gray corridors and red lights and pipes she had snapped pictures of. Catra and Scorpia leaned over, and Catra scowled.

"Hey!" she said.

Then the photos scrolled to a chance shot of the spooky red crystal in Shadow Weaver's chamber, snapped in a reflection of a corridor they had walked past – and there, for a single iota of a second, Luz saw a symbol. It wasn't anything like the runes she knew before...but she had gotten *really* good at memorizing flashes of images like that. Capturing runes from fire and melting snow had required a pretty quick memory and an even faster set of fingers. She scrawled the rune onto the page and then slapped it.

A red bolt of lightning exploded from the paper, smashed into the wall, ceiling, and floor, burning a hissing, smoking hole through the desk and setting the rest of the pages on fire. As smoke roiled up and Scorpia yelped and started to stomp on the papers that had fallen to the ground, Catra's eyebrows shot *straight* up to her brow.

Then she grinned.

"All right, Noceda," Catra said, slowly. "I guess you're on the team."

"Y-Yay!" Luz said, rubbing her singed fingers as Scorpia grabbed onto both of them and hauled them out as the fires caught on the electrical components and the entire room exploded.

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"And here's where we sleep," Catra said, gesturing around herself at the bunk room – it gave spartan a new definition. No longer did it refer to genetically engineered super soldiers, it instead referred to this room. There was a sink and a mirror, there were a set of about twelve bunk beds, and there were foot lockers, and that was *it*. There wasn't even privacy. Heck, they didn't even have blankets. No, wait, there they were – in the footlockers. Each bed had one pillow, and as Adora looked around, she saw that there were tiny bits of decoration here and there. She recognized Rogellio's bed – he had taken some of his shed scales and made a little hanging dream-catcher looking thing (though she was fairly sure it had a different meaning here! ...unless Rogellio was secretly from the pacific northwest tribes. She made a note to ask him late.)

She saw another bed where a skinny blond boy was sprawled, looking completely beat, while the black girl who had shocked her unconscious was giving him a foot massage.

"You really need to stop getting punishment detail, Kyle," she said, shaking her head.

“I didn’t even do anything, though…”

And there, Luz saw that someone had gone crazy against one of the walls – furrowed gouges that looked like they had taken a buzz-cutter to slice in. She knelt down, peering at them. “Wow, who went to town here?” she asked, then…

She saw that, between the claw marks, you could *faintly* see the outlines of a smiley face, and then another face next to it. One had a wild mane of poofy hair, and the other had a pony tail, but other than that, the details were lost under the slashes.

“That’s my bed,” Catra said, thumping down on her rump, then letting herself fall back on the pillow. She looked up at Luz, smirking slightly at her. “You’re gonna have to find another.”

“Heh, are any un-taken? I kinda have to take that one,” Luz said. “It’s not like we can there’s only one bed here. I have a girlfriend.”

“Wow, a girlfriend,” Catra said, her voice dry. “Never had one of those.”

“...are you being *catty*, Catra?” Luz asked, narrowing her eyes.

Catra gave her an icy look.

Luz frowned. She pointed at the two faces. “Bad break up?”

“Shut up,” Catra said, rolling to face away from her. Luz’s brain started to process the information. She narrowed her eyes slightly, and decided to test the water.

“Did…” She hesitated. “Did the Princesses…take her out?”

Catra tensed, then spun around. She slashed with her claws at Luz’s face and only through a titanic effort of pure will – will forged in the fires of meeting the Bat Queen and being thrown into what passed for Detention on the Boiling Isles, and facing down the Collector and Belos and every other two bit menace she had needed to square down – kept Luz from jerking backwards at the gesture. She knew that if Catra didn’t need her, if Catra didn’t respect her...then she had nothing. She had no one.

And people alone didn’t last long, not in the Boiling Isles or the Fright Zone.

“I said *shut up*,” Catra growled, her eyes flickering angrily.

Luz shrugged one shoulder. “It’s not like you’re the only one whose lost someone,” she said, letting her own bitterness creep into her voice. When she was focused on the two steps ahead of her – surviving the next five minuets, to be frank – then it

was...easier. But if she lifted her gaze up to step five, six, seven, ten, twenty, a hundred, however many steps it took to get from *here* back home...it made her blood boil. It made her furious. Belos hadn't killed her, but he had *stolen* her happy ending. He had stolen Amity. He had stolen a chance to really connect with her Mom. She felt tears pricking and she forced them aside, ducking her head down. "If we're going to work together, I...need to know you."

Catra glared at her. She laid back on the bed.

"...she defected," she said, her voice soft.

Luz nodded.

What I'm going to do, she thought.

Catra's eyes were looking unfocused. "She thinks she's better than me," she whispered, and Luz wasn't sure Catra even knew she was saying it. Her hand clenched. Her eyes narrowed. "She always thought she was better than me."

Luz felt a queasy flip in her belly as she looked down at Catra.

I'm going to rip her heart out, aren't I?

She shrugged her shoulders. “You seem...pretty scary.” She paused. “Wait, you did that to *metal* with your claws?”

Catra let out a soft ‘heh.’ She grinned at her. “Yeah? And?”

Luz’s brain felt like Catra had yanked hard on the spinny-gambly-machine arm thingy and her brain was whirring through possible sentences. The one that came out was: “T-That’s really hot.”

Catra smirked at her, slightly. “Okay, now you’re trying to butter up your Force Captain.” She said, sliding her hands behind her neck and reclining there. “I like that. Keep it up. You’re better at it than Scorpia. She keeps *hugging* me.” She shuddered in distaste. Luz, who very badly wanted to give Catra a bone cracking gigantic glomp of a hug, repressed her internal ‘aww’ and instead shook her head.

“Uh, no, I am not buttering you up,” Luz said. “For one thing, I am not yet bringing out the big guns, like my puppy dog eyes, or my quivering lips.” She said, clasping her hands and fluttering her eyes dramatically at Catra, who let out the kind of noise that girls only made when they were trying very hard to not giggle and were hiding it by coughing. “Secondly, I have a girlfriend. And while we do have some agreed upon polyamory triggers – for example, if we ever both get abducted by aliens who need us to do...you know…” She wiggled her fingers. “Experiments.”

Catra looked nonplussed.

“But you’re not one of them,” Luz said, standing up and turning to face the other beds.

Catra, who remained reclining, smirked.

She reached up and smacked Luz’s rump with one of her bare feet, causing Luz to squeak and stumble away from her bed. Luz spun around, and glared down at Catra’s smug, smug, smug expression. Luz thought she had seen smug, but this was pushing things to a limit so hard and so far that it had looped from smug to...to…

Downright adorable.

“...that makes it fun, though,” Catra purred. “After all, what she doesn’t know can’t hurt her. Huh?”

Luz stood very still, then jerked her thumb over her shoulder, hurriedly.

“Bed. Now. Bye. Goodbye. Bye. Forever. Bye.”

She turned and walked straight into a wall.

TO BE CONTINUED

Luz Noceda vs the Wicked Stepmom

Chapter Summary

> Luz Noceda meets a wicked step mom! Catra comes up with a great plan.

Luz Noceda slept fitfully.

A desperate battle. Magic, might, and every bit of will thrown at a vast, ravening darkness – a consumptive force that has wrapped around the Titan itself. The Boiling Isles vast corpse-form rising up from the seas, growling and gasping and lashing its claws about. Reaching. Eda and King were there, claws and magic alike weaving together.

And it wasn't enough.

Because she wasn't there.

Luz jerked upright, moments before the massive, clawed hand came down on her loved ones. The fear that clenched at her chest was eclipsed by only one thing – her head bonking directly into the bunk bed above her. She hissed, grabbing onto her head, her eyes half closed. "Owwwww!" She hissed, softly – not wanting to wake the others sleeping around her. The room was full of bunk beds, the light still dimmed, the soft susurrations of their breathing being the only noise she could hear. Her foot, though, pressed against something warm and soft and very much not herself. She blinked and looked down at the foot of the bed.

With her light adapted eyes, it was hard to *not* see Catra there, curled up, her tail twitching as she slept softly.

Luz had chosen a bed relatively close to Catra, despite trying her best to storm off. The reason was fairly simple: There were just not that many unused beds in this room, the Horde had a lot of soldiers and crammed them into barracks something fierce. But still, seeing Catra there made her do a little double take. She opened her mouth quietly, then closed it. Catra rolled onto her back, her hands lifting above her body as she kneaded at the air in the most kittenish gesture that Luz had ever seen. Sleeping, relaxed, her face was even cuter than it was when she was all sharp angles and focus. She made a soft mewing noise, then pawed more.

Mas te vale you stupid girl, she's an evil gata! Luz put her hands over her face, trying to cram the sudden rush of feelings. The feelings weren't all just good – yes, she wanted to immediately bundle Catra into a blanket and protect her from all bad things, which seemed to be a fairly natural reaction considering Scorpia. But she also…

God.

How could she be the worst girlfriend? Ever?

She was a whole *dimension* away from Amity, and rather than spending every single second of her life trying to get back to her,

she was sleeping! Thinking about other girls! Lying to people! Okay, well, the lying to people was kind of important. But still. She laid back on the bed, looking up at the bunk bed above her. Feeling guilty about Amity shifted quite smoothly to worrying about Eda and King. And Mom. And Stringbean! She had only had her palisman for what felt like five seconds and now she was separated from them!

Fear hit then.

What if Belos took over the island again. What if he's able to crush Eda like a bug.

Then anger.

I'd won! I beat him! He cheated!

Then fear again.

Amity must think I'm dead. Or worse. Is there worse?

Then guilt.

And I'm thinking of a gata-girl instead of her!?

Then fear.

What if they're already dead? Are we working like Cosmic Frontier time travel rules, or Jill and Zed? Or-

Then a nose bumped against her ear. Soft, wet, kittenish, there was a single dizzying moment of pure sapphic panic at the though that Catra had gone from sleep cuteining to sleep smootching, but then Luz rolled onto her side and had to clap her hand over her mouth to keep from waking the entire barracks up.

Because there, wriggling all snake style next to her head on her pillow...was Stringbean!

Her palisman had taken a dang long time to hatch, considering she had carved his egg from pure, untouched palisman wood – she had waited for them to come out for what felt like an eternity, and when she had finally popped out, Stringbean had come out just perfect: A snakeshifter, able to take any number of forms, and genderqueer, too! Except unlike Luz, they weren't a coward and used multiple pronouns. It wasn't that Luz was *scared* of being called he/him, it's just that that idea made her want to shrivel up into a ball. Like, even if she was, for example, turned into a handsome prince via an evil frog's kiss, she'd still want to be a she/her. Maybe them.

Stringbean had no such compunctions, and proved it by strutting around with he/him pronouns for a bit. Of course, it was easier for

him to do that then it was for Luz to do it, because palismans could communicate their intentions using their mental connections to their witches.

Luz, her hand still over her mouth, sat up again. She tried think-talking to Stringbean.

How did you get here!?

The mental image unfolded in her mind – her tumbling into the portal, Stringbean darting forward and sweeping into her pocket. There he curled up. The next image was her being dragged away by Lonnie and Rogellio, both of them bickering over who was going to carry her more. Stringbean rolled out of her pocket in the shape of a stylus, and laid on the ground, as if she was just a normal little cute pen for writing things. Then when no one was looking at him, they rolled away into a vent, falling in with a soft *tink*.

Luz nodded slowly, then gave him a thumbs up. *Good job!* She thought, then picked Stringbean up, hugging his tiny, snakey body to her chest, nuzzling the top of his head. Just touching him made her skin feel less like it was going to peel itself off her body and leave her as a very anxious skeleton.

Now, we just need to keep you safe from the Horde. They might want to experiment on you or something! She thought. Stringbean booped her nose with her nose, clearly amused at the very idea of being 'caught'. He shifted into a stylus and then slid into her pocket.

“You up?”

Luz jerked so hard that her head slammed into the bottom of the bunk above her again. She hissed, grabbing the top of her head as she turned and glowered at Catra, who was laying on her side, head propped up on her arm. Her smirk was quite wicked.

“Y-You!” Luz hissed softly. “You’re not allowed to be suave! You sleep-walked into my bed!”

“Who said I sleep walked?” Catra asked, then rolled up onto her hands and knees. With a fluid motion, she pounced and Luz found herself on her back, arms pinned above her head. The lithe shape of Catra loomed above her, grinning down at her – shadows making only her teeth and her heterochromatic eyes glint above her. Catra leaned in close, her voice soft. “What if I’m just trying to make sure my new *partner* doesn’t do anything...suspicious?”

“U-Uh, uh…” Luz said, gulping hard. Those feelings of anger, fear and guilt were twirling in her brain like someone had taken the big wheel from the *Price is Fortunate* and thrown it hard. It ticked, ticked, slowed, stopped right on *oh fuck me* horny.

Catra snorted. “You’re so easy to *tease*,” she said, then pushed herself onto the balls of her bare feet. “C’mon.” She shifted out from under the bunk bed with a lithe grace, standing and padding off, her tail drawing a line through the air that Luz had to follow or die. Luz scrambled out, grabbing her hoodie as she did so – while

her snakeshifter bestie writhed up next to her ear, chittering softly.

"It's okay, Stringbean," Luz whispered. "I know what I'm doing."

Stringbean seemed less than certain. But they flitted into one of Luz's pockets as she followed Force Captain Catra from the bedroom.

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The chamber that Luz stood in was large and undecorated, save for a zigging and zagging pattern of white hexagons on the floor. The walls were narrow and tall and the lights were dimmed. Catra stood before her in the room, with a staff in one hand. She slammed the butt into the floor and leaned on the staff, her grin lopsided. "So, Noceda," she said. "I'm putting my neck out for you. That means I gotta know if you can actually keep up."

Luz crossed her arms over her chest. "And you decided doing it before breakfast is the best time? Cause then no one can see me mess up and make you look stupid?"

Catra blinked, looking a little surprised. Then she snorted and underhanded her staff at Luz, who caught it with an *oof* as it slammed into her belly horizontally. She stumbled backwards, her hands gripping onto the staff, while Catra snatched up something from behind her back and tossed it too. With reflexes honed firmly

by several games of grudgby, Luz managed to botch catching whatever it was, then pop it up on one knee and end up with it balanced on her nose as she nearly toppled over backwards. She flailed, then finally managed to get her staff beside her and the other thing in her hand. It was a helmet, with a transparent visor. She slid it onto her head, a little nervously, while the hexagonal floor started to rumble and shake. Metal poles thrust up from the ground – and in the visor, she saw them outlined in a hazy augmented reality.

The poles were now trees.

Oh well.

That was nice.

They were spooky trees, though.

Luz scoffed. “I’ll have you know, I’ve handled spooky forests before,” she said.

“Mm. Yeah. And have those forests ever had princesses in them?” Catra asked, walking around to stand behind her. “Deadly, magical princesses? Who’ll stop at nothing to take you out?”

“Uh...you know, in my world, princess has a very different connotation,” Luz said.

“We’re not in your world, Noceda,” Catra said, her voice sharp. “So, if you can get to the end of this course without, ya know, dying horribly, then I’ll keep my word and won’t tell Shadow Weaver that you need to have your brain scrambled. Deal?”

“Uh-”

“Go!” Catra said, and a loud buzzing noise sounded.

Luz breathed in sharply, then breathed out. “Right,” she whispered, then tucked her head forward. “Ready, Stringo?”

Stringbean squeaked at her. She was ready. Okay.

Luz started forward, moving at a steady clip, her shoulders tensed. She had to rely on her two strengths: Reflexes and creativity. Now, yes, she was lacking her magic, but-

A robot popped out of the ground and fired a laser beam at her head. The bot, through her visor, looked like a sinister feminine figure, triangular faced, glowing white eyed, writhing with magical power. Luz flung herself to the side, rolled, came to her feet and swung her staff like a bat. “Hatcha!” she shouted, and the staff connected with the bot’s spherical body with a reverberating *clang* that rang up her wrists, arms, and shoulders. The bot seemed roughly as perturbed as a boulder might have. Instead, it swung

one of its four stubby limbs around and tried to take Luz's head off. Luz yelped and ducked low. She rolled backwards, came to her feet again, then yelped and put a metal tree between her and the bot as it started to blast where she had stood. The beams struck the tree and filled the air with smoke and sparks.

"Auugh, I wish I had a pen!" Luz hissed.

Stringbean popped out of her pocket and transformed into a pen. Luz gaped, then snatched her shapeshifting palisman out of the air.

"Ohhhh, you're the best!" She whispered, doing her best to snuggle the pen. Then she scrawled the new rune she had picked up on the ground – but she wasn't some *newbie* witch like she had been back on the Boiling Isles. She knew that if you modified runes, you could alter their properties. She just needed to learn the modifiers, and what better time to practice than when under laserfire from a killer robot in a psychotic training simulation run by an evil catgirl?

Well, lots of times, Luz thought, raggedly, as she slapped the rune and sprang backwards. The bot lurched around the tree, trying to draw a bead, and a purple spear of light exploded from the rune and impaled the bot, which stumbled backwards then exploded with a roar of smoke and fire. Luz coughed, covering her mouth with her hand – while an alert *bzzed* out and the fake trees dropped into their hexes.

Catra, looking a bit like someone had knocked over her favorite

sandcastle, was hurrying over. “What are you doing!?” she exclaimed.

“Winning?” Luz asked, dazed as she brushed her helmet back and off her head, letting it crash to the ground behind her with an alarming sound of plastic on metal.

“You’re supposed to *disable* the bots, not *blow them up*! Those things are expensive!” Catra said. “I-” she caught herself, then put her hands over her face. “Oh nooo, I sound like Adora.”

Luz blinked at her, then grinned a little sheepishly. “Well, does it mean I passed the test?”

Catra let her hands fall from her face. “Ugh. Maybe. But now we have to explain why the bot exploded.” She glowered at it.

“I’m just awesome?” Luz suggested.

That startled an almost amused laugh out of Catra – and then she froze. Luz knew immediately that something was wrong – purple red lightning buzzed and crackled along Catra’s body, sliding from her feet to her shoulders. Her spine went straight and her eyes were wide – while a furious voice snarled out from behind her.

“*You*.”

Luz stepped to Catra's side, her hands clenched, as she saw Shadow Weaver floating into the training room.

Before Luz could say anything, Shadow Weaver flicked her finger and Catra cried out in pain, falling to her knees and spinning around – an invisible force twisting her around like a top. Shadow Weaver glared down at her. "You *dare* and tap into the Black Garnet? You think you can meddle with my experiments, you useless-"

"Hey!" Luz shouted, then sprang between Catra and Shadow Weaver, her arms spreading wide. "Let her go! I was the one who tapped your frigging gemstone! Hurt *me*." She put her hand on her chest. "If you're gonna hurt anyone – but, before you do, maybe check with Hordak – he might be a little annoyed to find you damaging the best chance he had to get off this planet."

"What are you talking about?" Shadow Weaver asked, sounding taken aback.

She doesn't know, Luz realized. She clung to that information, with a white knuckle grip. She tried to give her most confident little smirk, her arms crossing over her chest to hide the fact that her hands were shaking, that she wished she had brought the staff with her and not left it discarded back in the training room's heart. She lifted her chin, and said, clearly: "If you're not authorized to know, then it's not my place."

"Lying to me is a dangerous game," Shadow Weaver said, her voice soft. "Catra has been doing it since she was a child – and

she's never managed it."

"Try me then," Luz snapped. "Go to Hordak. Ask about portals and First Ones. Assuming he doesn't destroy you for the...the…" She thought of the best possible word she could, and found it. Book six, chapter two. "...temerity."

Shadow Weaver lifted a hand, fingers twisting into a claw, as if she was going to strike Luz full in the face – but the momentary flash of pure, hateful rage passed in a moment and she lowered her hand. As she did so, the buzzing and humming sound behind Luz faded. She heard Catra's ragged breath – a sigh that held more tears than sobbing could have. She ached in her bones with the sympathetic urge. But she forced herself to stay still, looking up into those white eyes.

"You're...going to be an interesting subject, Luz the Human," Shadow Weaver said, then turned and started to float away. "But if you touch my magic again, I will make you wish that you were dead."

Then she left the room.

Luz puffed out a sigh. "Oof! That is one *moy mala* mama jama," she said, turning around to face Catra...and found that Catra was glaring daggers at her, her teeth clenched. The look in her eyes was pure murder. "Um, are you oka-" she reached for Catra, but Catra snarled and slashed at the air with her claws. Luz yanked her hand back, but not before pain bloomed – and bright red

blood, flashing across her palm. She clutched at her wrist, her eyes wide.

"I don't need your *help*!" Catra snapped, springing to her feet.

Luz gaped at her. "I don't know, where *I* come from, friends help when their friends are being *tortured*."

Not that she's my friend. I'm lying to her.

The thought felt very distant and cold, like stepping into mud, feeling it slide down your socks, into your shoes. Luz tried to ignore it.

"I'm not your friend!" Catra shouted, getting into Luz's face. "And I don't need a friend!"

Luz bit back her immediate response. She looked aside – but Catra didn't immediately storm off. Instead, she said. "...do...you need a...a bandage for that?"

Luz flushed. "Nah. It's fine!" She said, while blood dripped between her fingers and onto the floor. She glanced back and saw that Catra had ducked her head forward, her massive bloom of hair hiding her features. Before Luz could say anything, Catra had grabbed her two wrists in one hand – easy, considering Luz was

clutching herself – and started dragging her off towards the medical facility.

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Catra yanked the bandage sharply taut against Luz's palm and she hissed. "Wow!" she exclaimed. "You forget how much healing sucks when you don't have immediate access to healing magic." She flexed her fingers, feeling the throbbing pain of the disinfectant spray and green goop that Catra had slopped onto him – then looked up at Catra, who had stood and stalked to the corner of the room, where she was beginning to pace, frowning intently.

Gosh, she's cute when she's pensive, Luz thought.

Then.

She can cut frigging metal with those claws.

Then.

What am I doing thinking about her cuteness, she's evil!

Then.

But what if I fix her?

Then.

You can't fix her! You gotta get to Amity!

Then.

Did I fix Amity? I mean, Amity wasn't really broken, exactly. Compared to Catra, she was a una fina zanahoria! She hesitated. *A pretty carrot!? What am I talking about!? Her tail is so dang fluffy I have to pet...it! No! Stop!* She grabbed her own wrist as Catra spun around to face her – as if she could sense a tail petting had been coming in.

"So, your magic messes with Shadow Weaver's magic, huh?" she asked, her eyes narrowing. "Like stealing rat bars from Kyle?"

Luz, her hand still on her wrist, blinked at her. "You shouldn't steal rat bars from your friend!" she said. Then her stomach growled. "A-Also, can I have some of those rat bars? They're not full of smilk and eggled devs, right?"

Catra blinked at her. “They mostly full of rats. Why do you think they’re called rat bars?”

Luz’s face went green. Catra snorted and then sat her rump down on the counter, lifting her feet up and planting them on the cabinet door that she had pulled her medical supplies out of. She regarded Luz with hooded eyes. “How’d you make the magic...do stuff instead of just exploding?”

Luz shrugged one shoulder. “You can shape runes to make them do specific things.” She sighed. “I once jerry-rigged an ice spell to make a *sword*. An ice sword. I was so *cool* on the Boiling Isles.” She slumped back, her eyes looking up at the ceiling. “So, I just shaped the black garnet’s power to go in one direction, rather than every direction.” She frowned. “I think it’s some kind of raw energy – maybe just lightning with spooky effects. What other elemental runes might be on this planet…” She frowned, intently.

“Oh, there’s the Moonstone, the Heart Blossom, the Fractal Flake, the Pearl, the long lost Fire Runestone and the mythological Seventh Runestone of Power!” A cheerful voice cut in as the door was filled by the large, tankish shape of Scorpia. She was clutching a bunch of papers and had a tray of greenish bars of plastic-ish consistency balanced on one of her outstretched claws. “They’re mostly linked to the other princesses – Moonstone is light and teleportation and is in Brightmoon, linked to Princess Glimmer-”

“How do you know that?” Catra asked, her voice full of irritation.

“Force Captain orientation?” Scorpia said. “Also, some of it was

mentioned to me by my dad, when he was teaching me about how to be a princess."

"You're a *princess*!?" Catra and Luz said at the same time, Luz springing to her feet. She put her hands on her cheeks, drawing in the entire room's share of oxygen with one gigantic gasp.

"Ohmygosh you're a kidnapped princess, captured by the evil horde and raised to villainy by their wicked whims, unaware that your true allegiance is to the forces of good!" She squealed.

Scorpia blinked at her. "Uh. No. My father and mother let the Horde stay in our kingdom. We're polite like that." She smiled and blushed. "I mean, it's not like, uh, we were *using* the Black Garnet, so…" She shrugged. "Anyway, uh, want some ration bars?"

"I knew they weren't rats," Luz said, deflated, while she took a rat...ration bar and bit into it.

It tasted like rats.

As she made a face, Catra groaned as Scorpia dumped a load of paper into her hands. "Here's assignments for your squadron, Force Captain, just like you asked for. And logistic reports on weapon manufacturing," she said. Luz, by now, had managed to get a quarter of the bar into her mouth – rat or no, she was *starving* – and as she chewed on the material she was getting concerned that she might arrive at the Boiling Isles without any

teeth. Then she remembered toothhaste and shuddered from her head to her toes. Scorpia, then, dumped one more envelope onto the pile.

"And here's the invitation I got for Princess Prom."

Luz choked. Catra frowned, dumping every single piece of paperwork into the trash can save the last, holding it up between her fingers. "Princess Prom? Since when has there been a Princess *Prom*?"

"Every year!" Scorpia said. "It was mentioned in Force Captain orientation!"

Catra scowled.

Luz wheezed, her face turning red. She slammed her knuckles into her own chest while Stringbean sneaked out from her pocket and, with her body as cover, slammed his head between her shoulder-blades. This dislodged the mostly unchewed chunk of ration bars and Luz practically felt it splash into her belly.

"There's a *prom*?" she asked. "Wait, wait, just to check, this doesn't lead to a battle to the death against an ancient evil shapeshifting monster, right?"

"Not until we get there," Catra said, her voice an eager purr.

"Oh?" Scorpia asked.

"Scorpia, do you have a plus one?" she asked.

"I don't know, you have-"

Catra slit open the envelope, scowling – and a plus one fell directly into her palm. She took it, then proffered it to Luz, her grin wicked. "I have a plan, Noceda."

Luz gulped as Catra tucked the invitation into her breast pocket.

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Stringbean had some issues. They were whispering them in the back of Luz's brain as the skimmer shot over the landscape of the Fright Zone. Kyle was at the pilot seat, while Catra lounged back in her chair, whistling cheerfully as she tossed a shock stick up and caught it, then tossed it up and caught it. Rogellio and Lonnie were in the back of the skimmer, both checking over their supplies. Scorpia was standing behind Catra, clacking her claws together.

Luz gulped. *Don't worry, I know what I'm doing,* she thought to Stringbean, trying to cast his worries aside with her own. *I just*

need to subtly sabotage the evil plan so it fails, while also making it seem like I'm still on their side, useful, and thus, not worth kicking out of the Evil Horde or killing horribly. Then I use that goodwill to get close to the portal machines and learn more magic and figure out how to open a portal back to the Boiling Isles, then punch Belos in the face, and kiss my girlfriend and never once mention catgirl outfits to her ever not even once.

She nodded.

Easy! Simple!

Stringbean wriggled, then bumped his head against her cheek before skimming back under her collar.

"So, uh, are you sure...y-you don't want to be, you know, uh, with me? On the dance floor?" Scorpia asked Catra, who was dressed in her normal Force Captian clothes.

"Of course not," Catra said, her voice a wicked chuckle. "I want Adora's attention entirely on the new human. What's she doing. Where did she come from. What am I planning." She grinned. "And Luz, you're going to be more distracting than I can ever hope to me."

Luz looked down at herself.

Catra had gotten her...what was possibly...the snazziest and most evil suit that she had ever worn in her entire life. She might have preferred a bit of a skirt to go with it, to de-masc it slightly...but then again, this suit was *so* masc that it swept around to being femme, which was pretty gender of it. The color was a dark maroon that set off her dark brown skin, with a lighter red shirt underneath, and a really kicking untied bow-tie that looped around her shoulders, and rolled back cuffs. It left her feeling so unbelievably hot that it was nearly distracting.

"I-I still think you should be wearing the suit, Catra," Luz said.

Catra smirked at her. "I don't tend to put on suits with bombs in them," she said, as through the forward screens, they started to cut over wild, untamed forest that looked absurdly rich with life and chaotic wilderness. Luz nodded, then jolted.

"A bomb!?" she exclaimed.

Catra cackled, kicking her feet, while Scorpia shook her head. "There's no bomb in your suit," she said, cheerfully. "Since you're a loyal Horde soldier like the rest of us."

Luz gulped.

Would Catra put a bomb in a suit then have me wear the suit, then blow me up if I betrayed her? Luz thought. She didn't know. She wanted to think it was just a joke. But what if it was *not* just

a joke? She bit her lower lip, then scratched at her neck. "C-Can I know what everyone else's part of the plan is?"

"No," Catra said, casually.

"It's better if we don't know," Scorpia said, cheerfully. "I'm a terrible liar, I hate doing it, so I'll just not know,t hen if someone asks, I can just tell the truth."

"Right," Luz said, glancing back at Lonnie and Rogellio. Rogellio caught her look and then gave her a thumbs up, and hissed something that might have been encouraging. Luz smiled shakily back and gave him a thumbs up as well.

"We're almost at the Kingdom of Snows," Kyle said, his voice firm.

The radio crackled and a voice – gruff, authoritative and female – came through. "This is the Kingdom of Snows to Horde Flier. You are approaching our airspace." Catra grinned and flicked on the communicator, leaning over.

"Heyyyy," she said, her voice a playful purr. "We happen to have an invitation and a plus one for the Princess Prom. According to the rules, you have to let us land – since, well, neutral kingdoms don't usually blow neutral fliers out of the sky, right?"

There was a short pause.

“They’re neutral?” Luz whispered.

“Yeah, the Kingdom drew out of the Princess Alliance during the last war,” Scorpia said, nodding.

“There was a *last* war?” Luz whispered, her eyes widening.

But before she could say anything, the flier’s hover-engines whirred and the egg shaped vehicle dropped from the skies, heading towards a large mountain that had been carved into a glittering palace of ice and sheer stone walls. The only approach was a winding blue path – which did explain why so many fliers and aircars had been parked out front, though Luz could see riding beasts as well, and...also, what appeared to be a large sailing ship that had been crammed between two vehicles and was listing on its side. She pointed at it.

“Who was riding that?” she asked.

“I unno,” Lonnie said.

The Horde flier dropped down and the back unfolded with a whirr and hiss of steam, even as Luz stepped up beside Scorpia. “So,” she said, offering her arm to the big bug girl. “Uh. We should get our backstories straight! I’m Luz Noceda, the human, mysterious, off-world, magician, deadly talent, new recruit of the Horde, here to conquer Etheria with my grace and charm, and razor sharp

wit!" she said, spreading her hand out dramatically, her other arm snaking around Scorpia's elbow. "And you are fair Scorpia, Princess...of Evil!"

"A-Actually the Horde isn't evil, that's just what other people call us," Scorpia said. Then she chuckled. "Also, uh, isn't that backstory just what you are?"

"...right!" Luz said, blushing.

Catra shook her head and sighed. She stepped over, then whispered in Luz's ear. "Luz, there's just one thing before you go."

She called me Luz, Luz thought, dizzily.

Catra leaned in. and she kissed her. Right on the mouth. Her tongue was rough, and gentle, all at the same time. Her hand cradled Luz's cheek and the real passion she put into the kiss left Luz's head spinning and her heart thumping at a million miles a second. Catra drew back and whispered in her ear. "When you see her, say...*hey Adora*."

"S-Si…" Luz whispered.

She and Scorpia stepped down the gangplank and started to head forward. Scorpia grinned, a bit sheepishly – but there was a tingle of hurt in her eyes.

"W-We're not an item or anything!" Luz whispered, hurriedly. "Me and Catra. I mean. I have a girlfriend. Back in another universe."

"Right," Scorpia said, looking away, blushing. "Sorry. I. I shouldn't be thinking stupid things right now, we have a mission to do."

Luz felt her own heart squeezing up into a ball. She smiled, then leaned up on her tip tip top tippy toes and kissed Scorpia on the cheek.

"Caring about people is not stupid, Scorpia," she said, firmly. "You're one big bundle of awesome, and you should totally be able to...to throw Catra onto a bed and ravage her, as if she was Knight Gallant in the *Gallant and Godfrey* Azura spinoff!"

"I...uh…" Scorpia blushed – but before she could respond, they reached the front doors of the prom – which had started to open with a ponderous creaking groan, revealing a large ballroom and a pair of stairs that swept around and down to the dancing floor – which was full of people in beautiful dresses, gowns and other lovely outfits. The music was a cheerful, electronic tinged song that made Luz feel, achingly, like she was back at Gravesfield High and watching other people dance and feeling like she was clinging with her fingernails to the last moment of a part of her life that was...never going to come around again.

"Presenting, Princess Scorpia and guest, Luz Noceda...the Human," an announcer called out – drawing everyone's attention

to her.

Luz gulped.

You've done this before. Grom was a million times scarier than this. And Grom was throwing frights at me back when I thought Mom being mad was scary! Mom being mad is...almost...like, twenty percent less scary than Belos controlling the entire Titan! Luz thought as she grinned, then stepped onto the stairs, drawing Scorpia down with her – heading towards the whispering, murmuring people who were watching her arrive in clear interest, and towards the ruler of the Kingdom of Snows.

Princess Frosta was twelve.

Or maybe thirteen?

Or possibly eleven.

Luz stood before her – and then before she could say anything, an exclamation of shock cut out.

"Who the heck are you!?"

Soft murmurs and whispers rang out – while Priness Frosta sighed and then lifted her hand imperiously. "Princess She-Ra, you will allow the Horde's representatives to present themselves properly," she said while Luz looked at the person who had shouted out and pointed at her. The girl was in a red dress. A beautiful red dress, which suited her, because she was also beautiful. Blond haired, muscular, tall, amazonian, perfect, blond, amazing, perfect. Her hair was done into this adorable little poof that swept up above her brow and her eyes were the most remarkable shade of crystal blue and...and…

That was Adora.

That was the mysterious girl who had run off and broken Catra's heart. The girl that everyone talked around.

Okay, Luz thought. *I understand why Catra is like that, if I fumble that, I would also become evil.*

In the silence that hung in the air, Luz realized that she had to introduce herself. She breathed in slowly and thought to herself: *You are Luz Noceda. You got this.*

She slung of her suit jacket – the air was surprisingly warm, despite the fact the room was made entirely of glittering ice. She tossed her jacket over one shoulder, hooking the collar on her finger, letting it dangle there dramatically. Then she brushed her fingers through her short brown hair, flicking her head back and showing off the scar she had earned in her adventures, grinning fiercely.

“I’m Luz Noceda,” she said, bowing. “First One, explorer, witch and conquering general, here with the most beautiful princess in the whole land.” She reached back, taking Scorpia’s claw, tugging her over. “Thank you so much for allowing us to take part in this celebration, majesty.”

Just keep talking like Hecate, Luz thought. *It’ll work perfectly.*

Soft murmuring and shocked sounds whispered between the onlookers, while a femmy looking greenish lizard-creature said, loudly enough for Luz to hear: “Well, isn’t that just *precious*…” while flicking his or her or their hand excitedly.

“We are honored to have a...are you truly a First One?” Princess Frosta asked, her eyes widening as she leaned forward.

“Yes, I am,” Luz said, smiling. “I came from another universe – Etheria is new to me, but I’m...fascinated to learn what my people once did here.”

“Bow, no!” A hiss came from Luz’s left. Next to the amazonian perfection of Adora there was a black boy who was...his entire belly was exposed by his suit, like he had just removed the cummerbund and everything beneath it. He was being held back by a slender blond and a short, curvy girl with sparkly pink hair, both of them holding his arms. The pink girl was the one hissing. “No, wait!”

"But she's a *First One*."

Adora was looking at Luz with fierce, attentive eyes. In fact, with all of her attention.

Exactly like Catra planned, Luz thought, feeling her belly flip slowly in her stomach. She smiled at Frosta, bowed her head, and Frosta clapped her hands twice. The music started to resume and Luz lifted Scorpia's claw to her lips, kissing her like she was the most coolest badass princes/princess ever. She grinned at Scorpia, then said. "Can you get us some of those nice yummy snacks I want to have something that aren't ration bars," she whispered, while Scorpia nodded. Then she looked back at Adora – who started to walk forward, flanked by Bow and...by process of elimination, that was Glimmer.

Luz looked up into Adora's eyes.

Grinned.

"Hey Adora," she said.

Adora looked like she had been slapped.

I can fix this, Luz thought.

TO BE CONTINUED

Luz Noceda ruins Princess Prom

Chapter Summary

Luz Noceda makes several terrible decisions! Catra helps.

A subtle gesture from Princess Frosta was all it took for the musicians to begin playing – the music was somewhere between fancy and dancy and Luz had a momentary lock-up in her brain as she looked squarely at (well, slightly up at) Adora. Unconsciously, she swung her jacket off her shoulder and tossed it to a robed guard, who caught it and looked rather annoyed to be put into coat guard duty. Luz barely even noticed – her brain was instead spinning around a single point.

What frigging dances do they even do here?

Luz prided herself in being at least somewhat decent at dancing. In truth, this was due to a crippling and only semi-treated case of impostor syndrome when it came to social interaction, inculcated by a childhood of people freaking out about...oh, running down the list would be too long for an aside. Spiders. Folding her eyelids back and going 'bleep bloop' at them. That one time she had tried her improvised pyrotechnics for the thanksgiving day pageant. The sausages.

Reality, when viewed from, say the eyes of Amity or Camila Noceda, or any of the people who loved Luz and could perceive her from outside of her own skin…

Luz Noceda was a *spectacular* dancer. Lithe, graceful, poised, able to read the movement of her partner's body with a flash, it was part of the same athleticism that her time in the Boiling Isles had honed and refined – a feedback cycle that left her quite possibly the most talented dancer in the entirety of the Princess Prom.

Adora glanced away from Luz as the music started up, and Glimmer, who was busy holding back Bow from his explosion of questions, made a vague gesture at her. Out of the corner of her eyes, Luz saw some of the other people in the crowd beginning to dance – and it was one of those where people mirrored the actions of the others. Hand up, twirl, twirl, hand up, arm to arm, eyes to eyes. She grinned and pressed her forearm against Adora's, feeling the iron deep strength even through that little touch.

Luz's brain felt like it was skittering from point to point on a diagram. *Okay. I just need to – keep secrets – then once I – and now I just need to – make Adora think – then I-*

She fell back on the personae she had adopted. First One. Luz Noceda, witch extraordinaire. Badass. She smirked at Adora, but Adora spoke first.

"When did you join the Evil Horde? And where did you come from?"

"As I said, another universe," Luz said, casually.

“No one comes from other universes!” Adora hissed. “There’s just one!”

“Mm, so you think. Curious.” Luz smirked back at her, as they circled. Luz stepped in close, putting her hand on Adora’s hip.

“Catra put you up to this. Didn’t she?” Adora’s breath was soft and her blue eyes were fierce and probing...and concerned. Luz could see it, buried deep in there. She wanted to immediately start babbling – but would Luz Noceda, First One, babble? No. And more importantly, would Luz babbling about everything she thought and know get noticed by Catra. Would Catra set off the bomb she might have hidden in Luz’s nice suit? Luz didn’t gulp or flinch or freeze. Instead, she slid an arm around Adora’s back as the dance shifted subtly in character – everyone else was backing off, but she didn’t. She instead twirled Adora around, holding her close as she grinned at her.

“Ah, Catra! The girl you abandoned to the...what did you call it again? The Evil Horde?” Luz asked. “And let that awful Shadow Weaver do whatever she wanted to her? That Catra?”

“I-I…” Adora stammered and Luz realized, with a lurch, that she had let real anger flash into her voice. But why not? Adora had to have seen what Catra was going through. Right? Except Adora was fighting for the good guys, against the *Evil Horde*. Luz mentally kicked herself. She had to find a way to fix this. Adora shook her head, then pushed back – stumbling into some of the other dancers. “I didn’t abandon her! I asked her to come with me, but-”

Luz snatched her hand, yanking her back into the dance. Her voice was soft. “Well, she’s not here. Which is something I did want to talk about.”

Adora, her cheeks flushing, her eyes flickering with hurt, allowed herself to be swung around as the music slowed and then came to its flourishing finish. The dancers stopped in their movement – some heading off to pick up food, others waiting for the next song to start, laughing and talking.

“What is her plan? What is she doing?” Adora asked.

“Something flashy, I bet,” Luz said, shrugging one shoulder as she did so. Her voice softened and she leaned in. “But I think that we can help her, if we work together.”

Adora frowned. “Help her do what?”

Luz glanced to the side. Once the music started, she could whisper the words – or maybe mouth them. But before she could, Bow slid into the conversation like a wrecking ball and annihilated any chance that she could tell Adora that she wanted to *rescue* Catra from the Evil Horde and get her somewhere where she could do good instead of, uh, evil. Bow, his eyes shining with excitement, was holding a kind of sleek...tablet! He had a tablet computer! Luz’s eyes widened as she saw it, while he said: “You’re a First One! Uh! Can you tell me if my tablet is up to snuff, I built it at the Etheria Maker’s Fair inspired by some old First Ones components that they had there-”

“Bow!” Adora hissed.

Luz barely registered that a tall, pretty blond (the same one who had restrained Bow earlier) was glowering at her as if she was made of snakes.

“Wow, this looks...exactly like the kind of, uh, hand terminals I would use back on my starship,” Luz said, taking the tablet and turning it around in her hands.

“Starship!?” Bow squeaked, while a gasp and then a sound of slapping footsteps, then a new face peered in from the corner of Luz’s vision: She was a cute, skinny looking girl with purple hair, dressed in a rugged outfit that looked more suited for working in a machine shop than dancing. She had a pair of goggles that she had swung up to her brows, and her hair was *long*. Like, long enough to reach down to her back and done up in two pony tails. Then, before Luz’s eyes, one of her ponytails reached out and snagged a tiny treat from one of the food tables, bringing it to her hand, which then transferred it to her mouth.

“You have a starship? Which propulsion did it use – fusion power or some kind of magical energy tap, did it travel faster than the speed of light and, if so, which method did it use, a warp drive? Hyperspace? Telespatial portals? Was it armed? With what? What defenses did it have?”

Luz blinked, then started to tick them off on her fingers, drawing on mostly Episode 8, Season 2, *Nacelle,* which had mostly been the engineering girl’s turn for the spotlight. She had to force

herself to not slip into a rustic, Texan twang when she practically quoted Chief Trina Teller from memory. "Antimatter/Matter reaction for realspace, 5th space folding using Neckland Field Generators – using wormholes, obviously. The armament were two gravitic imploder lancers, three plasma cannons, and an atomic nuclear torpedo launcher." She nodded. "Defenses were primarily plasma shielding, mass screens, and some point defense using kinetic spalling launchers."

"Wooooooooooow!" The purple haried girl took out what seemed to be a small notepad and started scribbling.
"Gravitic...Imploder...Lancer, I can probably begin working on tha-"

"How did you get stranded here?" Bow asked.

"Oh, there was this huge jerk named, uh...uh...Emperor Belos," Luz said, realizing she didn't even need to make up a name to sound like she was staying in character. Adora frowned at her.

"Emperor Belos?" she asked, sounding skeptical. "Right, sure. It sounds to *me* like you're just making a bunch of stuff up that no one can even check or verify."

Luz, who had been making up a bunch of stuff no one could check or verify, scowled at Adora. "Fine then, do you want me to demonstrate my...First One-ey-ness?" She asked, arching an eyebrow.

"Sure," Adora said, nodding. "Or, maybe…" She grabbed onto Bow, jerking him close, whispering to him. Luz's ears perked as hard as she could, so hard that she nearly grew points like Amity's ears. But the music had just started and the dancers around them were giving the cluster of people rather fishy looks. Luz wanted to slip into the conversation between Bow and Adora – but before she could, the purple haired girl grabbed onto her arm, shaking her slightly.

"First One girl," she said, firmly. "I need to know, what other technologies did you have in your First One ship."

"I, uh-" Luz started, but before she could respond, Adora had grabbed onto her other arm.

"Come on," Adora said, her voice firm.

"Aww," the purple haired girl said as Luz allowed herself to be dragged away by a big beautiful amazon. The fact that she was not currently fainting with delight was because her heart was hammering in her chest and she felt sick to her stomach. Adora and Bow glanced around nervously – and a few guards gave them the kind of stern, monitoring look that could only come from people in face concealing helmets and robes. Luz forced herself to look less dragged and more led away eagerly, while internally, her brain was going from point to point again.

If they want to hear the truth, and we're alone, try and subtly indicate that you might have a booby trap on you. Wait, no, you got rid of your jacket, was the bomb on the jacket? If it was, then where was it now, in a coat room somewhere? Auugh!

They came to the corner of the big ballroom, and there, Adora shoved Luz into the wall with enough force to drive the air from her lungs. Luz blinked – did Adora know her own strength? – but before she could say anything, Adora said: "What did you mean by helping Catra?"

Luz breathed in, then reached up and tugged her collar flat. She wished she had suspenders to snap too. Note for future dressing up games.

"I meant," she said, hesitating. *How do I say leave the Horde without saying leave the Horde? How do I do this all without exploding?* Then Luz realized, grimly, that she would just need to take the risk. The longer she spent twirling her wheels and trying to play both sides as safely as possible, the more likely it was that Catra would do something stupid and irrevocable. As it was, she had already done enough being a distraction.

But…

It was one thing to say that, in your head.

It was another thing to speak when you had a good chance of exploding. Or…

Worse.

There was a worse, and it hit Luz's brain like a sledgehammer.

What if Catra learned that Luz had 'betrayed' her. What if she had to flee the Fright Zone. What if she had to spend the rest of her life here, on Etheria, fighting the Horde and never, ever, ever getting home. The image of Amity growing older and sadder and more distant from her was almost as horrible as the image of Amity being crushed under Belos' heel as he consumed the entire Boiling Isles. Both images tormented her in that moment.

If I stay with the Horde, I can get home, definitely. They have portal technology, Hordak is working on it, he said so himself.

"...I meant…" Luz said, again. All those thoughts had flashed through her head at a million miles a second – it had only felt like she had spent an eternity thinking. But even at her heightened rate of speculation Bow and Adora would only wait for her to finish her sentence for so long.

Which is why it was both kind of nice and absolutely horrible that the room chose that moment to quake like it had been hit with a half a dozen explosions at once. The ceiling shuddered and bits of ice-chips and fragments came spilling down onto the crowd. People started to rush for the exits as Princess Frosta stood, her voice shockingly calm considering her age. "Everyone remain calm! Head for the exits, and guards, to me!"

“Catra…” Adora whispered, then snapped her head around to glare at Luz. “You *liar*!”

“I wasn’t lying, honestly!” Luz said. “I just...was...sent here to distract you.”

“You’re not even a First One, are you!?” Bow sounded just as horrified.

“Well, technically, I could be!” Luz said, grinning weakly.

Adora let her go and turned, sprinting towards the sounds of the explosions – while Bow hurried after her.

“Wait!” Luz said, hurrying after them. “Wait, wait, I do want to-” She lunged, managed to get her fingers around Bow’s arm. He staggered – and was perfectly still and distracted for a sudden jabbing stinger, which punched into his back. He stiffened, then fell into Luz’s arms. Luz held him, her eyes widening. “Whoa, whoa whoa!” She looked around and saw that the stinger had come from Scorpia, who grinned confidently.

“Gottem!” she said.

“Uh…” Luz said, then yelped as two guards advanced on them.

“Unhand that guest!” one said.

“Cover me, Luz,” Scorpia said, grabbing Bow and slinging him over her shoulder.

Luz blinked – and realized she’d have to start talking really fast. The guards were both dressed in thick blue coats, with white fringe around their helmets that reminded her of fur. They also had ice spears. Ah man. That was cool. Luz spread her hands.

“So, uh, I can ex-” she started as they advanced on her, speartips at the ready. She jerked left as one thrust at her, while the other grabbed for her arm. Luz yanked herself backwards and, reflexively, reached into her pocket, yanked out her runing paper and her stylus, and then sprang back to land lightly on a table. “Don’t make me use this?”

“A pen?” one of the guards asked.

“Yeah!” Luz said. “The pen is mightier than the ice spear!”

The two guards scowled and advanced forward again.

Luz scrawled, then slapped down the rune on the edge of the table, then leaped to the side. The rune exploded with a wave of black lightning, sending the two guards stumbling backwards as the table – itself made of ice – turned into a fine must. One of the guards fell fully onto his back, clutching his arm, hissing in pain. Luz felt sick, even as she turned to run after Scorpia, who was at the exit out of the ball room.

I can fix this, later, I can fix this! Luz thought, frantically, as more screams filled the building.

"Awesome job, Luz!" Scorpia said, cheerfully, as they came out to find Ronnie, Kyle and Rogellio - all wearing definitely 100% stolen Snow Guard uniforms – waiting for them. Bow was tossed to them, and Scorpia turned to face Luz. "Go to the roof – Catra told me she wanted you up there."

"R-Right," Luz said.

She started into the confusion and the panic of the collapsing structure – the bombs, whatever they had hit, had caused everything to go haywire. The floor was growing slippery under her feet, as if the ice was beginning to melt, and the walls showed cracks. Luz's heart thudded in her chest as she pushed past screaming guests as they rushed for exists, then started up some stairs, taking them three at a time, her hands on the frigidly cold banisters – just in case she hit a patch of slippery ice. Her breath was fogging by the time she reached the roof and came out onto the sheer surface that looked out over the Kingdom of Snows' and all its blue and white and auroral glory.

The cold was getting sharper, despite everything looking more melty. Whatever magic Frosta had used to sculpt her castle was going completely...hay…

She blinked.

For just a moment, in the fog of her breath, she swore she could see a rune.

"Another rune from a runestone…" Luz whispered.

"You!"

Luz spun around. "Me!"

Adora had reached the roof too – through a different method, it seemed. There were chunks of ice beginning to float up and up around the building – and Adora was clinging to one.

Another was carrying Catra. She hopped cheerfully from the ice and landed beside Luz, her arm snaking around her shoulders as she grinned at Adora. "Ah, you've met Noceda? My new...*friend*?" she asked, cheerfully.

"Uh-" Luz said, while trying to squish the part of her that was squealing and kicking its legs at the way that Catra had emphasized friend.

"I knew it!" Adora said, her eyes flashing. "You are a *liar*, Noceda!"

“Oh, what did you tell her?” Catra asked, laughing. “The last time I saw Adora get that mad, it was when I beat her at the finals.”

“I wasn’t mad then!” Adora said, then shook her head, scowling. “What was the plan? Distract me with your new...new...new… girlfriend!? Then blow up the Princess Prom?”

“Girlfriend!” Catra gasped, faux shocked. “Luz, do you think we have that chemistry?” She asked, pressing herself against Luz’s side, her hand slipping along Luz’s belly. Luz spluttered.

“I-I-” she started.

Adora shook her head. “Well, it’s not going to work, Catra. I won’t let you get away with this.”

“Heh, Adora…” Catra said, grinning as her hand slid up and down Luz’s tummy, feeling her up quite openly – and Luz had never felt quite so objectified in her life. She felt a cold anger boiling inside of her as she saw Adora’s hurt and anger and how gleefully Catra was stoking it up with every purring touch – every cuddle. Every bit of pressure. “...I already did?”

Then she shoved Luz backwards. Luz yelped and fell straight off the roof.

And crashed directly into the armrest and seat back of the cockpit's left chair in the flier that had taken her to the Princess Prom in the first place, her head bonking directly into one of Kyle's arms. "Hey Kyle!" Luz said, panting. "I think Catra just tried to kill me."

Then Catra dropped down with the light grace of a cat pouncing onto a smaller, more bisexual cat whose fursona was that of an otter. Her nose almost bumped Luz's nose as she grinned – and only Luz might have thought of the Cheshire Cat in that feral grin and those gleaming eyes.

"Go! Now!"

Adora was standing at the edge of the roof, her eyes wide and shocked, looking down as Catra slumped against Luz, caressing her cheek – and Luz was so furious she barely even noticed the bound, gagged and unconscious Glimmer and Bow in the back of the flier until they were halfway to the Fright Zone.

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Catra cackled as she walked into the locker room, stretching her arms behind her back. "Did you hear that?" she asked, cheerfully. "*Silence* Shadow Weaver, I wish to hear of what Force Captain Catra has accomplished – oh, it seems she had delivered unto us vital assets, while you continue to lurk in your laboratory…" She cackled and then threw herself into a sprawling lean against the lockers, her grin feral with delight. "Oh Hordak gets *sassy* when-"

Luz grabbed onto the locker next to Catra and slammed it shut, nearly catching Catra's fingers. She glared at her. "Scorpia," Luz said.

"Yes?" Scorpia said, standing perfectly still.

"Leave," Luz growled.

Catra pursed her lips as Scorpia clicked her claws together with a nervous expression – like she wanted to both stay and run away as fast as possible. Catra, for her part, gave her no indication of what to do. Her blue and gold eyes bored into Luz's instead. Scorpia took one step back. Then another. Then she was gone, her feet clacking down the corridor.

"...yeah?" Catra asked.

"You *used* me to get back at your girlfriend!" Luz snarled. "You kidnapped her new best friends, why? To torture her!?"

"Uh, no," Catra said. "I used you to distract my *enemy* in a *war* we're fighting so we can *win*." She rolled her eyes, then casually slid under Luz's arm and walked away. Her tail flicked from side to side. "I kinda thought that was your whole deal, Noceda – that you're here to *help* us so you can get home, right? And does the Princess Alliance have all those machines Hordak has? No. Does the Princess Alliance even know what a portal generator is? What

other *universes* are? No!" She turned back to face Luz, arms crossed over her chest. "I heard that my own self."

Luz flushed. "You did have me bugged, huh?"

"Duuuuuh!" Catra said. "How else would I know if you stabbed me in the back?"

Luz put her hands on her face. "Argh!" She groaned, then shook her head, starting to pace back and forth. "That's not explaining the belly rubbing! And the cheek touching! And the calling me a girlfriend!"

"I, uh, didn't do that, that was Adora. And she's got rocks for brains," Catra said, her voice dry.

"You practically screamed it at her! With implications!" Luz said, throwing her hands up into the air.

"You helped," Catra shot back.

"I did not!" Luz exclaimed.

"Yeah, Noceda, you really did…" Catra said, her voice growing soft. She stepped in, her finger touching Luz's chin. The tip of her claw – pressed so gently that it left only a pale white line as it

caressed along Luz's skin – slid down to the thundering pulse point of Luz's throat. Her eyes slitted – blue and gold pools, deeper than the ocean. "You said *hey Adora* the exact way I did. You might as well have told her that we've been sleeping together for month."

"I-I...you…" Luz stammered.

"And…" Catra hesitated for a moment. "We did work together well. Didn't we?"

"We didn't work together at all," Luz hissed. "You used me."

Catra shrugged one shoulder. "We both got back alive, and got commendations. Heck, Hordak even gave you a chance to look at his machines."

Luz flushed. "I-I don't…"

"I thought getting back home was all that mattered to you. What do *you* care if we win or the Princesses win? Once you're gone, you have your own people to beat, your own wars to win. Belos, right?" Catra's finger slid back up again, rubbing along Luz's lips. "That actually makes you the best friend I can possibly have, right now. I don't have to worry about you trying to grab my spot."

Luz's cheeks burned. "*Vete al infierno gatita,"* she hissed, then turned, planning to stalk from the room. Catra grinned behind her.

"What did that mean?" she asked. "It sounded pretty."

Luz paused at the door. Her hand trembled at the door out of the locker room – her finger resting right above the door opening button. A tiny part of her knew that if she stayed in this room, she would do something she regretted. She was so...angry and frustrated and...Catra's eyes were so beautiful and deep, her body so lithe and toned and perfect, her features so compelling. Her voice was so husky and perfect, listening to it sent tingling sparks along her spine.

And…

And Amity was worlds away.

Luz clenched her hand.

Stringbean quivered in her pocket. They slipped out and their mind-speech was clear, even though Palsimans didn't quite use *words*. Run. Leave. Now. Now. Luz's eyes flicked to the door – and in the shining metal of it, she saw Catra looking at her, confident. Cocky. Victorious.

Luz turned back. Catra watched her intently.

Stringbean flitted back into her pocket, mewing softly.

Luz lifted her chin, glaring right at her. “It means go to...to Heck. Kitten.”

“Kitten?” Catra snorted. “What are you, Scorpia?”

“If I was Scorpia-” Luz started, then didn’t even know where she was going with it. “No, I don’t need to be a Scorpia to tell you!” She started forward. “You’re...a cruel and manipulative and slimy scum piece of...manipulative…” Catra slipped back – not giving ground as in retreating, but instead like a cat drawing her paw back, claws extended, glittering fiercely. Her hair pillowed against the lockers as Luz put her hands to either side of her head.

“You already said manipulative, Noceda,” Catra said, sneering.

“S-Shut up,” Luz hissed.

“Make me.”

Luz leaned in and kissed her.

Her mouth smothered Catra, and the purr that thrummed through her made Luz feel heady. This was so wrong. She could still pull

away. Catra's hands slid along her back, down to her hips. She gripped onto her, holding her firmly in place as her tongue – rough and textured, but far from unpleasant – pressed against her tongue. Catra kissed her back, and she did so...rather inelegantly. Luz had a momentary, hazy realization that she was actually better at kissing than Catra, but then it was overwhelmed by the raw, tactile sensation of body pressing to body. Catra was so perfect and warm, and the buzzing of her purr thrummed through Luz's skeleton. Luz couldn't so much think as react. Her arms snaked around Catra's back, drawing her in close. One hand dipped down, caressing along the underside of Catra's tail, scooping it up against the small of her back, while her hand cradled the back of Catra's head, fingers sinking into her wild mane of hair.

The only thing that hurt the raw physicality of the moment was the blunt bump of warm metal against Luz's brow.

She broke the kiss, gasping – and her left hand hooked on Catra's headdress, yanked it off and tossed it aside. It rang loudly as Catra chuckled – then squeaked as Luz leaned in.

Kissing is so nice, Luz thought, her head hazy and her thoughts tumbling through her head. *It's fine if it's just...kissing.*

Catra broke the kiss, gasping softly. "I haven't celebrated a mission like this...in...ah, ever."

"Ever?"

"Long time, I mean," Catra said, and her cheeks heated just a bit, turning red under Luz's gaze. Luz nodded – and shivered as one of Catra's fingers hooked against the collar of her nice suit. She tugged down, not using her claw, just her finger and her strength. A button popped free. Then another. And another. And with each one, Luz felt herself sliding deeper and faster down a slope she knew she'd never ever be able to climb out of. Her skin felt like it was on fire and she couldn't look away from Catra's fierce, glittering eyes.

Her shirt slumped off her shoulders. Catra teased it down and Luz shuddered as the fabric breathed along her arms. Her nipples were achingly hard and jutting. One of the advantages of her relatively modest figure? She could go without a bra…

"Catra…" she whispered as Catra leaned in, kissing her throat. Her fingers started to peel Luz's belt out of its loops, tossing it aside. The touch of her burning hot skin against Luz's skin was addictive, like a drug. And her *purring*. She thrummed, the cat-girl's entire body thrummed. Luz's eyes half closed as she buried her face against the wild mane of her hair, then started to tug at Catra's outfit. Finding a place to peel and pull apart her clothing was tricky...but then she found the zipper at the nape of Catra's neck. She tugged down, reveling in the rough burring noise of the zipper – nearly as loud as Catra's thrum. Catra wriggled and their breasts pressed together as Catra went in for another kiss. This one was fierce enough to send Luz stumbling backwards, crashing into a low desk that was normally used to field strip shock sticks and energy blasters. Several of them clattered to the ground as Luz fumbled at it, her right hand cradling the back of Catra's neck, her left squeezing the hard metal of the table, fingernails biting against the metal to simply...center her. When Catra broke the kiss, both of them were gasping softly.

“D-Damn, Noceda, you’re...pretty decent at kissing,” Catra whispered.

“Screw you,” Luz hissed.

“That’s the idea, isn’t it?” Catra grinned, then pushed. Luz squeaked and her shoulders knocked off more of the tools. A screwdriver rolled away, metal tinkling against the ground, as Catra crawled onto the table, which shifted under her weight. Her mouth closed around one of Luz’s nipples and she sucked, greedily, on her. Luz’s back arched and she sighed, softly. The feeling of another woman’s lips on her, after...after…

God, how long has it even been?

It felt like years. It might have been as little as three days. It all depended on how long that timeless fall through the World Between Worlds was, how long she had been knocked out by Ronnie, how long...how far…

She moaned as Catra’s warm, wet mouth kissed to her other breast, and her fingers pressed between her thighs. Luz still had her pants on, but Catra rubbed between her thighs, touching Luz and making her hips rock in time with the movement of her fingers. Catra broke the kiss, panting softly. “D-Dang, you’re soaked through your pants…” she chuckled. “I get you this wound up, huh?”

“You’re a real...ah…” Luz gasped as Catra snaked her hand under the hem of her pants. Now, her fingers – her claws carefully retracted, teased through the thin snarl of Luz’s pubic hair and to her sex. She pushed into her, then crooked her fingers and Luz bit her lip, hard.

Kisser, Catra may have been new at.

But she had definitely done this before – either to herself or...or…

Catra added a third finger and started to *finger fuck* Luz with a wild abandon, her whole hand moving with her thrusting fingers. Luz reached up, grabbing onto the edge of the table. She rocked her hips and gasped softly. Another energy blaster smashed to the floor as the table shifted under her, just enough movement that she should have been worried, should have thought of it...should have thought about all the reasons this was stupid. Even if Luz hadn’t been dating Amity – and a tiny part of her couldn’t forget it – this would have been the *worst* decision she had *ever* made.

That was what made it so very embarrassing that, within a few short minutes, she was arching her back, screaming. “Catra! Catra! Oh! Catra!” She gasped and trembled, her sex clenching on those fingers, spurting against Catra’s palm. Catra shucked Luz’s pants off, letting them puddle on the floor as Luz quivered on the table.

“Mmm, nice…” Catra held up her fingers, admiring her glittering fingers. “You were damn eager for that, weren’t you?”

Luz panted, softly.

This was stupid. But you can stop it now.

“Who said we were over, *gata*?”

You can stop now.

Luz stood.

You can...

Catra’s back slapped against tile as warm water cascaded down them and Luz devoured her mouth, her hands sliding along her flanks. The showers were theirs alone, the water turned to a heat that was almost painful. Steam fogged as Catra’s palms grabbed onto Luz’s buttocks. Luz pinned her illicit lover against the wall, then began to kiss her down along her body. She licked the scars and the tiger-stripes, nuzzling her.

“Ah...mmm…”

"You're perfect," Luz whispered, softly. "Perfect." She licked the sleek muscles of Catra's belly, then buried her face in the wild mane that Catra cultivated between her thighs. The thick feminine scent of her was like a drug, shooting straight down Luz's spine as she started to *devour* Catra's sex. Catra's breath came short, sharp, and shocked as her clawed hands scrabbled. One grabbed onto one of the metal railings that separated shower stall from shower stall. The other simply bit between ceramic tiles as she spread her thighs in shock. Luz licked and licked and licked, cradling Catra's ass, holding her up as if she was a chalice to drink from.

Catra's face, invisible to Luz, went through a string of shocked expressions – smugness wiped away into pleasure, pleasure into release, her eyes closing, her back arching, her tail slashing. Her ears pinned back against her head and she quivered, reaching down to grip onto Luz's head, holding her in place as she came – and crested, shot up, crested again. Her pleasure burst between her thighs again and still, Luz used every trick she had been taught to coax her higher, hotter, fiercer.

When Luz pulled back, her voice dazed, Catra was looking deeply shaken.

"Crikey…" Luz whispered.

"Huh?"

"N-Nothing," Luz whispered. Her cheeks burned. Shame filled her. She wanted to stand and run – but instead, the shower water turned down and Catra slid down the wall. She laid Luz onto her back on the warm, wet floor of the shower, pinning her there. She kissed Luz – but there was a faintly different energy to the touch. Luz's eyes closed and Catra's eyes closed.

In the shower, it was so warm…

So wet.

So slick.

So slippery.

So humid that there was no chance at all for Luz to see the glittering tears, tracking down Catra's cheeks.

***

Luz knew, deep in her belly, that she should have slept in an entirely different barracks.

Catra, instead, was sprawled against her, arm over her chest, face buried against her neck. Luz wanted to feel worse. She wanted to

feel low and stupid and cowardly. But the sheer wallowing physical *nowness* of having a warm, beautiful girl in her arms...it was...after the day she had had, it felt like a balm to her soul. She tried to think of...of what she could possibly say to Amity, or Eda, or her mom. No words seemed even slightly able to cover what she had done.

But...I was alone and...scared and…

Stringbean floated slowly into view, writhing into the air like, well, like a little snake. Their eyes were soft and...not even judgmental. That was the worst thing. Luz could have taken judgmental, she deserved judgmental. Instead, Stringbean looked worried.

"I-I can fix this…" Luz whispered.

"Mmm…" Catra murmured, shifting against her, burrowing in deeper. Then she squirmed, kicking one leg. "Mmn…"

Luz and Stringbean were very quiet, very still.

"Mm no…" Catra shook her head. "No, I...I didn't...sneak around…" She squirmed, then started to wriggle more. Her hand pawed at Luz – and Luz drew her in closer. She held the slender catgirl against her chest, burying her face against her mane. Catra kept trembling, and mumbled something under her breath. "No, mom, please, no…"

Luz closed her eyes.

"Hey, little *gata* girl…" she said, her voice as gentle as she could make it. "It's all okay. It's all okay. I'm here. I'm here." Her hand slid up and down her back, up and down. Up. And down. And Catra started to slowly relax into her. The soft mumbling became a quiet purr – rumbling through Luz. Stringbean flitted down around her face, then settled onto Catra's head, resting there. Luz blushed, then looked down at Catra.

Asleep, with her anger smoothed away, with her pain eased, she was just…

She was just...

Oh no, Luz thought, her heart thundering in her chest. *Oh no, it wasn't just sex was it, no, it was, it was.*

Stringbean looked at her – and this time, she looked exasperated. The mental rebuff was gentle and playful. Luz scowled at Stringbean, then whispered.

"I think Amity will be even madder if it's a *love* thing than a *lust* thing!" she said. "Why are you more judgey of the *get home* plan than the *screw cute girl* plan!?"

Stringbean squeaked, amused. Then...less amused. The images that flicked through her eyes were of the portal device, and Luz standing beside it...wearing the shining pin of a Force Captain uniform, her back straight, her chin lifted, her eyes steely.

Luz's cheeks burned.

"E-Even if I have to go that far," she whispered. "I just need to get home, then I can fix it."

Her hand slid up and down Catra's back as Catra cuddled her.

"I can…"

She laid back.

"I can…"

She closed her eyes.

Stringbean snuggled against her, and Catra's purring took a horribly long time to lull her to sleep.

Luz Noceda Helps Out

Chapter Summary

> Luz decides to try and fix the Glimmer situation. Catra makes a rational, logically motivated decision.

Luz woke from a dream of liquid warmth and cuddling to the sensation of an entire catgirl sprawling across her body, curling up and then making a soft mumbling noise. Also, pain! Pain in her wrist! Luz blinked and since moving would wake Catra, and Luz would rather be ripped apart by slavering handbeasts than wake any girl who was using her as a mattress, she simply remained very still until she was certain she could lift her hand up to see why her wrist hurt.

Stringbean looked a little apologetic and bumped at the small dimple he had left on her skin.

"S'fine!" Luz breathed under her breath. It was actually not fine, she felt as groggy as a pirate on labor day. Her brow furrowed at her Palisman as she tried to communicate silently 'why did you wake me up at this ungodly hour of the morning?' – and her Palisman communicated back equally as silently, by shapeshifting into a perfect replica of the curvy, pink haired girl from the Princess Prom.

Glimmer.

One of Catra's prisoners.

Oooh, Luz realized.

It was here where the fact she was a girlfriend came in handy. Not only was she better at kissing than Catra, she was also more adept at handling the intricacies of bodies in bed. Specifically, Luz had once needed to slowly wriggle out of Amity's grasp so she could get her hot loco and breakfast of spiced snails and kam. She started by wriggling a bit here. Gently shifting there. And to her surprise, Stringbean didn't just immediately spring to help, she actually shifted her shape into a tiny version of those crank-powered flat topped unfolding ladder things that people used to get up to tall places. With their efforts combined, Catra was gently shifted off Luz's chest and belly and onto the bed. Luz then tugged the blankets atop her, petted her head six or seven times, then kissed her cheek.

Not that she was in love with Catra. Luz's cheeks burned as she started to sneak away from the bed and towards the open door of the barracks, past sleeping teens. Definitely! Totally! Absolutely not in love with Catra. Not even a little bit! Luz kissed many arch-villains on the cheek. Like...uh…

Luz stepped into the corridors, still wearing her Evil Horde issued PJs, and peeked up and down the corridor. No guards. Stringbean flitted out to hover before her nose, wriggling happily, then turned into a shockstick. Luz caught him as he dropped from the air, then twirled her Palisman cum melee weapon. "Huh!" she said. "...can you do the sparky?"

Stringbean, obligingly, sparked and hissed from the tip of her new shockstick body.

“Wow, Stringbean, you are just...the best Palisman,” Luz whispered, hanging Stringbean from her hip, where she could be nice and unnoticeable. She padded down the corridor, her heart in her throat, peeking around each cross corridor as she made her way from the barracks, to the mess hall. There, she saw some burly, squiddy looking fellows cooking up the breakfast the cadets were going to be eating. The smell caused her belly to gurgle, but Luz wasn’t sure if it was hunger or fear. She crept past, then entered into one of the connecting mazes that ran between the factories, foundries and laboratories. But where were the *prisons*?

“You got another load of food for Shadow Weaver?”

“Her and her guest.”

“Poor kid…”

Luz’s ears perked and she peeked around the corner, seeing two of the helmeted guards that made up the masses of the Horde shaking their heads – one of them was pushing a tray covered in foodstuffs. There was fancy food, and there were bricks of ration bars. Luz was fairly sure who’d get which. She darted from corner to pipe, her back pressed against it, as the two guards split up, one of them heading down a northern corridor, the one with the tray heading down south. She snuck after him, her heart in her throat, wishing she had Gus with her. Or Amity. Or Eda. Or...anyone, really. No, wait, why wish Gus was here, when she could instead wish she was with Gus.

I miss my friends, Luz thought, while Stringbean bumped against her hip as comfortingly as a trumped up cattle prod could manage to be.

The guard got onto an elevator. Luz weighed running into the elevator and bashing him with the shock stick...but then she spotted something *else*.

"Oh ho ho ho!" Luz whispered to herself.

The elevator doors closed and she sprinted for the largely marked door next to it. The language and letters weren't English, or Spanish, or the Belosian script of the Boiling Isles, but Luz had seen enough emergency exits in her life to recognize the type. And lo, her supposition was rewarded with stairs. Lots and lots and lots of stairs. She started to take them five at a time, bounding up the stairs, her heart pounding. If she hadn't spent so long in the Boiling Isles, working on her own body, she was pretty sure she would have literally died most of the way up the stairs. Instead, she merely kind of wished she was dead. She came to the highest level, opening the door and peeking out – and there was the guard, trundling his trays down a corridor about twenty feet away. He took a corner and Luz breathed a sigh of relief.

"Made…" She gasped several times. "It!"

Peeking around that corner, she saw the guard shoving the tray into a room, then turning and walking away, shaking his head. An angry voice floated after him. "When I get out of this stupid-" The door shut automatically and Luz smooshed herself against the wall

as the guard came around the corner and walked past her without even noticing.

Hah! She thought, and Stringbean turned into a hovering palm with a twinkle of magic. Luz laid her palm down low and Stringbean gave her a whole high five, then turned back into a shockstock. Luz padded to the door, then tried the key-lock.

It was locked.

"Auh!" Luz hissed, then frowned, holding up Stringbean. "Stringo, can you...uh, become an optical cable attached to a camera, like in that TV show? The one with the cops?" She couldn't remember which show with cops she was thinking of, but how many cop shows could there be? Stringbean chirruped and quivered in her hands, then turned into a narrow cable with a kind of gun-handle device with a screen mounted on it. Luz's smile was so big that she nearly forgot she was trapped in a terrifying alternate universe mostly ruled by an Evil Horde.

"Have I mentioned?" she whispered, threading the optical cable under the table. "You're the best shapeshifter ever?"

Optical camera cables could not, as a rule, speak. Somehow, Luz still felt as if Stringbean was quite proud of themselves.

The camera came on and she twiddled the cable left and right.

There was the Black Garnet. There was a floating orb of glittering energy that held Glimmer – naturally, where else to hold a captive princess but an orb? – and there was *no* sign of Shadow Weaver. She grinned. "Now, how to get the-" The view cut off. She blinked, then frowned at the handheld device, but before Luz could ask Stringbean 'yo what the dealio', the door opened, revealing that the cable had grown a hand and slapped the door open on the inside. Luz beamed even brighter as Stringbean turned into his little snake form, allowing her to hug them as tightly as possible.

"Whose there!?" Glimmer asked, her voice sounding fierce. "Come over here, let me...frigging punch you!"

"It's me! Luz!" Luz said, pocketing Stringbean and hurrying around to Glimmer.

Glimmer shot her one of those murderous death glares that Luz was sadly getting used to getting.

"You," she hissed.

"I can explain!" Luz whispered, hurriedly. "But, trust me, I am here to help!" She looked around the room, eyes flicking from console to console, trying to find something, anything, that looked like a big off switch. Ah! Power cables. There were thick, huge power cables running along the floor. They were also arranged like spaghetti – cables twined under and over one another, spilling out

in all directions. Some were plugged into the wall, some into the Black Garnet's ominous technological cage, some into the device projecting Glimmer's bubble.

Before Luz could even start complaining about the cable situation, Glimmer...shimmered. She buzzed, crackled, and turned into a haze of pink sparkles, which slammed into the orb, which distended outwards like someone had punched it with a fist made of glitter. Luz yelped and sprang backwards, almost tripping over a cable as Glimmer re-cohered into her curvaceous self. Luz blinked several times. "D-did you do that, or did the orb do that?"

"I'm going to punch you...so hard!" Glimmer said, angrily. "I saw how Adora was looking after you showed up – you and Catra planned this, didn't you?"

"No! Well, yes, I mean, Catra planned it, I was more of an unwilling participant," Luz said.

"Didn't look unwilling!"

"Well, looks can be deceptive! I'm actually trying to defeat the horde. Well, kidna, I want to go home, but, like-"

"Riiight, back to the First Ones," Glimmer said, rolling her eyes. "Maybe you should pick more believable lies."

“Well, that was a lie!”

“I knew it!” Glimmer growled – and again, she turned into sparkles and flew at the orb. Luz blinked, slowly, cocking her head. As the orb twisted out of shape, there was a crackle of sparks and a sudden pattern that she saw, for just a second. Glimmer’s straining efforts lasted longer – long enough for Luz to be fairly sure she had gotten the shape of the rune down – but when they lapsed, Glimmer looked completely exhausted, her body sagging as she re-cohered. She panted. “What are you here to do? Gloat? Try and get more information from me?”

“No, I’m here to get you out,” Luz said, her voice determined. “Hold still!”

She knelt down, then tugged out Stringbean – and Stringbean, bless their heart – had picked the exact right form.

A pen!

Luz began to scrawl the circular diagram of the rune, her tongue jutting from the side of her mouth as she thought, her brain flicking around everything she knew about runes...and not just runes, but how they operated. If these runes were just a different alphabet, then she was in luck. She could just swap out one set of symbols for effects. But if they used an entirely different grammar...well, then she’d need to do some more experimentation. The shaping she had created on her few Black Garnet Blast Runes (tm, patent pending) had been very similar to the shaping she had used back in the Owl House...but…the

interaction between *two* runes was always where things started to get complex, and exponentially more so when-

"Noceda!"

Luz jerked her head up, blinking at Glimmer, who was glaring at her, as if she had been saying her name a lot.

"Huh?" Luz asked.

"What are you doing!?" Glimmer asked.

"Getting you out, with...this!" Luz said, then slapped her palm on the runes. They glowed, shimmered, sparked. There was a whirring noise and the orb started to pull outwards, as if hands were grabbing onto every corner of it and tugging outwards, pulling, straining. The orb grew thinner, more frayed, and Glimmer looked completely shocked. The orb reached the outermost edges of the pressure – and then the runes cracked. They hissed, fizzled, and burned up and Luz yelped and sprang to her feet. "Ah! Dang!"

The orb snapped back and slapped Glimmer – who had stood for a moment – back onto her rump.

"Y...You almost had it?" she asked.

“I think so!” Luz said. “The power exchange grammar on the Garnet Runestone and your runestone feeds into one another like I thought, bu the limiter effect is way lower...it may be because there’s no Titan blood to facilitate the flow of magic…”

Glimmer blinked at her. “Huh?” she asked.

“Well, okay, your runestones are-” Luz froze. “...wait, no, that doesn’t make sense, there has to be a magical facilitator.” She started to pace back and forth, then drew in a huge gasp. “There magic is being shunted elsewhere! I hit the cap on the power draw for non-priority features and that’s why the spell failed, the Titan never had that limiter, but that means, there is a magical flow on this world, and that it is being tapped for something! But...what?” She bit her lower lip. “Do you know if this world is built out of the body of an ancient dead god, or…?”

“Remarkable.”

Luz nodded. “Yeah, it is, bu-” She froze, then spun around, gaping up at Shadow Weaver, who loomed in the doorway.

“Do you not remember what I said, last time you drew on my power?” Shadow Weaver hissed.

“Uh…” Luz said, hesitantly, stepping back.

“And what, precisely, were you trying to *do* with the Princess?”

Those white on white eyes narrowed to slits.

"She was trying to get me to talk! But I told her, I'd never talk!" Glimmer said.

"Hmm," Shadow Weaver said. "There are better ways to...determine this."

Luz tensed, readying to grab for Stringbean – but he had rolled away when she had dropped him, and in his pen form, there was not a lot he could do. She sprang...and froze mid motion. Her knees crashed into the ground as red lightning crawled along her skin, then up to her ears, into her eyes. She clenched her jaw as pain lanced along her body while Shadow Weaver looked down at her, her voice soft. "Lets see…" She clenched her hand and Luz felt the spikes of pain reaching into her mind – and thoughts began to open, one after the other, like boxes being yanked apart by fingers made of knives. Tumbling from them came images. Catra's eyes, the warmth of her hand, the soft rumble of her purr.

No. That's not yours! Stop!

Luz's voice felt like it rebounded inside of her head, uselessly. The images flicked before her mind's eye again – one after the other, as if Shadow Weaver was perusing them in detail. She let out a quiet scoff. "Oh my *Goodness*." She waved her hand and the red lightning faded, leaving Luz gasping and sagging. "You think that you're in love with that pathetic creature? That manipulative, sneaking, crawling useless waste of flesh?" Shadow Weaver shook her head. "You don't know Catra like I do. She's lying to you.

She's *using* you. The only emotion that she has in her heart is for herself – and she will happily shove you onto Beast Island if it gets her one inch closer to *winning*."

Luz panted. "You're...ah...her *Mom*…" She growled. "Where'd she learn that from?"

"Catra was an annoying parasite attached to my project. The only reason she's even alive now is because she chose the right person to cling too," Shadow Weaver said. "Now...you are Catra's lover, and her cat's paw, and her dupe. But what was that under there…" The red pain came back – and Luz knew that the knife-claws were coming for deeper memories and thoughts.

For plans.

For her goal.

For her *escape*.

She clenched her teeth and threw every iota of her willpower against the magic. That worked.

Unfortunately, it also *hurt*. It hurt a lot. Luz clenched her teeth even harder, her eyes screwing shut. The pain increased, ratcheting up and up. Faintly, Luz could hear Glimmer shouting. "Leave her alone, Shadow Weaver! Stop!"

"I will rip your mind apart to get what I want, human!" Shadow Weaver hissed.

Luz screamed. She couldn't help it. It was a scream unlike anything noise she had ever made before in her life.

"*Let her go!"*

The pain cut off so intensely that Luz nearly fainted. She fell to the side, gasping, as she saw a blurr shooting from the darkness. Shadow Weaver lashed out – a bolt of lightning crashing into the wall, exploding with a flare of heat. Her eyes started to drag closed, her body screaming at her to embrace unconsciousness, to just stop existing, to be away from the pain of it all.

The last thing Luz Noceda saw was Catra's claws slashing into Shadow Weaver's mask, which shattered in a spray of red and glittering sparks.

Those sparks remained hanging in her vision as her eyes closed, dimming one by one.

Then, nothing.

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Luz's eyes opened, inch by inch. They felt as if they had been weighed down by stones, and that every single motion of her face – and just her face – was a titanic impossibility. Her arms were stones, and even breathing felt difficult. Through the thin slits of her eyes, she could see a curious looking face peering down at her. Red goggles, bright purple hair, and a welder's mask. Luz opened her eyes even wider, a jolt of adrenaline hitting her like a spike.

The girl flipped the mask back.

Revealing...

"So, the gravitic imploder lance that you said your ship used," Entrapta said, her voice cheerful and a bit shrill in Luz's pounding head. "Was the basis the same as artificial gravity technology, using a 5th space, 3rd space interaction effect?"

"Buhh…" Luz groaned. Slowly, life was beginning to tease into her arms. She sat up as much as she could and saw that she was in a sparse, utilitarian cot, in a sparse utilitarian room, with a sparse, utilitarian blanket. There was also two teddy bears, and something akin to a cake on a small plate on a tray that could be extended over her bed. The cake had been formed, she thought, out of ration bars, with a scrawled message on it.

GET BETR SOON

L, R, K

+C

(we made her sign this, K)

Luz blinked slowly.

"Um...wait!" Entrapta said. "Are you suffering from brain damage? You have been unconscious for two weeks."

"Two *what*!?" Luz exclaimed.

"Two weeks," Entrapta said. "They thought you might die for a little bit there. Lots of neurological damage, but it's all magical damage, and that stuff heals pretty quickly." She paused. "Sometimes."

Luz thumped back into her bed and blinked up at the ceiling.

Then she jerked back up again. "Wait, what are *you* doing here?"

"Well, after Adora decided that it was time to rescue Glimmer, I was given an objective!" Entrapta said.

"And it was?" Luz asked.

Entrapta opened her mouth, closed it, held up her finger. She then started to pat down her pockets, then frowned and took out a notepad. She flipped through it several times, narrowing her eyes. “I was to disable the alarm systems so that the rest of the team could get into Glimmer’s holding cell!” she said, brightly.

“...did you?” Luz asked.

“Yes!” Entrapta said. “Then I met...her.” Her eyes sparkled. “She was so beautiful and fascinating and perfect.”

Oh my god, Catra, you didn’t, Luz thought. “...and?” She asked, hesitantly.

“Well, I immediately had to get inside of her!” Entrapta said, cheerfully. “Really rearrange her insides!”

Oh my god, Entrapta! Luz slowly put her hands over her face.

“Oh, actually, let me show you!” Entrapta stood.

“No, uh, yes, I mean, uh, that is-” Luz’s voice, muffled by her hands, did not stop Entrapta as she gestured to the door, which opened, revealing an annoyed looking Catra.

Luz's entire face exploded into flames. At least that was how it was feeling. Catra walked in, then scowled at Entrapta. "I told you to stop looming over ...Noceda." She said, the pause fractional but noticeable, her ears pinning back against her head. Then a spherical bot, similar to the one that had nearly taken Luz's head off in training, came skittering into the room.

"This is Emily," Entrapta said, throwing her arms around the robot. "I met her right after the team got here, and reprogrammed her to do everything my old bots did, but better."

Luz blinked. "...oooooooooooooooooooh!" she said.

"Luz!?" Catra shoved Emily and Entrapta aside with a crash of metal and a squall of shock from the purple haired girl. She grabbed onto the edges of the bed, then leaned in, mashing her face against Luz's face, her brow and Luz's brow bumping together. "Luz, are you okay? Can you still speak? Do you have brain damage?" She grabbed onto Luz's face, tugging her eye wider, presumably to check to see if she had any of the signs of concussion.

"Gauh! No! I don't girl brain my you cat have damage!" Luz exclaimed, proximity to Catra and her prior confusion working together to produce similar effects as to a clot in the language centers of her brain.

"Hmm, seems terminal," Entrapta said. "I can do the autopsy, if you want."

"No! *No me hagas cirugía cerebral,* I'm fine, absolutely *moy buena!"* Luz said.

"Her linguistics are definitely running into issues, she's speaking total gibberish," Entrapta said.

"No, it's just another language," Catra said, sounding annoyed.

"Oooh!" Entrapta said. "Etheria has had one language for so long, I never considered there might be a second one, and she's not speaking First One."

Catra sighed. "Entrapta. Don't mention that to anyone else."

"Okay," Entrapta said, while Luz frowned at the two of them, then thumped back into bed. Her eyes flicked to the cake, then back to Catra. Catra didn't meet her eyes.

"So, uh," Luz said. "Was that a serious hallucination induced by intrusive magic or...did you attack Shadow Weaver for me?"

"I didn't attack her *for* you!" Catra snapped, her voice sharp. "I've been planning on taking Shadow Weaver down for ages – the fact that she was torturing Hordak's favorite new source of tech and information is just the perfect excuse. The fact she then let the

Princess get kidnapped and lost the Sword of Power is just extra spice ontop.”

“I thought you gave-”

“She lost it,” Catra said, glowering at Entrapta, who blinked at her, then shrugged.

Luz sighed. “What else did I miss?” She asked, trying to not worry about Stringbean. Stringbean was around. He was just hiding, being sneaky. Like he was *meant* to be.

“We attacked Bright Moon-”

That’s bad! Luz thought, schooling her face to hide her alarm.

“-got pushed back-”

That’s good! Luz thought, forcing her relief to stay deep in her belly.

“-but since Entrapta had joined our side, the attack we pushed through the Whispering Woods went very well-”

That's bad! Luz grabbed onto her own elbows to keep her hands from shaking.

Catra shrugged. "-then I got captured, escaped, they tried to get Entrapta back, but, heh, Entrapta chose to stay with us."

"Y-You did?" Luz asked, looking at Entrapta. "You turned on your friends?"

"Huh?" Entrapta asked. "No. My friends are fine." She looked down at her hands. "Well. I mean. I know that they don't like spending time with me. That's why they didn't really notice when I got left behind. So, it only makes sense to stay here, so I don't...um...you know…" She hesitated, then brightened. "Also, I get to look at all this amazing advanced tech!" She said, her hair lifting and spreading around her head, gesturing at the metallic walls around her. "It's so much more advanced than I was able to access back in Dryl!"

Luz whimpered. "Ohhh...OHHHH!" She waggled her arms, trying to get them around Entrapta, despite her currently noodly status. "Hug! Hugggg!" She surged half out of bed, Catra yelping.

"Whoa! Luz, don't do that!" She said, catching Luz as Luz managed to get one arm around Entrapta.

"A hug!" Entrapta said. "...why are you doing this?"

Luz managed to get her knees, which quivered and felt like

columns of water, under her. Her feet were mostly dragging on the floor as Catra kept her upright with her tight, corded strength. With this upright stance, Luz managed to get her arms more firmly around Entrapta. “I’m your friend, and so is Catra!”

“I know!” Entrapta said, confused. “That’s why I’m here?”

Catra tugged Luz back and away from Entrapta. “Entrapta, go back to working on bots,” she said. “I need to talk with Noceda.”

“Okay!” Entrapta said. “Remember, we should really talk about the imploder lance later.”

“Right!” Luz said, then sighed. “She is going to be so crushed…” she said, when the door shut. “When I have to tell her I think the imploder lancer is just something *Cosmic Frontiers* stole from the Torlandeier series.”

Catra blinked at her.

“Jiles Torlandeier?” Luz asked.

Catra cocked her head.

“Well, okay, so, there’s this planet called Torriar,” Luz said, holding her hands up, palms facing one another. “It was colonized by

humans from Earth, but then the wormhole back to Earth was collapsed by a stellar accident and everyone in Torriar was trapped there, and their technology reverted back to knights and swords! Because they were exposed to so much space rays, they had lots of mutants, so they have this huge prejudice against mutants, but Jiles, get this, he was exposed to this poison gas when he was in his mother's womb and-"

Catra grabbed onto Luz and kissed her.

Luz, whose body was made of 90% noodle by weight, found that there was a way for her to get more noodly. The answer was lesbians. Her body sagged and Catra took her down with her. The two of them missed the cot, and Luz found that the floor was actually about *as* comfortable as the bed she had been left to recover in. She blinked as Catra pulled away from her, hands on her cheeks, claw tips dimpling her skin, leaving her tingling all over.

"You are so stupid," Catra whispered.

"H-Heh…" Luz said.

Catra hesitated, then cocked her head. "Were you there to free Glimmer?"

Lie. Lie. Immediately. Lie. Tell a lie. Luz thought, her brain screaming at her. She had to lie because if she told the

truth...Catra would hate her. Catra would kick her out of the Horde. Heck, Catra would rip her throat out.

"Yes," Luz whispered.

Catra pursed her lips. Her face went through a remarkable array of emotions and none of them were easy for Luz to read – because reading her emotions would involve thinking past the screaming panic in her head. But then Catra punched her shoulder.

"Dummy," she said.

"D-Dummy?" Luz asked. "That's what I get? For trying to…"

"For what? Trying to betray the Horde?" Catra shook her head. "Glimmer was just a...tool to get us at Bright Moon. Her leaving then would still leave us with Bow." She looked aside. "Besides, Shadow Weaver would have looked bad, if she had let her escape. You kinda gave me a win win. I mean, anyone could see it like that."

Luz flushed. She wasn't sure if that made sense, actually. She opened her mouth – then yanked herself back with a mental jerk of the wheel. Her own brain screamed at her: *Are you trying to convince the evil catgirl to decide you* did *betray her*?

Shadow Weavers words echoed in her head.

You don't know Catra like I do. She's lying to you. She's using *you. The only emotion that she has in her heart is for herself – and she will happily shove you onto Beast Island if it gets her one inch closer to* winning*.*

Was that true?

What game was Catra playing?

Or…

Or was it even scarier.

Had Catra decided that Luz was more important to her than winning? But how the frick could that have happened? They hadn't known each other that long. But...Luz put her hand up against Catra's cheek, fingers brushing gently against her.

"You're not mad?" she asked.

Catra snorted. "I'm still winning," she said. "Why would I be mad?"

She leaned in, kissing Luz again. The kiss tasted bittersweet, like biting into the darkest, darkest chocolate. Luz wanted to push Catra away, to try and untangle her words and her feelings...but it felt too good to just lean into her warmth. And then Catra started to *purr*. Luz tilted her head to the side, slouching her body against Catra's. Catra actually allowed herself to lay back, and the two ended up completely on the floor – Catra on her back, Luz keeping herself up through sheer strength of will, her arms quivering as she kissed her and kissed her and kissed her.

Catra pushed her back, panting. "W-We should, uh...get to work. Lots to do."

Luz nodded.

Catra hesitated for a moment.

"You can't get up without my help, can you?"

"No, please help."

Catra's grin was lopsided.

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Luz rubbed her chin as she looked at the guts of the machine that Hordak had presented to her. In some nightmares, back before she had gone to a cool school with ghouls and witchcraft, she had dreamed about standing up before a class and have to give a presentation on something she had never even heard before. Also, her mom was there, and she was naked, and she could only speak Spanish and everyone was a racist, and the Principle was actually the Grim Reaper, and usually, by the end, Dad was alive again but also, dying, so she'd wake up feeling underprepared and like she wanted to cry.

In the hour long terrifying lead up to standing before this machine, she had felt like that nightmare become reality.

And now…

Giddy relief. Dizzy fall over in a faint with pure overwhelming joy at the tension being released.

The machine wasn't just sensible...it was *obvious*.

It was the same frigging magitech as her ding dang portal generator! The one she had built with Eda and King! That ran on a bike machine and a droplet of Titan's Blood. It was the same set of rune assemblages and energy channels. Yes, Hordak had 'machined components' and 'didn't have to use a leaf blower' and 'had safety margins' so the device 'wouldn't catastrophically explode' or 'turn into a magiquantum singularity' and 'destroy the world.' She rolled her eyes internally. As if that made him special…

“Yeah, I know your issues,” Luz said, nodding. “You need a power source. Something that can channel a pretty big chunk of magical energies through this conduit.” She gestured with one hand. “The Black Garnet-”

“We don’t use *magic*,” Hordak said, his bilious red eyes narrowing.

Luz frowned, slightly. “Okay, fine, the quantum waveform.” She nodded. “Whatever you want to call it, you need the power source. Have you tapped the Black Garnet for this?”

“Yes,” he said, scowling. “It hasn’t been enough.”

“Let me guess!” Luz said, snapping her fingers. “It’s because-”

“The power is being withdrawn into an unknown channel!”

She and the other voice spoke the same words in the same cadence. Luz and Hordak jerked their heads around to find Entrapta was dangling from some pipes in his cavernous laboratory, her eyes shining with excitement. Hordak gave a fierce scowl, clearly about to upbraid Entrapta for breaking in – but before he could, Luz gasped, then said.

“I noticed the exact same thing with my rune magic!” she said. “I wonder why intuitive spellcasters don’t notice it...unless-”

“Their magical power comes from their own life force, offsetting the channeling!” Entrapta and Luz said at the same time, Entrapta dropping down. Luz grabbed her hands, bouncing excitedly, the two of them looking into one another’s eyes.

“The channel has to exist somewhere in the substrate of the planet!” Luz started.

“It has to be big enough to be visible!” Entrapta said. “The First One Ruins across the planet – what if they’re not discrete structures! What if-”

“-the planet is-”

“A magical megastructure!” Entrapta and Luz finished at the same time. Luz released her and started to walk in circles, her eyes blazing.

“It’s like...what if you wanted to mimic the oomph of a Titan-”

“Titan?” Entrapta asked, cocking her head.

“-but you lacked a Titan, and so, you had to make an *artificial* one! The bones, the blood, constructed out of magitech rather

than letting natural evolution do it!" Luz said. "There has to have been natural magic here to tap into, but...yes! Yes!" She turned to face Entrapta. "It makes total sense, but can we prove it?"

"Well, of course we can," Entrapta said. "We already did."

"We did?" Hordak's voice was sharp. Entrapta smiled at him as she turned to face him.

"Yes, during the attack on Bright Moon! The data I pulled from accessing all the runestones corroborates what Luz says," she said.

"Does...this mean that Etheria's megastructure can provide the power to open a portal?" Hordak asked, his voice grave and grim in equal measures.

"Of course!" Entrapta said. "But I'll need to do some research first to determine the methods."

"We'd need to find any machinery that's broken and fix it," Luz said, nodding.

"Do so," Hordak said, gesturing with one clawed hand, then turned – his cape billowing as he stalked off, leaving the two girls standing beside one another in his lab. Luz's giddy excitement hiccuped...but no. No. If she made a portal, she could go home.

And then what portal would Hordak open next?

Luz pushed that worry away for future Luz. She'd be able to sabotage the machine, or something. She was sure of it. Stringbean, who was curled up inside of her pocket, peeked out and chirruped nervously. She smiled at Entrapta.

"He's...pretty dramatic, huh?" she asked.

"Who is he?" Entrapta asked.

"Hordak," Luz said. "You know, the leader of the Evil Horde?"

"Is that why he's named Hordak?" Entrapta asked.

"P-Probably," Luz said, blinking.

"Makes sense!" Entrapta said.

They stood together, for a long moment. Luz was thinking about everything she knew about Hordak – from what she had heard, he had come from somewhere else. A larger, more terrifying empire, something even bigger than the Fright Zone. The mental image of

a portal ripping open and a whole army that made the Fright Zone look like that hippy planet from *Cosmic Frontiers* ran through her head.

I can fix it, she thought. *I just need to build the portal machine to explode. Heck, I've even* done *that before.* She remembered one of her prouder moments, handing over the portal door to Emperor Belos, covered in fire runes with enough of a time delay that it blew apart in his hands.

"Do you think that he's entirely cybernetic?" Entrapta asked, breaking her from her reverie.

"Uh?" Luz blinked. "Maybe? I mean, probably. Well, actually, isn't cybernetic a mixture of biological and robots?"

"I was mostly thinking if he had normal genitals or not," Entrapta said.

Luz blinked slowly.

"Because he is, uh, extremely attractive," Entrapta whispered. "I wouldn't mention this to anyone else, but…" She shrugged, clearly not having words. Then, worriedly. "Y-You're not going to tell me that I am giving you too much information, like Mermista, right?"

“No, no, no, he’s *so* hot!” Luz said, holding up her palms, frowning. “Like. Wow. He’s got this really hot gothy vampire cyborg master going on here. All he needs to do is have a wine glass and go…” She mimed throwing it. “Enough talk! Have at you!”

Entrapta looked baffled.

“You know, uh, cause it’d be...drama is hot, dramatic boys are hot!” Luz said, taking Entrapta’s arm, walking with her towards the door. “W-We really need to find the machinery that’s busted so we can fix it and get Etheria working properly.”

“Let me show you the data I pulled when we attacked Bright Moon!”

Luz, nodding, followed after.

Sitting on his throne, trying to control his irritation at every delay between him and returning to the vastness of Horde Prime, Hordak listened as his Imp as the creature flapped down and began to replay the conversation between his new assets. Hordak listened, intently.

Then his brow furrowed in consternation.

“I...don’t know what any of those words meant,” he said.

The Imp made a snorting noise and Hordak scowled, lifting his fist – threatening.

The Imp flapped off, leaving the leader of the Horde alone.

Luz Noceda vs The Thing

Chapter Summary

> Luz Noceda visits the north pole. Guest starring: The Best Friend Squad!

The low humming of agrav engines and the whine of supersonic jets provided the exactly correct amount of purely awkward subliminal noise to the cabin. Luz and Scorpia sat across from one another in the not-quite silence, rocking occasionally with the juddering turbulence the flier cut through as they screamed northward from the Fight Zone and towards the polar reaches of Etheria. Luz tapped her fingers on her knees and tried to not look at Scorpia. Scorpia glowered at her. Luz tapped her fingers in another pattern, then tried to look at the ceiling above Scorpia's head. Scorpia glowered at her. Luz shifted in her seat, trying to lean on an armrest and look casual. Scorpia glowered at her.

What did I do!? Luz thought to herself. *Last time I checked, we got on like two evil houses on fire, except one of the evil houses was just pretending to be evil. And the other one...might just be mislead. I genuinely cannot tell.*

Scorpia glowered at her *more*.

"Sooooo...oooo...ooooooo…" Luz said, dragging the word out as long as she could.

The door to the cabin opened and Catra stuck her head in. "You two still alive back here?" she asked.

"*Soy una zanahoria lesbiana!"* Luz exclaimed and sprang out of her chair, tripped on her own feet, and crashed to the deck plating.

Catra's brow furrowed and she shook her head, walking over to glower down at her. "Don't act like a dummy, we're almost there," she said, sighing. "What am I gonna do with you, Noceda?" She asked, gently prodding Luz in the belly with her bare toe, before she turned and stalked from the room.

Luz flushed, her heart hammering from the Catra jump scare and her own guilty nerves. A gay carrot? Really? She had no idea where her brain even came up with these things sometimes. She remained on the floor for a long moment, but before she could say anything to Scorpia, the low whine of the turbines and the faint hum of the agrav engines shifted and her belly did flops that had nothing to do with her longterm goals and nervous guilt.

They were coming down.

She got to her feet just as the flier settled down with a creaking, crunching noise and the back of the cabin swung down, a gangplank revealing a blisteringly cold white wasteland, shrouded in arctic night and lit by glimmering aurora patterns in the sky – purples and blacks. Not for the first time did Luz hunt for stars or constellations. But this time, there was no doubt at all – the Fright Zone had enough lights on, even at night, that there was enough light pollution (the tenth worst kind of pollution in her book) that the stars might have been washed out...but…

No.

Etheria had no stars. None at all.

“Where are the stars?” Luz whispered.

“What’s a star?” Entrapta asked, curiously, as she walked down the gangplank, having emerged from the cockpit with Catra. Behind her, Scorpia grunted as she dragged the massive crate that she had loaded in the first place. They were out in a wild wilderness of ice and snow – without so much as a building in sight. Luz shivered and started to tug her Evil Horde issued jacket tighter around her body, wishing she had her hoodie. Not that her hoodie would have helped – the jacket was actually shockingly warm and threaded through with tech that could take the bite out of even more freezing weather. No, it was because it was a deeply sinister jacket. All red and black and gray. It made her look like she was actually part of the bad guys.

“Uh…” Luz said, but before she could even begin to think of where to start on what a star was, the crate was opening up and the device within came trundling out. It looked a bit like a gigantic drill bit on a circular platform, surrounded by spidery limbs – save that it was exactly that, only even bigger than Luz had thought possible. It thumped forward, twirled itself around and then dropped its drill bit into the ground and started to chunk the ice into a fine powder, spraying it up and to the sides. More bots scuttled off the shuttle as Catra tapped at her handheld tablet – frowning as wind ruffled her hair.

“All right,” she said. “The base should be up in a few hours – but we can make that faster if you get to work, minions.” She smirked, slightly.

Scorpia and Entrapta both shot Catra a look – Scorpia looking a bit hurt, Entrapta more curious. “Am I a minion?” she asked.

“Yes, Entrapta, you are a minion,” she said.

“Is Noceda a minion?” Entrapta asked.

“Yes, Noceda is also a minion,” Catra said, her cheeks darkening ever so slightly.

“Well, I kinda thought of myself more as plucky comic relief,” Luz said, putting her hand on her chest.

Scorpia muttered something under her breath – whisked away by the wind and by the grumbling of the drill. Luz felt her own stomach do a little flop despite not hearing it, and Catra ignored it: “Well, if you’re the plucky comic relief, then go and tell some jokes while you’re at it.”

Luz rubbed her chin as she turned towards the bots, who had already started to lever up the metal walls and lower into place the self-expanding foundations for the pre-fabricated base.

“Uh...knock knock!” she said, walking over to pick up one of the sealant spraying guns and start spraying sealant to caulk the thin chinks between walls shut.

No response. Scorpia had jerked her head up and opened her mouth to respond, then had pointedly turned back to her work, her shoulders stiff. Meanwhile, Entrapta hadn’t registered it was a question. Catra, meanwhile, was just looking at her is if she couldn’t believe that Luz would go with a knock knock joke to start with.

“The Aristocrats!” Luz threw out the punchline in a desperate flail.

Catra shook her head, smiling despite herself. “Noceda.”

“Yeah?”

“Get to work.”

***

The base was up, running, and the drill was still drilling, by the time Luz was finally able to sit down again and take some weight off her feet. She groaned and wiggled her toes inside of her work boots and closed her eyes as she tried to math out how long she had been in here. Not here, as in, the north pole but here as in the world of Etheria.

“Months, at least,” she muttered. “With the two week snooze, then finding this place, then convincing Hordak to come this way.”

It hit her then that...she hadn’t really sat down and *worried* about Amity, or King, or Eda, or her mom, for almost a week and a half. It had all been prepping the mission and studying Etherian technology with Entrapta and...and…

“Hey Noceda.”

The door to the break room shut with a click and Luz jerked her head up to see Catra was at the door, wearing her jacket. She had put on boots for the work, but those were off now. She liked having her feet bare, even on cold metal like this. Her eyes glittered in the semi-darkness of the pre-fabricated chamber, and Luz felt her entire body going tingling. Each time she thought to herself this was a bad idea...and each time…

Catra leaned forward and kissed her, hard. She kissed her into the chair so intensely that Luz was surprised she didn’t end up as a puddle on the metal grating. Her mouth pulled back to give Luz a chance to gasp for air like a fish – but then Catra was in for another kiss, hands on the armrests. The chair rocked back onto its hind legs and Luz let herself just wallow in the pleasure of the long, fierce kiss. When Catra pulled back again, she was thrumming with that delicious, delicious purring noise she let out when she was kissed good.

“A-Are...uh, Force Captains...allowed to, uh, smootch their underlings?” Luz asked, dazedly.

“Eh,” Catra said, shrugging one shoulder. “Who cares. It’s not like I went to Force Captain orientation to find out.”

“R-Right!” Luz said, blushing and then whispering. “S-So, uh. Uh. How long until we think we, uh, find the First One’s tech that Entrapta thinks is here?”

“Who knows,” Catra said, drawing away and shrugging. “Me? I’ve...got a few angles for this mission. Ways to make sure it all comes out right for me.” She grinned and started to pace back and forth. “You know there’s a pretty good chance that if we’re active here long enough, it might pull Adora and her friends?”

Luz nodded, her throat going dry. “Hope not.”

“Why? Scared that Adora might beat you up for being my...friend?” Catra asked, arching an eyebrow.

“N-Not quite,” Luz said, though now that Catra had mentioned it, that was an extremely normal and reasonable thing to be worried about. Triply so when said Adora was able to become a seven, eight foot tall living warrior goddess who could throw tanks around. Luz had seen the security footage. She shifted in the chair, and risked pushing herself to her feet. Fortunately, her

knees had not completely turned to water. She hesitated. “H-Have you ever considered…”

“Hmm?” Catra asked.

“Have you ever considered, like, ditching the Horde?” Luz asked, her stomach knotting. Catra gave her a funny look, her ears perking back.

“And...go where?” she asked, quietly. “The Crimson Waste? Beast Island?”

“I mean, uh, it might be nicer than the Fright Zone,” Luz said. She stepped over, then took one of Catra’s hands in hers. She slid her thumb along the back of a finger, to the tip, and very gently squeezed where Catra’s claws might snick out. Catra tensed, then shivered at the touch, while Luz murmured softly. “And then...well, you wouldn’t have to keep fighting Adora, right?”

Catra snorted, yanking her hand back. “I didn’t *start* this fight,” she said, her voice fierce. “Adora was the one who left me.”

Luz opened her mouth to respond – but then closed it. Thoughts screeched through her head.

Stupid. Stupid. If Catra leaves, then how do you get access to Hordak’s portal machines?

Then.

But if she stays…

Catra put her hand on Luz's cheek. Her voice was soft. "We're going to win, you know?" she leaned in, her forehead pressing to Luz's. "You're...like...a smarter, more practical Entrapta. You two can work together to make some First One machine that will make all the Princesses seem like nothing but sparkle and glitter." Her lips skinned back in something that was, in no way, a smile. "Then we'll see who leaves who, right?"

Luz leaned in and kissed that razor sharp expression, wanting to wipe it off Catra's face. She tilted her head and slid her hands along Catra's sides, then around to the small of her back, pulling her into the embrace as she stood up on her tip toes to make the kiss even fiercer. Catra leaned into her – and then pushed away, panting and laughing. "That's the spirit, Noceda."

"Mmm, well," Luz said, looking aside. "W-We should get to the control room."

"Or the bunk room," Catra whispered in her ear.

Luz's cheeks burned.

"It is pretty cold out there." Catra's breath was a promise of not just warmth, but of purring and pleasure and caresses.

This is a bad idea… Luz thought, again.

***

The bunk room had two beds for four girls. Two girls were missing. That left one bed, with two girls in it. Catra was laying on her back, her thighs scissored around Luz's neck and shoulders, while Luz simply feasted, her eyes closing as she lapped at Catra's sex, her tongue delving deep inside of her. Catra's claws bit into the steel wall above her head and she rocked her hips in time with Luz's eager, eager licking. Or maybe it was desperate? Luz was honestly not sure herself – was she licking so eagerly because she wanted to pleasure Catra, that she wanted to taste that tangy explosion when Catra reached one of her climaxes? Or was it desperate need to feel something other than fear and cold and paranoia?

Maybe it was both. She drank Catra down as Catra let out a yowling cry and a gasp: "Luz! Luz! Luz! Ah!"

She rocked her hips several more times, her tail lashing against the side of the bunk bed. Her legs scissored even tighter and for a heady second, Luz was a bit worried that the last thing she would ever do in this life was eat catgirl pussy.

Worth it, she thought hazily. But before her neck snapped, Catra slowly relaxed her legs, looking lazily pleased with herself as Luz pulled her mouth away from her sex, licking her lips slowly.

"Mmm, you are so *good* at that," Catra whispered, her voice husky with her cries of pleasure. Luz's smile was cockeyed as she crawled atop Catra, then slipped to the side, laying next to her. Catra's hand caressed her breast, stroking her awkwardly by crooking her arm around – and then, with no better option, Catra rolled onto her side, nose to nose to Luz. Her eyes were half closed as she slid her hand wonderingly along Luz's naked body. The biting chill of the base was beginning to creep back in – so Luz reached down, yanking the thin blanket up and above their heads, entombing both girls in warmth.

In that warm darkness, Catra's eyes seemed to practically glow. Luz could see, from the way they flicked, just where she was looking.

"You're beautiful, you know?" Catra whispered. Her hands slid along Luz's hip, up to her breasts. Her fingers found Luz's hard nipples and gently teased them, drawing a soft whine from Luz before she could stop herself.

"Shut up, *gata* girl," Luz said, laughing softly. "Ah. You're getting mushy."

"Mmm," Catra purred. In the darkness of their blankets, her mouth found one of Luz's nipples and she sucked, greedily. Her hands grabbed onto Luz's ass, drawing her in close, and the fuzz

of her hair and the twitch of one of her ears tickled Luz's nose just enough to make her giggle and squirm. Which, of course, was when the door to the bunk room opened and Scorpia's voice cut in onto the conversation.

"If you're not too busy, Force Captain, we have something."

Catra swept the blankets back and sat up, totally unconcerned with the fact she was naked and in the middle of banging a subordinate. Luz, being quite possibly the only person in the room who might have heard the term 'ethical code of conduct', squeaked and tried to cover her breasts with her arm while also hiding her face with her other hand.

"What's up?" Catra asked.

"Well, I didn't want to interrupt you," Scorpia said, her voice fully sweet – but it was sweet in a way that rang falsely to Luz's ears. "If you want, I can come back later."

"No, I'll be right there," Catra said. "Give me a second."

"Well, if you're sure?" Scorpia asked.

"Go, go," Catra said, waving her hand.

The door swung shut as the big scorpion woman stepped back out again, leaving Luz's entire face on fire and her hair smoking with pure concentrated mortifons, the particle that carries mortification. "D-Do you think she's mad?" Luz whispered.

"Nah, Scorpia's a big...what do you call that thing where you're nice to everyone?" Catra asked, her voice dry.

"A cinnamon bun," Luz provided.

"A moron," Catra grumbled.

Luz bounced from foot to foot as she tried to dress while exposing herself to as little cold floor as possible. "You shouldn't treat Scorpia like that," she said, her voice firm. "She's a hard working good egg, and butch! Butch means beautiful, if you ask me." Luz hopped again, then hopped one last time, finally getting her sock on. She glowered as Catra languidly rolled from the bed and landed, bare feet, on the floor. She smirked up at her.

"What, do you have a crush on her?" she asked, her eyes glinting.

"I-I am trying to keep my philandering down to just *one* girl, not...rack them up like I'm...uh…" Luz hesitated. "Like a...a girl collector!"

Catra snorted and stood. She prodded Luz's chest. "You know, you keep calling this cheating – but your girlfriend doesn't seem to be super keen on finding you," she said.

"It's another universe!" Luz said, stung by this indictment on Amity's character.

"You got here," Catra said, shrugging one shoulder. "I think if she's willing to let you slip through her fingers, she can't complain if you find a way better girl to shack up with." She smirked, grabbing onto Luz's ass through her leggings. Luz's cheeks burned and she gave her a playful punch to the shoulder.

"Better?"

"I mean, I am pretty awesome," Catra said, grinning with such over the top smugness, such complete confidence, that it was impossible to not burst into giggles. Luz slid her arms around Catra's neck, pressing her forehead against her, her voice soft.

"Well, I will say, getting with a catgirl has been a top ten fantasy of mine," she whispered just as playfully back. "Right under getting with an elf girl, and right above makin' it with a vampire girl."

"Damn, Noceda," Catra said, laughing softly. "And here you said you *weren't* a girl collector."

“Its different when it’s fan fiction.”

“I have no idea what that is,” Catra murmured. She leaned in and kissed Luz.

It took them, in the end, almost twenty minutes to actually get to the command and control room. Catra looked utterly unrepentant, while Luz waved and blushed and muttered a shy ‘sorry’ at the oh so chipper ‘glad you finally made it’ from Scorpia.

Entrapta hadn’t even noticed.

“So, what did you find?” Catra asked.

“A layer of substrate in the sub-glacier levels,” Entrapta said, cheerfully.

“What about that?” Luz asked, her attention drawn to a momentary waver on the screen.

“Hmm!” Entrapta swung her gaze to the left. “That appears to be a movement on the motion tracker. I wouldn’t have even noticed that – it’s too intermittent! Good eye, Luz!” She reached back with her hand, pawing at the air, until Luz helpfully slapped palm to

palm – she had taught Entrapta the move and Entrapta seemed to only partially get it.

"Wait, movement?" Catra asked. "What kind of movement?"

"Is it a horrible shapeshifting alien who can take the form of anyone it kills, who will replace us one by one as we fall into an increasing air of paranoia and terror?" Luz asked, grabbing onto the back of Entrapta's chair.

"Probably…" Entrapta said, tapping at the keyboard with her fingers and her hair, running through a series of scans and making Luz's heart clench like it had been caught in the icy hand of winter itself. "...not!"

"Oh fhew," Luz breathed.

"Noceda, Scorpia, check this out," Catra said, her voice firm. "We wanna make sure that we're not facing any major issues out there. "

"Rightio!" Luz and Scorpia said at the same time. Scorpia frowned at her, and then clicked her claws and started towards the door. Luz made sure her jacket was on, then started fiddling with the integrated tech built into the collar. She tripped a switch she didn't know was there and squeaked as the entire jacket poofed up until she was a bit like a walking marshmallow, colored in a particular sinister palette. Her arms jutted out to her sides and she wobbled through the door and into the crystal clear night. There was a

storm, just barely visible by how it darkened the purple haze of the night sky, off in the distance. Scorpia carefully took out a scanner with one of her claws, while Luz came up next to her and wobbled encouragingly from side to side.

"So, uh," she said. "Nice, uh, polar night, right?"

"Oh, sure. It's juuuust swell!" Scorpia said, her voice tight as she started to stomp away, her tail lashing.

"...I get the feeling that it is not actually swell, um, are we...cool? I mean, not cool as in cool, but, like, cool as in-" Luz started.

"We're fine!" Scorpia snapped, turning around to glare at her. "I mean, it's not like you just toodled in out of nowhere and immediately became Catra's best friend. It's not like *I* wanted to be her best friend, and that I was here first, and that she never once even noticed me, but she spent *weeks* by your bedside. Nursing you back to health, making sure your pillows were changed every single night. Oh no, no, we're just *peachy*! Absolutely…" Her claw snipped the scanner in half. "Peachy!"

Luz blushed. Hard. She tried to hold her hands up in a placating way, but her marshmallow poof of a jacket was keeping her arms at her side. Instead, she wobbled in as peaceful a way as she could manage. "S-She likes you! I mean, kinda! I mean, uh, that is…"

"I don't need your pity, Miss Noceda, if that *is* your real name,"

Scorpia said, turning and glowering at her. "You know, I've been suspicious of you since you arrived – with your whole First One chicanery and why *did* you end up near the Princess, right before she got broken out of jail?"

"Well, uh, I can answer that one!" Luz said, taking a step back.

She was saved, fortunately, from this increasingly awkward conversation by a screech and the sudden impact of a titanic, mack truck sized centipede limbed, toothed worm, whose teeth snatched her up and carried her away with a scuttling rush that left Scorpia blinking in the haze of snow kicked up by the beast's passage.

Scorpia sighed, then muttered. "Catra will be mad if I let her get eaten…" She said, turning to face the beast, who was rocking its head back and forth, swinging Luz around, doppling her yell so it became a 'waaahAAAAhhhAAAAhhAAAAhhh' to Scorpia's ears. She hesitated a moment more, then started to trudge forward, grumbling under her breath.

Luz screamed and waggled her arms – until one of the sharp teeth hit one of the inflated air bladders in her jacket. The insulating cushion let loose an alarmingly flatulent noise, and left her suddenly dangling between two teeth, hooked on it and now able to, at last, move her arms. She snatched a rune and glanced at it for a moment – it was a perfect replica of the rune she had seen when Glimmer had been using her powers.

One of the issues with testing new magic was that, well, she didn't want to draw the ire or attention of Hordak – Shadow Weaver might have been disgraced and thrown into jail, but that didn't mean that her influence was completely gone. The last thing that Luz wanted was for the 'dissect her brain' question to come back to the table. This meant her experiments had been spotty and minor scale, so, she was actually not very sure what this rune would do.

It might teleport her a few feet away and to safety!

Orrrrr, it might explode her into a million sparkles!

She hesitated...and the worm tilted its head backwards, so that her feet dangled over its blazingly hot throat.

"I don't wanna get vored!" Luz squeaked and slapped the rune onto her chest.

She exploded into a million sparkles.

Then the sparkles clumped back together again into a shocked, gasping Luz Noceda. Unfortunately, she was right at the feet of the gigantic worm. One of them lifted up to come squashing down onto her head, but she flung herself forward, rolled, came to her feet – and saw a second one was coming down at her head as the worm lurched forward.

Clack!

Two pincer claws snapped onto the leg and held it up. Scorpia stood there, her muscular arms straining, her face going beat red as she strained, her teeth clenching.

"Get outta here, Noceda!" she hissed.

"One sec!" Luz said, then scrawled a circle, carving in the same ice rune that she had seen in Frosta's palace. Her palm slapped down just as Scorpia's grip clacked open and the worm started to lurch forward...and then the pillar of ice that Luz had conjured crashed into its belly, causing the whole thing to jerk upwards and come to a stop. Luz joined Scopria in sprinting away, rushing towards the outbuildings of the base. They rushed in through the door and Scorpia slapped the close and lock button. The worm crashed into the doorway – and it rang loudly, then went still.

Luz panted. "Thank you!" she gasped.

"Don't…" Scorpia gasped. "Mention it."

They both looked around the storage room.

Luz started to pat around her jacket. "Where's my...comm…"

“Mine got snipped in half,” Scopria said. Then she blushed. “B-By the, uh, worm.”

“Yeah, yeah, it was the worm, totally!” Luz said, nodding, her voice entirely serious and non-sarcastic. She was trying to be supportive, since, well, Catra had called Scorpia a moron. But Scorpia worked hard! She tried a lot of things!

Scorpia looked at her fishily.

Luz started patting more – and then her fingers slid into her pocket and she pulled out Stringbean. But her palisman, her lovely, amazing, multifaceted palisman, her perfect little noddle of adorable sweetness, had become a comm. Luz whispered. “Thank you,” she said, tapping at the comm, and then Catra’s voice came through it.

“Noceda, what is going on out there?”

“Giant worms!” Luz said. “Huge gigantic…” She thought back.

The worms had been segmented, but there had been something strange about their eyes – smooth, rather than faceted. She frowned, turning to Scorpia.

“Scorpia, were those worms, like, robots or was that just me?”

“They seemed kind of bot-ey,” Scorpia admitted.

There was a squeaking yowl noise – the kind of noise Catra made when she was shoved bodily away from something by an excited Entrapta. Then Entrapta’s voice came through the comm. “Was it a first one robot? Also, what communication unit are you using? I don’t recognize this frequency?”

“Uh, a fancy one!” Luz said. “And yes, it is a first one robot!”

“Catra-” There was a crashing noise, a blare of static, and then Catra’s voice came through the comm again.

“Smash it,” Catra said, angrily.

“Noooo!” Entrapta’s voice, faintly, came through the comms. “Capture it! It’s First One’s tech! We can *do* stuff with it!”

“Ugh, fine, capture it,” Catra said. Luz clicked the comm off and tucked it into her pocket, where it could turn back into Stringbean.

“Okay!” Scorpia said, clacking her claws. “Do you think my venom can work on it?”

“Probably not,” Luz said, then rubbed her chin. “Unless. It may be

partially biological. It depends on what's under the metal." She snapped her fingers. "I got an idea! But it requires us to work together, despite our differences and, possibly, become closer as friends, which will then lead to us having an abiding respect until the jealousy over Catra overwhelms one of us at the most dramatic moment to leave the other dying in the third act finale!?"

"...y...I...can...uh…" Scorpia said. "Yes, but not all that other stuff!"

Luz nodded. "Okay. Here's the plan."

***

The massive first one worm smashed into the side of the outbuilding. The Horde, though, was primarily an invading army – they built prefabricated structures to take artillery fire and magical attacks normally used to blast apart hovertanks. In short, the building could withstand a few glancing smashes, even from a gigantic worm. That didn't mean that it would last *forever*, though. The head of the beast smashed into the side of the structure once, twice, three times, and the by the time it was done, a good chunk of the roof had started to sag inwards.

Which was when, with a spray of sparkles, Luz appeared off to the left.

"Yo, worm butt!" she shouted. "Your butt is...wormlike!"

The massive worm turned towards her and then...turned back to smashing the building. Luz's brow furrowed for a moment – but, well, she had a plan for this part of the plan if the shouting didn't work. She pulled a pair of runes from her pockets, holding them between her fingers like she was Rambit from the Y-Men, and then slapped them both onto the ground and tapped them both. The runes flared and red-black bolts of lightning leaped out to smash into the sides of the worm. They didn't do enough damage to hurt the creature...but they did as heck draw its attention.

The huge worm screeched, turned, and rushed at Luz. It had enough legs and feet that it was able to clear a remarkable amount of ground. Luz turned, sprinting away – then slapped her next teleport rune onto her chest seconds before the teeth closed around her. She vanished and appeared above the worm. She dropped onto its back and grunted as her palms scrabbled wildly for handholds. Her fingers caught between armor plates and she clung on.

This was where things got a bit tricky. The worm veered to the left, clearly planning to come back around to where she had been standing before – it seemed a bit stupid and hadn't realized that she was on its back. She scrawled hurriedly, improvising the rune on her own wrist as she clung on with her left hand, drew with her right. She slapped her wrist, hissing as a crackling rope of raw lightning sprang into her palms. She looped it out and the buzzing rope locked around the wormbeast's mouth, snapping into its teeth like a bit.

"Yeeha-aaaaaaah!" Luz screamed as she shifted her grip from the beast's back to her makeshift energy reins – and then found that

the creature going flat out was able to move so swiftly at the wind picked her up and waggled her behind it, dangling from the reins like a kite on the air. Her legs kicked and she kept screaming as the beast sprinted past the drill-pit in the heart of the arctic base, then ran back the other way.

From the inside of the command center, Entrapta and Catra both watched.

“Should we help...them?” Entrapta asked, sounding a little unsure.

Catra sighed and put her hand on her face. “Noceda,” she grumbled, sounding halfway between chagrined and entertained. “She’s pretty good at her job. She knows what she’s doing.”

“She does?” Entrapta asked, so innocently shocked that Catra glowered at her.

The beast charged back the other way, sweeping Luz past the window, her scream dopplering past them again.

Outside, Luz shifted her grip, then managed to swing her legs around. She planted her feet against the back of the worm’s curved neck-bit and then yanked hard on the reins. The whole creature screeched around her makeshift bit and reared backwards. She yelped as her back smashed against the metal plates of the creature’s backsides, but at least she was no longer being whipped around. Instead, she hauled hard to the left and the creature surged in that direction in a blind rage and panic.

This caused it to rush directly at one of the other out buildings – the bot warehouse. She aimed the head with a yank and tug and let out a whoop of pure delight as the head of the worm rushed straight at the doors.

Which opened *right* before the head crashed into them. The worm's shoulders and legs caught on the frame and Luz sprang off the side of the beast, landing there with a thump as the doors tried to close. Its huge body reared and tugged backwards – the legs digging in and shoving, but the door had made a seal it couldn't pull away from.

A crackling buzz of sparkles exploded to the left of Luz – forming after a moment into a shocked, panting looking Scorpia.

"That rune works!" she said, sounding delighted.

"Start scribbling now!" Luz said, drawing her stylus – which was once again a helpful Stringbean. The ice and snow proved an excellent writing surface and she slapped the rune she had shown Scorpia how to make. Since she was more experienced at runing, her first loop of chain made of pure magical ice was done well before Scorpia's first. But before Luz had finished her second, Scorpia's claw clacked against her carefully scrawled rune – cut into the ice with her own pincer-tip – and the second set of chains looped up, around, and cinched home.

Luz drew, slapped, drew, slapped, drew, slapped, then collapsed onto her rump, panting as her palms sank up to the wrist in the cold ice. She yanked her hands free with a hiss, her fingers having

gone numb – but despite the fact some snow was trying to wriggle into her pants and cool her boots, she was currently looking at something that would make any demon hunter back on the Boiling Isles proud.

One genuine First One's piece of biomecha, restrained from head to toes, by link after link of frozen ice and the doorways of their bot warehouse. Scorpia walked over to stand beside Luz, nodding as the worm wriggled and squirmed in its restraints...but it couldn't get out. Luz grinned, shakily.

"Got it!" she said.

"Yeah. Great job!" Scorpia said, slapping Luz's back with one pincered arm.

"Thanks…" Luz laughed. She stood, shaking her hands off, then blushed. "...I'm sorry."

"No, I'm sorry," Scorpia said, looking aside. "Y-You made such a funny knock knock joke earlier, and I didn't even say whose there. I've been a real...a real bad friend." She turned away, putting her arm over her face.

"No, no, no, I've been a way worse friend!" Luz said. "I mean, I-I...I...have done...so...so many things that...I regret…" She gulped.

Like cheating on Amity. Uh, helping the Evil Horde build a portal engine. Oh, and now, without even thinking about it, you captured a super powerful piece of First One tech to give to Entrapta, which will lead to who knows what *in terms of weapons advancement. And you only just realized that frigging now, great job, Luz!*

"I'm going to make sure the worm cannot escape!" Luz lied, badly.

"Right!" Scorpia said, missing it entirely.

Luz ran towards the tail end of the worm, then scampered around to the far side of the worm. There, she started thinking furiously. How could she sabotage the worm without making it seem like *she* had done anything. Maybe she could...could… She shook her head, every idea coming to her mind seeming completely obvious. She sighed, then put her hands on her head, groaning.

"Arrrgh! Come on, think!"

Well, what if I made it look like Adora and her crew did it? Luz thought.

A glittering sword slammed directly into the side of the worm right before where Luz's stood, slicing in so deep that the gold filigreed hilt crunched against metal. A spray of sparks and smoke went

gushing from around the sword's impact point and the entire worm laid still.

Hah, genius work, Luz! Luz thought.

"Wait," she said, then jerked her head around just in time to see Adora's fist rushing right towards her face.

Luz dropped to the ground with a yelp and the fist whistled over where her head had been for a single second. She lay on her back, her palms raised. "Whoa, wait!" she said, and then Adora lifted her fist up – about to bring it smashing down again...and then a spray of sparkles popped up and Adora's wrist stopped – caught by Glimmer.

"Wait!" Glimmer said, fiercely.

Adora blinked.

"It's Luz!" she said.

Adora blinked. "Oh!" She said, looking chagrined.

Luz panted, softly. Right. She was wearing the bad guy uniform. And it was dark.

“Wait, you remember me trying to help you?” Luz asked, sitting up.

Glimmer nodded, looking at her nervously.

Luz felt as if an entire knot of her ongoing tension had come free in a single jolt. She smiled up at them.

I knew it! She thought. *I can fix it.*

“So, what are you doing here?” she whispered, standing up.

“We’re here to stop whatever the Horde is up too,” Glimmer said, Adora nodding, while Bow walked over, looking concerned.

“It seems that they’re trying to tap into some First One’s machinery – it may be related to using the tech built throughout Etheria,” he said. “We need to stop that.”

“...oh...kaaaaaay!” Luz said. “Y-Yeah...we, uh…”

Internally, she started to scream.

Luz Noceda and the Big Betrayal

Chapter Summary

> Luz talks Catra into doing the right thing. Then Catra ruins everything. Goddamn it, Catra.

Luz shut her mental screaming up with a firm nod.

"Okay," she whispered. "Uh...right. Okay."

All I need to do, she thought. *Is have the good guys heroically stop us while actually allowing the Evil Horde's plan to reconnect ancient Etherian technology together to form Hordak's portal generator so I can go home and get back to my girlfriend while also, not hurting the feelings of my current girlfriend who, herself, is a part of the Evil Horde.*

Luz nodded and stood there, her eyes going slightly out of focus.

"...are you okay?" Adora asked. Her voice grew concerned. "D-Do you have...brain damage?"

"She did get hit pretty hard by Shadow Weaver," Glimmer whispered back.

"Uh no!" Luz said. "My good am brain!" She shook her head. "I just need to, uh, think of a...a...thing! To, um...do...stuff!"

“What?” Glimmer asked.

“What stuff?” Adora asked.

“Well, uh…” Luz tapped her fingers together. “I need toooo...buy...time!” She nodded. “By, uh, that is, I need time to, for, for, uh, for-”

“For me to show up.”

Everyone’s heads jerked up. Standing atop the large First One biomecha that Luz had helped to capture and Adora had quietly shut down via direct application of Sword of Power to central control and power unit, was Catra. She had her arms crossed over her chest and was smirking down at Adora, Glimmer, Bow. “Hey Adora,” she said, before hopping down to land on the sword’s hilt, which still jutted from the side of the wormbeast. She kipped down from that to land next to Luz, her arm snaked around her shoulders. “How do you like my best friend? She’s pretty sharp, huh?”

Adora was looking deeply betrayed, her blue eyes flicking from Luz to Catra to Luz again.

Luz’s throat choked.

“Now, this is the part where she shows off her magic,” Catra said, smirking. “Right babe?”

Adora and Glimmer looked at Luz, blinking. Luz felt Stringbean squirm in her pocket. Her brain locked up – the choices were too impossible. She almost felt like she wasn’t even moving her arm as she reached into her pocket...and she watched, in slow motion, as she flicked her rune out with a single finger. It landed at Glimmer’s feet and exploded upwards with a spray of ice, shooting a fist right at her jaw. Glimmer vanished into an explosion of sparkles and Catra grabbed Luz by the nape of her neck and yanked her back seconds before Adora’s fist connected with Luz’s jaw. Instead, Adora’s fist smashed into the biomecha, crunching into steel plates and causing Adora to yelp and hiss, wringing her fist out.

Then there was no time for thinking.

No time for thinking at all.

Catra shoved Luz forward and to the left. Luz tumbled, rolled, came to her feet, saw that Catra was yanking the sword of power out of its resting place. She grinned, holding it away from Adora as Adora snatched for it, shoulder checking Catra against the metal. Bow drew and knocked an arrow, dropping his homemade tablet into the snow. Luz grabbed onto the tablet and smacked his knee with it, jerking his shot off so that the arrow and the net that exploded from it winged over Catra’s and Adora’s head. Bow yelped, jumped, and Luz sprang to her feet.

"Lo siento, lo siento, lo siento!" she said, dropping the tablet. Before Bow could do anything more, Glimmer appeared behind Luz, locking a muscular arm around her neck, snarling.

"You frigging *jerk*!" She shouted. "Was trying to let me out part of a plan!? Did you *scheme* that up with Catra!?"

"Gurk!" Luz choked, stumbling backwards. Catra snarled, dropped under Adora's arms, sprang through her legs, grabbed onto Bow's shoulder, flipped over him, and smashed the heel of her face into where Glimmer would have been, had Glimmer not vanished. Catra instead ended up landing on Luz's shoulders, and Luz flailed her arms to keep herself from collapsing into the snow.

Catra hopped off her back as Adora yanked the sword from the metal housing that she had plunged it into. At that exact moment, Scorpia came up and over the stilled biomecha, her claws clacking as she leaped up and landed behind Adora – who was holding her sword up.

"By the power of Grayskull!"

The explosion of radiant white light that blasted into Catra and Luz made Luz blink and then gape.

Adora as She-Ra was…

Still…

Wow.

She was an eight foot tall blond goddess, rippling with muscle and clad in a pristine white gambeson and fluttering red cape and skirts. She loomed over even Scorpia, her eyes fierce as she looked down at the whole lot of them. Scorpia lunged, her tail plunging forward, but Adora didn't so much *move* as simply snap her hand into place – it was eerie, like watching a machine at work, faster than human eyes could track. She grabbed onto Scorpia's tail, then whipped her up and over her shoulders and down into the snow with an explosion of white powder that almost bowled Bow over.

"Oh, sorry!" Adora said, her voice sounding remarkably similar, despite the fact she was now a giant.

Catra grinned, then sprang over and kicked Bow's bow from his hands. He scowled and sprang backwards, while Adora swung her sword in a curving arc, which Catra nimbly dodged, her hands sliding into her pockets, as if she didn't even need them for this fight. Or she just had cold fingers.

"Wow, I knew you were jealous, but this is getting a bit ridiculous," Catra said. She was drawing Adora's focus – and Luz knew why.

She's setting her up for a shot. For my shot.

Fortunately, Luz didn't have to choose between blasting the objectively correct heroic woman who was fighting the woman that Luz was desperately, madly in love with. Why was it that it took a giant swinging a sword at someone's face to make what was obviously true impossible to ignore? Luz's entire body was blazing with a need to protect Catra, her sweet, cunning, evil, sneaky, brilliant, hurt, sad, precious kitten – the contradictions of Catra only made Luz want and need even more stark and intense.

Of course, all that want and need was moot because, currently, a woman with the ability to teleport five times every three seconds was trying to kill Luz with laser beams. Glimmer appeared, blasted, appeared, blasted, appeared, blasted. Each concussive burst of glitter sizzled past Luz's face, shoulders, arms, while she focused entirely on dodging and yelping. She threw out two ice runes, slapping both before they even finished fluttering to the ground, and formed a shield wall that shot up out of the ground and blocked two blasts. Then she sprang backwards, away from Glimmer's focus, and saw that Entrapta was sitting on the side of the First One's biomecha, humming as she pried open the side with a crowbar.

"Entrapta!" Luz said. "Help!"

Entrapta wordlessly tossed her a package, which landed in Luz's chest. It was a roughly star shaped object wrapped in paper, with a big warning label printed on it that said *Danger: Disables First One Technology!!! Do Not Use!*

“But this says not to use it!” Luz said.

“Put it on her sword,” Entrapta said, then slid into the hole she had made in the side of the biomecha with an alarmingly moist *squish* noise. “Aha!”

Glimmer appeared before Luz, panting softly – catching her breath, or catching her magic? Luz wanted to study her in a lab. You know. Later. And with her consent. She was not evil!

“You’re...so...evil!” Glimmer exclaimed. “You put on this innocent, sweet, woe is me act, but every single thing you do is some kind of lie!” She clenched her fists. “You made *rescuing* me a lie! Who *does* that!?”

“I-I…” Luz stammered. “Listen, if I could explain-”

“You can’t explain working for the people who are destroying my *planet*!” Glimmer said, her voice thick with rage, her eyes almost brimming with tears. “You can’t explain *fighting* on the side that killed my *father*. You just *can’t*.”

Luz felt as if she had been smacked.

Behind Glimmer, she saw Catra had been backed up against the First One’s artifact. Adora’s hand was on her chest, jamming her in hard, pinning her against the wall. Her sword was raised – and

Adora was saying something. But all Luz could see was the gleaming sword. It's razor sharp edge. Luz reached up, grabbing into her pocket for Stringbean. And she felt the reluctance. The hesitation. The urging voice from her precious Palisman.

Luz thought back: *I'll fix it, I'll fix it, I'll-*

She scrawled the rune on the parcel. Glimmer blinked, realized what she was doing, sprang forward.

Luz slapped it.

The parcel flashed into a thousand glittering sparkles.

Then it appeared again, landing right on top of Adora's magical sword.

The paper surrounding the package ripped apart in a flurry of brown paper – revealing ruby red crystal, and worming, writhing tentacles, which spread first like moss, then like grids, their organic texture transmuting into something mechanical and yet still chaotic as they bifurcated and spread throughout the metal of Adora's sword. She gasped, cried out, clutched at her head as Catra dropped nimbly away, skidded abckwards, and grinned as she stood beside Luz.

"Nice one," she said. "We've see this tech before – it makes Adora loopy. Like she just got really-"

Adora screamed. Her eyes turned brilliant, ruby red as her muscles seemed to bulge even more than they already did. Red filiaments burrowed along the underside of her skin, glowing brilliantly. She turned to face Glimmer, Bow, Catra, and Luz. Her eyes flashed and she stepped forward, crushing Bow's discarded tablet with a spray of sparks.

"Uh, Adora!" Bow said, scrambling to his feet. Then he yelped and sprang backwards as Adora swung her sword in a curving arc that nearly took his and Luz's head off – Bow was saved by Glimmer, Luz was saved by Catra. But before any of them could do anything, Adora started to hack wildly, swinging her sword like a maniac berserker, smashing it down onto the icy ground with every blow. The hissing noise of cloven air split the battlefield with every swing, and Luz turned and sprinted away from Adora, shouting at the top of her lungs.

"Berserker protocol! She's gone all Quib-Quib! Run! Run! Run!"

The whole group joined her – with only Scorpia left behind, ignored as she laid in the pile of snow that Adora had tossed her into.

They came around the First One drone and saw that there was another one emerging from the snow and the gathering storm. Catra, Luz, Glimmer and Bow skidded to a stop. "Oh come *on*!" Catra growled. Luz, though, already had one of her runes out. She

flicked and the paper slapped to the chest of the construct. She hoped it was big enough – more magic for more mass, but also, short range meant...she rushed forward, leaped up, and slapped the rune seconds before the construct smashed into her friends. It vanished in a spray of sparkles, and appeared between them and Adora, while Luz dropped back into the snow.

"Come on!" She shouted, gesturing with one hand, thinking furiously as she did so. There had to be a way to deal with this! There had to be!

"You stole my magic!" Glimmer shouted as she ran up to her side. "That's the weird glitching I've been getting! You're *stealing* my magic!"

"I'm more using the same power source," Luz gasped out.

Behind them, the construct flew into three large, sparking pieces as Adora stomped through it, her sword smoking and sparking – she had cut through it like it was butter and tossed the pieces aside as if they didn't weigh anything at all. The only reason, Luz realized, why they weren't all already dead was that Adora was walking after them at a fairly sedate pace.

Is that her trying to slow herself down? Or the berserker in her toying with us?

Luz hoped it was the former. Much more power of friendship. Much nicer.

"I have an idea!" Catra said, then banked off to the left. Luz followed her, since there was a 0.00% chance of her not following Catra. Then she realized that Catra was, quite literally, leading them towards a cliff. Okay, there was a 0.05% chance that Luz might not follow Catra. The cliff in question was the one created by the huge drilling machine that Entrapta had packed up and brought to drill to the ancient Etherian machinery buried beneath the snows and ice. Catra came to the edge of the cliff, stopped, then turned. Luz turned with her.

Bow and Glimmer had both gone the other way – and, lo, Adora was still coming after them.

"We have to get that thing off the sword!" Luz hissed to Catra – unaware that, at that moment, she was saying the exact same thing Glimmer was hissing to Bow.

"Are you stupiud?" Catra asked. "We need to get the sword away from Adora. I'll get you the opening."

She grinned, then walked forward. Adora, panting, stopped as Catra came within swinging range. She lifted her sword up above her head and Catra cocked her head – and Adora hesitated.

"...we're sleeping together, you know," Catra said, casually. "Luz and I, pretty…" She lifted her right hand and made a huge dramatic production of *retracting* her pointer and middle finger claws. "...regularly." She smirked at Adora.

Adora brought the sword smashing down. Catra sprang back. And Luz sprang forward and slapped the rune right onto the side of the sword. The sword buzzed, crackled, and there was a definite lurch as it tried to resist the magic. But Luz clung on tight and the sword and her vanished from Adora's grasp with a spray of sparkles. She hit the ground, rolled, and came up just in time to see that Adora had returned to her normal red jacketed self, shorter, more slender. She wobbled, then fell to the ground, caught by Catra's arms.

Luz stood, holding the sword in her hands, her heart hammering.

I can...I can fix this. I can fix this. I can fix this, she thought, frantically.

Glimmer clenched her fists and Bow lifted his bow.

Then both stiffened and fell over.

Scorpia grinned as she stood behind them, having slipped around in the confusion and the chaos. She clacked her claws together. "Thanks for the distraction, Luz! Couldn't have done it without you!"

I can fix this! Luz thought as she lifted her hand up, giving a shaky thumbs up to Scorpia.

***

It was a lot of hard work, fixing an ancient Etherian machine. Luz did it all in a daze. Part of her brain was squealing in excited shock at every connected port, every new realization of how the massive machine that was Etheria worked. The planet had to be honeycombed with immense power conduits and rune-channels, connecting each runestone to one another, turning the magic of the place into...something. The First Ones had built it to do something, but what still eluded her and Entrapta.

But the whole time that she worked Adora, Glimmer and Bow were in prison, watched over by bots and by Scorpia. And the whole time, Luz felt Stringbean's nervous wriggling inside of her pocket. Her mental connection was a little frayed. A little unfocused.

It's okay, Luz kept thinking. *I'll fix it*.

Now, she stood behind Entrapta as Entrapta hummed cheerfully and clacked away at the keyboard sitting before the circular table where she had the Sword of Power ensconced. Cables ran into and away from the sword, and several scanners had been aimed at it – while Entrapta fed data out of the sword, Luz paced back and forth.

“So, uh, where are the prisoners being held?” she asked.

“In the prison, probably!” Entrapta said.

“Right, right!” Luz said.

The door to the room opened and Catra walked in, sighing. “I don’t know what was worse, all the work at the north pole, flying back here, or the debriefing with Hordak,” she said, her whole body shuddering slightly from her head to her toes. “At least it’s flipping over with now.” She smirked at Luz. “What are you still doing here? You’ve done basically everything you need to do today.”

“I, uh, need to help Entr-”

“Nope. Force Captain commands you take the rest of the day off,” Catra said, grabbing onto Luz’s hand.

“But Ent-” Luz stammered.

“Entrapta,” Catra said.

“Hmm?” Entrapta lifted her head. “What?”

“Do you need help, or do you want to do me a big favor and let Noceda escape to relax with me?” she asked.

“Oh! Uh!” Entrapta swiveled in her chair, using her elongated hair to shove and spin the chair around to face the two of them. She regarded Catra, who was giving her a big, obvious nod, then looked at Luz, then back at Catra. Entrapta narrowed her eyes, then hazarded: “Y...Yes!”

“See! She’s fine,” Catra said, yanking Luz towards the door. Luz yelped, flailing her free arm, looking back at Entrapta, who waved cheerfully as the door shut between Luz and her. Within the room, alone with the sword and the data emerging from it, Entrapta smiled.

“Note to self! You understand social dynamics perfectly,” she said, sounding pleased with herself. Then she started to tap away at the keyboard again, narrowing her eyes. Data began to feed out of the sword – and Entrapta began to run it through the database. She narrowed her eyes and then cocked her head. A sine wave began to scrawl its way across the screen, warbling and twisting. Then, slowly, the sine wave started to become more and more erratic. Entrapta leaned back in her seat and her hair reached out to pick up a cup – tiny, of course. She drank from it, watching as a simulation started to play out.

Once it was complete and the final bits of debris were finished dissolving into sparkles, Entrapta smacked her lips.

“Faaaaaaascinating.”

***

Luz followed Catra up, and up, and up, and finally, came to a ladder that Catra ignored completely. She instead leaped over a sheer drop of almost fifty meters straight down into some whirling turbine fans that jutted from the roof of the lower levels, caught onto a radial antenna, then swung herself up onto a tongue of metal that jutted out and over the highest spire of the barracks. It was, if Luz didn’t miss her guess, an large flier docking and refueling platform.

Luz, meanwhile, simply used the ladder.

“You know, ladders exist for reasons! To prevent cats from falling to their deaths,” she said, trying to sound exasperated as she stuck her head up and over the edge of the refueling platform. Catra was sitting on her butt, her legs stretched out, her palm resting on a pillow. And a blanket. Someone had draped a blanket and laid some pillows up here. And was that a metal container, the kind normally used to schlep around ammo cells?

Luz’s brow furrowed.

“What’s all this?” she asked, swinging herself up.

“Uh...ya know, just...hanging out with the girl who basically won us the war,” Catra said, shrugging one shoulder.

“...is this a *romantic* picnic!?” Luz squeaked, her hands going to her mouth as she sat on her knees.

Catra opened her mouth, then closed it. She drew her legs up under her, sitting crisscross applesauce. She looked down at the metal case, then swung it open, to reveal a few ration bars. “...I mean, I wouldn’t say it’s...romantic!” she said, hurriedly.

Luz’s heart hammered in her chest.

Catra, we need to talk. She thought. *Just say those words. Catra, we need to talk about your evil problem. Have you ever considered quitting evil? We could get you on...some kind of evil patch! Or a substitute evil, we could replace addictive and harmful evil with, say, healthy and entirely sustainable snark! You could try that!*

Instead, she said. “Wish we had something better than ration bars to eat.”

Catra’s grin was lopsided. “I mean, we do, Noceda.”

Luz's entire face went red. Her brain made a noise that you normally had to throw a keyboard into a blender to get. She crawled over and then laid down beside Catra. She laid her head on the pillow, then sighed. "Catra, we need to talk."

Wow.

Those words had just come out of her mouth. Catra, for her credit, didn't immediately bolt away. But Luz could see the shutters and bolts slamming down across her features, her eyes growing dark – and both were such beautiful colors, it felt to Luz like she had just hucked a rock through a stained glass window. "N-Not about breaking up!" she said, hurriedly. Catra blinked at her, then frowned.

"Noceda," she said. "Just say it."

Luz blushed. Hard. "I...I have a girl back home," she said.

"Yeah, and?" Catra asked, thumping back onto her pillow, looking up at the sky, her hands clenching across her belly. Luz could practically hear her tension, like a violin being drawn in a horror movie – the bow sliding along the highest, most pure note. Making her spine tighten. Her fingers clench.

"A-And I want you two to meet!" Luz burst the words out. "Because Amity's really cool and you're cool and...and I like you

both and...well, I can have both of you, we can, that is, you and Amity, and-”

Catra looked at Luz as if she was insane. “What?” she asked.

Luz’s entire face burned. “What?”

“No, I’m the one asking what, *what*?” Catra sat up. “Luz, if I meet this...Amity girl, she’s going to try and kill me!”

“No she...might!” Luz said, her hand going to Catra’s hand. “Wait, you think she’d try and kill you? I mean, for me?”

“Of course, I’d kill for you,” Catra said, shrugging one shoulder.

Luz’s eyes almost filled with tears. “R-Really?” she whimpered.

“Don’t get...mushy, Noceda, I’m a Force Captain, fighting people is my job,” Catra said, yanking her hand back and looking away. Luz threw her arms around her shoulders, hugging her tightly and making the sleek catgirl squirm and wriggle in annoyance. Then she put her hand on Luz’s chest and shoved her away, scowling. “And you can’t have *two* girls. You have to choose.”

“Since when?” Luz asked.

Catra rolled her eyes and then stood up. She paced away to the edge of the platform – which, Luz was glad to see, did have rails. Catra hopped up to perch *on* said rail, her bare feet balancing there with a cat's grace. Luz's heart squeezed almost out of her chest as Catra shook her head, her tail lashing angrily.

"Since always," she said, firmly. It was axiomatic, obvious.

"...your mom told you that, huh?" Luz asked.

"She's not my mom," Catra said, her voice quiet.

Then why did you know who I was talking about? Luz thought. Aloud, she said. "My mom said that love is love, and you can love anyone you want."

"Well, I don't...love you. You're a nice lay is all," Catra said.

Luz flushed, feeling a warm heat, like she had been smacked. "Really?" she asked.

"I…" Catra hesitated. "I mean, I like you. And you like me. And that's enough, right? Don't bring up anything stupid. Like dating other girls!" Her eyes flashed – and Luz bit her lip, hard. She could see that Catra's claws were out and digging into the metal. The

realization hit Luz like a wrecking ball – swinging in full into a building, smashing it, bringing it tumbling down. Down. Down.

She's terrified of losing me.

If Luz had needed a giant with a sword to see it, Catra had needed the idea that Luz might leave her. Or not even leave her, *share* her.

That's not healthy, Luz thought. She gulped, slightly, then reached into the metal box. She pulled out the ration bar and noticed something unusual about it – it had a slightly softer texture, and when she nibbled on it, she found she could chew it without needing to wet it with her spittle for a solid ten minutes. It was still tacky and hard, but she managed to swallow it in a reasonable time frame. Softly, she asked: "Are these the best rat bars in the entire Fright Zone?"

"I kinda stole em from the refractory right when they got out of the machines," Catra admitted, sheepishly.

For me. Luz thought. "For us."

"Well, duh," Catra said.

Luz stood. She walked over to the railing, then held the bar out to Catra, smiling at her a little. Catra plucked a bit off...but rather

than popping it into her mouth, she pressed it to Luz's lips. Luz opened her mouth, then shivered as Catra's thumb pressed to her lower lip, the claw-tip teasing her. Luz chewed. Swallowed. Hoarsely, she said. "Well, I like you," she said. "More than just a good, uh, sexy time."

"Really?" Catra asked. "Why?" Her voice was playful.

Luz decided to hit her where it hurt: In the truth-zone.

"Well, you're smart and fierce and clever," she said, leaning on her elbows against the railing, letting her hands dangle above the Fright Zone. Catra chewed on her half of the rat-bar, her ears twitching up as she listened to Luz's voice. "You fight hard, even when you're fighting stuff that's way stronger and scarier than you. And...you're hurt. You're really hurt, Catra, and you keep going despite it. You don't let the people who hurt you make you...scared of trying. And, yeah, not...everything you're trying is the right thing or even a smart idea but…" Luz couldn't take her gaze off her hands. "But...you're still here. Despite everything. You're still here." Her hands shimmered and blurred for some reason.

Catra wasn't chewing anymore.

"Catra…" Luz whimpered, her eyes closing. "If...If I said we had to...to run away. To never come back to the Fight Zone again, would you?"

“W-What?” Catra choked. “What are you talking-”

Luz closed her eyes tighter. “Just...would you, *gata*? Would you?”

The silence stretched.

“...I mean...this place is...stupid anyway,” Catra said, her voice gruff – she sounded, to Luz’s ear, like she was looking away. “I mean, yeah, we kicked the Princess Alliance’s butt, Shadow Weaver is in prison. So, like. Sure. Whatever.”

Luz closed her eyes and nodded, hurriedly. Tears rolled down her cheeks. Tears of shame and relief. *She’ll leave.*

Luz could see it now.

She and Catra would walk away. Adora and Glimmer and Bow, she could let them free. The Horde could be fought, its machines smashed, its dreams of reaching out to an even vaster, even more terrible force could be destroyed. Luz Noceda and Catra could find some quiet, happy corner of Etheria and be together – and no one had to get hurt. It was not a bad life. It was *not* a bad life. It was just a life without King’s little squeal. Without Amity’s blushing when she got Spanish wrong. It’d be life without Willow showing some new plant spell, without Gus excitedly sharing his opinion on some human rubbish he had found. It’d be a life without Eda, without Mom.

Catra's hand squeezed her shoulder. "But we're not gonna leave now," she said, grinning lopsidedly. "Not until we're done with the picnic. Right?"

Luz giggle-snorted. She had so much snot. How had she gotten so much. She sniffled and whimpered, then mewed as Catra gently pushed her away from the railing, sat her down on the blankets and the cushions, and then started to kiss her. Luz mewed again. "Nooo, I'm *gruesa!*" But Catra just kissed her again – though, carefully avoiding any of her snot.

Luz found some of her runing paper and blew her nose with a honk that made Catra burst out laughing. Then, pressing to her, Catra began to purr. She thrummed with the noise, pushing Luz down onto the blankets, holding her. Buzzing. Luz closed her eyes.

"T-That's no fair," she whimpered. "I should still be crying."

Catra purred quietly, her eyes closing as she hooked one leg over Luz's belly.

"Sorry to interrupt your social pair bonding!"

Entrapta's voice jerked both girls upright, making Luz yelp and Catra growl fiercely, claws snicking out. Entrapta looked grave.

More grave, more serious, more focused than she ever had in her entire life.

"You need to see this."

***

The screen finished displaying the information. Luz sat there, rubbing her chin, while Catra frowned, her ears pining back against her head.

"So, like, what? There's a little boom?"

"Nooo, a big boom!" Entrapta said, her voice firm. "The structure of Etheria is able to focus the magical energies of the runestones – but that energy needs to be emitted. Without a target or focusing aperture, it will release chaotically, creating a cascade that will rip through the entire planetary mantle. Within fifteen seconds, the energy release will create a harmonic overload that will cause total structural integrity loss on a global scale!"

"And that's…" Catra said.

"Bad," Luz said. "The world will explode."

“A-All of it?” Catra asked, her eyes widening.

Entrapta nodded. “It’s too dangerous to even think to try and activate it.”

“But…” Catra spluttered. “We...I promised Hordak a weapon to defeat the Princess Alliance. A tool to make his portal thingamajig work!”

“Rune,” Luz whispered.

“Huh?” Catra asked.

“...you’re a genius, Luz!” Entrapta exclaimed, then sprang to her feet. “I’m going to run simulations on that!”

She turned and rushed out of the room, then came back and sat down at the computer, beginning to type hurriedly. “I forgot the computer is in this room!” she said, cheerfully. Luz barely heard her.

“What are you two talking about?” Catra asked, her lips turning down into a scowl.

“Okay,” Luz said, slowly, dumbing down her immediate response to Catra’s level of arcane understanding. “You know how I scribble my runes and they make stuff happen?” At Catra’s nod, she continued. “With the full power of Etheria behind it, I think I can make a portal rune that can...punch a way back home. It’d need to be, like, huge. Maybe fifty meters wide, carved into solid steel so that it has enough cohesion to last.” She nodded. “But it can work.”

Catra grinned. “I knew I kept you around for a reason, Noceda!” She snapped her fingers. “Scorpia!”

The door opened and Scorpia leaned around the corner.

“Get Luz everything she needs. Now!”

And that was how Luz found herself directing a team of helmeted Horde soldiers with laser cutters as they carved into a massive plaza before the main barracks. Others dragged power cables that led into the prison complexes and the research laboratories, and several others were followed by a cool and disinterested Hordak. His hands were clapsed behind his back as he narrowed his eyes at Luz. “Specialist Noceda,” he said. “Report.”

“Uh, sir, I am...making a teleport rune that should bash us a home way way home, that is, home!” She said, nodding, her heart lumping in her chest. “If I get this right, it...portal! Portal! Make!”

“I see…” Hordak’s gaze swept over the half finished rune. Two Horde soldiers who had paused in their laser cutting hurriedly got back to work.

“Lord Hordak,” Catra said, emerging from the barracks. “My-”

“I have been informed,” Hordak said. Then he snapped his finger. “Force Captain Catra, get Specialist Noceda a badge.” He turned his gaze upon Luz, and he gave her the thinnest of smiles. “She is, henceforth, Force Captain Noceda.”

Luz blinked, and felt a disquieting flop in her belly. She gulped, hard. “T-Thanks, uh…” But Hordak was already gliding off. As he left, Luz looked back at the rune.

This is all going fast, she thought.

“Here ya go,” Catra said, smirking as she pinned the badge to Luz’s chest – Luz’s clothing was by now completely replaced by the Horde’s uniform, and Luz only now realized just how total the transformation was. Luz gulped, then took a hold of Catra’s arm, tugging her aside.

“C-Catra,” she whispered. “...do you trust me?”

“This is the kind of question people say before they do something really stupid,” Catra said, frowning at her.

Luz's cheeks heated. "The rune. It's not exactly going to work the way that Hordak thinks it should work. If...my designs are right, then it's going to make a one way portal back home." She whispered. "To my home. And...and you can come with me."

Catra blinked at her.

Luz took Catra's hands, her heart thundering in her chest. She was taking a risk, such a massive risk. But she had to. She *had* to. "We can be together, and away from Hordak, and from Shadow Weaver, and the Fright Zone."

"I-I…" Catra whispered, her eyes wide. Then, her tail stilling, she whispered. "I need to think."

Luz felt her fingers slipping through her grasp. She wanted to chase after, but Catra was gone already – turning and walking away so quickly that Luz would need to sprint to keep up with her. Luz was tempted to do so...but a CRASH of falling parts and cries of alarms forced her to dither between running after Catra and rushing to the rune. In the end, she rushed for the rune. Good thing, too. The Horde soldiers had almost messed up the interlock on the fourth quarter. Luz directed the last hour of forging with a frantic focus, her entire body singing with nerves. It was like someone was drawing her tighter and tighter and tighter.

The rune was done.

She stood before it, watching the slowly cooling metal, watching the huge connectors thrum softly. The Black Garnet would provide the initial *kick*. After that, the Sword of Power and the rest of the runestones would provide enough energy to blow into the world between worlds, to her home. To the Owl House. To her mother, to her lover. She stood there, wearing a Horde Uniform, her Force Captain badge pinned to her chest, and with Stringbean squirming in her pocket.

Luz turned and started into the laboratory.

She found Catra and Entrapta in the control room – where the Sword of Power was situated, still waiting.

"Think we should bring Adora here? So she can watch?" Catra asked – in that tone of voice that meant she was half serious, half kidding, half lying to herself. Luz didn't even have the time or energy to untangle what secret desires Catra was sublimating into her urge to gloat and play the evil conqueror. She was just-

"It's not going to *work*!"

Entrapta's voice cut across their conversation, jerking Luz and Catra's gaze to her.

“What?” Luz asked. “No, no, no, it’s going to work, I’ve done this kind of-”

“Your rune is a great idea, brilliant!” Entrapta said. “But it’s not enough. The energy emission here is *planet destroying*. Tuned properly, it could destroy Etheria a million times over – I have no idea why the First Ones so overdesigned their emission outputs!” She said, shaking her head. “But this isn’t enough bleed off. If we’re *lucky*, it’ll create a portal, then blow up Etheria. If we’re unlucky, it’ll blow up Etheria, then create a portal!”

“What’s the difference?” Catra snapped.

“One may destroy *other* planets that may exist,” Entrapta said, cheerfully.

Luz’s chest felt hollow.

Stringbean squirmed in her pocket. He was trying to get out. She turned around, turning her back to Catra and Entrapta, and snatched Stringbean from the air before she could fly up and reveal himself. “Stringo!” she hissed.

“What do you got there?” Catra asked.

“Nothing!” Luz said, using her desperate begging mental voice to please please please have Stringbean disguise himself. They did

so, turning into a shockstick, which Luz hung from her belt to try and look nice and normal and not suspicious. Catra shook her head, then frowned.

"Are you a hundred percent sure on this?" she asked.

"Uhhhh…" Entrapta considered. "Thirty percent."

"Thirty!?" Luz spluttered. "Let me see that math!"

She stepped over, leaning over and peering at the diagrams that Entrapta got playing across her screens. She tried to focus, while Catra said: "Thirty percent?"

"Well, Catra, thirty percent is really high for the planet I and all my friends are currently on. It's...it's too much of a risk!"

"Too much!? Really, Entrapta?"

Luz couldn't quite follow the equations. She saw where Entrapta ended, and where she started, but everything in the middle *refused* to cohere into something she could follow. Thirty percent? It could have been three percent. Or zero point three percent. There might have been any number of mistakes in there, it wasn't like Entrapta was perfect or anything. She lifted her gaze to Catra, heart hammering in her chest.

Catra opened her mouth, then closed it.

"...if we open this portal…" She said, slowly. "And then it closes, Hordak could open his own, right?"

"Y-e-s-ssss?" Entrapta said.

Catra wasn't looking at her. She was looking at Luz.

"So, we'd win…" Catra said, softly.

"Definitely!" Entrapta said, sounding more confident.

"I'd win," Catra said.

"Absolutely! You'd beat the Princess Alliance!" Entrapta said. "But, um, thirty percent that the *whole planet* would explode!"

Catra was looking at Luz.

Only at Luz.

Catra's mouth parted. Closed. Then…

"...cancel it," she said.

"Huh?" Luz asked.

"We're not doing it," Catra said. "It's not worth the risk."

Luz gaped at her. She stepped around Entrapta. "C-Catra, we-" She grabbed onto Catra's hand – but Catra yanked her hand free, shoving her back. She glared into her eyes.

"We're not going to blow up the planet! We're...I'm not...I'm not going to risk-" Catra's voice came in slow motion, thudding into Luz's ears.

We're not-

Amity's smile.

-going to-

Mom.

-risk it-

Luz Noceda. Force Captain.

Luz jammed the shockstick into Catra's belly. The movement was as sudden and unexpected to her as it was to Catra. Catra gaped at her, her eyes widening as sparks and lightning roiled along her body. Then she dropped to the ground, smoking. Luz looked down at the shockstick – which writhed in her hand, transforming into Stringbean, who meeped and flew away. The shock of his mind and hers detaching from one another was almost as much as the numbing nimbus that had wreathed around Catra's body.

Entrapta blinked in confusion. In shock.

"W-Wha...what did you do?" she asked.

Luz grabbed onto the lever that would activate the spell and threw it, sparks hissing.

"I-I...I'll...I-"

The Sword thrummed.

The Rune glowed.

Etheria trembled.

The end of the world sounded like a-

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Howling.

Emptiness.

Luz Noceda stood in a space that was not quite a space. The walls were made of jagged crystal, and the floor was liquid black and shimmering. Cubes floated up, drifting towards the past. Luz's body was wreathed in shimmering smoke. She trembled, looked around. Her head rang, like…

She stumbled.

She fell.

She dreamed – she dreamed of Catra, and of lights. She dreamed of her home. She dreamed of her father. She dreamed of that last day.

She dreamed of wrinkled skin, drawn taut and papery. She dreamed of bleeping machines, soft and hissing.

When she opened her eyes, she saw the first of the cubes drifting up past her. She groaned, softly. "I...made it?" she asked. She grabbed onto one of the cubes as it floated by, clinging to it. She, for a moment, could peer through a rippling distortion. The mirrored surface was not solid. It was *liquid.* She was looking through a pool of water, not glass nor mirror. And what she saw was a large beast of frilled spines and snorting fire.

She recognized it from Cool Aunt Lilith's book on extinct fauna – a *demonicus pyrokus rex.*

It had been alive on the Boiling Isles about, uh…

Sixteen…

Seventeen million years ago?

Luz released the cube, watching it float up and away.

Then she blinked.

"Oh no," she said.

Her voice echoed.

Echoed.

Echoed.

Echoed…

Luz sat down and started to watch the cubes shifting by.

"M-Maybe time will speed up?" she whispered.

A funny thing happens to a human mind when it is alone. It starts to make up things to try and fill in the empty spots left by deprivation and isolation – voices whispered from the sidelines, hallucinations start, and cognitive breakdown is nearly instant, from the perspective of a lifetime. A few months, give or take, that's all that happens. But no one has ever done experiments on what happens to human minds alone...in a space without certain laws.

Luz Noceda did not need to eat, drink, or sleep after the first twenty four hours. Her body was suffused with the energies of this strange between place – creeping and crawling into her. She was barely aware of it as she sat there and cried. But eventually, the screaming and the clawing her fingers to bloody ruins against the walls and the manic sprinting as far and as fast as she could from cube to cube to cube wore away.

Eventually, she was left sitting alone, watching the cubes shift and move aside.

And something funny happened to her perception of time. Unmoored from drinking, sleeping, and all the other ticking clocks a body normally used, time began to stretch like taffy, then compress and compact. The cubes shimmered and floated by as she whispered to herself, again and again – a mantra that became almost geologic in its timescales.

"I'll fix it."

"I'll fix it."

"*I'll fix it*."

Through the cubes, her eyes saw – in flickering flashes of day and night, the color of time itself blurring into a uniform haze of gray –

the spreading of daemonic life across the corpse of the Titan. She watched as animals grew, changed, died, their forms adapting to the constant pressure of evolution. The trees spread, then died, then spread once more. The demons started to walk on their hind legs, they started to use tools, they died, then spread once more.

Luz Noceda bore witness to things that would have rewritten entire textbooks – and they barely penetrated as she watched the wheel of time spin and spin and spin. Her body remained in perfect stasis, an eternal eighteen year old. No drink. No sleep. Nothing but the time, rushing through her mind.

She saw the first humans entering the Demon Realm.

She saw their ears become pointed and sharp edged, evolution spurred by tool use and magic – faster than was normally possible. Seeing them made time seem to slow as she glued her face against the cubes, and watched as civilizations grew. Her mind, desperate for something, anything to focus on that wasn't just the passage of days and the ticking of an invisible clock, clung to their lives. She watched children grow. She watched them find love. She watched them have children. She watched them die. She watched their children die.

"I...will...fix it…"

Time slowed.

Slowed.

Slowed.

Then…

Luz grabbed onto the cube and snarled, furiously.

"*You*!"

And Philip Wittebane, the knife still slick with blood, screamed and almost fell directly out of the window behind him.

***

THREE HUNDRED SIXTY SEVEN YEARS, FIVE DAYS, SIX HOURS AND THIRTY TWO SECONDS LATER

ONE DIMENSION TO THE RIGHT

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Camila Noceda, the one time mother of Luz Noceda, blinked slowly. She took in the sight of Adora Grayskull, the orange tabby cat that had formerly been Catra, the Gravewalker who had been built using the memories and body of both Caleb Wittebane and Kat Weaver, Scorpia, Entrapta, Bow Porter and Glimmer Park, and Amity Blight...and what she said next shocked everyone.

"Why are you in *She-Ra* cosplay?"

Adora Grayskull, of the House Grayskull from the Boiling Isles, who had been raised as a human being for most of her life, opened her mouth and said: "Uhhhhhhhhhhh...what's a She-Ra?"

Which was when Adora's little hair tie unfurled itself, rolled off her shoulder, then transformed into a sleek, snake-like noodle of a creature, which perched up and chirruped at the lot of them.

TO BE CONTINUED

Stringbean and the Big Switch

Chapter Summary

> Stringbean explains everything. Adora decides to save a girl (to save the world.)

Once upon a time, there was a girl, far from home…

Adora Gray sat in a bedroom that was not her own and watched the rain splatter against the glass. Through the window, she could just barely see her house.

"So, uh, yeah, this is where I've been staying," Vee said, her hand rubbing against the back of her neck. The fact she looked identical to Adora was still giving Adora...well, okay, actually, it was the tenth weirdest thing that had happened in the past jumbled twenty four hours. Adora smiled at her.

"It's nice!"

It was a room that had once been crammed with old *Cosmic Frontier* memorabilia that had been hastily converted into a living space. There were still some shockingly racy Baivery posters on the wall – the famous Captain Avery/O'Bailey slash fiction that had kept the *Cosmic Frontier* fandom alive in the dark eras of the early 2010s, when the show had been off the air, the books had been unpopular, and everyone had begun to notice that the setting of the distant future of 2008 had been about two years ago.

Vee...also known as Experiment Number V...sighed.

She sat down on the bed next to Adora, her fingers touching together. “I didn’t mean to take over your life.”

“No, no, I get it,” Adora said, nodding.

Vee had been born in the laboratories of Emperor Belos – yet another one of that lunatic’s ideas to conquer and control and eventually destroy the Boiling Isles and magic. She had escaped with others of her kind – and had come upon the portal door that had let Adora into the demon realm. Slipping into the human realm and taking advantage of her inherent shapeshifting powers, she had taken Adora’s form and tried to hide out using her life.

It had been, in retrospect, a pretty unlucky choice.

In the awkward silence, Adora examined her twin sister. She could see a strange...halfway state in her face, in her stance, in her eyes. Vee hunched and ducked her head forward, as if she was ready for a barbed word or a smack at any second. But she also had the littlest of smiles, and her eyes darted up to meet Adora’s.

“So, how long have you been living with Mrs. Noceda?” Adora asked.

“Well, um, about a week,” Vee said. “Basically, after I took over your life, um, your mom...well…”

“She was my mom,” Adora said, sighing softly.

“And, uh, I was just crying and walking home from school and Mrs. Noceda stopped me. She asked me how I was doing and...I just...told her everything.” Vee drew her knees up against her chest, letting her bare feet rest on the bed. She tucked her chin against her knees. “She said that no one should be allowed to do that to anyone, even if they were their mom. So, she called Child Protective Services, and bothered the police, and-”

“Whoa, really?” Adora’s eyes brows shot up.

Vee blushed. “A...And...I...kinda...sorta…” She hesitated. “Shapeshifted to have broken ribs.”

Adora blinked.

“So, the cops arrested your mom. Sorry.”

Adora’s mouth opened, then closed.

Her mother had never, ever, ever actually *hit* her. She had withheld food a few times, especially when Adora had gained a pound or two. She had screamed once. But usually, it was all just

words and expectations and a yawning pit in the depths of her soul, like nothing she'd ever do would be good enough. Ever.

"Dang, Vee," Adora said, laughing, quietly. "That's almost Catra-ian. In...a complimentary way. I mean. Sneaky and clever! Not evil."

The meow of annoyance that came from under foot drew both girl's attention down.

Catra, still in the shape of an orange tabby cat, was glaring up at Adora. She planted both of her paws onto Adora's shins and dug the claws in. The fact Adora was wearing jeans didn't actually help as much as they shout. She yelped and jerked her legs up – and Catra bounded from where she had been to land on Vee's lap, growling and yowling at them. Adora couldn't speak cat, but she didn't have too.

"Fine, fine, we'll try and turn your back!" Adora said, and Catra stopped growling. Vee, her hands planted to either side of her hips, looked as if she was physically restraining herself from grabbing and petting Catra as much as she could.

The rainstorm continued apace outside, providing a quiet murmuring undercurrent to the rest of the house. Glimmer and Bow had taken the other guest room, and Camila was still downstairs with Amity and the little snakeshifter who had explained everything that had happened. Which was the number two weirdest thing that had happened in the past twenty four hours. Adora and Vee peeked around the stairwell corner, down at the kitchen, where the snakeshifter was still mewing and

squeaking, wriggling around on the table like a noodle. Camila, holding a cup of coffee in her shaking hands, nodded and bit her lower lip, while Amity frowned and took notes on a pad.

The snakeshifter – Stringbean – stopped their chirruping and peered at Adora. Camila, whose eyes were red rimmed from her crying jag earlier in the day – looked up at them and smiled, weakly. "Come down, honies. We're...we definitely need a break for a bit."

Adora nodded.

The girl wanted to do the right thing, but it was hard – she was surrounded on all sides by people who needed to help. She was alone, and she was scared, and she tried…

Adora, Camila, Amity, Catra, and Vee all sat around the table, Catra sitting on her haunches before Adora, licking the back of her paw in a regal sort of way. Camila wiped her eye with one finger, then sighed. "I-I suppose I should explain earlier," she said, softly. "My...husband and I always wanted a child."

Adora nodded.

"But we...never managed to have her." Camila looked down at her hands. "We stopped trying. So, to hear that...that I could have had a child. That I could have had my Luz." She smiled, slightly. "That's what we were going to name her – if she was a girl. If she

was a boy, we would have gone for Vesper! Or Juan, we hadn't picked."

Adora nodded, slightly.

"And to hear she was so special too," Camila said, looking down at Stringbean.

Stringbean chirruped and Catra meowed angrily, then pawed at him. Stringbean wriggled, then finally, sheepisly, began to squeak and warble. Adora's brow furrowed.

"Wait, how *did* you survive?" she asked, realizing that the Palisman hadn't even mentioned that, not in any point of his recounting of his adventures in that other realm, that other timeline. That place with the other Adora, the other Catra, the other Glimmer and other Bow. The place that Adora still couldn't remember. Stringbean tucked her own head under her tail and warbled, softly.

"How can you not know?" Amity asked, frowning intently.

Squeak squeak!

"Hmm!" Amity rubbed her chin, thinking as she did so. "Maybe-"

The door to the kitchen opened and, with a squishing of soaked galoshes and raincoats a crinkling, Entrapta came into the house, carrying huge bags of groceries in her hands and her hair, beaming brightly. “Sustenance has been acquired! And we got tiny food this time, actually!”

“It’s was hard to get too,” the voice behind Entrapta was muffled by the hood – and then said hood was thrown back...allowing Manny Noceda to step in and kiss his wife on the cheek. Camilia slid an arm comfortably around his hip, drawing him in, despite the fact he was still dripping wet from the rain outside. “But we managed to find something Entrapta here can eat.”

Catra hissed at him.

“Oh don’t you fret, she was thinking about your condition the whole time there,” Manny said, pursing his lips down at Catra.

“Uh, thank you, Mr. Noceda!” Amity said, clasping her hands together.

“Don’t mention it, Adora,” Manny said, chuckling. “Once you get used to the idea that magic is real, getting tiny food for a princess just seems normal.”

“I’m technically not a princess in this new timeline,” Entrapta said, looking around for a place to sit, then shrugging and hopping up onto the counter. She pulled out the first of the tiny cakes from

the grocery bag and popped it into her mouth. As she chewed, she pointed at Stringbean, grunting in an authoritative way. Stringbean seemed to take her meaning – and shapeshifted into a replica of a large, complex looking rune carved in steel. As he rattled into place on the surface of the table, everyone leaned over, looking at it.

"This is one of those magical runes?" Camila asked, uncertainty.

"Yeah," Amity said, sighing. "I studied some with Catra, but this is beyond me."

"Oooh! This should have worked!" Entrapta said.

Everyone looked at her.

"But Stringbean said that the you in the other timeline said that there was a thirty percent chance of it failing," Adora said.

"The other me wasn't this me!" Entrapta said, blithely – she seemed to take the extremely unsettling idea of multiple timelines, copies, and alternate universes as casually as she took the fact that cross-universal subconscious magical communication (her phrase) had inspired the creation of an entire frigging TV show based on them. Adora was still not even thinking about that because it was simply *too weird* for her to deal with right now. Entrapta continued. "This me, the me right now, has been studying magic and the Golden Guard's runes, and knows exactly why Luz Noceda's attempt to return to her home went wrong!"

"...how did it go wrong?" Amity asked.

"There was a seventy percent chance that the portal would open and Etheria survives. End result? Luz gets home. There was a thirty percent chance that the portal would open and Etheria explodes! End result? Luz gets home!"

"And we all die," Adora said.

"Yes!" Entrapta said. "But all runes are shaped by the intention of the caster when they're activated. That's how the fine tuned effects are created – Catra demonstrated that a lot! When she fought you! And tried to kill you! Many times!"

"Yes," Adora said, while Catra growled softly, her fur bristling up.

Entrapta cocked her head. "So, obviously…?"

Everyone looked at her blankly. Then Amity gasped.

"...wait," she said. "Are you saying we're all *here*, in this world-"

"Because Luz shaped the rune to get everyone out of there!" Entrapta said, her hair snatching another small cupcake up and popping it into her mouth. She chewed on it happily, swallowed,

then continued. “Transplanting an entire planetary population between multiple dimensions and across a lot of time took most of the rune’s energy. So it only got her halfway home – trapping her in the space between worlds, where she has been ever since.”

“Oh my *god*,” Camila whispered, hand going to her mouth.

“So...our girl,” Manny said, slowly. “Our baby girl has been trapped there? For how long?”

Entrapta blinked. “I don’t know,” she said, then hesitated. “B-But she did survive! With only minor mental instabilities and godlike powers.”

Camila and Manny looked at one another, their faces set and determined in equal measures.

“Well. How are we going to help her, then?” Camilia asked.

“I don’t know!” Entrapta said. “But this rune is a good place to start. We just need a power source. Magic enough to blow through the dimensional barries – akin to titan’s blood, or something of equal power. But first, more tiny food. I’m *starving*.”

As she took more food from the bags, Adora leaned back in her chair. “No. First things first...we have to fix Catra. If we’re going to be doing anything, we need Catra.”

Catra purred smugly.

Amity crossed her arms over her chest. “Yeah,” she said. “For one thing, she needs to have a mouth so she can apologize. To me.” She glared at the orange tabby. It was then, at that evening, in the Noceda’s house, that Adora saw a miracle on par with Jesus splitting the loaves or walking on water.

A cat that looked ashamed.

“Well, lets try magic,” Amity said, then stood up, her chair scraping. She lifted her hand, her fingers glowing as she frowned and focused. She drew a circle of shimmering purple light in the air, her brow furrowing. The magic flashed and a pink light surrounded Catra – then cracked apart into a spray of sparkles, sloughing onto the table and skittering away. Adora shook her head slowly.

“It needs more power,” Amity said, while Stringbean wriggled, then flew over to land on Adora’s shoulder.

“Titan-Ra could do it,” Entrapta said. “Based on my off the cuff observations.”

“But...the sword’s broken,” Adora said. “A-And…”

Her hand went to her chest. She felt the familiar panic-tightness of her lungs, squeezing her. She half closed her eyes.

"I...I don't have a bile sack," she whispered.

She tried to not feel the stinging of tears at the corners of her eyes. But it was impossible to not feel a spike of rage and anger and loss so intense that it made her hands shake – her mother had *ripped out* a part of her, without even asking, without even checking. Her whole youth, her childhood, all of it had been built on her body being twisted without her even knowing the case. How many broken bones had she gotten because her witch-born self had been deprived of the nutrients and vitamins and the *magic* that she had been born deserving to get?

"Well, try, maybe?" Amity asked, her voice nervous.

"By the Honor of Grayskull," Adora said. She didn't even need to finish saying it to know it wasn't going to work. She dropped her hand, then sagged and then shook her head. "I...I need to think." She stood up and walked away from the table before anyone stopped her. Distantly, she heard Camila saying – *well, it is late* – and then she was in her room. Well. Vee's room. She closed the door and leaned against it, knowing that Vee would be up here, to use the bed, while she slept on the futon that Mrs. Noceda had pulled out.

Adora just…

She just needed a few minutes alone to *figure this out*. To feel all the things she was feeling. She closed her eyes, resting her head against the door and breathing slowly.

Now, we need to help her – not just for her, but for everyone. To save the world…

The soft cheep cheep of Stringbean's voice caused Adora's eyes to open. The little snakeshifter had wriggled under the door and had hopped up onto her knees. Adora smiled, weakly. She reached down and petted Stringbean's head. "You're a good Palisman," she said. "You know...I bet you ended up in this world, because Luz knew that you had to be safe. Belos ate Palismans for food, didn't he?"

Stringbean squeaked and nodded, emphatically.

Adora sighed.

"I can't do it," she whispered. "I…"

Stringbean chirruped.

"No, I have to do it alone," Adora said. "I can't take Amity in there, to get hurt-"

Stringbean squeaked, then bumped her head against Adora's other knee – aggressively.

Adora flushed. "With Catra? You want me to...to not just zap her back to human, er, uh, cat-demon form, you want me to make up with her? Because...in…" She trailed off. She had been about to say *in both worlds, she was evil*. But that wasn't true. Was it. Catra had told Luz to not use the rune. She had, for a fleeting moment, seen someone else as more important than her. And if that Catra could...could this Catra?

...she already did…

Adora put her hands over her face, rubbing. "She's loyal to Belos."

Stringbean squeaked.

"...loyal to someone else?" she asked. "Who? She was willing to kill me, cause-"

Stringbean chirruped and rolled his big expressive eyes.

"Lilith!?" Adora blinked. Then she put together everything she had seen. She clicked her tongue. "Huh. You're right. Lilith was like her...adoptive mom." She bit her lip, starting to see a path. A tactical and emotional route towards not just *victory,* but towards everything that victory could promise. Love. Happiness.

Friendship. She blushed and nodded as she did so...and tripped over the first step. "But I can't. I'm not Titan-Ra anymore. I'm just...I'm just some magicless witch. No bile sack. Useless."

Stringbean focused.

The mental image was of Luz Noceda, in her horde costume, looking up at someone in awe, her eyes shining. She looked like Amity had, upon seeing Adora in the form of Titan-Ra. It was a view of a girl that could be quite addicting, something that Adora felt chagrined at how...intensely she appreciated. Then Stringbean shifted to a tiny Catra. She smiled up at Adora, and then twirled on one foot, bowing low.

Adora sighed, then reached down, touching the tiny Catra on her tiny head.

"Make it count," Stringbean said, aloud.

Adora blinked. "What?"

Stringbean jumped. She flew up and landed right between Adora's breasts, transforming mid flight into his sleek snakeshifter form. Stringbean pressed to Adora's shirt, then wriggled beneath. Skin to skin, the Palisman glowed – and then vanished. Adora felt something thump deep inside of her chest. She grunted, then clutched at herself. She gasped and trembled, her fingers tightening as she closed her eyes. The pain was intense and

shocking, growing hotter and redder. It was like the worst heart burn she had ever had, a throbbing ache deep inside of herself. She gasped out once more...then felt the pain recede. Moment by moment, it lessened, until there was only a dull ache. She stood, her knees shaking, as she patted around herself, looking around.

"S...Stringbean?" she whispered.

But they were gone.

They were *gone*.

What had the Palisman done? What had-

Adora's hand trembled. She lifted it up...and then focused.

And a spark of brilliant gold shimmered at the tip of her finger. The magic swelled within herself and she swirled her finger in a slow circle...and yanked forth a glittering sword of pure silvery light. She grasped the new Sword of Power, feeling its heft, its weight – deep in her chest, her bile sack throbbed and she stood there, her eyes glimmering with tears.

Make it count.

Adora closed her eyes.

“Thank you,” she whispered. “I will. I *will*, Stringbean.”

She walked to the window, then tossed it open. She stood on the sill, hopped down, onto the awning of the roof, then down to the grassy back yard. Rain soaked her as she looked up at the uncaring sky, at the universe that *took* and took and took and never seemed to give anything back. It had taken her parents. It had taken her childhood. It had taken King and Eda. It had taken Luz, a girl she somehow knew intimately without ever having properly met.

It had taken Stringbean.

“By the Honor...no…” Adora thrust the sword into the air. “By the *power* of *Grayskull*!”

Lightning slammed down into the sword tip and Adora’s whole body burst into dark flames. The crackling heat swept up along from her feet to her head, burning away her clothing and leaving the thick boots and the fluttering cape and the gambeson of herself as Titan-Ra. Her claws glinted and her eyes flashed gold as she lifted her head, the broad brim of her hat catching the rain and shimmering with the impact of it – a golden halo twinkling around her body. She grinned as she looked down at her palms...and she had expected to look different.

But…

She was still Adora. Wasn’t she?

She flexed her fingers, slowly, then turned back and walked into the house.

She had work to do.

***

Catra, the orange tabby, was snoozing as the rest of the house settled in for sleep. A clawed finger hooked onto the nape of her neck, catching the fuzz and lifting her up, causing her eyes to blink open, then her claws to come flashing out and her legs and arms to start whirling and flashing like a little killer can opener. Then she was swung into the bathroom adjoining to the kitchen, the door shutting with a click behind her. The lights came on and Catra saw she was being held up by a grimly determined looking Titan-Ra.

This caused her to, at the very least, stop clawing at the air.

She was set down into the dry bed of the sink, which she filled like an orange liquid. Her eyes glinted up at Titan-Ra, as if to say: *Well? Get a move on!*

Titan-Ra drew a slow breath, lifting her palms up, her fingers spreading as runes shimmered along her wrists. She spread her fingers and then clenched her jaw. There was a buzzing crackle. A spray of sparks skittered along the counertop, sending tiny curlicues of smoke as they hit the grout. The glow in the sink grew pale red, then orange, then pale white, then flashed brilliantly – and once the light had faded, a fully grown Catra was sitting on the counter, wincing as her back was jammed into the faucet.

Said Catra was also completely naked – her body bare and exposed and utterly lovely. Titan-Ra looked at her, and Catra knew she still had it. She smirked slightly.

"So...now we go and kill that crazy witch?"

"No," Titan-Ra said, frowning at her.

"Adora!" Catra hissed. "She's *insane*. You heard what Stringbean said."

"Yeah, I did," Titan-Ra said. She planted a big palm up and over Catra's head. Catra's ears pinned back as she felt herself trapped between two Titan-Ra's. One looming ahead, the other filling the mirror behind her. "And in another life-"

"Not my life!" Catra pushed away from the sink. This ended up sliding her off the counter and molding her body against Titan-

Ra's bulk and warmth. The urge to grind against her, to hug her, to b...to be *weak* burned through Catra. She took every feeling she had right now – feelings about the Emperor, and Lilith, and the Boiling Isles, and the stupid story that little snakeshifter had blabbed about, and she crammed them all down. Later. She had to win.

She headed for the door, her tail lashing.

"I don't remember it either," Titan-Ra...no...Adora. She was *Adora*. Catra wasn't going to give her the power of Titan-Ra's title. "But that doesn't matter."

"Yes it does!" Catra turned around, her eyes narrowing to slits. "You don't do things to help total strangers."

"Yes, you do," Adora said. She walked forward. "But also, it doesn't matter because whether we remember it or not, it *happened*." She grabbed onto Catra's wrist, lifting her hand away from her chest before Catra could claw at her. "Luz is out there – and she saved all of us. Maybe she saved us from herself, but she still *saved* us. She suffered. And we need to *help* her. Not kill her." Her voice grew soft. "We have to all *make* it. The other end."

"And then what?" Catra snapped. "We all fall in love and become one big happy four way polycule with me and Amity and you and Luz?" She sneered. "Grow up, Adora. That's not how this happens."

“Why not?” Adora asked. Those gold on black eyes were so guileless. So trusting. It made Catra want to *spit*.

“Because we don’t get happy endings!” Catra hissed. She wrenched her hand away from her wrist. “Dykes and trannies and faggots don’t *get* happy endings. That’s for people like Camila – she gets a husband, she gets a family, she gets kids. We get shit parents and camps that torture you and even if we fucking get something, it gets taken away from us!” Adora was casting some kind of spell on her. Invisibility, surely. That was why she kept blurring in and out of focus. “So trying is *stupid*. It was stupid that I tried. It was *stupid*.”

“You...weren’t really fighting for the Emperor. Were you?” Adora’s voice was soft. “You were fighting for Lilith.”

“Shut up,” Catra hissed.

Her eyes closed and Adora’s hand slid around the back of her head. She felt the cool touch of those claws against her scalp. Adora’s forehead pressed to her forehead. And she was quiet. She did remain silent. She did shut up. And Catra was forced to...think about what she had said. Had she tried to throw herself between Belos and Titan-Ra to save the Emperor? Yes. Obviously. But...the Emperor was also why she was in the Emperor’s Coven. It was why Lilith was...her…

“Shut up,” Catra whispered.

"I didn't say anything," Adora whispered. Her voice actually held a tiny bit of laughter – and a lot of tears.

Catra leaned into her. Her face mashed against Adora's chest and she felt her strength sliding out of her body. Her arms went weak and she trembled, her voice hitching as she started to cry. "I'...I'm sorry…" She gasped out. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry…"

Adora held her – and Catra didn't know who she was even apologizing *too*.

Was it…

Was it Adora?

No.

No it wasn't. Was it.

Titan-Ra flashed away. Adora and Catra's eyes were on level again, and when she sniffed and wiped at her nose, Adora offered her a bit of tissue paper. Camila bought thick, downy tissue paper. It felt almost impossibly decadent to blow one's nose on it, but Catra did so – making a decidedly un-cat-like honking nose. She sniffed, then whispered. "C-Can you get me some clothes?"

Adora grinned at her. “Sure.”

“I mean, after you’re done admiring me,” Catra said, her voice so snotty and thick nosed that it was funny rather than annoying. Adora grinned, then leaned in and kissed her. The kiss had been completely unplanned, unprepared, unexpected. But as she tilted her head and leaned in...Catra kissed her back with a wild, fierce passion. Her mouth opened, her tongue swept into Adora’s mouth, her hands went to her hips. She pressed her naked body to Adora’s clothed one, holding herself against her as she moaned and kissed and kissed and kissed – and then when Adora broke the kiss, Catra kissed her again – giving her just a single second to gasp for air. Her heart thundered and her vision threatened to black out as Catra clung to her like she was a raft in a storm tossed seas.

Finally, Adora had to put her hands on Catra’s shoulders, shoving her back against the door, which shivered with the impact. The two gasped.

“Crikey…” Adora gasped.

“...crikey?” Catra sounded baffled. Then she shook her head, her eyes closing. “D-Don’t let it go to your head, Gray.”

“How can I possibly do that!?” Adora asked, flushing. “Catra, I-”

“Shut up!” Catra closed her eyes even tighter. “Just. I’m being stupid, I-”

Adora kissed her again. This kiss seemed to last forever. It was gentle and it was sweet, and it lingered. When Adora drew away, her voice was soft.

“We *are* going to have a happy ending,” she breathed. “Even if we have to kick God in the...butt to do it.”

Catra’s ears were up and twitching. She was rumbling, deep in her chest. A purr.

“Which means we are going to get your dressed and we are going to have you *apologize* to Amity Blight. And you are going to beg on your knees for her forgiveness.”

Catra’s ears pinned back. She closed her eyes.

But rather than snapping, hissing, snarling, or even drawing her claws...she simply nodded.

“Right,” she whispered.

Beat.

"Okay, c-can you strangle me first? Snap my neck? Throw me down a big pit? A-Anything? That all sounds easier. I can go fight, uh, a local neo-nazi mob completely naked, just-"

"Come on."

The door opened and Adora yanked her girlfriend out – heading up the stairs, where she could hunt for something approximating clothing.

***

Adora gently rapped her knuckles on the door that led into what was normally a computer office and had been turned into another tiny niche for someone to sleep. In this case, Amity. The door opened and Amity's blue head peeked out. Right. Her hair had been turned to a blue color by Luz Noceda, with her barely controlled powers.

"I- ...what are you *wearing*?"

The question was aimed Catra, who was blushing hard as she stood in a knee length T-shirt with Tyranicus Prime, the half T-rex, half-ninja, all cop star of Transofficer: Robots in Law Enforcement, which was one of the many, many, many niche T-shirts that Manny and Camila Noceda had collected in their long marriage. It

covered her body reasonably well, but it was also *extremely* silly and decidedly three decades out of sync with Catra's actual sensibilities.

"We couldn't find p-" Adora started.

"It's the only shirt!" Catra snapped, hurriedly, her cheeks flushing.

Amity sighed, slightly. Her amusement and her confusion looked as if they were being buried under boulders, the light in her eyes dimming as she frowned. "What do you two want?" she asked, her voice flat.

"Well, uh, Catra wanted to say something," Adora said, firmly.

Catra gulped. "C-Can we come in?"

"Anything you can say, you can say *here*," Amity said.

Adora nodded.

Catra, though, was slowly looking away from Amity, and then down the corridor. There, Bow and Glimmer were peeking from their room, with Scorpia and Entrapta peeking from the door across from them, and Vee was peeking out of her room as well, all of them doing the absolute worst job concealing it that anyone possibly could have imagined. Catra looked back at Amity.

“Are we...*sure*?” Catra whispered.

Amity rolled her eyes, then stepped back, gesturing. There was almost no space in her makeshift room – she had to perch herself on a desk that Manny normally used for his day job, while Adora had to cram herself into the corner where the door normally was resting when it was opened, and Catra...Catra dropped to her knees next to the sleeping bag that Camila had dredged up from the basement and used as a bed for Amity. She put her hands onto the ground, bowed her head low, and said.

“I’m really really really really really really really really sorry.”

Adora blinked. She had not expected Catra to go for that right away. She expected a lot more sidling around the idea, pawing at it like...well…a cat.

“You’re...sorry,” Amity said, slowly.

“Yes,” Cata whispered.

“You’re sorry that you lied to me? That you pretended to be someone you’re not, to seduce me, so you could...what? Destroy the rebellion?” Amity shook her head. “What *was* your plan, exactly?”

Catra was quiet as she lifted her head up. She blushed.

"I…" She hesitated. "W-Well, uh…"

Come on, Catra, keep on with this, you're doing so well! Adora thought, blushing hard. She also tried to be as invisible as possible in her corner. She felt her heart thumping against her newly reforged bile sack. It was a decidedly odd sensation. Catra closed her eyes.

"...in the other world," Catra said. "Everything Stringbean showed us about Luz. I...I recognized what that other Catra was doing. Because it was what I was doing. I'm...*just* smart enough t-to lie to myself really, really good." She ducked her head forward again, her shoulders slumping, her ears drooping. "I-I thought I had this big plan to defeat Titan-Ra and show up Adora and...*win*. But in truth? I just...I just wanted to be...to…" She trailed off. "I'm sorry."

Amity looked from Catra to Adora, then back to Catra.

"What did you do to her?" Amity asked.

Catra snapped her head up.

"Like...did you cast a spell?" Amity looked curious.

"Hey!" Catra said, her cheeks burning. Then, more quietly. "I...Titan damn it, Amity, it's because we don't have *time*. Every second here, Luz...does...something more out there. And I...if...if I was willing to lose for her, then I am...I…" She trailed off, then closed her eyes. "In every...single timeline I seem to be surrounded b-by women who I don't deserve. So, I reacted the way I always do." She shrugged, her hands pressed flat to the floor. "I lashed out."

We don't get happy endings.

"And Adora kicked me in the butt."

Even if we have to fight God…

"A-And...I realized that I am not getting lucky in a third universe." Catra lifted her head up, her eyes brimming with tears as she looked up into Amity's eyes. Amity looked down at her, her ears lifting up subtly. The tips trembling. "So I better start deserving you now."

Amity pursed her lips.

"I-I'm sorry too!" Adora added, blurting it out. "I. Kinda came off sorta. Bad. When. In high school. Hexside. I mean. I-"

“Adora, shut up,” Amity said. “You’re *Titan-Ra*, you don’t have to apologize for anything.”

“Oh,” Adora said, blinking.

Amity knelt down. She put her hand on Catra’s shoulder.

“I accept your apology,” she said, her voice brittle. “But we’re *not* okay.”

Catra flinched.

“However,” Amity said, her voice prim. “I’ve been...taking notes. About Luz, and you, and Adora. And I think that, once we have saved the world and brought Luz to her senses, that I could be...convinced...to accept a date.” She smiled, slightly. Her primness dimmed slightly. “One date. For each of you. We’ll see how things go from there, then?”

Catra blinked. Then she smiled, shyly. “I...I’d like that.”

“Can I and Catra go on a date too?” Adora asked.

“Adora, you don’t need to date me, you’ve known me since we were kids!” Catra snapped.

“Okay, actually, you two should go on a date while I watch,” Amity said, giggling as she put her hand over her mouth. “It would be...um...educational.”

Catra blushed, then sat back onto her haunches, her butt pressing to her ankles. “Okay, I’m willing to apologize and work to be a better person, but lets not push things too far.” She said, frowning.

“By which she means of course,” Adora said, taking hold of Catra’s arm, yanking her to her feet.

The two left, leaving Amity shaking her head slowly.

Once the door was closed, Amity’s entire face turned beat red and she put her hands over her face, whispering.

“Girls.”

***

The gang stood in the crisp and cool morning – the sun shining down through skies that had blown to clear blue, the brightness of the sun only making the chill feel more stark and intense. Adora had her sword resting on her shoulder, her face grim and her voice focused.

“All right,” she said. “I am pretty sure that, with my powers as Titan-Ra, we can bust a hole back into the Demon Realm. We don’t know what or how much Luz has done in there with her Collector Powers. What we do know is that she is...not in a good place right now.”

She looked at Glimmer and Bow. Glimmer had her staff out, and Bow had a bow that he and Manny had bought together by hitting a hunting store. The arrows were all made by Bow’s own hand, and he was trying the new pulley system for his bow with a gigantic grin. Delighted to hold a human bow, Bow was. They both met her eyes and nodded, determined.

“But we know that she’s, at heart, a good person,” Adora continued. She kept tracking her eyes across the group.

Scorpia nodded, her claws clicking together. Entrapta was looking off at a butterfly – but despite her head being turned aside, she still lifted her hand to give a firm thumbs up.

“And we’re not going to let her hurt anyone – not now, not ever…”

Catra and Amity, standing side by side, both nodded. Catra’s body was covered in runes tucked into pockets and pouches, and she had two packs of runeing paper on her hips, with a dozen styluses tucked into her belt. Amity was cracking her knuckles.

"...we're going to bring her home," Adora whispered.

Manny and Camila both stood side by side, looking nervous, but ready. Manny had a binder. Camila had a baseball bat. Together, they looked ready to cover both possible solutions to their wayward, dimensionally displaced, temporally terrifying daughter.

Adora turned back to where the dimensional door had broken – where she could feel the tingling thinness of space between worlds. She knew this was the spot.

"And Vee promised she'll keep the house safe for as long as we need," she muttered under her breath. Since. Well.

Adora already owed Vee so much. Asking her to throw herself into fire and danger again – after inflicting her own mom on her, even for a few weeks?

No way.

Adora drew her sword off her shoulder, then clenched her hand around it. Magic crackled and she lifted her blade above her head then brought it swinging down in a curving arc – slashing a shimmering white line. Adora lifted her leg up and kicked the air as hard as she could.

Reality itself splintered outwards – and the whole group sprang through the crackling hole, seconds before it snapped shut.

Trapping them in what the Boiling Isles had become.

"...this may be harder than I anticipated," Adora whispered, softly, as she looked up and up...and up.

TO BE CONTINUED

Amity Blight Saves the World

Chapter Summary

> The gang all works together to kiss one girl! Also, the thrilling conclusion!

The Boiling Isles had been unwound and spread apart, like the middle of an explosion, caught in the exact second where the shock-wave has propagated, but the pieces haven't quite managed to splatter against the walls. The chunks of the landmass were not aligned – instead, they angled off into different directions, some were even entirely upside down, buildings and trees facing towards the burbling, hissing seas. The shape of the Titan's skeleton was still visible and even arranged in almost the correct pose for a standing person – save that all the parts were floating away from one another and disconnected. The skull was cocked to the side, and blazed with a purple light.

Adora gulped as she put her clawed hand up onto her hat, tilting it backwards to look up and up along this expanse of chaos.

"I think Luz may be having problems with her powers," Bow said, his voice soft.

"No, she's not," Catra said, and Adora saw it too. She looked down at Adora, while Amity frowned, then sighed.

"Yeah," Amity said. "This is just like Land God Amok, book 12."

“Oh my god, you’re right,” Manny said, startling each of them. “When the Land God goes mad.”

“You’ve...read...the Good Witch Azuara series?” Amity asked, while Adora looked back up and towards the swirling landmasses.

How do we even get there? She thought. The skull. It felt like the right place to her – not just because she had also read the Land God Amok too, but because she could feel the pulsing of her heart, drawing her towards it. Luz was there. Doing what? *Trying to fix it,* she thought, while a swirling pulse of magic emerged from the side of the skull, sweeping along a profusion of the caught landmasses. Where it went, it left the stones and tumbling bones...changed subtly. The colors had shifted and the slow motion movement of the lands had altered, turning their trajectories to new and chaotic directions.

But not back together.

“Heh, uh, well,” Manny said, rubbing the back of his neck. “I picked it up on a lark – I needed *something* to read and it was easy, cheap, and colorful. Then it turned out, I really liked it.”

Adora pointed with her finger. “There!”

Everyone looked and Glimmer nodded. “Yeah, I think we can get there…”

The tiny landmass Adora had spotted was between the foot – where they stood – and the shin bone – which was currently canted at a forty five degree angle, so, it could possibly be standable upon. But as she turned to the rest of the group to lay out her plan, Glimmer slapped her hand onto Adora and Bow's back, then focused. The pink flash of light and magic crackled around Adora, and when it faded, they were standing on the boulder that hung in the air...and despite the fact that they were facing up towards the sky, gravity tried to pull them, hard, to the left. Adora yelped, grabbed onto the side of the boulder, and snagged onto Glimmer with one arm, while Bow snatched onto her hips and dangled from their legs.

The disorientation lasted for a flash, then Adora's instincts guided her. She scrambled one handed, then pushed herself up and found herself standing on the boulder. Except she was perpendicular to the group that was gaping up at them from the foot. The boulder's gravity was *not* directed alongside the axis that Adora had expected, and she groaned.

"Great, every landmass has its own facing."

"No, that's good!" Bow said, standing and brushing dust off his shirt, which he subtly started to roll upwards, to show off his tummy muscles. "It means we'll not have to cling to the roof of Hexside, see?"

He pointed and Adora saw that Hexside was, in fact, upside down. It was also several miles overhead, rendered toylike by the distance. Glimmer grabbed onto them both, focused, and they

appeared with a flash on the forested chunk that they had been aiming for. The land here, despite being canted at a forty five degree angle, felt like they were standing on perfectly level ground. Adora grinned at Glimmer. “Go get the rest of them,” she said. “Will you be able to handle it?”

“Sure can!” Glimmer said, though her skin looked lightly dusted with sweat. “It’s gonna be tiring by the end, but...”

She shrugged, then vanished with a spray of sparkles.

“Okay,” Bow said, then tested his bow, twirling his finger and conjuring an illusory arrow. “We’re still not sure what we’re going to run into here…”

“Well, well, well!”

The voice that broke into their conversation was subtly wrong. It was too high, too scratchy. It was not exactly the voice of the *sane*. Adora turned and saw someone stepping around the corner of the woods. She reevaluated her opinions rapidly.

It was not the voice of the exactly *real*.

The figure was like a blurry sketch of a human or witch. All angular planes and buzzing, crackling edges. The lines and vertices of their oddly geometric body were completely wrong,

turning into jagged angles and intersecting planes with every movement of their body – creating the flickering on/off look of a bugged video game character. The only thing that remained constant was the eyes: two glowing, jagged rents in the angular geometries of their head.

"What the- ...what are you?" Bow asked.

"Of course trespassers wouldn't recognize Gilana the Tree Sprite!" the figure buzzed at them, lifting their – her – arms and juddering from side to side.

"Right," Adora said, ransacking her memory – Gilana was a friendly character from the books. She had helped Azura and even shown mercy to Hecatae, when required. She served a greater queen. Was that Queen...well, it had to be...she gulped, then spread her arms in a bow. "Uh, forsooth, Gilana, we're here to see, uh, yonder Queen Luz!"

"*Liiiiiiiiiiiar*!" The false Gilana buzzed and turned into a warbling cloud of static. "You want to *hurt* her! You all want to hurt her!"

Her cloud split, then split, then split again – and suddenly Adora and Bow were surrounded by dozens of the jagged figures. Bow knocked an arrow made of raw illusory magic, while Adora gripped her sword.

"We're not here to hurt Luz!" Adora said.

“Then why *did* you leave her!?” One of the Gilana’s sprinted at her, fingers twisting into claws. Adora lifted her sword to block the buzzing crackle. She felt a physical impact, not just the haze of static – and when she grabbed onto the Gilana’s chest and prepared to hurt her, she felt something hazy under the static. There was something there, something more than just a construct conjured out of Luz’s imagination and isolation. She hesitated – and this allowed the Gilana to slash at her face with her claws. Adora jerked her head back mere seconds before she lost a good chunk of her skin – and then Catra dropped down between her and the creature, slapping a rune onto their chest and causing an explosion of vines to loop around her and bind her into place.

“Only I get to claw up Adora, and we do it consensually now,” Catra said, smirking.

“No we don’t!” Adora exclaimed.

The vined up creature writhed and tried to drag itself free. But through the hazy, shifting pattern of the corruption…

“It’s the triclops girl!” Adora exclaimed.

“Boscha?” Bow asked, lowering his bow before he shot one of the other snarling creatures, focusing on dodging away. “These are people?”

"I think they are, so, uh, don't-"

Camila, who had just arrived, thanks to Glimmer teleporting in with her, Manny and Entrapta, screamed and swung her baseball bat at one of the creatures. The *clonk* sound of the bat impacting with a skull was pretty remarkable. The creature fell over and sparks hissed and bubbled away, revealing a prone, insensate witchling – a man, who Adora didn't recognize. Bow, though, blinked. "Oh my god, Mrs. Noceda, you just killed Mattholomule!"

Mattholomule groaned on the ground as Camila blinked and held her bat tighter. "H-He's just unconscious!" she said, then whispered under her breath. "*Oh Dios, nunca le voy a mencionar esto a la PTA."*

"Don't worry, witchlings are pretty tough," Adora said, using her sword in a two handed grip to block a slashing set of claws. She smashed her pommel into the top of a flickering figure's head. When they sprawled, it was another girl from Hexside, though Adora couldn't put a name to her face. The other creatures snarled into the melee – and Glimmer transported Scorpia in. Scorpia, then, immediately rendered most of the fight moot. With the speed of a striking, uh, scorpion, Scorpia slammed her tail into the spine of each of the attacking figures and left them all sprawled on the ground. Hexside students, one and all.

"Collector energy, focused and used to create a metastable personality layer over a consciousnesses bearing witchling!" Entrapta said as she knelt beside the prone and groaning Mattholomule, poking his cheek with a stick she had fetched off the ground. "Fascinating…"

“Uh, don’t poke Matt with a stick,” Bow said.

Entrapta hesitated, then set the stick down, before leaning over and poking his cheek with her finger. “The energies have dissipated – I think they’re related to a certain level of coherency within the host.”

“Bonk em, then they’re not evil anymore, got it,” Catra said, then grinned at Camila. “See, Cammi, they’re fine.”

“Cammi?” Camila asked, while Adora grabbed onto Catra by the scruff of her neck, dragging her away from their hostess. She leaned in, hissing.

“Cammi?”

“What?” Catra asked, shrugging. “It’s a cute nickname.”

“Are you *flirting* with Mrs. Noceda!?” Adora hissed even softer.

Catra opened her mouth, her tail flicking. Then her ears drooped. “Uh. It’s a reflex.”

“Oh my god, Catra.”

A lightning bolt slammed down into the center of the clearing. Blazing purple light flashed over everything and Adora and Catra sprang away from one another to face it. The entire group watched as the purple fires crackled, buzzed, then faded away. And there was Luz Noceda. Her body had been somewhat healed from the *last* time that Adora had seen her – the cracks and winding lines of fire that had been trying to escape from her skin had been sealed away, refined down to just a single purple circle of fire that surrounded one eye, which had turned a brilliant gold. It was as if she had compacted her Collector powers down into one tiny spot, and left the rest of her untouched. She was dressed in a hoodie and shorts and those sleek leggings under the shorts, with pale white tennis shoes.

"...Luz?" Camila asked, her voice nervous. "A-Are you my Luz?"

"M...M...Mom?" Luz blinked, looking at her, her eyes widening. "W-What are you doing here? No, no, no, you're mad at me!" She drew her legs up, shaking her head. She closed her eyes. "It was okay, she said she was okay, she's okay."

Adora felt as if the entire moment was hanging on the thinnest of threads. She shifted, subtly, moving to stand between Catra and Luz. The last thing she wanted was for Luz to see Catra and…

And what?

Freak out?

She wasn't sure if Luz's anger at Catra was because of guilt over what Luz had done, when she had been trapped in the other world...or anger over what Catra had done, when Catra had met Amity in the new timeline. Or...well...maybe it was both. Whatever the option, she wanted to limit it as much as possible.

"Y-You're my daughter," Camilia said, softly. "I know you've been alone for a long time. But we're here for you now."

"W-We…" Luz blinked.

Then she saw Manny, stepping forward. He was holding the binder full of photos. Adora had watched him pack them – family photos, pictures of him and Camila, and of their hopes and dreams. None of them had Luz, but each of them had the hope for her, hidden inside them, even if she had never come to pass in their world. Adora looked from them to Luz...and saw that Luz was shaking her head, her eyes closing tightly.

"No. No! No! No! No! Not again! Not again!" She screamed. "Go away!"

"Luz, wait-"

"I said *go away*!"

Purple fire streamed from her and Adora yelped as she was caught up in the tidal wave. The energies buzzed against her, overwhelming and burning. She tumbled, fell, skidded...and then pushed herself to her feet. She was alone in the clearing – alone, save for Luz. She had her hands over her face, sobbing. She curled in on herself, while shadows grew around her. They projected up around her – shapes of beds and bleeping machines and wires, running into a skeletally thin body, the face obscured by shadows. Adora gaped at the view...and whispered.

"Oh no."

Luz lowered her hands, then glared at her. "Y-You. Why are you still *here*?"

"Luz, wait!" Adora said. "That wasn't your imagination! Luz, your father, he's-"

"*Shut up!*" Luz shot off into the sky, leaving behind a rumbling *boom* of displaced air.

Adora lowered her hand, then slammed her sword into the ground and shoved herself to her feet. She was completely alone. Even the shades had been banished by Luz's sweep of power. She looked around herself, slowly, then started to jog towards the edge of this floating landmass.

If everyone else had been banished, she'd just need to find them.

***

Amity slammed, hard, into a remarkably soft wall, rebounded, and hit an even softer bed, face first. She groaned, then pushed herself up onto her hands and knees. She lifted her head, looking around – and then yelped as a figure dropped onto her head. "Weehhhh!" Tiny paws and claws slapped at her, while she tried to process that she was in a...room that looked an awful lot like her room, if it had been sculpted entirely out of psychadelic colors. She grabbed onto the thing battering at her, yanked it off, and held it at arms length.

"...the Clawthorne's dog?" Amity asked, blinking in surprise at the small, furred creature.

"I am not their dog!" The figure shouted. "I'm King!"

"Oh," Amity said, then set him down on the bed beside her. "What are you doing here? Why did you attack me?"

"I...thought you might be the weird insane god that has captured us all," King said, sounding a little huffy at how little his attack had done.

“She’s not a god,” Amity said, frowning as she stood up. She brushed her hands through her electric blue hair – a reminder of how easily her body could be twisted, changed, and altered by Luz. The memory was disconcerting. But Amity was used to people with power over her that she’d need to work around. She sighed, then walked to the door of her room. She tried opening it – only to find that the knob wasn’t a knob. It was as if the whole door was one piece, and the knob was just a molded chunk that extruded from the wall. “...for one thing, she can’t really make a door.”

“I thought it was just a prison,” King said. “She crammed me in here, while apologizing and saying she’d be back to give me treats. Then she came back and gave me a bowl full of bugs, then ran away crying. Well, flew. Which is silly, the bugs were delicious.” He licked his lips. “They tasted just like ice cream!”

“Huh,” Amity said, then frowned. “Well. That’s Luz Noceda. In another timeline, she and you were best friends.”

“Weh!?” King sat back on his haunches.

“And we just need to get her to calm down and accept our help,” Amity said, then frowned, intently. “The first step is talking to her. How often does she visit this room?”

“It’s hard to tell,” King said. “Because, well-”

The light outside the window shifted, suddenly and jarringly, to complete night. The sun and moon had shifted around and the stars came out with a sickening lurch. Distant, melancholy music started to play – echoing throughout the village of Bonesburrough, which Amity could just *barely* see out the window. She stepped up onto the bed, standing on her toes to peek out – the window was situated far higher than it should have been. Bonesburrough looked as if it had been partially merged with a place of iron and steel and hissing technology...Belosian machinery, almost, save it had a harder edge. The centerpiece was a large, curved tower that jutted from where Hexside should have been. Sitting on it was a distant figure, her palms cupped over her face. She seemed to be surrounded by shimmering shadows – phantasms that Amity couldn't quite make out. She felt King scrabble up her back, peering out the window with her.

"Yeah," King said. "When she's sad, the skies get dark, and sometimes, sappy music plays. But I've never seen anything like that before."

Amity let herself drop from her tip toes to her heels. She frowned, rubbing her chin.

"Her powers aren't entirely under her control," she said, softly. "Have you ever had a thought you can't get rid of? Imagine that, but it becomes real."

King looked unsure. "What do we do?"

“Well, first, we get that door down,” Amity said. “Do you know where Edalynn or Lilith are?”

“No,” King said. “I’ve been stuck in here!”

“Okay. We get that door down, we try and find Edalynn and Lilith, or the rest of my friends. Adora and Catra are here.”

“Catra, the Golden Guard?” King asked.

“Well, she’s not that anymore,” Amity said, then flushed. “W-We, uh, we’re actually gonna go on a date if we survive this. Not that you needed to know that. I should stop talking. I’m talking too much. Door! We’re gonna...door! Now!” She said, her entire face going redder with every inch she dug herself. She twirled her finger, and focused. Conjuring abomination goop from nowhere was hard – but she had time enough to focus on it. And so, she made her first thimble full, which splattered to the ground.

“...and?” King asked.

“Just give me a bit!” Amity said, a bit irritated as she lifted her finger and twirled it again.

Another thimbleful splattered onto the ground, making a rather pathetic purple pile.

“It’s gonna take a while,” Amity admitted.

***

Catra hissed as she skidded to a stop – the transportation had been so similar to Glimmer sending her sparkling around that she almost wanted to slash out with her claws out of pure reflex. Instead, she forced herself to yank her claws back and regard where she was. She was in a metal corridor – an intestinal spread of pipes covered the walls and the ceiling was grated. The floor was gunmetal gray, and the whole place smelled faintly antiseptic. She scowled as she turned back – and then yelped. Luz Noceda was standing behind her.

Her purple eye mark was gone. And she wasn’t in the same hoodie and spanks combo – she was dressed in a red jacket that reminded Catra achingly of Adora’s, and she had a badge on her chest that...was also faintly familiar. She gave Catra a curious look.

“Uh...Catra...what are you wearing?”

“What am I-” Catra looked down at her rune magic get up, then at Luz. “What are you wearing?”

“My...uniform?” Luz arched an eyebrow, cocking her head. “Uh. Catra. Did you bonk your head?” She stepped close, peering in, narrowing her eyes as she took hold of Catra’s head, peering at

her as if she was checking over a machine. “Catra, did you get brain damage?”

“No!” Catra exclaimed, shoving Luz back against the nearby wall. Luz giggled, shaking her head.

“Then, come on! Lets get you into your uniform, we’re late for the ceremony,” she said, shrugging.

“What ceremony!?”

“Okay, you are not shaking the brain damage allegations, *gata*,” Luz said, her eyes crinkling as she grinned lopsidedly at her. “The ‘we won the war’ ceremony? The one we’ve...been...working for for, like, ever?” She asked, her hands sliding to Catra’s hands. She leaned her head down, kissing one of Catra’s knuckles. The electric touch of lips to skin made Catra’s entire body tingle. It was...disconcerting, to say the least, to have a girl so obviously and earnestly know her, while Catra felt nothing but a big yawning gap.

Then Luz giggled and peeled Catra’s palm off her shoulder, freeing her wrist so she could kiss her right *there*.

Catra hadn’t known that she had an erogenous zone there. She hadn’t known that a nibble there could make her entire body feel as if she had been hooked up to a magical rune of lightning. She

stood perfectly still as Luz kissed along her arm, to her throat, then to her ear, stepping in close.

"And after, we can celebrate…" She crooned. "Just us, together."

"Uh…" Catra trembled.

Her brain skipped.

Then it clicked into place.

This isn't Luz.

Or…

Well.

Maybe it was Luz.

Luz could do anything, as a Collector. Right? So, why not forget? Why not wind things backwards? Catra blushed and then decided that no, it was not her own sapphic lusts guiding her choices, this was solid tactics. "Lets go, then, babe!" she said, grinning and sliding her arm around Luz's back. Luz giggled.

“That’s Force Captain Babe to you, *gata* girl.”

Catra and Luz walked along the corridor – and around the first corner, Catra swore she could see a final shifting and settling of walls and floor, as if everything around her was being hastily thrown together by contractors pushing things around on dollies. The chamber was empty, save for Hordak, who was standing on a podium. He looked oddly flat. Catra cocked her head. No, Hordak wasn’t *oddly* flat, he was literally flat. There was no third dimension to him at all, he was only visibly real if you looked at him dead on. Catra looked from him to Luz – and she saw the strain collecting around her eyes now. She clung tighter to Catra, her body trembling, while the room became hazy with the faint shapes of Horde soldiers, all of them moving silently, their arms waving.

“Luz,” Catra said, her voice soft.

“I...I…” Luz screwed her eyes shut. The room warbled. Then it blew apart. The only part that remained intact was the tiny scrap of metal Catra was standing on – the walls flew away, the ceiling twisted apart, and Catra saw that they were standing on a palm of the Boiling Isles – Hexide and Bonesburrough were distant objects that she could see over a vertigo inducing drop down miles and miles of empty space, with the only thing between being boulders, tumbling bits of earth, displaced trees, and one griffon who had been frozen mid spider-belch.

Luz’s eyes were still closed. “We’re here. Together again.”

“Luz, it’s okay!” Catra said, feeling like she was drowning in muck. She wanted to say so many things – they were all confused and stuck in her throat. She instead put her hands on Luz’s shoulders – but then Luz started to blaze with that purple fire again. It flared between the cracks in her skin, tingling along Catra’s palms.

“We’re...I’m...I can fix it!” Luz hissed. “I can...I can-”

Her body exploded into a spray of purple sparkles and flames. Catra realized only now that she had been leaning against the other girl – she fell to her knees through the sparkles, trying to grasp for her. But the Luz-figment was gone. Catra felt the confusion come up her throat. The only issue was it came out all too clear.

“Luz!” She gasped out, tears brimming in her eyes.

So, that’s what it feels like, Catra realized, dizzily. She had never known what completely and totally unconditional love had felt like, until that scant brush with Luz. Every other love she had ever had in her life had had...hooks in it. The messy relationship with Adora, the lies around Amity, the power dynamics with every other girl she had picked up as the Golden Guard. Catra barely knew Luz, but at this moment, if anything had happened to her, Catra was pretty sure that she would have to kill everyone in the world, then herself.

“But it’s not going to come to that,” she whispered, dizzily.

She stood on her tiny platform of stability, tensed, then leaped. She sailed up, down, dropped onto an outcropping of rock, then slapped down a rune. The vine that burst from it gave her something to swing on – clearing a twenty foot gap to land on the next rock.

There was one nice thing about going down.

Gravity was working *for* her now.

***

Adora dug her claws into the rocky earth and hauled herself up and over the lip, then swung herself up and onto the latest lip of her climb. She laid on her back, panting softly. Titan-Ra or no, climbing this much and leaping this often was taking its toll. She looked up at the sky, closed her eyes, and muttered. "Almost there."

She stood and surveyed the chunk of land she had been heading for for the past half hour: It was what contained most of Bonesburrough. However, it had been merged with what, from what she had seen of the *She-Ra* show that Camila had mentioned, a good chunk of the Fright Zone. She felt a buzzing tingle in her chest…

Luz was nearby.

She gathered herself and leaped – then landed on the alleyway between two buildings. The air was thick with the smell of magic, and she advanced forward, moving cautiously, sword in her hand.

"Psst! Adora!"

She jerked, spun – and lowered her sword.

Eda grinned at her, peering out from around a corner.

"Eda!?" Adora whispered, then stepped forward and threw her arms around her older witch, squeezing her tightly, then pulled back. She looked Eda over. She looked as if she had been living in the streets for a few days – dirty, tired, but generally herself. She hadn't been transformed, transfigured, or altered in any way. Of course, that made Adora a little bit suspicious. So, she kept herself somewhat reserved as she whispered. "How did you manage to hide out here?"

"It has been a crazy few days," Eda whispered back. "But that girl?"

"Luz Noceda," Adora supplied, helpfully.

"Right. She's captured a bunch of people and changed them. I managed to hide out with Rayne Whispers."

“Whose Rayne Whispers?” Adora asked.

“My old enbyfriend,” Eda said, shrugging. “It’s kinda complicated. How do you know who this insane demigod is?”

“It’s kinda complicated,” Adora admitted.

“Well, I’ve been observing her. Her pattern is pretty simple,” Eda said. “First, she’ll go and talk to some new person – the Blights, Kikimora, sometimes Lilith…” She frowned, slightly. “Then something will go wrong – they’ll say something, or she’ll do something, then she runs off and night falls.” She points up at the sky. “And she cries to herself. And I’ve been thinking that’s when we strike. When she’s distracted, we can hit her with one of these…” She reached into her vest and pulled out a small schematic for what appeared to be a ballista that shot flaming demons. Adora took the schematic, then crumpled it up and threw it over her shoulder.

“No,” she said.

“Listen, she’s hurt so many people, we have to stop her!” Eda whispered.

“That girl is your adoptive daughter,” Adora said, her voice flat. “She’s hurting. And she’s in pain. We’re not going to kill her. Or

even punch her." She put her hands on Eda's shoulders. "We're going to *talk* to her."

Eda blinked at her. "I…" She hesitated. "What are you talking about?"

"In another world, I wouldn't have been there," Adora said, her voice tight. "Luz would be. She...should have been there." She turned away, her hand tightening and pressing to her chest. She felt the buzzing tingle, as if her own heart was trying to sing out against what she was saying. But it was true. She had to admit it. "When she said I stole everything, she was right. I-"

"Oh that's giraffe hockey, and you know it," Eda said, her voice short and sharp. She grabbed onto Adora's shoulder and spun her around. The fact Adora was currently Titan-Ra meant that Eda had to glare up at her, rather than look forward. "Adora, you deserve to be my daughter. Cause…" She hesitated, then smiled. "Cause while I may have had another weird, messed up, cool daughter in another universe, I would never, ever, give it up for having you, you big dumb brave idiot." She grinned, reaching up and wiping a tear out of Adora's eye. "You deserve to be here, just as much as Luz does."

Adora blushed, looking aside.

"Now…" Eda breathed in, then out. "Since the last time I saw Luz, I was running away after setting the curtains on fire, I think you might do a better job talking to her than me. But tell her…" She hesitated.

“I know,” Adora smiled, reaching down and putting her clawed hand on Eda’s shoulder. She nodded. “It’s going to be okay. It’s all going to be okay.”

She stepped from the alleyway, then headed down the road. Eda watched her go, biting her lip.

“Go get em kid,” she whispered.

Then.

“Rayne, are you still up for building the demon-launcher 2000? Just in case?”

The shadowy figure behind her stepped into the light. “Only if I get to fire it,” Rayne said, their voice wry. “You might jump the gun. Again.”

“You’re no fun…”

***

The door in the corridor was closed, locked tight. This was, in part, because it wasn’t actually a *door*, it was more of a slightly

decorated part of the wall, built smooth and flush with the rest of the corridor. That was why when the massive abomination fist punched its way through in a haze of splinters and dust, it left a gaping hole that spread to two other rooms to either side, and took a chunk of the ceiling down with it. Amity stepped into the dusty cloud, coughing and waving her face to try and clear the dust away.

King, who was perched on her shoulder, sneezed as Amity looked around the interior of what was supposed to be her family home. She frowned. "Luz...clearly has only some memories of this place."

"It looks accurate to me," King said, while Amity pointed at one of her father's abomiton guards, whose gloopy face had been reconfigured to try and approximate a kitten, with ears and a little smile.

"She tried to make the abominations into Catras," Amity said, walking past the guard – noticing that, like the door, it had all the seeming of an abomination guard, but it had none of the substance. Her magical talent didn't tingle with the proximity of abomination goo, and she saw that the machinery and clockwork that her father had perfected was just all one big piece, rather than something that actually *worked*. Amity shook her head as she headed down the stairs, and found that her mother was in there – save that she...looked…

Well.

She looked like someone had turned her into a doll made of wood and string. Then someone had blown her into pieces. The bits were scattered all over the living room. Amity put her hand on her mouth, then whispered. "I really hope Luz isn't lying when she says she can fix it…" She said, softly, while King nodded.

They stepped out through the front door and into the surreal Bonesburrough. There, in the distance, was the weeping Luz. And between her and Amity was the wild array of streets...and...as she took a step forward, the ground burst open. A black claw crawled up and out of the underground, dragging itself up. Another oddly imperfect creation – but Amity had read the Azura books enough to recognize the Slimebeast from book five, Azura's Revenge.

The Slimebeast screeched. "She doesn't deserve you!"

"What!?" Amity asked, stepping backwards.

The Slimebeast unfolded its long, bony limbs – exactly like how they were described in the book, Amity had to credit Luz for that – and laid itself low to the ground, dangerous and ready to scuttle forward and start slashing at her.

"Luz is a piece of garbage!" the Slimebeast gurgled. "Look at how much she's hurt everyone. She lies to everyone. She doesn't care about anyone but herself. You're *perfect*, Amity, and she doesn't deserve to be in the same room as you. Pearls before swine! Before swine!"

"That's ridiculous, I'm not perfect!" Amity said. "And Luz *isn't* a piece of garbage." She frowned. "You are."

The beast charged forward on a writhing mass of glop. It was similar to an abomination worm, writhing and wriggling forward, but infinitely more awful. Fortunately, Amity had been doing weapons testing for her father since she was old enough to dodge roll. She came to her feet as the beast smashed into the front of her house, sending a spray of splinters and dust into the air. Amity felt King shifting around on her back – and as the massive Slimebeast reared up to bring its bone claws into bear, King sprang forward on Amity's shoulders and shouted.

"*Weh*!"

A coruscating ring of force, banded by rainbow lights, exploded outwards from his mouth with enough force to propel him backwards onto Amity's shoulder. The ring impacted into the center of the Slimebeast's chest, blowing apart black glop and bones, revealing an empty hollow in its immense frame. It crashed backwards, limbs splaying out.

Amity still completed her magical circle. Abomination goo glowed from her pockets – leaving a sticky mess, she preferred having a bottle for this, but she hadn't had *time* to get one – and formed into a thickly shafted spear with a broad, leaf shaped tip. She gripped it in both hands and advanced towards the beast, planning to make sure it was firmly and completely dead.

One of its bone-scythes whipped out as she got close. Amity, prepared, leaped over the sweeping arc of the attack and brought her spear stabbing down into the head of the creature. Something crunched and it gurgled. "No...no...she deserves to hurt...she...deserves to…" The light animating the creature – a purple glow that flickered within its eyes – dimmed, then faded. Amity sprang backwards as the Slimebeast exploded into a haze of sparkles. Amity twirled her spear and then let the abomination goo lose its cohesion and slither along her arm, down into her pocket again.

"You'd think Luz's minion would be nicer. If I was creating minions, they'd only talk about how great and perfect I am," King said, startling a giggle out of Amity. She reached up and scratched the top of his head.

"I know you would, King," she said, then squared her shoulders. "But I don't think this is the only inner demon we're going to have to fight."

More shapes were emerging from the streets of Bonesburrough. Some were from Azura. Some, Amity didn't recognize – skintight uniforms and jagged devices that might have been futuristic weapons carried by space adventurers. Some were twisted echoes of her own friends and family – but they all lacked the hazy outlines of the earlier Hexside students. Amity was pretty sure the closer they got to Luz, the less she needed to use coherent foci for her constructs. And the closer they got, the more desperate a part of Luz was to keep them away.

"Stay back…"

“She’s worthless, worthless…”

“We hate her…”

“She’s not worth it…”

The voices overlapped one another – and Amity’s lips pursed.

Sometimes, in the darkest nights, after she had failed at something, after mother had spoken to her about needing proper friends...after she had stopped talking to Glimmer and found *proper* friends, like Boscha...she shook her head, slightly.

“This is going to be remarkably cathartic for me,” she said, aloud, trying to cheer King up.

“Yeah!” King said, punching one of his palms with a clawed fist. “Lets show these inner demons what some *outer* demons are like!”

Amity charged forward, her abomination goo flowing along her arm, forming into the world’s mightiest fist. She brought it directly down onto depression’s face.

***

Adora leaped once, twice, three times – each time, her feet clacked off metal. The last sent her to an apex that dropped her down onto a rooftop that was far wider than it should have been. From the base of the tower, Luz's brooding place had been a thin sliver of metal, with enough room to dangle one's legs over the side and cry, and little more. But now that she stood here, hat whistling in the wind and heart thundering, she felt as if she was a bug standing on something immense and impossible. Luz was a small figure in the center of a cyclopean stillness of metal and empty, howling sound.

Floating around her was shimmering, hissing shades. Echoes.

Adora's shoulders squared. Her feet seemed to echo impossibly loudly across the metal, and soon, she was standing before Luz. She was curled up in a fetal position in the air, her face mashed against her knees. To her left was a gauzy, half-translucent shape of her father, Manny. Save this wasn't the hale, healthy figure that Adora had gotten so little time to know. He was skeletally thin, his body pierced through with tubes and wires. His face, looked pained. He could barely breathe through an oxygen mask settled onto his face – and his hair had been peeled away by some medical treatment. Even his mustache was gone.

To her left was a searing figure that shone with a brilliant light. A judgmental set of blue eyes – and something close to the awful power of a god, or *the* God – shone from them. Luz cringed away from them, while a languid, slinky shade with gold and blue sparks for eyes pranced around her, cavorting and laughing.

"You really thought I loved you? Pathetic."

“You left me for her?” The shade of Amity was so thin and nearly empty – more a purple and pink impression than something that could actually be seen. “Really?”

Adora squared her shoulders. She hadn’t seen Amity, or Catra, or anyone else in her quest here – there was just Eda and her...ahem...plan. It was all on her. And in her chest, she felt the burning need to approach Luz and just *make it better*.

“Luz?” Adora asked, her hat fluttering in the breeze. The shades lifted their gaze up – but it was the one who glowed with the inner fire. Adora realized, with a lurch, that this was Luz’s own feelings towards *her*. The massive figure drew a sword of pure and brilliant light. Adora shook her head. “I’m not going to fight you.”

Luz didn’t respond. Instead, the slinky shade cackled. “She’s here to finally put an end to your stupid, pathetic, miserable life. How long have you been waiting for it?”

Luz put her hands onto her ears.

“Don’t listen to them!” Adora said – and lifted her sword up, parrying the blow that the shade brought swinging down. To her surprise when her sword and the other’s met, there was no ringing impact, no feeling of strength. It was as if she was fighting nothing but a shadow in truth. She braced her sword with both hands – then one, using the other to grab onto the glowing shade by the chest and lift her up. The glorious being that Luz saw

Adora as flailed her arms, clearly shocked to be so manhandled. Adora threw her bodily over her shoulder, sending the glowing form skidding away, then over the edge of the metal railing. "I'm not here to fight you – I'm not here to *judge* you."

"You should!" the slinky shade hissed. "If you knew half of what she's done!"

"Yeah, you made mistakes. We've...we've all made mistakes!" Adora said, desperately. She took a step forward – and the slinky figure stepped between her and Luz. She scrawled a glittering, dark rune onto the metal and the rune exploded to life. Black vines, sickly and rotting, slammed into Adora's chest, shoving her backwards with significantly more strength than Adora had expected. She dug in her heels, braced her armored forearm against the pressure of the vines, and took one step forward. Metal squealed and crumpled under her heel, buckling under the pressures. "I've made mistakes! I...I let my friend Kat down. I let her *die*."

She took another step forward.

"I failed Eda and King when I needed to keep them safe!"

She took another step forward.

"But...I…" She shoved the vines down with a crash. The whip-crack transmitted along the tendrils swept along and then

delivered all that kinetic force to the shimmering shade of Catra, who was sent skidding backwards, arms crossed over her chest to keep herself from being smashed apart. "I am going to do better! We can't undo the past! We can learn from it! We can grow! We can forgive each other...and we can forgive ourselves!"

"Luz Noceda can't learn *shit*!" The shade hissed. "She's useless, she's- *gurk*!"

The sudden, shockingly violent noise was followed by a brilliant white spike of ice emerging from between the shadow Catra's chest.

The ice blade jerked back and the shadow Catra fell to her knees, revealing the real Catra, her eyes blazing with anger.

"Just from one catty witch to another?" she snarled. "Get more than one insult. Repeating yourself endlessly makes us all look bad."

Then she kicked the shadow Catra away, sending her tumbling towards the paradoxically nearby edge of the vast metal space. Adora took a step forward – and Catra stood by her, both of them looking at Luz, who had lifted her gaze up. She peered over her own knees at them, and then buried her face back against her legs. The metal around them groaned, creaked, rippled. A sudden low drone sounded in the distance – and a breeze picked up. Then it grew. And grew. And grew. What started as a whipping wind became a gale. Catra grabbed onto the metal floor with her razor sharp claws, skidding backwards a few inches before she

rooted herself. Adora, though, felt as if the wind was simply blowing through her.

"Go...away!" Luz said, her voice muffled as the shade of her father shrank and shrank. Darkness surrounded them. The breeze slackened and the noise of the whirring was replaced with a soft *chhh-huck...chhh-huck*...and the quiet bleet bleet of heartbeat monitor. The sound of the bleeping and the rasping was so tinged with the sensations of sickness that Adora swore she could smell antiseptic and despair and death.

"You're not alone, Luz," Adora said, her voice tinged with desperation. "Please. Let us-"

"Do you know what happens?" Luz hissed, her eyes flashing. "What happens when you love people? They get taken away! They a...all get taken away...and...and…" She closed her eyes and she screamed. "And *I can't fix it*."

She unfolded from her fetal position. Purple fire blazed around her and her two eyes – one human, one Collector – blazed.

"Don't you get it!?" She shouted, her voice thick with unshed tears. "If Dad's alive...then it just means I will have to watch him die again! I can't! I did it once! I can't do it again! I can't! I can't!" She swept her hand to the side – and reality itself distorted around her palm. Metal tore upwards like a wave in a tossing sea and Catra flung herself aside to avoid it.

“Luz!”

The voice was distant. Adora snapped her head up. She saw that Amity had managed to clamber onto the metal structure, her hand grasping a pick-ax made out of abomination goo, which she had clearly used to hack her way up onto the roof. King clung to her shoulder.

“No!” Luz put her hands over her face. The wind started again. It screamed and Catra yelped as her feet were yanked out from under her. She clung to the floor, digging in grooves with her claws. Amity brought her pick-ax down seconds before she was blown off. King yelped and skidded down to her ankles, holding on for dear life.

The only one who wasn’t knocked backwards was Adora. It was as if the wind simply blew around her.

“Luz!” Amity shouted.

“W-Why doesn’t it work on you!?” Luz was glaring at Adora. Adora started to walk forward, bit by bit – moving past Luz, towards where Amity was clinging on for dear life. Luz waved her hand, snarling. Purple fire screamed along Adora’s body, blazing and crackling...and she felt it skidding off her form as if it was water. She felt her molecules buzz and quiver, as if they were trying to be torn apart, and scattered. Tossed to the highest cosmoi and left to wander for eternity. But it simply refused to work. “Why!? Why can’t I…”

Adora grabbed onto Amity by her hips. She turned – and saw that Luz was trying something new. Metal hands wrenched themselves up and out of the structure, animated by Luz's powers, and rushed towards Adora.

"You have one chance, Blight!" Adora hissed. "Make it count!"

She threw Amity up and over the gale force winds.

Metal crashed into her. Whatever immunity Adora had did not work on raw physical power, and she grunted hard as the metal screamed against her, pushing her inch by inch closer to the drop off. She dig her fingers in.

Catra clung as the wind dragged at her.

Luz, though, only had eyes for Amity, who landed with a grunt in the eye of the storm. Her blue hair was sent whirling around her head as she looked into Luz's eyes.

"I-I can't…" Luz whimpered, her eyes brimming with tears. "I can't fix it…"

"You don't have to fix it," Amity whispered. She took hold of Luz's hands.

She stepped close.

Luz trembled. "I-I'm…I'm…"

"Don't you get it, Noceda?" Amity whispered. "You're not alone."

She leaned in, gently, then kissed her. The metal pressing against Adora stilled, then died. The winds dimmed. The sky remained dark – but a pinprick of purple light shimmered between the two girls. It grew brighter...and brighter...and brighter still.

Adora sagged next to Catra. Their hands met, their fingers mingled.

And the brightness covered all.

When it retreated, the four girls stood in the orange and brown forests around Bonesburrough – before the Owl House. The door was open and the faint smell of the boiling seas reached their noses. Luz drew away from Amity, blinking a few times.

Then she smiled. "Hey, *batata*," she whispered.

Catra blinked, then whispered to Adora. “Did she just call Amity a potato?”

Amity laughed, then leaned in and kissed Luz, deeper still as the sun shone down on a world made suddenly right.

Luz chose the most reasonable thing to do at that moment, considering everything.

She fainted.

***

Luz Noceda, several million year old teenager and current holder of a not insignificant chunk of the potential energy of the observable universe, opened her eyes. She was laying in a comfy bed, with warm sunlight shining down next to her, and with a heaping pile of flowers, presents, and cards heaped next to her bed. She sat up, blinking slowly, then looked around. Sitting in her room, head tilted back, mouth opened in a gormless snore, was Adora Grayskull, her arms crossed over her chest even in sleep, and a little bit of drool dripping down her chin. She was parked near the door – but the door wasn’t closed, locked, barred, warded or guarded. She didn’t even have her sword. More, her hair had been left untied. Wild and disheveled, it framed her face like a waterfall of gold.

Luz blinked, then realized with a lurch that Adora Grayskull had spent the entire evening watching and waiting for her to...wake up.

Luz felt a weird giddy thrill at that. She looked down at her hands. They looked like hands all right. She wiggled her fingers. They remained fingers. She sighed, then thumped back into bed.

"Mhm! Uh! I'm awake!" Adora exclaimed, jerking upright.

"H-Hey…" Luz said, smiling sheepishly at her. "Uh."

Adora smiled back at her. "Y-You, uh, you've been out for a while, Noceda."

"H-How long?" Luz asked. Her voice still felt fragile.

"Three days," Adora said, nodding. She held up her hands. "Before you freak out...everyone's fine. I think when you're not, um, trying so hard, your powers work a lot better." She smiled, wryly. "Everyone who was turned into something they're not transformed back. And the Boiling Isles are once more themselves. With Emperor Belos dead, Angela Park has led a return to the old style of representational democracy that Belos stamped out." She nodded. "In short, things are...fine. Well. Mostly fine." She hesitated. "Amity is still trying to get her hair to be purple."

Luz blushed. “A-And you?”

“I…” Adora hesitated, then laughed. “Jeeze. You know. I...I still feel weird being asked that. Even if Catra and Amity both say I need to stop being so self sacrificing.” She blushed. “I’m...good. I think. But...I...I had to be the first person to wake you up.”

Luz gulped. “Because I’m super dangerous and you’re the only one who can kill me?”

“What!? No!” Adora exclaimed, horrified.

“Wait, is it cause your Titan-Ra powers can seal away my collector powers so I can’t hurt anyone?” Luz asked, her eyes widening.

“Uh…” Adora blinked, half standing up. “I don’t know if that they can? I never checked?”

“Wait, I still have my collector powers!?” Luz asked, and the whole room shuddered faintly – as if it was picking up on her sudden jolt of fear. Adora held up her hands.

“Whoa, whoa, whoa, yes! But...but...like…” She hesitated. “You have Collector powers. You may not know how to *use* them super well. But, like, just because a guy in a forklift crashes it doesn’t make forklifts evil. It just means they have to get forklift certified!” She smiled, shyly. “You’re not evil because you made mistakes. Maybe a little, uh. Goobery. And, like, give a goober a gun, it’s...pffhew, bad! But...we can...there’s...I mean…”

She trailed off.

"What is it you wanted to talk to me about, then?" Luz whispered, her eyes growing sightly haunted.

"S-So, um." Adora gulped. "Y-You know...Stringbean?"

Luz sat bolt upright. "Stringo!? My Palisman?"

"Y-Yeah, uh…" Adora trembled. She put her hands together. "H-He, uh, she, that is, they, uh, they hid out. On my head. As my hairband loop." She pointed at her hair. "And, he, uh...uh…" She put her hand on her chest. "One...one second! Kinda got a bit of heart burn." She frowned. "Oh I shouldn't have eaten those-" She gasped. "I...uh...uh…" She gasped as a glow blaze between her fingers...and then she grunted and jerked backwards as her shirt ripped open and Stringbean popped out, sailed up, then landed on Luz's lap.

Adora blinked, her mouth opened in shock.

Luz gaped as well.

Stringbean chirruped, smugly.

"*What*!?" Adora screamed as Luz grabbed Stringbean up into her arms, hugging her to her chest.

"Stringbeannnnnnnnn!" She squealed. "You're the best! Oh my *God*!"

"What!?" Adora fell to her knees, her hands going to her chest. There was no gory hole – just a faint discoloration.

Stringbean giggled and then flew up into the air, then shapeshifted...into a bile sack. The exact kind of bile sack that witches used to cast their magical spells. He fell into Luz's palm with a *splat* and Luz squealed. "You're so frigging clever!" She said, holding Stringbean up between her fingers as he dripped magical bile.

"I-I thought they sacrificed-"

"Well, yeah, sure, Palismans can do that," Luz said, grinning warmly as Stringbean turned back into a snakeshifter and writhed along Luz's wrist, coiling up to her shoulder with a smug flick of her tail. "They can give their energies to heal a very dead witch. But, like. Were you dead at the time?"

Adora shook her head.

“So, all Stringo had to do was give you a bile sack. And, like, a bile sack is the third weirdest thing Stringbean has become!” Luz said. “He’s the cleverest little snakeshifter ever! Yes he is! Yes he is!” She bumped her nose against Stringbean, while Stringbean let out a cheerful warble.

Adora blinked, her hand going to her chest. “Well, uh. Huh.” She laughed, softly. “Course, now, I don’t have a bile sack.”

“That’s no fair,” Luz said, then waved her hand. Adora grunted as she felt something shift inside of her body. Magic tingled along her fingers. She blinked a few times, while Luz squeaked, yanking her hand back. “S-Sorry!”

“Uh…” Adora hesitated. “No. It’s. Uh. It’s fine.”

She paused.

“You should definitely *ask* permission first, you know. Next time you do that.”

Stringbean chirruped. A promise was made.

He’d bite her next time, to remind her.

“That’s fair,” Luz said.

***

Luz and Adora came down into the heart of the Owl House, where everyone was waiting to see her. Handshakes, hugs and promises for future get togethers were shared. Luz, looking faintly overwhelmed by the outpouring of love, approached Camila and Manny Noceda. She blushed, waving at them. Manny slid his arm around her shoulder, while Camila leaned over and started to kiss her cheek. The three started to speak, eagerly, in Spanish among one another. Adora laughed as Eda showed off Rayne Whispers, while Catra did not manage to avoid being hugged tightly by Lilith Clawthorn.

“I’m very proud of you, Golden Guard,” Lilith said. Then she paused. “Well, I suppose that’s less of a mark of pride now.”

“It’s fine…” Catra blushed and smiled.

Soon, food – both human for the humans and demonic for the witches and demons – was laid out and Luz, Adora, Catra and Amity were leaning together over a pizza that was half covered in choze and half in cheese.

“So…” Luz hesitated. “S-Should, I, like...ya know…” She wiggled then mimed untangling a set of two intermingled cosomi with her fingers. The gesture seemed to be entirely baffling to everyone.

“Should I, like, fix things? Like, Glimmer and Willow have been sqouzened together. And, like, where did all the Evil Horde people end up?”

“I think some are in the human realm, some have to be here,” Adora said.

“Yeah, like, should I...f...fix...that?” Luz asked.

“No,” Amity said, frowning.

“But it’s all messed up!” Amity said.

“Yeah, but I don’t want to stop existing so some other Catra who probably isn’t as cool as me to take over,” Catra said, shrugging one shoulder. “Besides, there’s, like, a bazillion million other universes, there’s probably one where everything’s normal. Fuck em. They have their normal boring bullshit, I want to have my happy fucking ending.”

“Catra, language!” Camila Noceda called from down the table.

“Sorry Cammi!” Catra said, blushing.

“C...Cammi?” Luz whispered.

“Ignore her,” Adora cautioned.

“Are you hitting on my mom?” Luz hissed.

Catra regarded her. Then she clearly considered the wild extent and power of Luz’s abilities.

“...no,” she lied, bald facedly.

“Oh my God, Catra wants to bang my mom,” Luz whispered, putting her hands over her face.

“Hey, consider it a compliment, it means I’ll still be into you when you’re forty,” Catra said, clearly thinking this would help.

Amity giggled, while Adora groaned and Luz threw her head back and laughed. “Oh my *god*!” She shook her head. “You really are Catra. Despite it all, you are still Catra.”

“The one and only,” Catra said. “Excepting other universes, of course.”

“Does it not...bother you?” Amity asked, her giggles fading. “That there are other timelines, with other you?”

“Nah,” Catra said.

“I mean, this is where we live,” Adora said. “It’s what matters. Right?”

Luz and the others nodded.

After the dinner, Camila approached Luz. “Before we head back to the human realm,” she said. “And see about getting you adopted – since, well, uh, legally, you don’t exist. But we can fix that. We can make you our daughter in truth...but, uh, before then, you have to recover, and...you have your, uh...girlfriends.” She blushed. “The power point, by the way, was very informative. I knew about bisexuality, but not about polyamory. It’s...very…”

“Very modern,” Manny said, nodding approvingly.

“And progressive!” Camila added. “But here. Your parents are two nerds, like you. And that means, we have books for all occasions.”

Luz held up the book. It was called *Aberrant Talents: Progenitor, Book One* by Geoffrey Steer. The cover had a glowing blue woman firing laser eye blasts at what looked like a man made of steel, surrounded by soldiers with assault rifles, dressed like they were from the Vietnam War. Luz blinked.

"It's a guide to having supreme cosmic powers," Camila said as Luz opened the comic to a random incredibly depressing looking page.

"More of a guide on what *not* to do," Manny said.

"H-Heh…" Luz grinned. "I think I already got some ideas on that. But this will have way more advice!"

"Like don't support the US government!" Camila said, cheerfully.

"And spend more time curing cancer, less time exploding terrorists," Manny added.

Luz had a very funny look on her face.

Then she smiled, shyly.

"You know? That's a really good idea. I should learn how to do that."

***

Glimmer and Bow were lounging at the window, watching the stars. Luz and Catra were both sharing runing advice. Amity laid with her head in Catra's lap, and allowed her newly purpled hair to be petted. Adora, meanwhile, stood off by the corner, her arms crossed over her chest.

Her bile sack was back. Her power was now well and truly hers, not granted by some other creature, not something to be whisked away.

But there were one question that made her frown and think worried thoughts.

Was…

Was Horde Prime still out there?

Lurking and waiting? Could he be drawn by the dimensional energies that Luz had released?

Is he even a threat? She frowned. *I suppose it depends on how quickly Luz gets her powers under her control…*

"Adora!"

She shook herself, and saw that Amity was sitting up, gesturing her over. Adora blushed and walked over, then knelt down next to

the group.

"What are you doing brooding over there?" Amity asked.

"Just...thinking about the future," Adora admitted. "What comes next?"

Catra snorted. "A foursome."

"C-Catra!" Luz said, blushing.

Amity bit her lip. "I mean…" she hesitated. "She's not *wrong*."

Adora found it was quite impossible to think about Horde Prime and quibbling issues like that. The future would take care of itself, after all.

The four girls laughed, and then fell into quiet conversations. Despite Catra's jokes, there was still time enough to get comfortable with one another, with this world, with their new lives. The conversation wound on, deep into the night, and eventually, even a demigoddess needed to sleep. As Luz snored, cuddling platonically against Amity and Adora at the same time, while Catra purred at the foot of the bed, Stringbean wriggled free from the group.

The snakeshifter grew tiny wings, then flapped out the window, into the warm summer breeze that blew off the coast. He flew up to the rooftop of the Owl House, past a snoozing Hooty, and then settled down. There, he waited...and then the stars overhead wheeled. They spun. They formed, then, into a cheerful smile and a sparkling set of eyes – the tiny white dots patterning shifting to give those sky-spanning lips movement.

One eye winked, and a cheerful voice spoke.

"Told you! Minimum amount of change, maximum amount of impact."

Stringbean chirruped, her voice accusing.

"Oh I knew you could handle guiding Adora to the right spot. Once she found the sword – thanks to you, I note, it was all set."

Stringbean wriggled and squeaked an annoyed question.

"Why not just fix it from the moment Belos broke it? Uh, listen, I'm an *adult* Collector now! I have to follow the rules. Those rules exist for reasons! Do you know how *broken* things get if we throw our weight around? Do you want another ding dang Unsided incident?"

Stringbean cocked her head.

“It’s...a Collector thing, don’t worry about it.” Those starry eyes glittered. “Don’t worry. Everything will be fine now. Happy ending. Now...you have only one job. Take care of Titan-Ra and the Princess of Portals, why don’tcha?” The big eye winked.

Stringbean sighed, then settled their head down.

The stars wheeled overhead – the face was gone, and the voice was silent.

She supposed that put everything into place.

Tomorrow was going to be a new day.

For everyone.

THE END

End Notes

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